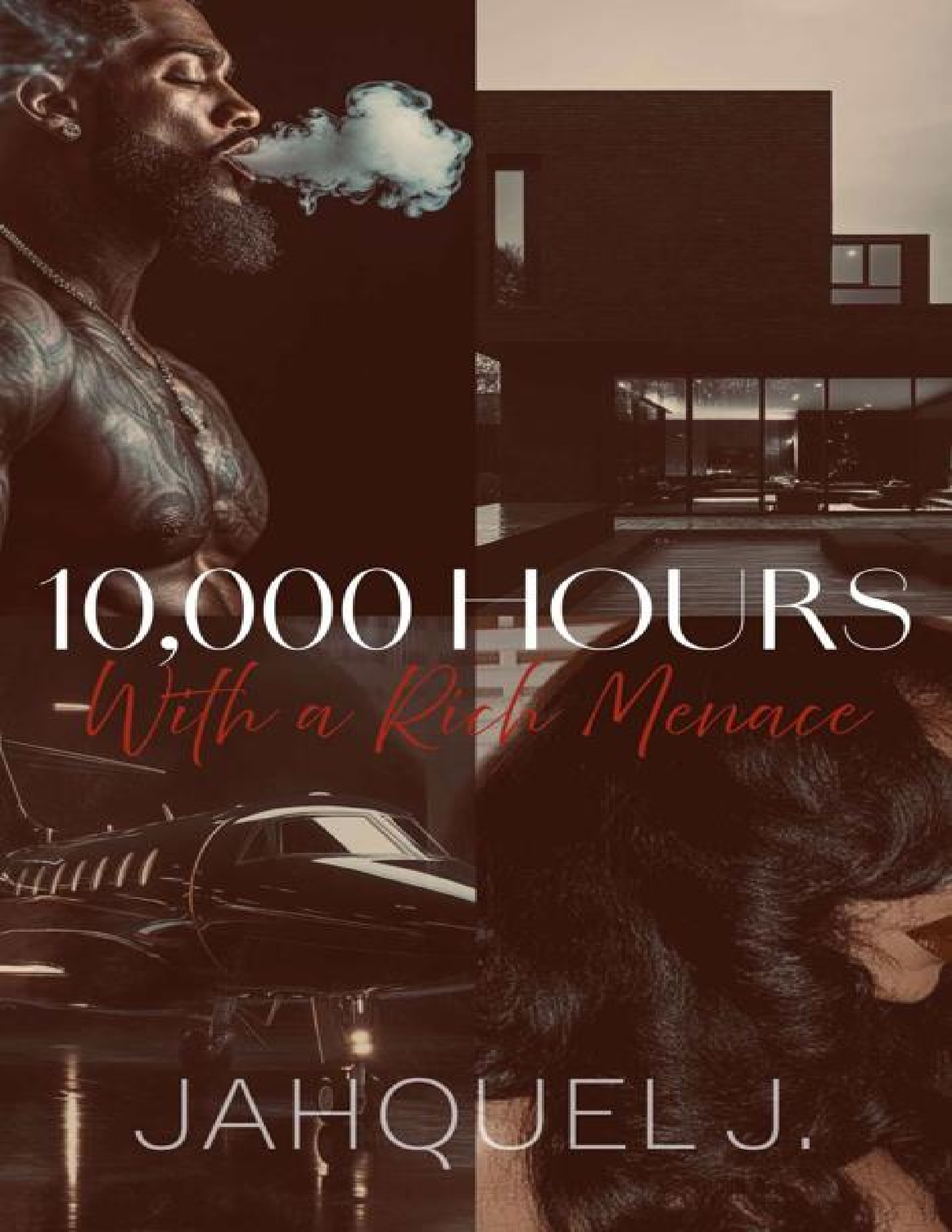




10,000 HOURS

With a Rich Menace

JAHQUUEL J.

10,000 Hours With A Rich Menace

JAHQUEL J.

OceanofPDF.com

Copyright © 2025

Published by Jahquel J.

www.Jahquel.com

ALL RIGHTS RESERVED

Any unauthorized reprint or use of the material is prohibited. No part of this book may be reproduced or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, or mechanical, including photocopying, recording, or by any information storage without express permission by the publisher. This is an original work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are either products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously and any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead is entirely coincidental.

Contains explicit language and adult themes.
suitable for ages 16+

Cover Designer: Talena Sams (T- Designs)

OceanofPDF.com

**Join my mailing list here + check out my website for autographed
paperbacks:**

[JOIN HERE!](#)

www.Jahquel.com

Join my official reading group:

[Jahquel J's we reading or nah group?](#)

Be sure to bless my page with a **[LIKE!](#)**

CONNECT WITH ME ON SOCIAL MEDIA:

[http://www.instagram.com/ Jahquel](http://www.instagram.com/Jahquel)

[http://www.twitter.com/Author Jahquel](http://www.twitter.com/Author_Jahquel)

https://www.tiktok.com/@_iamjah

**When writing my books, I run off coffee, anxiety + overthinking. Like
to contribute to my coffee habit? You can purchase me a coffee [hereeee!](#)**

I made a Patreon, if you're interested you **[Join here!](#)**

OceanofPDF.com



OX

Jahquel J's Catalog ♦



Jahquel J. - Author

Brookwood Series

Interconnected Standalone Series
From Come Over To Come Home
He's My Next Mistake
From Replied To Wifey
Welcome To Brookwood

McKnight Family

In Love With The King Of Harlem 1-5
In Love With An East Coast Maniac 1-3
Rose In Harlem: Harlem King's Princess

Lennox Hills Series

Interconnected Standalone Series
I'm Fine...Thanks
Yeah... Thanks
Never Better... Thanks

Delgado Family

Capone 1-3
★ Cappadonna 1-3.5
★ Capri 1-3.5

Mathers Family

Confessions Of A Hustla's Housekeeper
1-4
Confessions Of A Hustla's Daughter 1-2★

Vanducci-Cromwell Family

A Staten Island Love Story 1-3

BAE Series

BAE: Before Anyone Else 1-3
He's Still BAE 1-3★
BAE: Holiday ★

Wolfe Billionaires
Interconnected Standalone Series
Wolfe In Chic Clothing

Davis Family

Staten Island Love Letter 1-5
Staten Island Love Affair 1-4★
A Brownsville, Harlem & Staten
Island Holiday Affair

Homies, Lovers & Friends

Homies, Lovers & Friends 1-5
Homies, Lovers & Wives★

Series:

- Crack Money With Cocaine Dreams 1-2
- Never Wanted To Be Wifey 1-2
- To All The Thugs I Loved That Didn't Love Me Back 1-4
- All The Dope Boys Gon Feel Her 1-2
- Good Girls Love Hustlas 1-3
- I Got Nothing But Love For My Hitta 1-2
- She Ain't Never Met A N*gga Like Me 1-3
- Married To A Brownsville Bully 1-3
- Thugs Need Love 1-3
- What A Wicked Way To Treat The Woman You Love 1-2
- Finessing The Plug 1-2

Standalones:

- My Lover, My Dopeboy
- I Can't Be The One You Love
- I'm Riding With You Forever
- Forever, I'm Ready
- Emotionless
- Blaquehatten
- Ho, Ho, Housewife
- When Can I See You Again?
- What You Know About Love?
- Hearts Won't Break
- Pretty Little Fears
- Save Myself
- Two Occasions
- I Didn't Mean To Fall In Love
- Second Chance Christmas

* Spinoff

www.Jahquel.com | hello@Jahquel.com | @Jahquel_

OceanofPDF.com

Author's Notes:

While I know we're smack in the middle of season four of the Infernos, I interrupt your broadcast to give you Menace Caselli. Menace is not the Delgatos or the Infernos – he's his own person. I ask that you take yourself out of the Infernos and Delgatos to truly immerse yourself in Menace and Stevie's story.

Stevie lives within her head or the clouds, so while something that she did isn't something you would ever do, keep in mind:

This is fiction

Don't write the book off because the FMC is different.
(Cause some of ya'll be harder on these women characters than the men...
uh huh.)

Did I mention it's a fictional book written for entertainment?

Pull it together, kay?

I laughed at so many parts reading about Wanda and Mitchell – you'll find out soon enough what that means. I loved writing both of them because they are both polar opposites, but I also believed that your opposite makes the best partner. What fun would it be to have someone exactly like you? This book is about two people finding love with someone they would have never expected to love.

10,000 Hours With A Rich Menace is a standalone.

There is minimum drama (at least my version of that.) However, this book focuses on Stevie and Menace. There isn't drive-by's, shoot-out's etc. Because if you read the Delgatos, Menace pops in and out – my guy stays to himself.

There are a few things within Menace book that sets up the scene for some other books. You get a look at Menace and who he is, the Caselli's and their family dynamic.

This book is the start to the Caselli family.

If you're new here, there is no other book you HAVE to read before this one. Menace was briefly mentioned during the Delgato series; however, you can jump right into this and go back and read (if you haven't read.)

The families mentioned within the book are the following:

The three founding families of Staten Island:

Davis Family:

[Staten Island Love Letter \(Book 1-5\)](#)

[Staten Island Love Affair \(Book 1-4\)](#)

The Vanducci- Cromwell family:

[Staten Island Love Story \(Book 1-3\)](#)

The Caselli family – This is their intro.

[Don Caselli](#)

[Xo, Unlawfully Yours](#)

Other families mentioned:

The Delgato Family:

[Season one: Capone \(Books 1-3\)](#)

[Season two: Cappadonna \(Books 1-3.5\)](#)

[Season three: Capri \(1-3.5\)](#)

The Infernos

[Season four: Inferno Gods: Quasim](#)

The Amante's

The Amante Cartel: The Inc – Coming soon.

Concrete Roses – [Preorder here](#)

A few things to mention:

Willshire hotels are owned by The Willshire family – [Lennox Hills series](#)

New Jersey Black Jackets football team is my football team in my upcoming sports romance – [Preorder Here.](#)

Evermere, Texas is a fictional city in Texas.

[Caposcents](#) is a real company.

Oh, and guess what – there's no cliffhanger....

I made a Patreon, if you're interested you can join. [Join here!](#)

[OceanofPDF.com](#)

Here's to having a nigga that hates his toothpaste
being squeezed or food touching but will make a
nigga bleed behind you.

OceanofPDF.com

Playlist:

[Apple](#)
[Spotify](#).

If you enjoy Pinterest boards, check out the one made for 10,000 Hours
With A Rich Menace.

[Pinterest](#)

[*OceanofPDF.com*](#)

Synopsis:

Imagine your best friend invites you on an all-expenses-paid trip.

Luxury at its finest.

A five-star resort, designer shopping sprees, fine dining, and balling out like there's no tomorrow. She swears her new man is head over heels for her and doesn't mind spending big.

While she's out on a date, you decide to unwind with a bubble bath. The warmth relaxes you, lulling you into comfort. You dip your head beneath the water, letting the silence consume you. But when you resurface, the silence is shattered.

A man is standing there. Watching you.

Before you can scream, darkness takes over.

You're knocked out, blindfolded, tied up, and on a jet—your paradise suddenly replaced with the cold reality of Staten Island, New York.

That's when you learn the truth.

Your best friend stole a lot of money from a very powerful man. A man with ties to an even more powerful family. And to save herself, she didn't run.

She offered you up instead.

The blindfold is yanked away, but at first, all you see is darkness. Then, as your vision adjusts, you lock eyes with *him*.

A tall, brown-skinned man, his body inked with tattoos.

One look, one breath, and you realize the truth.

You've been handed over to Menace Caselli.

Not as a prisoner.

As his wife.

OceanofPDF.com

Prologue



Stevie Raye

MY MOM ALWAYS JOKED THAT I WOULD BE LATE TO MY OWN FUNERAL because I was always running behind on time, and so unorganized. My mother had OCD, so growing up every room in our home was perfect.

Well, except mine.

She would always joke that she birthed her complete opposite, but we were thicker than thieves. After my parents' divorce, my mother tossed me into everything to help soften the blow of my father being out of our home.

Although, he wasn't ever there to begin with.

I don't know how many times I had to sit in the middle of my bed and listen to my mother and father scream back and forth because my father was gone for more than a few days. She would scream, trying to get him to understand the effect of his daughter having an absentee father in the home.

He never cared.

It was funny that she said I would be late for my own funeral, and I was on time for hers.

Well, it wasn't funny.

I stood in front of her casket, and stared at her beautiful chestnut skin, her favorite peach lipstick that she would buy from Mary Kay covered her lips. Her curly hair was pushed back away from her face, and she looked like she peacefully resting.

Like I usually found her when she came home from a long day of work. As a therapist, she sat and listened to everyone's problems, and no one ever listened to hers. Every time she came home, she would say, "*Stevie, my brain is just tired,*" and would go rest on the couch to avoid oversleeping before dinner.

The couch was her favorite place to sleep and enjoy her time. So, it was no coincidence when I came in from work and discovered her napping on the couch. After showering, painting for a bit, and then deciding on dinner, I decided to wake her up so she could change out of her work clothes, and we could enjoy dinner together.

Her hands was cold to the touch, and she had no life or breath in her body.

Gone.

Long faded from the world where I was. My mind wouldn't allow me to believe that she was gone. It told me she was napping, and I needed to continue to prepare dinner for her. My heart nor my mind couldn't take my mother being gone.

She was my best friend. My everything, and the only parent that I had. My father had always been in and out of my life, never sticking around for too long. He was an associate more than a parent.

As much as my brain and heart wouldn't accept reality, here I stood in front of her casket in a small church in Flatbush, Brooklyn, with a few of her colleagues, my cousin, Skyler and her mom, and the man from her favorite corner store saying goodbye to her.

I heaved a deep breath as the tears fell down my cheeks. I've always been such a time bomb, never knowing the proper timing to show up somewhere, being messy, and always forgetful. I talked to myself most days and even answered myself. It was safer to live in Stevie's world than the actual real world. My mama was the person who kept the train wreck on its track and now she was gone.

Forever.

"Whenever you're ready we can go," Mario, my boyfriend, put his arms around me and gave me a tight squeeze.

I looked up at him, his bronze skin, curly hair, and freshly plucked eyebrows. Mario was way too pretty to me, and it was to be expected. I met him on a photoshoot set while working as an assistant. I was fixing one of

the model's nails that day, and Mario came over and asked me to give him a quick manicure.

His height and perfect chiseled cheeks was enough for me to give him the manicure, and instead of offering me a tip or something since I wasn't *his* assistant, he slipped his number to me on my way out.

I would have much rather the money.

Still, this was a model that clearly was interested in me, so I couldn't turn him down over non-payment for a funky manicure. Oh, how I wish I would have turned him down because the pressure for sex, attitude problem, and his fear of commitment had been more of a headache than the damn manicure.

I continued to try with Mario, knowing that neither of us were going anywhere. He didn't want to be in a relationship because he wanted to do him, and I was just being strung along for the ride.

My mom told me she thought I was settling by being with Mario, and I didn't understand what she meant. Mario was a model, and from the amount of women that stayed under his comments, he was well wanted from all walks of life.

And he wanted me.

Well, only a piece of me since he couldn't seem to commit to being my boyfriend and wanted to keep things *light*.

What did that even mean?

The creak of the old wooden church doors caused us both to turn, and I landed eyes on my father. Steve Raye. My mother was so in love with my father that she decided to make me his namesake, with a little extra flare.

Everyone called him Raye, and it been like that for as long as I could remember. He came in dressed in a black suit, with his hands tucked in his pockets and his head down. Too ashamed to look me in the eyes because he showed up late to his own ex-wife's funeral.

Not only that, but he also refused to help me with her funeral arrangements. Mama had health insurance so that paid for everything and left me behind a decent chunk of change. She worried, so I knew she wanted me to be taken care of well after she was gone.

My mother was an only child, and her parents had both passed on. Aside from a cousin or great-aunt here and there on her side, she didn't have much family. My uncle, cousin, and aunt were all from my father's side. It had

always been just the two of us, and with as much love as my mother had given me, I never needed anything else.

Tessa Raye was the most overbearing loving mother that I could have asked for. At times we would butt heads because she wanted to control my life. While I lived my life day by day, my mother planned her entire day and life down to the second.

Despite our differences, she was my best friend, and she always meant well. I feared what would become of me now that she was gone. I didn't have any one to wake me up when I overslept in the morning or reminding me of important things that I would always push off until the last minute.

"Hey Baby Girl." My father made it to the front and peered over at the casket, at his ex-wife. I was old enough to know that Steve Raye was the love of my mother's life, but she wasn't the love of his.

Gambling was.

Even at fifty-five, he was sharp as ever with his low-cut fade, thick beard, and freshly lined hairline. His coca skin glistened and he smelled like coconut butter and shea butter combined, the only vivid thing that I remember about him.

"Hey."

Mario kissed my temple and left me alone with my father, standing in front of my mother's casket. I thought he would have been first to go, not her. Honestly, I would have been happier if he went instead of her.

I needed my mother.

"She looks beautiful," he broke our silence.

Skyler's mother sucked her teeth, clearly disgusted that my father had bothered to show his face.

"I did her nails."

"Hmm."

I move closer and stared at her once more before kissing her forehead. "I love you, Mommy. I promise I will make sure I keep it together... whatever *it* is," I sniffled.

My father stood there unsure of what to do or what to say. He should have said sorry. Sorry for not being there as a husband or a father. Sorry for stringing a woman as great as my mother along for years, knowing that he had no intentions of being a good person, husband, or father.

All Steve Raye cared about was himself and gambling. Give this man ten dollars and he would bust a blood vessel trying to turn it into a hundred.

For as long as I could remember, I had sat with my father in underground casinos while he tried to double his money.

A few times he had people knocking on our door looking for him because he owed them money. Steve Raye's favorite words were, "*You know I'm good for it.*" He was in fact never good for the money.

"Stevie, I know I haven't been there for you. I'm in a good place right now... got this gig lined up and the money is good."

He was too stupid to realize how much of a slap to the face it was to hear that he had a good thing going and couldn't contribute to helping me bury my mother? I wasn't even concerned about the financial aspect of it. He could have made a call, arranged the church, something would have been anything while I mourned my mother.

I was her only child so everything was left up to me handle – alone.

"You always in a good place, but it's never mentally."

He screwed his face up. "You sound just like that damn woman." Skyler gasped when the words left his mouth.

I had heard my mother tell him that more times than a few and he always brushed her off. Never wanting to change for his family. "That damn woman was my mother... your ex-wife. She deserves to be addressed as more than that *damn* woman, Raye."

He choked. "I am still your father, Stevie Raye."

"When? When have you ever been a damn father to me, Steve? What doctor appointments have you ever attended or school conferences you sat in on? When mama was tired and doing it all alone, where were you? So, please spare me with the bullshit of being my father only when it's convenient to use. Where have you been since I called you to say she passed? Your fucking daughter called you distraught and you took four days to get back to me... so Steve, move the fuck around and leave me alone." I shoved past him, walking down the aisle and out of the church.

What the fuck has Steve Raye ever done for me? The only person I ever had was about to be buried six feet into the ground. It was Stevie Raye up against the world – alone.

Some family.

No friends.

Alone.

Stevie Raye



FIVE YEARS LATER...

WHEN THE BUS DRIVER SAW ME RUNNING TO THE BUS STOP, TRIPPING AND falling on a crack in the sidewalk, I thought he would have some kind of heart to keep the bus parked and allow me to pick myself up from the floor, and continue to the bus.

So much for wishful thinking because his ass pulled away from the stop after seeing me laid out on Pitkin Avenue like a snow angel freshly fallen from the sky. Since he was pulling away anyway, I looked up at the sky while lying on the dirty sidewalk and silently asking my mother what was she trying to teach me.

It had been five years since I buried her, and nothing ever got easier. The more I tried, the harder everything seemed to be. Life was such a push and pull, and I couldn't figure out the lesson in all of this.

Time didn't make me more punctual or less messy. I was still the same Stevie, just a bit more lost than I had been before. I was always looking for a sign from my mother and could never find one. Anything from her that would tell me to keep pushing, and everything would work out the way that I needed it to.

Something that would make living without her easier.

Newsflash: It never got easier without her being here.

The last time I saw my father; he was in that church trying to be a father. I hadn't spoken or seen my father since that day I left him in the

church. It usually took me a while to cut people off. However, once I was done, the cord was cut. He was my father, and I would always love him because he *was* my father. However, I had no room in my heart for the selfishness. My mother put up with it until she couldn't anymore, and I refused to carry that burden of trying to stay connected because I happened to come from his ball sack.

No thanks.

"Stevie, can you please get up off the ground... the next bus is coming," Alex, my store uncle, peered over me, as I continued to stare up at the sky.

His brown skin, thick eyebrows, and headwrap stared back at me. Alex, though I'm sure that wasn't his real name, had always been my mother's favorite store owner. She would stop in for a coffee every morning before her commute into the city. He would give her conversation and then 'forget' to charge her for the coffee because he loved her conversation more than the three dollars for the cheap coffee.

Since my mother passed, Alex had stepped up as family. I loved Alex, but I knew I stressed him out daily. Not everyone could have the strength that my mother had when it came to dealing with me. Alex's store was on my block, and his entire family took turns running the store. No one worked as hard as he did, though.

"What's the point, Alex? I missed the bus, I'm late on my portion of the rent, and my phone should be going off in a few days." I closed my eyes, becoming comfortable on a sidewalk that I'm sure a family of rats had scurried across the night before.

He held his hand out and I accepted his help on getting up. The back of my jean jacket was dirty because I decided to lay here instead of getting up and waiting for the next bus. Alex gave me a hug and then went into his pockets, and I shook my head and moved back, almost landing on my ass again.

Alex stabilized me before counting out money and forcing it into my hands. "You pay your phone bill."

"You have a wife, children, and family to take care of... I cannot keep accepting money from you, Alex," I protested.

He waved me off, something he always did whenever he didn't want to hear my protest. "You are family, Stevie. We spend some holidays together and you babysit the kids when me and Rishi need the help. This is more for me than you...I need to keep an eye on you." He smiled, while hugging me

before giving me a quick push toward the bus stop, where the next bus was coming.

“Thanks, Alex. I will pay you back as soon as I get some money.”

“Nonsense... have a good day. Make lots of pretty nail art, huh?” He winked, and I smiled before paying my fare and taking a seat in the front.

Aside from my cousin Skyler, and her daughter, Estella, Alex had been the only family that I had since losing my mother. Well, my nanny too, but she didn't count. Alex was at her funeral and had honored his promise to always look out for me. When my mother made him make that promise, of course I was a reckless teen, and she wanted all eyes on me when her eyes couldn't be. Alex took it to heart and had been keeping an eye on me since she passed away, giving me that fatherly love that I often missed. When I moved out the neighborhood after my mother passed, he still kept in touch and made sure to see me twice a month.

I could count on him and his wife to swing by my apartment in the Bronx with food for me. They had welcomed me as their family, so they worried about me at times. Alex knew how my mother was, and how much she kept an eye on me, and he wanted to honor the promise he made to her. When my cousin's boyfriend – that wasn't her boyfriend – told her that he wanted to move her out of the Bronx and into a new apartment, I convinced Skyler to move to my old neighborhood.

Mario was gone before my mother's coffin could become comfy in the ground. He said I had too much going on and he didn't know how to help me through whatever I was going through. Guess I should be grateful that he was honest with me, and didn't continue to string me along. I guess that was the sign I was looking for from mama all along.

I should have known the minute I rushed into work late that there was going to be some drama going on. There was always some kind of drama that brewed in Cindy's shop. Despite all the drama, the shop was always packed out and always moving right along.

It had been a little over a year since I started renting a booth as a nail tech in Cindy's shop. The booth rent was fairly cheap for this part of Brooklyn, and I enjoyed being around people. I've always taken clients in my apartment on the side.

After booking a client that clearly saw me with her man, I decided to stop giving my address out and rent a public space with lots of witnesses

around. That was the last time I ever booked another client in my home, and the last time I ever spoke to that man.

How was I supposed to know he had a girlfriend who was pregnant? On our date he told me that he was single. With how big her stomach was, and how tightly balled her fists were, I could tell that she got down and would beat my ass. The baby would probably get a few licks in on me, too.

Cindy was sweet and she always looked out for me when I was late with my booth rent. She never made me feel like shit when I came late handing her money. She had to be in her early forties with a thick coke bottle shape, small waist, and a short pixie haircut.

From the way all her different men came bringing her lunch, money, and flowers, Cindy was pressure back then, and even now. I bypassed Mandy and her boyfriend going at it again for the third time this week.

“That hoe came into this shop and stared at me the whole time she got her hair done. You not going to convince me that you not fucking her, Raymond!” She hauled off and slapped the hell out of him, while he tried to duck away from her crazy ass.

“I can’t fucking control what a hoe do when she come in this bitch... give me the keys to my fucking car, Mandy. I already had to take a cab to get down here and you playing games.”

Mandy rolled her neck while I hung my jacket up and went to make me some tea to get my creative juices flowing. “Fuck you and those keys. I left them on the train this morning... good luck finding them.” Her lips twitched up in a smirk while Raymond looked like he was about to murder her.

“Bitch, you did what?”

Cindy cleared her throat. “Mandy, take that shit on out my shop. It’s way too early and clients are starting to come in.”

Mandy happily floated past her man who went through eight different emotions at once while she was in complete peace with ruining his. As she and Raymond left the shop, Priscilla walked in at the same time.

Priscilla was as close as I was going to get to a best friend. We met a year and a half ago at a bar, got to talking and we had been locked in ever since. She was the girl who got men to do whatever she wanted. If she wanted her bills paid, she would have them paid by some sucker who just wanted to smell her pussy.

She didn't work because why would she? If she had men paying her bills, there was no reason to get up and clock into a job that paid less than what she made from them. I watched as she shook off her Burberry trench coat, that cost nearly as much as my portion of my rent. She sat down the coffee she had brought for us to enjoy while she filled me in on her life and I gave her a fill-in.

"Good morning, Stevie!" She smiled, as she bounced her ass down into my chair, and flipped her jet-black hair over her shoulder.

"Morning, Priscilla. I thought you would still be in Jamaica." I slid back in my chair and gathered all my things to get ready on her nails.

She texted me earlier in the week to reschedule because she was going to be out of town. I never rebooked because I planned to use the two-hour block to sit in my thoughts and figure out how to get my portion of the rent up in three days.

After my mother passed away, I was able to handle the rent with the rest of the insurance money. However, that eventually came and went, and I was stuck having to pay the rent alone. I posted an add on social media for a roommate – dangerous, I know – and I ended up finding a bunch of weirdos that seemed too dangerous to co-exist with just for rent.

It wasn't until my cousin's mother died – a curse for sure – that she asked to move in with her daughter. Skyler and Estella were both great, and we were the Golden Girls.

"He canceled our trip because something came up, so I'm here in the cold annoyed." She rolled her brown eyes, and looked at her nails, that seemed perfect enough to me.

She was a bit dramatic about the weather. It wasn't cold. I think she just wanted to wear that expensive coat. Then again, if I had the option to be in Jamaica than Brooklyn, New York, I probably would be just as dramatic as Priscilla was being.

"Well, at least you can brave the *cold* with me," I snickered, and she pinched my arm, and laughed.

"Bitch, you need to get out of town or something... always at work or home. Where's your life, Stevie? I know you mentioned your mom passed, but damn... she wouldn't want you to be boring."

It stung whenever someone spoke about my mother. "Living your life cost money. I'm late on my portion of the rent again."

“Oh, I can help you out with that.” Priscilla motioned for me to give her my phone and I hesitantly handed it over toward her.

I watched as she went between her phone and then my phone. “Done... sent you thirty thousand dollars. Keep five, and then send me back twenty-five thousand,” she said like it was nothing to send someone thirty-thousand dollars to their account.

I slid from my table and looked at her like she was doing good drugs. “Priscilla, what...where did... what the hell?”

She laughed. “I have a suga daddy who gives me whatever I want, and I just needed to transfer it from this international account to a US account to avoid the pesky fees. You have a credit union account, right?”

“Yeah. My mom added me before she passed,” I looked at my account balance, and then back at Priscilla.”

“Perfect. I have a few more transactions to make, so can I use your account? Of course I’ll make sure to kick you some money, too.”

“Is this even leg—”

She loudly clapped her hands while looking at her phone. “I have a great idea... let’s go out the country and escape the real world.”

“Um, I would, but I need to save this money.”

She sighed. “I’m inviting you, Stevie... everything paid for, and you don’t have to pay anything. Do you have a passport?”

“Yes.”

The only reason I had gotten a passport was because my mother forced me to. For her fiftieth birthday, we went to Mexico and had the time of our lives. By the end of the trip neither of us wanted to go home. We even joked about abandoning our life back in the states, opening a smoothie stand on the beach and living out the rest of our life in Mexico as ex-pats. I missed her so much that these memories never felt good.

“Girl, we are going on a trip that you’re never going to forget. Pay your rent and go on and load your Shein cart with some clothes because we’re going to the Bahamas.” She jumped out of her chair and did a little dance. “I will book our flights soon... we’re going to have a ball.”

The thought of leaving behind all the stress and depression in New York sounded like a dream. If she had thirty thousand to wire to me from her suga daddy’s account, then surely she could afford a trip and to cover me.

“Okay,” I agreed, hoping that my mother would show up this time and give me a sign I needed to make a decision like this.

I guess no sign was a sign to go and enjoy my life for once.

OceanofPDF.com

Maverick Menace Caselli



I DIDN'T TALK UNTIL I WAS FIVE YEARS OLD.

My mother always said I was different, and because I refused to use my words she worried. I was always the kid she worried about the most, even though I was the oldest. When Kora came, she had to split her time between a new baby and her nonverbal son.

Since the age of two, I had been to every therapist or enrolled in every therapy that money could buy. My father was the kind of nigga that didn't feel the need to worry. *He'll talk when he got something to fucking say... don't seem like he got much to say, Constance.* I would hear them arguing because I wasn't verbal.

The worry lines always appeared when she rubbed my head and kissed my cheek. It wasn't that I didn't know how to talk, I knew how to talk. I just didn't want to talk, and I would always stop myself when I felt like it.

In school, they picked on me because I didn't say shit, and the teachers paid me extra attention. When it came to my schoolwork, nobody could touch me because I knew my work. It wasn't that I didn't know anything – I knew plenty. I just didn't talk and never felt moved to say anything. Every grade, test, assignment I passed without ever saying a fucking word.

I went to private school, and there wasn't a bunch of kids that looked like me in that bitch. I was an easy target being the Black boy, and then not speaking, they just knew they hit the jackpot. Until I cornered the biggest one in the bathroom during recess and beat his ass with the cover from the back of the toilet.

The teacher was horrified when she went into the bathroom and found him on the floor barely hanging onto life. She screamed while shaking me and asked why I would do such a thing, as if she hadn't witnessed these pink bitches bully me since the school year started. I smiled in her face and told her, "*Bitch tried me, and I showed him.*"

No matter how much time had passed, the look on her face as she shuttered while looking at me was something I would never forget. I wished I could have taken a picture and showed her ass what she looked like, then printed it on a T-shirt.

My father paid off that boy's family and it was never spoken about. They graciously accepted the money because they could have been burned to death in their home instead. The Eaton family wasn't anything to fuck with, and my uncle, Nash Eaton, ran a tight ship. Nothing happened without him or my father knowing.

After I spoke to my teacher, it was a wrap after that because I never shut up. I ran that school like my name was on the sign outside of it. Always correcting them when they were wrong and talking out of turn. There was no way they could control me or stop me from doing whatever I wanted.

The teachers spoke with my parents and told them that I was different. I learned early on that being *different* in that school was bad. They might as well have branded me with a scarlet letter.

It was in seventh grade that I met my best friend. Corleon D. Bruster walked into the school, another Black boy. He came in like he knew he was the shit, and he was smart, which made me feel better. I hated a stupid person, and the fact that he was another Black boy and smart piqued my interest.

Baked chicken, white rice and corn – had to be fresh corn. That was my lunch every day. Every time I opened my lunch box; it was like I was having it for the first time. Corleon sat at the table with me and watched me every day for a week before he decided to ask what the fuck was wrong with me.

"You hate looking at people in the eyes, huh?" he broke the silence between us as I cut into my chicken breast and peered up at him for five seconds before returning back to my food.

I counted.

He respected my silence before I decided to speak to him. "I don't like when people stare at me."

“Or touch you,” he noted.

“Yeah.”

“We can sit in silence, and you don’t have to worry about me touching you... shit weird anyway.”

I looked up at him and smirked as he continued on eating his school lunch and I continued with mine.

Corleon was heavily into technology. Loved the shit and would be a computer if that was an option when he was born. Our friendship was organic, he was patient with me and never pushed me. He understood that I moved differently, and that I wasn’t like everyone else. He became my right hand in everything.

Core was like a second brother. His loyalty to me and my family was something that I could never overlook. He didn’t give a fuck what the last name Eaton meant; he was just there because of who I was.

Maverick.

In high school, I was picked up from school early by my uncle’s driver and brought to his mansion. I hardly ever spent time with my uncle because he was always so busy, and truthfully, I never really liked his ass.

He treated his younger brother, my father, like he was his flunky because he was the first born, the heir to the Eaton throne. When my grandfather passed away, my uncle stepped into his role and ran everything the Eaton’s touched how he wanted.

Our family was powerful, and one of the founding families on Staten Island – the oldest founding family. We had our hands into everything, and it was my father who decided to step into his own.

His older brother had been given everything, and he was often overlooked. He had this beautiful family, wife, and nothing ever seemed good enough for my old ass grandfather. Nash was his star, and my father was the spare that he really didn’t even want. I always watched how my grandfather and my uncle treated my father.

They acted like he was a stranger trying to mooch off the family’s name. As if he wasn’t good enough to reap the benefits of what had been built. It was my father who decided to start Case House.

My uncle nor my grandfather wanted anything to do with his pipe dream, as they called it. I watched my father do all the leg work and grind it out knowing he had something to prove. He named it Case House, short for my mother’s maiden name - Caselli.

As much as he loved his last name and knew how powerful it was, he wanted to do something without using the Eaton name, and he did. It didn't happen overnight, but Case House had got a reputation for having some of the best pussy in the city. He was making so much money that he didn't need that Eaton money.

His connections were no longer from his brother, they were his own. Shit, he even started walking like he was that nigga, no longer having to play second because Bash Eaton was doing shit on his own without using his family's name.

The day that I was driven to my uncle's estate and sat down in his office, he told me that my father and mother had been killed. Someone came into our home and shot them while they slept. Shit never sat right with me because my mom was an early bird who was up before any of us. She saw me off to school earlier that morning.

Just because she was a kept woman, didn't mean she sat around eating donuts while painting her nails. She was always on the go, doing what needed to be done around the house or anything to make the family's life easier.

My pops wasn't even in town, so how the fuck did someone murder them in our home? I had a man that I was supposed to trust, a man that was the head of our family and I didn't trust him. Something in my stomach told me shit was off, and when I questioned him, he couldn't get his story straight.

The shit never felt right to me.

We stood in front of our parents' caskets holding hands. Landon was only four, Zoya was seven, and Kora was fourteen. Everyone always promised to take care of the kids when someone passed. The promises of keeping the kids together and being there for them were all lies. I heard so many people crying and promising that they would step up, and they never did.

Nash Eaton never stepped up in the way that I thought he would have. We were moved out of our family home and into a single-family home that he bought for us. He hired an au pair that lived in with us, along with her daughter.

Jeffie.

Nash didn't give a damn about the woman having a daughter or having her move in with us. Long as he didn't have to waste time out his day to

care for his deceased brother's kids, he didn't care. Angelica was heaven on earth, and everything that we needed because our parents were gone. She was tough as shit, but she had this soft side that came out whenever I needed it.

It was because of her that I had been diagnosed with ADHD and OCD. She kept telling me that I was special and there was something that she couldn't quite put her finger on and had me get tested. Aside from being diagnosed with ADHD and OCD, the doctors just said my brain was wired differently. It made a lot of sense because I always knew I was different, and the way I did stuff wasn't shit that other kids my age even cared about. Things had to go a certain way, and if they didn't, I felt like my entire world was ending. I hated that I felt like this and wished like hell that I could change the shit. After my parents were murdered my obsessive-compulsive disorder became worse. The shit didn't only fuck with me, it messed with my siblings as well.

Angelica never tried to change me, though. She recognized what I needed and made sure that I had those things to keep my head on straight. A red beet smoothie every morning, my favorite Coldplay song had to play while I worked out. Breakfast was always hard-boiled eggs and toast, and if I was really feeling different, I might have a salad.

Jeffie grew up watching her mother do everything to make my life normal, and she naturally picked up on it, and took on *taking care of me* – let her tell it.

I witnessed Angelica putting her life on hold because of me and my siblings. She had her whole life out there that she should have been living, and she stuck around because of us. Soon as I turned eighteen, I made sure I got full guardianship of my brother and sisters and stepped up to raise them. Nash barely did his part and money was decent, never enough to raise three children and put them in private school like he did for his kids. I had to figure out what to do *without* the Eaton money.

My cousins, his children, were distant as fuck. You would have thought we were stepchildren, and not his brother's biological children with the way they treated us. Corleon was right there along with his mother helping me when it came to raising three siblings.

He was right there helping me with homework and when Zoya went through her rebellious stage. Girl always wanted to be in the hood when I was trying to keep her from it. Kora always listened, always doing what

was right and following my plan. My uncle was powerful because of that name, and I wanted to make sure that we were powerful because of our abilities *and* name.

The root to evil was that Eaton money, and it had my uncle around the neck choking him out. I refused to ever beg another nigga for anything, and I didn't care if we shared the same name as each other. My parents were gone, and my siblings were all I had left, so I went out there to do what needed to be done to provide for them.

Give them a fair advantage and to make sure they could fulfill the roles that I had for them. They would hate me for it but thank me when they were in rooms because of their abilities and not their names. Seeing their faces was all I needed to make sure we never had to ask a nigga for shit. I never wanted them to ever have to ask anyone for anything. I would provide for us, stepping into my father's shoes.

Raising them wasn't easy and it came with more damage to our relationships than anything. However, I did what I had to do to make sure they were good. I can't say that I would ever change things because then they wouldn't be where they were now. I'd be the bad guy and wear the scars if that meant they could have the life that wasn't given to me.

That was taken from me.

Before he was murdered, I got a call from my father's best friend. He called me from an overseas number and told me a lot of shit that connected a lot of pieces that never made sense to me when I was younger. My uncle wanted Case House. He wanted it because it had grown bigger than he ever expected, and my father wasn't willing to part with it. He built that shit brick by brick even when no one believed in him.

It was Nash Eaton who ordered the hit on my parents, so he could take over Case House. As if he didn't have enough. He had to take my parents away from me because of greed. His access to money and pull was so large that he didn't need Case House.

He wanted it.

My father's best friend was murdered shortly after, and I knew it was Nash. It was clear that he wanted to make sure that anybody who knew something was wiped away. I noticed after my father's friend was killed; he started coming around more.

He wanted to know if I knew something.

Years had passed since my parents were murdered. Had I not received that call, my uncle showing up more wouldn't have made sense. He was tossing around money and things that would have been helpful years ago. I had already put two sisters through college and law school and was putting a brother through college. Where the fuck was his ass when I needed him?

When we needed him.

I played my part, pretending like I was so excited to have my uncle around. Nash Eaton may have been smart but I was smarter and played my role the way that I needed to play it. Doing what I wanted meant that I had to step to the other founding members and get their approval, which wouldn't be easy.

It was me asking them to kill the head of the third family, something that wasn't a light thing to ask and was risky even putting my neck out there and asking the shit. I remember going in there with Core right by my side and laying everything out in front of them.

That bitch had my parents killed because he wanted something that he had no rights to. A business that he never wanted anything to do with. Nash was used to getting everything he wanted. He had never been told no before and that was what fucked him up.

His younger brother – the spare – telling him no didn't sit right with him. When he took him away from us, he never considered his nieces and nephews. He didn't give a fuck that we would be in this world without our parents.

There were technically four founding families, however, the Vanducci-Cromwell's were always counted as one because of their close ties to each other. The heads of the Vanducci, Cromwell, and Davis families sat at the table and stared me down as I told them everything. They all sat at that table reading me, taking in my body language and seeing if I understood what I was asking them.

With a deal that I had to fulfill on my end, they gave me the blessings to do my uncle in, and I did just that. Taking my uncle out wasn't as easy since he had children, and they would step into his role if he was murdered.

With the way my cousins acted with me and my siblings, like they were better than us, as if we didn't deserve to have the Eaton name, I had fun making sure they were no longer with us. Ego was something that would be a man's biggest downfall.

Nash was all too excited to have his nephew groveling at his feet, wanting to learn the family business. It turned his freaky ass on to know that his brother's son needed him.

I admit, the shit tasted like poison.

For my family, I would make sure that we were good, so I did what I had to do. Getting close to my uncle was easier than I thought. So easy that he didn't see it when I played Russian roulette with his children and wife in front of him before turning the gun on him.

I smiled, as my chest heaved up and down with blood across my face. Core was right there to hold a towel for me, so I could quickly wipe the blood from myself.

"You did it... you good... Maverick Eaton runs shit now."

I remember turning to look at him. "The Eatons are gone... the Caselli's are here. Menace Caselli runs shit now." I got rid of any trace of my father's name, and we took on my mother's maiden name.

I was Menace Caselli, and I owned Case House along with everything that the Eaton's used to own, and the lawyer that I sat down with after the funeral made sure of that.

Stevie



“STEVIE!” I HEARD ESTELLA BURST THROUGH THE DOOR WITH SO MUCH energy.

So much for her being tired and wanting to take a nap before dinner. Skyler came in with her backpack on one arm and her work bag in the other hand. I stuck my paint brush into my messy bun and bent down to kiss my favorite girl on her cheek.

“How was school today, Beautiful?”

She shoved her hand into her pocket and pulled out a crumbled-up sticker she had stashed in there all day waiting to show me “I was a good girl,” she told me, and I pinched her cheeks.

“That’s because you’re the best girl ever... go and take your bag from Mama and wash your hands, okay?”

Estella snatched the bag from her mother and took off down the short hallway to her room. I stood up and looked at my cousin and I could tell she was worn out. She crossed the living room, tossing her work bag onto the couch before plopping down beside it.

“Mercedes called me and told me that you paid your portion of the rent, and even next month, too.”

Mercedes, our land lady, was a motor mouth, so I wasn’t surprised she called Skyler and told her.

I whipped my paint brush back out of my hair and went back to perfecting my canvas. “Uh huh... no need to worry about next month for me.”

“Guess I’m wondering how you paid this month and next month’s rent. Then the random call about the passport.”

Without even turning to look, I knew Skyler was staring a hole into the back of my head. As I slowly turned, all her attention was on me. “I can’t ask a random question, Skyler? Priscilla helped me out with some money for doing a favor for her.”

Skyler adjusted herself on the couch. “I don’t like her, Stevie.”

I turned back around and continued painting. “You have voiced that opinion already. I don’t judge your friends.”

I chewed on the end of the paint brush, no longer in the mood to paint. I was a mood painter, and whenever I was in the mood I loved to pull a canvas out and create. It didn’t matter that I never finished a piece. With the way that this conversation was going I could feel the creativity slowly leaking out of me by the second.

“I don’t get a good vibe about her, and we promised we would be honest with each other about everything,” Skyler reminded me, as she often did.

Slumping my shoulders forward, I took a deep breath. “She’s my only friend that I have. You know how hard it is to make friends. I’m either too weird, or the girl that overshares... I just want to have a friend.”

It was easier making friends when you were a child. I bet Estella didn’t have problems finding friends to share her crayons with. When you became an adult, quality friendships were hard to come by. Every time I had a friend, it never lasted because something always happened. They either used me for whatever they wanted, or I found out they were talking bad about me.

I have to admit that I was the problem, too. When you were my friend, I went above and beyond. I wanted to be there for you, and I often overplayed my part for people who didn’t deserve it. I’ve always been the different girl who everyone talked about. I was made fun of because I wore glasses, and I was always thicker than the other children in my class.

When all the girls had straight hair, here I came with my big thick curls that covered my face. I never truly fit in as a child, and I really didn’t fit in as an adult. I liked different kinds of music, and I talked to myself at times. I enjoyed peculiar things, and I didn’t take myself seriously because life was too short for that.

“You have me, Stevie.”

My mother and Skyler's mother were both married to the Raye brothers. Both my uncle and father weren't worth the skin they were in, and married women that were worth more than gold. Me and Stevie called it the Raye curse.

Both our mothers were gone while our ain't shit fathers were still sucking up the air. I knew it was bad to wish death on someone, especially your father, but I wished it could have been him instead of my mother, and I knew Skyler felt the same.

"I know that... I just want my own friends, too. You're my cousin and I know at times you put up with me because we're family."

"That is not true. You are one of my favorite people, Stevie. I do understand you wanting your own friends not tied to your little cousin. Please be careful with her, I don't trust her."

I messed with the end of the paint brush, rubbing paint onto my fingertips. "Nanny called me today."

Skyler rolled her eyes so far into her head that I thought they would get stuck. "What the hell does she want?"

Nanny was our grandmother from our father's side, and she was a wicked woman. It made a lot of sense why her sons were the way that they were. Since she was my grandmother, I tolerated her more than Skyler did. Skyler refused to have anything to do with her from the way she acted when her parents divorced.

"Her usual check in to make sure I spoke to my father... which I haven't, and I tell her that every time."

From the look on my cousin's face, I could tell she wanted to speak about anybody but our grandmother. "I understand that you have a closer relationship because you lived in the same city as her. Stevie, you don't have to deal with her because she's our grandmother. The way she acted like our mothers were the poison while her boys were the prized possession is enough for me to never speak to that bitch again."

My grandmother lived in Queens, so when I was growing up it was a quick train ride to visit her. I would spend weekends over her home when my parents had plans, or when she wanted to take me to a friend's party.

It didn't take away the fact that she showed me how much she hated my mother. My father could never do any wrong in her eyes. It was always my mother, and her ways – whatever that meant. Meanwhile my father could

never keep a job, and my mother not only had a degree, but she also had a career that took care of our home.

In my nanny's eyes she was a witch who trapped my father and took the life that he could have had. I think we were all trying to figure out what life that was because according to my mother, my father had never been shit.

He would clean his act up for a few months and then get back to the same mess that he was accustomed to. Even having a child didn't make that man change, so I couldn't understand why nanny was so upset with my mother.

If anything, we needed to be upset with her for having not one, but two men that weren't shit and were selfish.

"Has nothing to do with that. No matter how my mother felt about her, she always encouraged me to have a relationship with her. Plus, she's becoming older and needs things. My father is never around and your father lives out the state." I shrugged, hating how big my heart was at times.

My heart had always been big, and it was a gift and curse – mostly curse.

I could be stabbed and the person who stabbed me could trip, and while bleeding and dying, I would be worried about the person who just stabbed me tripping and hurting themselves. It was something that I needed to work on.

"The reason they have aids to help her old and bitter ass. She never has cared about our mothers or us... well, not me. Do you know she had the nerve to call me the day of my mother's funeral and say that hopefully she's a better person in heaven than she had been here on earth... the day of the funeral, Stevie."

I sighed. "She didn't bother to call or come to the funeral for mine."

"Which makes me think you're crazy for helping out the wicked bitch from Flushing."

I snorted. "Stop... we talk here and there, and I bring her groceries when I can. My father isn't around to help her, and she is our grandmother. Aren't you supposed to accept older people for who they are?"

"Yeah and also leave them where the fuck they have you fucked up at. I refuse to ever help that woman, and I hope you see how toxic she is."

"I hear you."

She stared at me for a second before Estella came running back into the living room. "Mama, I have to poo." She jumped from one foot to the next

while Skyler jumped up from the couch.

I was saved by the poo bell because I knew Skyler would continue to over analyze things. Even though Skyler was younger than me, she acted like she was the oldest between the both of us. Was she more mature than me?

Sure.

Did she make sure our budget was perfect so we could afford to eat and wouldn't be sitting in the dark?

Sure.

I lived with my head in the clouds while she was a realist and more grounded. While I liked to see the brighter things, Skyler was much more into seeing what was in front of her. We were complete opposites, but she was my person, and I was glad that I had her. Even though I knew I drove her ass crazy all the time.

Like when I started hanging out with Priscilla. She immediately told me that she didn't get the best vibe from her, and I waved her off because I had a friend that was mine. Skyler had her own life that was separate from mine, and I loved that for her.

All I wanted was my own friend that wasn't attached to my little cousin. I was twenty-eight and I didn't have any friends of my own or a life that I could be proud of. Dating was a joke because all men cared about was sex.

The minute I even mentioned that I was a virgin they all got this silly look in their eyes like they had struck gold. Even when I didn't tell them that I was a virgin, they all wanted the same thing. A mediocre dinner or lunch date, and then they were ready to pull your panties down and fuck.

Staying a virgin wasn't some lifelong quest that I had sought out to become. While my friends in high school were losing theirs and regretting it, I was being selective on who I allowed to get close to me. I didn't take my virginity lightly; it was something that should have been given to someone special.

I didn't want to look back and shutter when I thought about the person. At the very least, I wanted to smile at the memory, even if me and the person weren't together or speaking anymore. The quest of remaining a virgin continued on, and I just never paid it any thought because sex wasn't something important to me.

I saw what sex could do to a person and it put me off from ever wanting a man to get that side of me. I've been on plenty of dates, even dated men

for longer than a month, and none of them gave me that feeling I wanted to feel.

The feeling that the man I was about to connect souls with was my person. Someone that would protect and care about me. I got nothing with the men these days because they all behaved like horny teenagers.

Never wanting to court a girl and always wanting to just have sex before they moved onto their next victim.

As much as I loved my cousin, I saw what having sex had gotten her. I loved Estella beyond the stars and the moon; however, the man that came with Estella was the reason I was good on men. Skyler had to deal with a man that has never cared about his daughter, and now he wanted rights to the same daughter he never gave a shit about.

Men were gross and until God came down and put me in my future husband's arms, I was going to stay single *and* a virgin.



I HOVERED MY PHONE OVER MY CLIENT'S FRESH SET AND TOOK VIDEO FOR my social media pages. She was so in love with her nails that she couldn't stop smiling and praising me for my work. I took a few more pictures and videos before she paid the remaining balance, hugged me, and then she was out the door. She was my last client of the day, and everyone had already left for the night.

Cindy came from the back of the salon, sitting her purse in her chair before she sat in my chair. "Give me a quick manicure, nothing fancy like you're used to." She smiled.

I paused before grabbing my tools for a manicure. "You look tired, Cindy."

"Well, thanks. I think that is the polite way to say you look old and worn down." She let out her signature cackle.

It wasn't a good day if you didn't hear her cackling with her clients or teasing me or one of the other girls in the shop. "I don't think you could ever look old or worn down... even if you tried." I pushed back her cuticles.

“Some days I appreciate not looking like how I feel.” She sighed, as she allowed me to work on her nails.

Cindy had Lupus and some days were harder than others. Some days she would come in and she was on top of the world, and then others you could see the pain and how tired she was. It didn’t matter which kind of day it was, she always came in, ran her shop and loved on her clients. She had no clue how much she inspired me on the days when I didn’t want to climb out of bed.

“Are you taking care of yourself?” I asked her, already knowing the answer to her question. It was hard getting her to put herself first because this shop was her entire life and world. It was her legacy, and everyone who came through the door knew how important she was to the neighborhood.

“As best as I ca—”

My phone interrupted our conversation. I saw the name, quickly slid my finger across the screen and placed it on speaker. “Hey Priscilla, what’s going on?”

“I’m about to wire some money into your account... keep two thousand and send the rest to me.”

“Um, okay... thanks.”

“Don’t mention it. Also, were you able to figure out your passport situation?” Priscilla questioned.

“I’m all good... I was reading the expiration date all wrong.” I snorted, as I continued to get into Cindy’s cuticles while she rested her eyes.

Priscilla laughed. “I swear you are so goofy at times. Whenever you have time, send me over the information so I can book our flights.”

I became excited at the thought of going on a vacation and not having to worry about anything. It had been so long since I was able to let my hair down and just exist without work, bills, or worrying about my mother being gone.

“Will do... thanks again for this,” I smiled at the phone, as if she could see me.

The extra money was helping me pull my life together. I was able to order nail supplies since I was running low and have some extra play money which was always rare. All of my money went to paying my bills, so I never had enough to do anything that I wanted.

Having the option of taking an Uber or the bus home was a luxury that had never been afforded to me. I hated to ask my cousin for money because

she was a single mom. I was her older cousin, and it looked pretty ridiculous asking to borrow money when she was making do while having another mouth to feed.

“Don’t even mention it. I’m excited to hang out and really get away from everything.” She groaned into the phone. “Girl, this that nigga right now... I’ll call you later.” Priscilla quickly ended the call before I could speak.

Cindy looked at me, then looked away. “What is that look about? You give it every time she comes into the shop to get her nails done.”

“That girl is bad news, Stevie. I know you love to see the good in everyone, but she doesn’t mean you any good. I get a bad feeling about her.” Cindy pretended like she got the chills.

“You and Skyler need to let me have my own life. The girl hasn’t done anything except help me out without me ever asking.”

Cindy kissed her teeth as she focused on what I was doing to her nails. “I know women like her, and it never ends up good. Those are the kind of women that use you until they can’t anymore. I’ve been friends with a few women just like that girl... just rotten.”

As much as I appreciated Skyler and Cindy, I needed them to leave me alone. I was an adult, and though at times I struggled with remembering that myself, I was free to make my own choices on who I wanted in my life.

Priscilla was the kind of woman that men tossed themselves at and bought her whatever she wanted. She never had to do much because there was always a man right behind her ready to smell her dirty draws.

I wasn’t like that in the least, and men actually scared me at times. Priscilla knew how to handle and talk to men, while I was naturally shy. I was an introvert and most times I lived in my own head and found comfort there.

I avoided my neighbor for three months because I didn’t want to strike up a conversation. Once I was comfortable with you then that’s when my weirdness came out of every pore of my body.

Whenever we went out for drinks, it was always Priscilla who did all the talking. We almost always got free drinks because the minute she sat at the bar she tossed on that charm. It was a charm that I wished I had at times.

One where I didn’t get so tongue tied and nervous whenever a man paid me any kind of attention. It wasn’t that I was insecure, because I loved how I looked, and I never wanted to be anyone else.

I often wished that I had the confidence to say what I mean and mean what I say. The confidence to catch the eye of *that* guy.



CORNELL WAS FRIENDS WITH THE RAPPER ZAY'S COUSIN, AND HE HAPPENED to be in town. He was currently on tour with Zay, the rapper's entourage, and I thought that was so cool.

I had never met a celebrity before.

Well, Cornell wasn't the celebrity, but Zay was, so when he asked me to come out tonight, I washed the paint out my hair and pulled myself together. It wasn't often that I went on dates or was asked on them.

It wasn't that I was unattractive, either. I was the kind of girl who stumbled on her words or would make a dark joke where they wouldn't know how to respond. I watched Anime, loved to paint, and constantly talked to myself, and even answered myself.

Mom always would joke that it wasn't a problem that I spoke to myself, the problem occurred when I started to answer myself. Well, mom, the minute you were lowered into the ground I started to answer myself.

Men didn't come knocking down my door to ask me on a date. Whenever they did, it was because they were so infatuated with my shape, and didn't care about anything else.

As a midsize girl, I was pear shaped, and it was something that I hated whenever I was in school. Always wearing baggy sweatshirts and pants, never embracing my curves.

The boys in school didn't make it any better. On the rare occasion I was spotted with my gym uniform on, they would whistle, and holler, "*Damn nerd, where the hell did you get that ass?*"

It made me uncomfortable, so I layered even more clothes on. In twelfth grade, I was dating Tony Moore, and I thought I was in love. If you asked me, I just knew we would be married with children.

He was my first boyfriend, and the first boy that had ever showed me some kindness. Tony didn't want anything in return, only my time and

attention. We spent every day together, either at my apartment or at the library.

It was raining one afternoon, and I had lost my keys. My mom worked in the city, so it was going to take her some time to make it home, and Tony offered to take me back to his place so I didn't have to wait in a library.

He was always so caring and considerate that way, so we took the train to his house. I remember being so excited because I was finally going to my boyfriend's house. This counted as a new step in our relationship, and I had been counting all the steps we took within the relationship.

Tony's parents weren't home, and we had his room to ourselves. We shook off the wet coats and boots and got comfortable in his room. He went to grab us some snacks, while I cracked open my textbook to study for our English final we had the next morning.

He came back with snacks and soda for us, closing his room back. I thought nothing of it because this was Tony, my boyfriend. The boy who had been nothing but kind to me for months. I had no reason to think anything of him closing the door because we were studying and having snacks.

Tony started out on his computer chair, and then he moved toward the bed. We started making out, something we've done plenty of times. His hands would roam my body, and I never minded.

It made me feel good.

He continued to kiss me while his hands went up my skirt, and I removed his hand. His hand was right on the edge of my panties, and I wasn't ready for that. I remember him sucking his teeth and becoming irritated while pushing my hand on his dick, showing me that I got him all worked up.

The knock at the door saved me, or so I thought. His older brother popped his head in and smiled when he saw me. He, too, closed the door behind him and my chest was slamming against the inside of my chest. Why were they staring at me like rabid dogs wanting to rip me apart?

Tony and his brother sexually assaulted me that afternoon. Had it not been for their mother coming home and singing their names, it would have gone further. What made things worse is when his mother found me in the room with him and his brother, she treated me like a whore.

Told me that I shouldn't have been anywhere with two boys. Acted like her boys were innocent angels and I was the harlot that tried to take

advantage of them, when they took advantage of me.

Tony held me down while his brother rubbed between my legs and licked my nipples. I had tears in my eyes, my eyes were red, and my clothes were disheveled, and she blamed me and put me out of their house.

I remember riding the train home feeling so violated and sad. My mom knew something was wrong with me, still, I never told her what was wrong. The next day Tony roped his arm around me while I headed to second period and told me that if I told anybody what happened, I would look like the fat whore, and he would tell everyone that I fucked him and his brother at the same time.

It was already hard being the Black girl who wasn't Black enough because I was different. Then, I was too Black for the White girls. Hell, even the Asians, though a few, didn't even want to hang with me.

I spent the majority of my time trying to blend in so I could graduate and never look back at high school again. Since then, I never spoke about what happened to anyone except Priscilla. I protected my heart and my virginity like it was a blood diamond. In my eyes, men sucked, and no one deserved to have me in that way.

"You excited to meet Zay?"

Cornell's voice brought me back to reality. "Yes... I love his music."

He nodded his head, and his hand found its way onto my lap.

It's alright, Stevie. It's a hand on the lap, relax, I reminded myself as I continued to enjoy the ride to the arena.

"My sister and her friends got a suite, so we gonna hang with them for a bit, and then we're going to see about going backstage."

I wanted to correct his *see*, because last we spoke, he said we were going to be backstage. Zay was one of my favorite rappers, and I wanted to meet him.

He was so humble and talented that it didn't make sense how much of God's favorite he was. On top of being humbled, and talented, he was fine. My mom always said it was dangerous when a man knew he was fine, too. Zay knew he was fine.

"Sounds great."

He smiled at me, and I continued to enjoy the ride while anticipating meeting his sister and her friends. Women, even grown women, could be so catty and still hold onto that mean girl behavior.

It was harder meeting friends as an adult than a child. At least you had crayons and your favorite cartoon to bond over. As an adult, making friends was hard, and made you want to be alone forever.

The minute I mentioned I watched Anime, or made a reference to it, they gave that signature awkward eye roll and politely dismissed me. It was the reason that me and Priscilla became friends.

She didn't treat me like that. Sure, she said I was different, but she also said she liked it because people often got boring, and I brought some fun into her life.

We went through the back entrance of the arena and through security. Bypassing all the suites, I had the urge to pop my head into one suite when I saw Berkeley talking to a man.

I loved her celebrity vlog and kept up with it often. She was talented because one second, she could report on celebrity news, then the next she was into politics, and then world news. Her pen was multifaceted, and it was amazing. She captured the news in a way that made you care about it, especially when most people hated to read the boring stuff within the media. Not since everything happened with Vincent Morgan, the man that was running for mayor.

"Sasha, what up?" Cornell said as we entered the suite.

A short light skin woman turned around and smiled, rushing into Cornell's arms. "I didn't think you would come... you know since you traveling the world with Zay."

"I make time for you anytime." He kissed her cheek, and she looked over at me with a warm smile. "This is my friend, Stevie."

She extended her hand. "Hey Stevie, help yourself to anything you want... the show is about to start soon."

"Nice to meet you, Sasha. Thanks so much," I bit the inside of my cheek, hoping I didn't sound too corny.

She smiled. "No problem... Cornell, you think you can get us backstage?" Sasha stared at her brother hopeful, and I wanted to tell her good luck.

This nigga was talking about *hopefully*, so I put my dreams of telling Zay I wanted to have his babies to the side.

It was clear Cornell didn't have as much pull as he liked to pretend. He had to call Zay's cousin, his best friend, to allow us through security in the back.

Then the suite he was trying to front with wasn't even his. It was his sister and her friends. "Hey Nell," I turned and saw Berkeley.

"Hey Berks, what's good with you?"

I looked between them and got this feeling that they had mattress tangoed before. It was the way she looked at him with this flirtatious look in her eyes, and how he kept licking his lips while taking her in.

"Hi, I'm Stevie... I'm a fan of your work."

Berkeley noticed that I was there for the first time since she greeted Nell. "Hey Stevie, thanks so much... are you and Nell...dating?"

"We're friends," he quickly corrected her.

Ouch.

"Oh, you guys look super cute together... are you hanging in our suite for the show?"

Cornell nodded his head. "Yeah."

"Oh, cool... make sure you stop being a stranger, Nell." She patted his shoulder and then walked over toward where her girls were.

There was part of me that felt like I had no reason to feel any way. Cornell wasn't my boyfriend, and he was free to mess around with anybody he wanted.

"You hungry?" He finally snapped out of watching her ass in the black dress she wore.

"I can use a drink," I muttered while hugging myself.

It felt like I was interrupting something, and I didn't like that. The least he could have done was pretended he didn't want to fuck this girl in my face. I watched as he went to go get us a drink, and I went and sat down.

The show was starting, and everyone was out their seat cheering and rapping along with the words to his song.

"Started out with nothing but a dream and a plan, hustling every corner just to make some bread. From ramen in the kitchen to steak on my plate."

I bopped my head to the music while rapping along with Zay. All the women in the suite were on their feet shaking their asses, making videos for their social media. Sasha and her friends started to take shots while they had these ring lights on the top of their phones to get the perfect lighting.

Cornell was on his phone texting someone, and from the way he was aggressively texting, it couldn't have been a good conversation. He let out a low huff, and then tuned into the show, not truly paying attention to it.

He had probably seen the show dozens of times since he was on tour with the man. His phone pinged and he quickly replied before shoving his phone into his pocket.

“Come on, Stevie, we out.” He stood up, and his sister turned to see him getting ready to leave.

“Where you going?”

“I got some shit to handle, and need to bounce,” he vaguely told her.

The show was good, and I wanted to tell him to leave me behind and handle his business. This was a date, so the proper thing to do was to leave, although I *really really* didn’t want to.

“Is everything alright?” I asked, as he held my hand, and we walked down the hallway.

We left the same way we came, and Cornell still hadn’t told me why we had to leave. I sat in the front seat as he whipped out the arena and headed down a few streets before he pulled down a random block and parked.

“I really like you, Stevie... you different from other chicks I fuck with.”

Why did he think that was a compliment? Why did men always think saying things like that was a compliment? Yes, I enjoyed being different now, though it was something I didn’t always enjoy. However, why did he think because he thought I was different it was a compliment or a prize?

“Um, thanks.”

I couldn’t return the compliment because I had dated men like Cornell before. Men who thought they were the bees’ knees, and it was a blessing for me to even be in their presence. It was like all I attracted and instead of running the opposite direction, I always ran right toward them, then cried when it didn’t work out.

“You know you the wifey type right?”

I held back the urge to gag because the word *wifey* irritated me in more ways than one. It was a word made so men could validate women wanting to be wives without actually committing and using the actual word *wife*.

There were so many people walking around calling their girlfriend *wifey* because it sounded good and made her feel better. I despised the word, and hearing Cornell use it like it was an honor irritated me.

“How do you even know that?” Cornell was just talking a bunch of mess to make it sound good.

Meanwhile, I was worried about the concert that we had left. The only reason I continued the useless conversations with him was because of the

promise that he would take me to this concert.

"I have a good feeling about my future wife." His hand reached across and landed on my thigh.

He smoothly rubbed my thighs, and I put my hand on top of his, repulsed. I wasn't afraid to admit that I was scared of men. Ever since Tony and his brother, the trauma and guilt had followed me throughout the years. It's the reason I could never give myself to someone.

There was no one that ever made me feel safe enough to want to lose my virginity. "You're sweet. Why did we leave the concert?"

I continued to hold his hand while he continued trying to rub further up my thigh. "Why we talking about that when I got you to myself... that's what I wanted." He leaned over and tried to kiss me, and I moved my face, so it landed on my collarbone.

"Why you being like that, Steve."

"It's Stevie," I corrected.

He kissed my neck, and my skin felt like it was going to crawl away. "We can go back to my place, and I can show you how much I want you to be my wife... look at my dick, look at what you doing to me."

"I'm not sleeping with you, Cornell," I told him out right. There was no need to beat around the bush, kiss, and imply that something more would happen.

That was the mistake I made with Tony years ago. I should have left the minute we went from kissing to him feeling me up. I blamed myself for not removing myself from the situation as they took advantage of me.

"Why you fronting with me, Steve."

"Stevie!" I firmly corrected.

He chuckled and kissed my cheek. "Sorry, baby... you look so good tonight. You so fucking thick it makes me hard looking at you."

All of these words were a turn off because he was trying to have me in the front seat of his car, a rental, and on a random street in Brooklyn.

"Take me home, Cornell."

"Why the fuck you always fronting on me, Stevie? Every time we've been around each other, you act like you don't want me?"

I scoffed. "I'm sorry that you think showing I want *a nigga* means that I have to take my clothes off and have sex with you."

"You like playing those petty ass fucking games." He lunged across the arm rest and grabbed my face, forcing his tongue down my throat, and I

squealed in his mouth as I hit him and pushed away from him.

He was stronger than me, so I fumbled around on the door handle until I was able to pull the handle, and I fell out of the car, breaking our kiss. Cornell looked at me crazy as I was between the sidewalk and the car.

“Get the fuck up out the street, Steve!” he hollered, and went to get out the car, and I scrambled onto the sidewalk with my heart in my chest.

“It’s fucking Rick James, Bitch... I mean, Stevie! I said no, and you wanted to take what wasn’t yours, fucking creep!”

“Bitch, you calling me a fucking rapist!” he hollered, as I scrambled down the street toward the subway.

Cornell was a creep and the fact that he forced me to kiss him and then would have continued to have his way with me was enough for me to get home on my own.

As I settled on the train home, I couldn’t help but feel overwhelmed. It wasn’t that I didn’t want love, I craved having actual love. I wanted someone to choose me and make me feel whole. I wanted to give myself to someone and know that I was theirs and they would protect me.

At this rate, I was convinced I would be single, a virgin, and a pending cat mom for the rest of my life.

Menace



“I CALLED AND DOUBLE CHECKED IF THE PASTA IS MADE FROM SCRATCH. You hate that boxed mess, and I would rather know before you try and throw somebody through the window,” Jeffie informed me, never looking up from her iPad.

I pulled my eyes away from the window, wondering if she slept with that damn iPad. It was never away from her. Whenever you saw Jeffie, just know you saw that iPad right with her.

Duke, my armed guard and driver, looked into the rearview and nodded before he got out. In the back of my Rezvani Vengeance, I was untouchable. It wasn’t only bullet proof; the shit had a military armored package on it.

I’ve always known the Eaton name was powerful, and the amount of power my wicked ass uncle had was something I probably would never understand unless I was in his position. I was now in his position, and I realized that our family had our hands into everything.

That Eaton name made the entire world rotate, and when I took over, I held that power in my hands, and now the Caselli name made the world go ‘round. I couldn’t move like I used to, and I had to be ten times smarter because there were men who wanted my position.

Weirdos probably woke up thinking of the day that they could take out Menace Caselli. If I learned one thing about my uncle, it was to trust no one. That was easy for me because I was naturally fucking paranoid, which is why I stayed to myself.

Here I was wiping my uncle out because of the fuck shit he did to my parents, only to step into a role where there were men out there in the world

that wanted to kill me. They would never admit it, and they would shake hands with me and make deals while seething on the inside. Added with the fact that I knew every government official's dirty secrets. I wasn't foolish enough to think because they spent money with me that they wouldn't snake me.

You see how the fuck they did Malcolm X, and the founder of the Black Panthers. When it came to those bitches, they liked to hold shit over *your* head, not the other way around.

To make sure nobody decided to start feeling themselves, I had security with me at all times, and I drove around in this fucking tank. Duke knocked on the back window and Jeffie looked at me, as she checked her gun in her purse, and I leaned forward, and grabbed mine from the divider between us.

Hopping out, I put my gun in the back of my sweats, rounded the truck and went into the restaurant. There were thousands of restaurants within the city, however, this one was a special one. Any time I came to this restaurant meant I was meeting with the other founding families of Staten Island.

I made sure Jeffie was in front of me as she pulled her purse onto her arm, and Duke watched my back as we entered the restaurant. "What do you think this meeting is for? They don't ever call a meeting randomly like this... you nervous?" she whispered as we entered the restaurant.

"The fuck I need to be nervous for... those niggas breathe the same as I do." I looked around the dark restaurant with ambient lighting.

I usually hated coming here because you could barely see your food or the menu. They were so busy trying to create the ambiance that I was going blind trying to read the menu or examine my food.

Jeffie shook her head. "Aside from Karter, you are the youngest at the table. You should be at least a little worried about this meeting."

I wasn't nervous because I always played my part. The Caselli family didn't make any noise unless noise needed to be made. We were quiet, and not too many people knew about us unless they were about to be dealt with. I ran shit peaceful and never made much noise because I didn't have to.

The Eaton name was loud while the Caselli name was quiet. "You worry too much."

She snorted. "My job is to worry about you, Maverick."

Jeffie knew I hated whenever someone called me by my government name, and she was one of the only people that honor was extended to. Jeffie was my family, and at times I liked to call her my savior. She knew me

better than anybody, and she often pulled me in when I felt myself slipping away. Aside from Corleon, she was someone who knew everything about me.

Even if Jeffie told me tomorrow she couldn't work for me, she would always be taken care of. She had a loyalty that you didn't find anywhere else in the world, and for the Caselli's that meant everything.

Loyalty wasn't something that was always extended to us.

From Kora to Zoya to Landon, she had a relationship with each of us. I knew we drove her ass crazy at times, too. We all had grown up together, and there was a bond between all of us that couldn't be broken.

"You need to focus on your own life, too, feel me?"

She cut her eyes at me as we continued toward the back of the restaurant. "We both need to focus on our own lives. Kora, Zoya, and Landon are grown, and you need to worry about your own now."

Waiters pulled the curtains back, and we entered the room with a dining table. Awaiting at the table was Ghost, Rahmeek, and Karter.

"Meeting in the middle of the day... dramatic much?" I stood at the top of the table, knowing that none of them would move to dap me up.

I was particular about people touching me. It took nearly five years for me and Corleon to embrace. They all understood and respected that it was love and nothing personal.

"You're a busy man, Menace... plus, I got some other shit coming up, so this needed to be done now." Ghost was the first one to speak.

"Who the fuck died?" I asked, as I slumped down in the chair on the other side of the table. Jeffie made her rounds hugging each man, as they asked how she was doing.

After her little greeting parade, she finally sat her ass down beside me and pulled her iPad out to work, which is what she usually did at these meetings.

In between eating, she would work while we hashed out whatever the meeting was being called for. Today, she wasn't so into her iPad because she wanted to know why the fuck we were here in the middle of the day.

"Your family's role within the three families." Rahmeek cleared his throat, cutting into his bleeding ass steak.

"Beating around the bush hasn't been something we've ever done, so why we about to start now?" I questioned, sitting up in the chair, snatching the menu from the waiter.

I always knew what I wanted before I came to a restaurant. Even though I didn't eat out much and had a chef at home that would prepare me whatever I wanted. I couldn't focus on the menu because I wanted to know the true reason for this meeting and why the fuck they wanted to talk about the Caselli's role within the three families.

"You right." Ghost cleared his throat, taking back his drink before looking at me. "When you came to us about the problem you had with your uncle, we gave you the approval to proceed and take his role within the three families."

"And for that you always have my respect and loyalty. There's nothing that you can't ask for when it comes to me... have I not been loyal to each of you niggas?"

Karter nodded. "You already know."

Rahmeek finished chewing his food before he spoke. "You have. However, you're a man that always holds up his end of the bargain, and you haven't."

"The fuck is he talking about, Ghost?" I turned my attention to Ghost who sat at the head of the table looking between me and Rahmeek.

"You've been able to step into your uncle's role, even changing the family's name. The one thing we asked was that you take on a wife and produce an heir... which you haven't done."

"Fuck," I grumbled under my breath.

"Yeah, fuck," Karter mocked, clearly tickled that it wasn't him up on the chopping block this meeting.

"You wiped your family out, Menace... while I respect and support your reasons, because my daughter, Skye, was impacted by the sick shit that your uncle has done... you gave your word and now it's time for you to stand on it. You need an heir and a wife... I don't care the order."

"His ass needs a wife... someone to calm his ass down. Free is my voice of reason, the calm within my storm."

Rahmeek took back his drink and nodded his head. "Giovanna is the same to me. As much as I handle business, she's always that voice of reason and has been that for years. Every strong man has a smart woman beside him."

I looked at Karter who nodded his head in agreement. "Star is my life... couldn't do what I do without her. As much as we never agree with these

old heads, I have to side with them this time, Mens. I'm able to run Kew because of my wife."

"I agree," Jeffie added, and I nearly snapped my neck turning to look at her traitor ass. She was acting like my name wasn't on those deposits that went into that account. "Sorry, Mav... you do need a wife. You have to start worrying about putting down some roots of your own."

Ghost smiled at Jeffie. "Listen to my girl. She has kept you from going off the rails for years... she knows a thing or two."

I leaned back in my seat and looked at all of them. "This a meeting to talk shit about how Menace lives his life... why he don't got a bitch."

"Not a bitch... a wife," Rahmeek corrected.

"And an heir... you have neither," Ghost reminded me. "We need to know if something happens to you, you have that heir who will step in for your family."

"Landon would step in."

"He's not an heir," Ghost countered.

"So? How many times has Staten stepped in for you at times?"

Ghost wiped his hands and sighed. "Steps in for me... not runs shit for me. I have a son who will step in."

"Same. Lennox will step in when it's time," Rahmeek added.

I looked at Karter. "Nigga, I got my heir... being that the Vanducci and Cromwells are roped into one family technically, I'm good." He polished off the rest of his drink. "They had the same talk with me... can't help you out, homie."

I rubbed my hands together and looked at them becoming anxious and annoyed at the same time. This wasn't the conversation that I thought I would be having today. We could have discussed any damn thing, not this.

"The fuck y'all want me to do? Find some random bitch off the street and make a child with her?"

"How the fuck else you think kids are made? You got to actually touch a woman, Mens." Ghost laughed.

Even Jeffie's messy ass snickered while pretending to look at her phone. "Getting pussy is never the problem... these bitches," I shuttered.

"Kim is not that bad, Mav... you are way too hard on her. She's not perfect, no woman is perfect. You're never going to find the perfect woman." Jeffie gave me the same speech that she seemed to have programmed in her brain.

“Kids are fucking dirty.... Landon was the worst growing up. Nigga liked to play in the dirt...willingly,” I expressed.

Ghost and Rahmeek both laughed. “You made us a deal... we came through on our end... you need to come through on yours. I would hate to cut you out that import deal that we have with the Delgatos and Infernos... you not hurting for money, but the money we’ll make from that deal...” Ghost whistled.

I don’t know why they didn’t just have me meet them at a gas station. They had us meet at this restaurant and I didn’t have a fucking appetite because my mind was in overdrive. The thought of finding a woman to share my space with and produce a child with sounded like fucking torture. They should have just whooped my ass and tossed me in a cage.

Scooting my ass across hot coal sounded more pleasing than having to be nice to some bitch that I didn’t want, just to produce a child and give her my last name.

A child that was full of fucking germs and coming from the mama who was a germ. The shit had my chest tight just thinking about it. “Mens, you alright?” Jeffie had the nerve to ask.

She looked at me picking the skin on my thumb, and I stopped and focused my attention back to the three dick wads who decided to ruin my life this afternoon. “Yeah.”

“Kim isn’t that bad, and she would make a good wife for you.”

I looked at Jeffie like she had spit in my face. “Wow, now I have to tell Corleon that you doing that shit now... why put me in that awkward situation, Jeff?”

She rolled her eyes. “Kim is very nice, and she actually put up with you... came when you called. I would say she would make a great wife and mother.”

“And I would say sleeping with dolphins is also safe, Jeffie.”

Ghost chuckled. “My daughters swam with dolphins... they had a ball.”

“And I should call CPS on you and Free.” I pointed across the table, snatching my phone up because I was ready to go.

“Mens don’t risk being put out of this deal... get married and produce an heir... or step away as the third family,” I heard one of them call behind me.

My name was powerful, and I had connections all over the world. I had the world at my fingertips so the threat of not being the third founding

family of Staten Island shouldn't have meant shit.

Except, it meant everything.

In a time when everything was so murky, Ghost and Rahmeek trusted my word and took me under their wing. As everything was being turned over to me, and our name was being switched, it was them who was there to help me keep my head in order.

As much as I couldn't wait for the day to end my uncle, it wasn't as easy wiping out my family. It was something that kept me up some nights. All of them deserved hell, but it was different when you had to be the person sending them there.

Stepping back as the third founding family meant losing that connection. That sense of family that we had built. We weren't the closest, and I didn't spend holidays with them. Still, I knew when I picked up that phone and needed a favor, they didn't hesitate to come through for me. If I couldn't be there for one of my siblings, I knew without a doubt that the Davis and Vanducci-Cromwell's would step in and take them under their wing. That was what the founding families offered each other.

Loyalty.

Security.

It wasn't some shit that could be bought or spoken about, these men had stepped up and showed me that they would be on the front lines, and I have done the same for them.

"And allow the fucking Amante family to step into my position? I killed for this shit... deserve to be in this position."

Rahmeek nodded in a proud father type of way. "Then do what needs to be done...that import deal is too big for you to step away from. I don't care how many billions you have."

I turned to leave as Jeffie went to say her goodbyes, and I pulled my phone out. Don's ass had called me hella times like I was his bitch or something. I picked up the phone and hit his name and listened to the call connect.

"Yo, we got a problem."

"Meet me at my crib," I replied and ended the call.

It was always *we had a fucking problem*, and never *Menace we got you a gift for being great*.

Jeffie caught up to me, and I made sure she was in front of me as I held the door open for her, then walked around and hopped in the back. "Take

me to the crib, D.”

“Got it, boss.”

I pulled my phone out my pocket as I scrolled all the Case House requests while picking with my skin. “Stop doing that... we’ll figure it out.”

“I don’t remember him saying you had to marry some bitch and get her pregnant.”

Jeffie snorted as she laughed. “We don’t need to focus on that right this second... I think the guys just want to see some progress that it is happening. They don’t expect you to fall in love, get married and have an heir all at the same time.”

I denied a request for one of our Case House girls and then closed out the app, putting my head back to enjoy the rest of the ride back to my house. It was rare that I left my house for anything.

My crib was designed so I never had to leave that bitch. The only time I left the crib was to leave the country, and that was to make money. I spent most of my time alone, aside from when Jeffie was around.

How the fuck was I supposed to open my heart and allow someone in? Shit sounded impossible. Kim was good because she knew how to open her mouth to suck dick, and her legs to take it. After that, I usually sent her on the way because she got on my nerves.

Whenever I was around Kim, I felt overstimulated. From how much perfume she used to her nails clacking on her phone when she would send a text message. Not to mention the bitch kept the typing sound on her phone.

Every time she came around me, I always weighed my options on how bad it would be if I killed her. Shit, it wasn’t like she was useful for shit anyway. Bitch was always doing shit to fucking get me mad.

We been distant since I threw her out the villa in Monaco and accused her of fucking dogs – which I still had a suspicion of.

There wasn’t the right woman out there for me. My own siblings barely wanted to be around me, so how was there a woman out there for me when my blood barely came around. I mean, shit, I couldn’t really blame them.

I wasn’t the most pleasant brother growing up, and I had did some shit that some of them would never forgive me for. I always moved in love because I wanted to protect them. They never saw that part though; it was always me being the bad guy – ruining their lives.

Menace



I REMEMBER WHEN I WAS YOUNGER, AND MY MOTHER HAD KORA. A NIGGA was pissed because I wanted a little brother. All I wanted was a little brother to follow behind me and be exactly like me. I had a whole list on how I would train him and how he would listen.

Back then my parents should have known something wasn't right because why was I, as a child, carrying around a list on how to train a little brother that I didn't have. Either way, I wanted a little brother.

When I was finally blessed with one, it was years later, and the nigga didn't listen. Don was the complete opposite of me and did whatever the fuck he wanted. The only thing I could never or would ever take from him was the fact that he was so damn smart.

He skipped a grade in second grade because of how smart he was. The teachers were trying to figure out why he was correcting them, and it was because he was bored and wasn't challenged in the classroom.

Aside from being smart, he was hardheaded and did what the fuck he wanted. Going to college was something that he had no choice but to do unless he wanted to end up panhandling on the side of the highway.

Finishing college was the only way he could get his trust fund and Don wanted that shit bad. Both Zoya and Kora had access to their trust funds and never touched it. I almost wanted to keep it from him because I felt like he was going to go through that shit. The few times I saw him at a Case House property, I warned him that they were off limits.

He could fuck Wendy Williams for all I cared, long as he didn't touch none of the women at Case House. I had strict rules when it came to

crossing those lines and Landon knew he better not have broken them.

Duke came walking in from the front smacking on an apple. “Don just pulled through the gates.”

I nodded my head, lowering the newspaper that I was reading. Leave it to Landon to bring his ass during my designated quiet hour. Every day for an hour I scheduled time to read the newspaper. I liked to sit in silence because my mind was always going. Whenever I sat in my study, it was quiet, and I could actually focus on what I was doing.

My mind wasn’t thinking about twenty things at once, and I could enjoy reading something without thinking about all the other shit I had going on in my life. My attention span was one of a child, and the minute I got bored, I was onto the next thing.

I had been the same way as a child, always unable to focus without doing a million things before doing my assignments. Though they were always right, and I passed my classes, it took a lot to get them done.

It was the main reason that I had structure. Everything in my life was planned out, even when it came down for me to take a shit. I knew what I was doing for the day two weeks in advance. Chaos was my enemy, and I made sure to keep that shit far away from me.

“Something came up that I couldn’t get around.”

Without looking up from the magazine, I replied, “You get around whatever the fuck you need to when I tell you to come see me.”

Landon stood there, looking like me in every way. He carried himself the same way, except he wasn’t as organized and quiet as I was. “Mens, my life don’t fucking revolve around you. I had some shit that needed to be handled.”

“Your life and your sisters’ lives revolve around me. Every time either of you need me to handle something that’s when I can get a call to ask me to step in and mind y’all business. So, yeah, when I fucking tell you to come see me, you do that shit.” I looked at my watch, a Cartier crash, that I gifted myself for my birthday.

I spent every birthday alone. My brother and sisters called to wish me a happy birthday and sent flowers to the house that I saw when I returned home from Aspen.

Always in Aspen.

“I’m hungry as fuck,” Landon sat his bookbag down, and crossed the room to sit behind my desk.

I bit the inside of my cheek as I watched him move the paper weight and other shit that I had strategically placed on my desk. “Eat when you’re done telling me this twenty-four-hour news.”

He opened his laptop. “I was going over Case House Vegas numbers the other day, and shit not adding up.”

I didn’t trust many, so when it came to doing things in house, I made sure that it was my family. Landon was in college now for cyber security, but he had graduated with a bachelor’s degree in accounting.

It was Core who told me to force him to go back for that second degree. Landon had always been into whatever Core was in, and seeing the knowledge that he knew without a degree was some wicked shit.

“I don’t like when shit don’t add up, Don,” I replied, going back to my newspaper, figuring I could finish this article while he ran down whatever to me.

“Me either... Ryan hit me up and told me that new nigga ain’t been moving right... said shit been missing, and he been scheduling girls for shit outside of the app.”

I put the newspaper down and looked across the room. “Oh word?”

“Stealing from us is wild... Kennedy told me that he approached her first, and she told him that she only does work that is coming from the app and has your approval. The other girls that he has been using are new.”

“Why the fuck is Kennedy telling you anything, Don?”

He sucked his teeth and continued on his computer. “Why we focusing on the wrong shit? I happened to be in Vegas and ran into her... damn.”

“Why the fuck you in Vegas, Landon?” I questioned.

He looked up from his computer. “My fucking business... I’m not a fucking little boy no more... I’m twenty-four, and don’t need you worried about why I’m somewhere. I ran into Kennedy; we went to dinner, and I sent her on the way. She was out there with her girls, and I was out there with a shorty I’m messing with.”

“And had time to go and have dinner with another woman... lie to me again.”

Landon bit back his remark and then looked at me. “I know because you don’t have shit else to do but have scheduled nap times and shit, that worrying about what me, Zoya, and Kora are doing is the only entertainment that you have. I didn’t come over here for a lecture about who I can be around... I’m not fucking Kennedy.”

I folded the newspaper up, no longer interested in the current events in the world. "It's only you and Zoya that give me problems... she wants to keep fucking with a nigga whose days are limited, and you want to test the waters of Case House."

"We're grown, Mens... respect that shit. Everybody can't be perfect like Kora."

I looked at my brother, and then at the book on the side table. It was wrong to toss that shit at his head.

Yeah. It was wrong to throw things at him.

"Kora knows that I do everything in her best interest. Where have I ever steered her wrong? It's you and Zoya's ass that need to understand the same thing and it would be peaceful around here."

"This why you spend holidays alone," he mumbled as he continued to type on his computer, and I looked at my watch.

I hadn't spent a holiday with my siblings since they went away to college. They used to come home, then that stopped. Holidays weren't big in our family, and they usually just sent holiday wishes in the form of a text message.

Last Christmas, Kora came over and chilled with me for the day. Me and Kora were naturally closer than the younger siblings. Where me and Kora stuck together, Landon and Zoya did the same thing.

Of course they would, they were the two causing me the most headaches with their bullshit. Zoya did everything when it came to going to college and then law school, down to her career. When it came to her personal life, she didn't take any advice and did shit to spite me. She knew her nigga's days were limited, and she wanted to lay up with him and play stepmother.

Zoya's ass loved to shop, so I knew her ass had some designer black outfit to wear when they lowered that nigga in the ground.

"Like I was saying," Don snapped his fingers, getting my attention because I was focused on something else. "These new bitches and that new nigga that Ryan put on been stealing."

"Hmm."

"*Hmm?*" Landon mocked, trying to figure out where my head was at.

I could overlook a lot of shit, except stealing from me. I was very generous with my team, and they knew as long as I was eating, they would be too. When I took over Case House, my uncle had them eating scraps. He

was always deducting money from them for some stupid ass reason. The houses that we owned for Case House, he had them paying him rent, as if they lived there.

The houses were only used when clients didn't want to go to their own hotels. We never allowed the girls to go to a client's personal home. It was either one of our homes, where there was security and privacy, or they would use a hotel, where security and privacy was also an option.

There was never a reason for anybody to steal from me. Not when I would give the shirt off my back for my girls. I would do anything for them because of their loyalty and how they made sure Case House remained the best.

The reason I was so passionate about Case House was because my father was. Aside from his kids and wife, his love was Case House and making it what it was until my uncle stepped in. That nigga turned it from high class escorts to a damn brothel.

No health care for the women, paying them whatever he wanted, and the condition of the houses were deplorable. I remember visiting the first house after everything was transferred to me, and I made one of the girls go to the nearest store and get cleaning supplies.

I cleaned that bitch from top to bottom. Cleaning calmed me and centered me. In that moment I needed to be centered because I wanted to kill my uncle for the second time, and he was already dead.

"I went to meet with Ryan while he's in town, and he showed me the amount of money they're making... this ain't no little shit, Mens." Landon looked at me. "How do you want to proceed with this?"

"What do you have?" I relaxed in the chair, and listened to my brother break everything down. Landon was like Core and could find anything out with just a few strokes of a keyboard.

He was a headache any other time, however, when he had a computer in front of him, it was a sense of peace that I saw in him. "Nigga was sending the money to his bitch... and she was sending it to her friend's account. Stevie Raye... you ain't gonna believe what the fuck I found out."

"What?"

"She's related to Skyler... that's her cousin. I knew the name sounded familiar, so I went and looked her up, and she's the one that's been receiving the money into her account."

I stood up and started pacing with my hands behind my back. “Now Core gonna be all in his feelings because I killed Skyler’s cousin.”

Landon laughed and I turned to look at him and he dropped the smile. “Mens, you dead serious?”

“She fucking stealing from me... hell yeah.”

Landon relaxed back in the chair. “I don’t think she knows about the shit. She really thinks she’s helping a friend out.”

“A friend is sending you large amounts of money and you don’t question the shit?”

Landon raised his eyebrow. “Have you ever met Stevie? She would help a burglar rob her damn house.”

“I want them brought to me... her included.” Before I could even call her, Jeffie came into the room with my smoothie.

“What’s that look that you both giving me?”

“You know Stevie, right?”

“Yes... Skyler’s cousin.” She slowly dragged her words while looking between me and my brother.

“That bitch a thief.”

“She’s not,” Don added.

Jeffie handed me my smoothie and looked between us. “What are you talking about? Stevie is in the Bahamas right now living her best life.”

“You know all that information and ain’t tell me? I thought we were family, Jeff?” I looked at her with a serious expression and she shook her head, dug in her pocket and put a napkin onto the desk.

“Good looks. Lupita makes the best fucking macaroons.” Don tore into the napkin and devoured the first one.

My macaroons that my chef made just for me. “Jeffie, why the fu—”

“I knew Landon was coming over and had Lupita make a few extras. The seventeen you always request are in the kitchen, Maverick.” She cut me off and sat on the edge of the desk. “About Stevie, what does she have to do with anything that you have going on.”

“The bitch is a thief,” I repeated for the second time. She was acting like she couldn’t hear or something.

Jeffie cut her eyes at me and turned toward Don for answers. “I don’t think she knew she was transferring stolen money into her account.”

“Stevie is a little bit out there,” Jeffie agreed with Landon.

“Well, she can be a bit out in that grave when I get my hands on all of them muthafuckas... Get the jet fueled and go with Duke to bring them to me.”

“You’re not going?” Don questioned.

Jeffie snickered. “You know he don’t take spontaneous trips. He has to know about them well in advance... stupid superstition.” She eased up from the desk and walked toward the door.

“You right. I ain’t lived with this nigga in so long that I forgot some shit.” He went back to doing whatever on the computer, and I sat back down in my chair.

“Mens, you cannot kill Skyler’s cousin.”

“Don’t think I asked you, Jeffie,” I replied, snatching my newspaper, then tossing it across the room. “Fucking stealing from me... I give them fucking everything... and they stealing from me!” I roared, pissed.

“Greed.” Jeffie folded her arms, probably feeling lonely since she wasn’t holding that damn iPad in her hands.

“They spending big money, too... hacked into her bank account. Willshire Bahamas... sheesh,” Don whistled as he was scrolling through what I assumed was her transactions. “Dior, Gucci, Prada... bitch has expensive taste.”

I was becoming more angrier by the second. “I’ll go and get everything set for the jet... remember you cannot kill her, Mens.”

She gave me that look on her way out and I ignored her ass. “Why the fuck you still here?” I grumbled and left out the room.

“First you mad I didn’t show up, now you throwing me out,” Don smacked on my macaroons while I headed down the hall to go into the bottom level to my gym.

My blood was boiling and only one thing could control the feeling I got when my blood was hot.

Running on the treadmill until I felt like I was going to fucking vomit.

Stevie



“STEVIE, I THOUGHT YOU CUT THINGS OFF WITH HIM? EVER SINCE YOUR last date with him,” Priscilla looked over my shoulder, as she plopped in the chair across from me with a plate filled with food. “What did happen on that date?”

We were in a lounge at the airport waiting to board our flight. I was still shocked that I was going on a trip, and we were flying first class. I had never been in an airport lounge in my life.

This was how the other half lived because who filled up on all this food before a flight?

Rich people, that’s who.

I looked at the string of text messages that Cornell had been sending me. He was worried that I was going to air him out on social media. He didn’t care that he tried to take advantage of me. *Nell* was worried that me speaking out would get him kicked off tour with Zay.

If Zay knew he had a creep in his camp, he would for sure make sure he was good as gone. Nothing but positive things surrounded Zay and his career, aside from the beef with his ex-fiancée.

Priscilla was stuffing her face with crab bites as she waited for me to answer. “He’s been reaching out to me. Trying to apologize because he had taken something that night...he’s trying to save face because his best friend is cousins with Zay.”

Priscilla screwed her face up. “Even more reason to cut him off. He’s not even direct friends with Zay, and he’s being weird with you like he’s important.” She looked truly disgusted.

“Yeah.”

Priscilla polished off the rest of her crab bites and then wiped her mouth. “Girl, we’re about to be on a resort toasting to the good life and you are over here being depressed. Leave Cornell and his weirdness alone. What you need to do is be messing with these get money niggas.”

“I don’t want to mess with any kind of man right now. The experience has been a zero out of ten starts.”

Priscilla checked her phone. “You just haven’t met the right one. I guess I can say the same thing, too.”

“Um, isn’t your boyfriend the whole reason we’re going on this trip?” I questioned as I took a sip of my cucumber water.

Priscilla dramatically pulled her head back while letting out this rich bitch laugh. “Stevie, you need to realize every man ain’t meant to be your boyfriend. I play the game like these men play it, and he probably has other hoes... he’s gonna fly in, so I may be with him, too.”

I didn’t care if she told me she was going to swim with the pigs. As long as I had a drink, my current read of the month, and sun, I didn’t care what Priscilla did with her time.

As we were called to board, it was an entire new experience being able to get on the plane before everyone and being offered drinks soon as we sat down. Priscilla kept her sunglasses on as she flipped through the menu and acted like she belonged.

It was hard for me to act like I belonged because I didn’t belong here. First class was a dream to me, something I had never experienced. This was all new to me, so I was taking everything in while recording and sending it to Skyler.

Her dry responses told me that she was still pissed that I went on the trip. She spent the entire night while I packed last minute things telling me that something didn’t feel right, and I should stay.

She even offered to take me to the Bahamas, and we could bring Estella. The girl tried everything to get me to stay and when she realized I was going, she gave me money to make sure I was safe.

Skyler meant well, but she had to realize that I was older than her and didn’t need my little cousin telling me how I should live my life. Skyler had always been mature for her age, always worrying, and always doing what was right.

I think the one thing she did that was out of the ordinary for her was getting pregnant. When she first moved to New York for college, we weren't as close because she was living her life with her friends and getting the taste of freedom.

Every time I saw her; she was on the go and living her life with the wrong people. Something changed, and she got back to the Skyler that I knew. The girl that was serious about what she wanted out of life.

When her mother passed, she became more guarded and stricter with her life. I understood, she had Estella to care for now and she couldn't rely on her father to help her.

"Bottoms up," Priscilla handed me a shot and I took it back as the plane got ready to take off.

"To a vacation that we'll never forget!" I smiled, as we clinked glasses, and got ready to enjoy ourselves on this trip.

I needed this.



THE WILLSHIRE HOTEL IN THE BAHAMAS WAS BEAUTIFUL. THE SIX-STAR resort was everything I didn't know I needed in my life. The minute we landed, they sent a tinted air-conditioned SUV to the airport that whisked us to the hotel. We were able to check in at a private counter where they handed us champagne and snacks while they got everything squared away.

The night before, Priscilla had transferred money into my account, so we used my card to place a hold on our accommodations while we were here. I didn't care because the forty thousand she had sent to me was more than enough to cover us for this week.

We had been here for two days, and I had only had breakfast with Priscilla. I know I said I was good with having a book and sun, but I wanted some girl talk, too. She only spent the night in our suite the first night, and this morning she came strolling in the suite looking like someone nailed her to the cross.

Her hair was all over her head and makeup smeared. She wore the same clothes from the night before, as she smiled when she saw me at the table in

the kitchen.

Yes. The suite had a whole kitchen.

“Good morning, someone looks like they had a good night,” I grumbled, taking a sip of the green tea that I made.

She fanned herself and went to the coffee machine, pushing a pod in and leaning on the counter. “That nigga broke my fucking back last night... girl, you need to come out tonight with us.”

I had no desire to be around Priscilla’s boyfriend, or the men he was with. She claimed he came with a few friends, and I didn’t want to be the friend that had to make useless conversation because my girl was with their boy.

“I thought we would hang out today. Maybe go to the beach or sit by the pool and try all their drinks.” I got excited at the thought of just us girls hanging out.

Priscilla’s face told me that she would rather eat dolphin shit than to do what I suggested. It was weird because she invited me, and as much as I knew we didn’t need to hang every moment of the day, I thought we would at least hang a bit.

Other than my cousin and Priscilla, I didn’t have any friends. I remember my mother always pushing me to make friends, thinking that everybody wanted to be friends with the girl who rambled and struggled with ADHD. They all thought I was weird, and I hated being the *weird* girl.

I craved a friendship outside of my cousin where I could just be Stevie. As much as I was close with Skyler, I often felt like she was forced to be my friend. As if she felt bad that her older cousin was a loner who would rather spend her nights painting or watching anime.

“We can go shopping today... there’s a few stores I want to hit before my date tonight.”

“Oh.”

“Stevie, I will cover anything that you want. Remember, this trip is on me... you should come out tonight with us. His friend is fine... finer than him.” She winked, as if that would seal the deal for me. I wanted nothing to do with a fine friend, or any man for that matter.

“I actually have plans tonight,” I lied.

While Priscilla was out being slutted out, I was going to fill that huge tub with bubbles, listen to my favorite playlist, and relax while watching an Adam Sandler movie - my comfort movies.

When my mother passed away, I stayed held up in our apartment watching Grown Ups for weeks. I didn't even switch between part one or two, I continued to watch part one.

I could recite the entire movie without a second thought. Actually, I liked to think of it as a hidden talent, and I knew it was going to get me out of trouble one day.

She grew excited as she quickly ushered over toward the table and scooted in the chair. "Was it that cute bartender that kept flirting with you?"

"Yes," I lied knowing that she wouldn't let up until she was satisfied that I was with someone.

As much as I admired my friend, I could also point out that she was very motivated by men. Men were her entire life, and that wasn't my reality. I didn't need a man to live. The one man that should have been there for me never was. He was too busy doing and being everything else to anyone beside his daughter and wife that needed him.

Wanted him home.

I had only experienced love when it was broken, never when it was whole. Never when it felt like an old school song. The heartbreak is what I witnessed; the disappointment of the person you vowed to do life with. All of that scared me, and aside from the Tony situation, it caused me to shut men out.

My mother thought she would have the man she married forever. He promised to love her, right before God. He gave her his word, and the minute that the signature on the certificate dried, he was doing him, breaking those very promises he had given her.

I never wanted a love like that to find me.

Stevie



A BUNCH OF BAGS SAT AT OUR FEET AS WE SAT AT AN ICE CREAM SHOP IN the resort. Priscilla said she wanted to do damage when it came to shopping, and she did exactly that. We had went to every designer store and boutique that was on the resort, and she swiped my card and purchased everything.

I got a pair of shoes and some things for both Skyler and Estella. As much as I loved to shop, I didn't want to spend the day in and out of stores. I wanted to explore the Bahamas. Do a few excursions, lay out by the pool, and actually enjoy the trip. Aside from shopping, Priscilla continued to stop because her boyfriend kept asking her where she was.

When she put that baby voice on, I knew it was him on the phone and rolled my eyes. I realized today that the rest of this trip would be filled with me being alone, doing what I wanted to do. She wanted to stick up her boyfriend's ass, and I wasn't about to beg her to hang out with me.

"Are you sure you don't wanna come tonight? His friend says he wants to meet you and you've been hiding." She sipped her milkshake while I enjoyed my cone.

It made me real uneasy how she kept trying to push her boyfriend's friend on me. Every time he called, she would ask me if I was sure, as if I didn't make it clear multiple times that I didn't want to hang with them.

Priscilla vouching for them meant nothing to me. She switched men like wigs, so did she really know any of those men *well*?

Exactly.

"I have my own plans, remember?" I reminded her like I had been doing each time she asked me.

She giggled. “Girl, nothing is off the table with them... big money. I’ve never fucked with a nigga that has money like this. Girl, it’s damn near spilling out his pockets.”

“I love this for you.”

She was so tickled as she swung her crossed legs while looking at her phone. “I could love it for you, too, but you want to play hard to get. How about we come back to our suite later on?”

“How about you don’t.” I smiled.

“Fine, Ms. Boring. How do you expect to ever find a boyfriend if you never open yourself up to being loved?”

“You think a man that’s not even your boyfriend, and his friends is where I’m going to find love?”

Her phone chimed and she jumped up. “Oh, we need to be getting back to the suite... he told me what time he’s coming to get me. My baby is taking me to an exclusive restaurant on the resort.”

“Fancy,” I muttered as I helped her collect all the bags so we could make the trek back to our suite.

The suite was nice and quiet now that Priscilla was gone. Between the music, the chatter with her other friends on facetime, and trying on a dozen outfits before settling on one that looked like it needed more material, she was finally gone.

Of course, she couldn’t leave until she asked me if I was sure I didn’t want to go. This time, I closed the door in her face and locked it while heading to my room to take a relaxing bath.

She wouldn’t be back tonight, and I knew it from the way she popped her birth control and washed it down with rum. I’ve always suspected that Priscilla was a wild card.

Other than drinks and a few dinners, we’ve never been on vacation together. It was like being in a relationship with a man, and you didn’t really know him until you moved in with him.

Even though she hadn’t been in our suite that much, I could see her differently than the friend I was always excited to see when she made time for me.

I used to stare at her in admiration because she played these men like they played us. That admiration was slowly fading away, and I was seeing her as thirsty, and money hungry. All that man had to do was call, and she was breaking her leg to go run to be with him.

That was pretty far from being cool, calm and collective. Skyler, if anyone, showed me how it was to be cool when it came to a man. She had Corleon head over heels for her, and the man would give her the world if she asked. Not that she acted unbothered, she also didn't jump at his every move.

I drizzled the hotel bubble bath into the water, and lit a few candles I got from the gift shop on the way up to our suite as I listened to "Fire and Desire" by Rick James. I moved my hips as I listened to Rick talk his shit.

This was my favorite song in the entire world. I remember singing into a brush with my mother in our living room. We would sing this song at the top of our lungs, then bust out in a fit of giggles.

"Looooovveeeeeee!" I belted out as I did a fake strip tease, as if I was doing it for my man.

Wishful thinking.

I flung the shirt across the room while rocking my hips from side to side, then I dipped my toe into the water. The water was the perfect temperature as the rest of my body followed and I did a happy shiver, allowing the warm water to engulf my body.

With my eyes closed and the music blaring, I inhaled the sweet salty mix of the candle and felt more relaxed than I had in a long time. My body was literally loosening up by the seconds as I settled into this tub.

I wanted to feel this warm, this safe, and this relaxed for the rest of my life. The thought of returning home back to the hustle and bustle of my life made me cringe and my jaw clench. My life wasn't all bad, I just didn't know what was next for me.

Since I lost my mother, I had been trying to figure out what was next. What was Stevie Raye supposed to do? I had no sign from her, and at this point not even God could tell me what was next for me.

Nails paid the bills (barely) but that wasn't my passion. It fell into my lap and aligned with the fact that I loved to create art. Painting had always been my first love, and I have loved it since I was a child. Except, being an artist didn't pay the bills.

It was a nice hobby to have, however, I couldn't feed myself on it. Especially since I could never finish a piece. There were so many unfinished pieces in the living room at home that drove Skyler crazy.

She hated that I clouded our living space with my unfinished canvases, and even tried to hold a intervention to get me to stop buying them. No

matter how many times I put one to the side – unfinished, I found myself at the art store scanning my rewards card to get discounted canvases.

I held my breath and went under the water and remained under there for a few seconds before I came back up, opening my eyes and nearly stopping my heart at the same exact time.

“Ahhhh!” I screamed as I tried to gather the bubbles to cover my chest up. Between the music, my heart thumping in my ears, and the sound of my screams I was overstimulated, scared and on the verge of passing out.

The man standing in front of me was large. He had to weight over 350 pounds of muscle, and he was tall. Even though I was sitting in the tub, I’m sure if I stood next to him, he would tower over me.

His caramel complexion, thick beard, and freshly twisted locs were in rope twists, pushed back out of his face. His thick eyebrows, dark menacing eyes, and pink lips were just staring at me. His arms were covered in tattoos as he stood there looking at me like he wasn’t invading my privacy by not only being in my hotel suite, but my bathroom too.

It was then that I noticed he was holding something in his hand, and it was clothes.

My clothes.

“I’m gonna step out the bathroom so you can change into these... try something and I’ll make this TV fall in the water with you... got it?”

I swallowed a huge lump that was in my throat and slowly nodded my head. My hands were shaking, and my chest was tight. “Sir?”

He paused his stride and looked at me. “I really think I’m going to pass out.”

Why did I admit this to a strange man in the bathroom of my suite? I was scared and you often did things that you wouldn’t have done if you weren’t. Me and Skyler always used to play hypothetical games where we would predict how we would act if something happened.

A strange man in my suite on vacation wasn’t a scenario we ever practiced for. “He don’t pay me enough for this shit.”

“W...who doesn’t pay you?”

He snatched the towel from the heated towel rack, opened it up and walked toward the tub. “Step out slowly... hurry the fuck up,” he barked, as he held up the towel and looked the opposite direction.

My legs felt like rubber when I stepped out the tub, my breathing labored because I was calculating if I could bolt across this bathroom and

get some help for myself. This was one of those moments I wished that I would have gone out with Priscilla and her boyfriend.

I quickly slipped on the clothes he had for me, and he snatched the towel down and went into his pocket. "Hold this," his deep voice said, as he grabbed me up and put a cloth over my mouth and my eyes became blurry until everything eventually faded to black.

OceanofPDF.com

Menace



DUKE PULLED UP TO ONE OF THE WAREHOUSES I OWNED ON SOUTH AVENUE in Staten Island. I owned a bunch of warehouses all over the city. Some empty, and some functioning businesses. This one happened to be empty.

It had been a week since I had Duke go and snatch sticky fingers and her friends. He opened the door, and I hopped out, going around to open the door for Jeffie. “Maverick, you listen to me... keep a calm head. I already don’t like that she’s been here for a week, and I’ve been quiet to Skyler.”

I stopped in my tracks and looked at Jeffie, one of my best friends. Shit, I would go as far as to say she was my damn heart because there was no one closer to me than her. Corleon counted, but me and Jeffie were soul mates.

Not no freaky shit either.

She understood me like her mother did, and for that I would always have a high respect for her. “You remember that Skyler may be your freaky sister-wife, but I’m family... your soul mate, right?”

Jeffie pointed her finger into my chest. “Me and Skyler are not sleeping together, Maverick... I’ve told you that already. I have a loyalty to both of you, and Stevie is innocent and you’re going to see for yourself. Let’s not bring this soul mate mess up... just because *you* went down a rabbit hole on platonic soul mates doesn’t mean we’re about to have this conversation again.”

She turned on her feet and walked through the door that Duke held open for us. “Where the fuck are they? I said I’m on my way, had Duke give you the ETA, and here I am in this stink ass warehouse, and I don’t see them in chairs with their mouths gagged and wigs in they laps.”

“Boss, you never said that was the plan.” One of the flunkies looked at me, and I had half the mind to pull my gun and empty it into his chest because I was so pissed.

“The curly head one kept crying so we kept her in the back... Mens, she had a panic attack twice,” Beans, one of my top generals, and Don’s best friend replied.

“I don’t have time for this shit,” I rubbed my temples and took a seat in the chair that was set up for me – the only thing these niggas had ready for me. “Bring me out that nigga and his bitch first.”

One of Bean’s flunkies went to the back, and I heard him hollering before two others brought out a man and a woman with cloth sacks over their heads.

“Please don’t kill me... please, I don’t know what we did, but I promise we can fix it,” the woman’s muffled voice sounded through the bag.

I stood up as they slammed them both down in the chair, and she broke out in a hysterical scream. “Yo’ ass wasn’t fucking crying when you were stealing, huh?” I snatched the bag from her head, and she jumped back because of how close I was to her face. “Your breath smells like fucking Kangaroo pussy, Bitch.”

She took a large gulp and closed her mouth as her body shook and she tried to calm herself. “I...I haven’t been able to brush my teeth or shower.”

“Do you think there’s showers in hell?”

Tears poured down her face at my question. “N...no,” she tried to get out, and it came out all chopped and screwed because she was bawling.

“Then why the fuck do you think you getting a shower and pillow service in my hell?”

The whimpering from her was driving me fucking crazy. I didn’t bother to snatch the cloth bag off homie’s face, I swung my arm back and sent it crashing into his face. The blow from my hit knocked his ass and the chair onto the floor as he howled.

I don’t know how it was possible for shorty to have even more tears, but she was a blubbering mess. We couldn’t understand what the hell she was over there crying about because she was a fucking mess.

“Speak with your mouth and make sure I understand everything you’re saying because I’ll pull every tooth out your mouth with twine around each tooth and that metal door over there,” I snarled while staring in her face.

She took a deep breath and tried to contain herself as best as she could, while her boyfriend was on the floor howling. "My...my friend. She was with us and she...she is single. You...you can have her."

"You steal from me and then you offer your friend's pussy, and think that's gonna get me to change my mind on sending you through the meat processor in the back room?"

"Oh God!" she shrieked to herself as she tried to find her words. Anything that would save her from being killed and turned into ground meat. "She...she's a virgin."

Jeffie scoffed from behind me.

"Oh word?"

She must have thought her friend's virgin status was going to save her. I mean, I was intrigued because she was untouched. Nobody had soiled her, which meant she was clean.

Squeaky clean.

It made me all that more interested in her. "Yes... you can take her as your wife, or whatever. She's always complaining about not finding the right guy." I motioned for them to pick up homie, while he was still over there moaning in pain, while choking on his blood.

When they snatched the bag from his head, his entire jaw was out of place, the bottom half was more to the left than the top. "So, this is the nigga with the bigger dick than mine, huh?"

He was trying to say something, and I couldn't make out what he said, so I kicked his ass into the chest with my sneaker, sending him back onto the floor, squealing in pain. Like they had done seconds before, they lifted him back up.

"I...I didn't know, man," he stuttered, speaking out the side of his mouth, while I looked over at his girlfriend who was staring at him horrified.

"He got a big dick?"

She looked at me as if she didn't know if she could answer the question or not. "Um... ye...yeah."

"Big enough for you to die over, right?"

"Nooo, please nooo... my best friend, you can have her."

"Who the fuck are you to even offer her up?" Jeffie's voice floated through the warehouse, as she stood with her arms folded, truly disgusted with the woman's actions.

Her actions were disgusting, however, she had me intrigued with her *best friend*. “Bring her ass out.”

Beans went to the back and was gone for a few seconds before he nicely walked the woman out. She wore a bag over her head, as she spoke to him. “Thank you so much for not putting them on me this time. Last time it dug into my skin,” her voice was low, and sweet.

Little fucking thief had the nerve to be kind, and have a beautiful voice, and I hadn’t even seen her fucking face yet. “No problem, Stevie.”

I looked at Beans and he shrugged. “She’s nice... not like this bitch who spit in my fucking face.” He kicked the other shorty’s chair, and she yelped.

“Priscilla, are you alright? I asked them about you,” she asked about her friend, clearly worried about her well-being. Not knowing her friend offered her virginity up on a silver platter.

Beans carefully sat her down into the chair, and she sat there with her hands folded like she was waiting to be interviewed for a job.

He looked at me and I nodded for him to remove the bag from her face. Carefully, because clearly Beans was being nice cop, he removed the sack from her face. I couldn’t even front, I didn’t expect for my heart to hit the inside of my chest like it did when he removed it. Her strawberry blond curls were flattened to her head, thick eyebrows were perfectly arched, and her cute button nose sat right in the center of her face, making you look down to her pouty pink lips. They were dry, and she realized it because she quickly licked them as she stared at me.

Freckles dusted the top of her nose and under her amber eyes. Her almond complexion had a slight tan to it, which was to be expected since she was on a trip with my fucking money. As she sat there, her thighs filled the chair. I wasn’t paying attention to her body much on her walk out here, but from the way her thighs and hips filled the chair, she was thick.

Her hands unfolded, and she quickly hugged her arms, which were bare. She rubbed them as she looked away from me. “Here you go, Stevie.” Beans came back with a pair of glasses, and she put the circular glasses on, and that’s when my brow raised.

Little sexy blind ass couldn’t even see me, because once she saw me, she really felt self-conscious sitting in front of me. I could tell she was looking over herself and trying to fix how she sat.

Homie slowly peeled his eyes from me onto her and nearly knocked his own self out the chair. “St...Stevie?”

Her head snapped in his direction. "Raye?"

"Stev...Stevie, what in the fuck?"

Shorty in the middle looked between her dude, and Stevie. "You know him?"

"That's my damn *father*." The way she said father told me that he wasn't a good one, and they didn't have a relationship with each other.

"Oh, this shit interesting," I pulled my seat up, flipping it in the opposite direction and taking a seat. "Soo, how did you meet?" I rested my face in the palm of my hand as I spoke to shorty in the middle, while she squirmed in her chair.

"In Vegas."

"Oh, when he was stealing money from me?"

I could hear Jeffie's heels entering the warehouse again, and Stevie looked past me. "Jeffie? What... what is going on?"

Jeffie rushed over toward her side and checked over her, pissing me off. She was acting like I wasn't conducting business. Her ass was lucky that I could tell sexy over there wasn't involved. The girl was acting like she didn't know why she was kidnapped from another country and held in a warehouse for a week.

"You were stealing from Case House, Stevie... I know you didn't know because you would never, but why would you trust her?" Jeffie tossed, showing her disgust up close instead of across the warehouse.

Stevie shook her head quickly and pushed her glasses up. "I would never steal from someone... I mean, I do eat the grapes in the grocery store, but I get hungry at times and a few grapes isn't that bad."

"It's still stealing, Cleo!" I barked.

"Cleo?" she asked.

"Yeah, you and your Set It Off crew thought you were hitting a lick."

Jeffie rubbed her shoulders. "Skyler has been worried about you. She warned you about this one... Gosh... I hate being caught in the mi—"

Her head snapped up in Jeffie's direction. "No, she cannot find out about this. I will tell her that my phone fell in the pool or something."

"How you gonna do that when you're dead, Sweetheart?"

Stevie turned her head toward me slowly and took a deep breath. "That is true... I want my last words to be that I didn't steal from you. I steal grapes from the grocery store, not money. Priscilla tell them about the money Raye was sending you."

“Wait a minute, why do you call your father by his name?” I was so damn interested in her little nerdy fine ass. “Yo, Raye, why your seed calling you by your name?”

He was over there in pain, trying to keep his eyes opened because that punch I delivered was going to have him in pain for the next week. “Since her mother passed, she ain’t want to be close.”

“Wrong! I called you, needed you, and you weren’t there. I had to bury her alone, and you showed up late to her funeral,” her voice cracked. “Matter fact, go on and kill me already so I *don’t* have to have this conversation.” Her legs started to shake as Jeffie rubbed her shoulders. “No, please don’t kill me... I was bluffing, I don’t want to die, Mr. Sir.”

“Menace,” I replied.

“Mr. Menace,” she corrected herself as she looked into my eyes, pleading for me to spare her life.

Something that I had already been told that I had to do because she was *family*. How the fuck was she family when Skyler wanted to be Ms. Independent woman, and I wanted to fuck this little quirky shorty in front of me.

“Menace,” I corrected her – again.

She straightened up. “I hate when people call me Steve, so I get it. Please don’t kill me.”

I looked over at her father, and then shorty in the middle that was holding onto every word that came out of Stevie’s mouth. “Why you letting people put money in your account?”

“I have a credit union... I don’t know if you know how that works, but not eve—”

“He owns one, Stevie,” Jeffie informed her.

She gulped. “Well, I thought it was that... I didn’t know she accidentally stole from you.”

“You don’t accidentally steal from me.”

“I guess that’s true.”

Jeffie whispered something and she remained quiet, as I pulled my gun from behind me and shorty hollered out. “I’m so sorry... I thought it was his money!”

“You thought my money was his money, and her pussy is yours, right?” I looked over at Stevie, who was confused. “Your friend offered you up... said you a virgin.”

“What?” she whispered as she looked down at her hands.

She was disassociating and I never gave a fuck about what someone said or felt, but I felt something when I looked at how hurt she was. Here she was trying to get them out of trouble, and her friend offered her virginity the first second she opened her mouth.

“Stevie, I’m sorry. I’m not trying to die, and he fine as hell... it’s not gonna be bad.”

I looked at her and watched as Jeffie looked at me. “Stop, Jeff.”

“I didn’t say nor do anything,” she continued to rub her shoulders, as she shot the friend a stink eye.

“I can cook... I can make you something good to eat. Just not that, please,” she pleaded, and my fucking stomach dropped.

I looked down at my gun, and aimed it near shorty’s leg, firing a shot at the floor near her. She toppled over onto the floor trying to get away while Raye did the same. Stevie was so damn hurt that the gun shot didn’t phase her.

“You not his wife... trying to cook him food,” one of the flunkies chuckled, and I aimed the gun and shot him in the arm.

He went from trying to clown her to holding his arm while squealing out in pain from the bullet I put in his arm.

“I won’t kill you.”

“In exchange for?” her eyes slowly met mine.

“You’re going to marry me... I need a wife, and you need your life saved, no?”

She looked at her friend, and then father. “Marrying you saves them?”

“Maybe.”

“I don’t kn—”

“Child, marry the damn man. My life on the damn line and you debating... you always been a little slow, Baby Girl,” Raye spat, trying to keep his breath even.

“The fuck you said to my wife?” I aimed my gun at his ass next, and she jumped up out the seat, and I saw all that ass.

“Please don’t shoot him,” she pleaded with me.

Despite not being close, or caring much for him, she cared enough to spare his life. “Wifey, he stole from me... can’t let that go with a slap on the wrist.”

She looked at me repulsed when I called her wifey. “Don’t call me *wifey*,” I watched as she choked the word out.

I looked at her as she looked between me and them. “I’ll marry you if you don’t kill them... please, I really would fall apart.”

“Stevie, she tried to sell you to the highest bidder,” Jeffie reminded her.

She sighed. “I know, and that really sucks.”

“They fucking stole from me, so why the fuck we discussing shit like death isn’t in their immediate future?” I interjected into the little pow wow about what I was going to do.

Jeffie nodded her head toward the exit, and I groaned, following behind her. “You need a wife and she’s willing to become your wife. Is proving a point more important than being removed as the third founding family?”

“Actually, yeah. Hell yeah.”

“Maverick,” she whispered.

“What the fuck you want me to do? Throw these bitches a birthday party and send them on their way. We’re not talking small money, Jeff.”

She paused and I could tell she was thinking. “Compared to what you’re worth, any amount is small money. Case Farms... send them both to work there until we figure something else out. They work there for now to start paying back their debt.”

“I’m with a lot of shit, but you not about to make me into no damn slave owner.”

Stevie was talking to her janky ass friend and had turned with her back facing us, and I saw her ass in those damn sweats again. “Is there any more room for me in those jeans!” I started singing, startling everyone in this bitch except for Duke, Beans and Jeffie.

I couldn’t help but belt the words to the song out because her ass was singing the words to me.

Duke chuckled while Jeffie folded her arms. “This is the solution to the problem, she gets to keep her father and that rodent alive, and you get a wife.”

“Why you more concerned about this than me?”

“Because you’re stubborn and will walk away as the third family because you hate being told what to do.” She looked at Stevie, and then back at me. “I just have a feeling about this.”

“Yo, Wonder... how bad you want to keep your friend alive?” I walked back over toward them, and her friend started crying on command.

I walked over toward her and rubbed my gun against her jaw before resting my gun on the table next to her. Leaning my arm on top of her head, I started picking at the front of her wig, while waiting for my future wife to tell me what needed to be done.

“My name is Stevie—”

“Wonder... answer the question.”

She looked at Jeffie, who tossed her hands up. “How do you know I wasn’t the master mind of all of this?”

“I told you the girl was—”

I quickly turned, tapping her father’s jaw, and I’m sure I probably knocked that shit back into place with the way he was back squawking on the floor again.

“Is your purpose to get him to kill you, Stevie?” Jeffie asked, trying to understand this woman. Shit, I was trying to understand her, as I continued to pick shorty’s wig.

It was something soothing about picking the hairline of this shit. “Why would you lie to me, Priscilla? I thought we were friends.”

“We are friends... ouch.”

I started picking the pimple on her forehead. “Stop lying. You offered her virginity up like it was yours.”

Stevie put her hand on her hips and looked at her, and I licked my lips as I took her in. “Why do that to me? I told you about Tony.”

“Who Tony?”

“Nobody,” she quickly shut me down.

Priscilla had more tears than a newborn with the way she kept turning those shits on and off. Every time she thought she was in the clear, she would stop crying. The minute she wasn’t, then she started hollering and throwing on those fake ass tears.

“I’m sorry, Stevie... I thought I was gonna die.”

“Who says you’re not?” I mumbled, and she tried to move her head, and I put it back into place and continued picking in her face. “You stealing from me and not even investing in good skin care... skin look fucking gross.”

“I would have never done that to you.”

“I’m sorry, Stevie. That was so wrong on my end, I shouldn’t have done that.”

“Then my father.” She looked on the floor at her father moaning, too scared to move because I would put my foot in his ass.

Her eyes nearly bulged out. “Relax, you got hella black heads,” I continued to pick in her face while she sat there uncomfortable.

“I didn’t know that was your father... I swear. We met in Las Vegas, and he was tricking. You know me, Stevie. If he got it, I’m there.”

“Now you about to die... if he got it, I’m dead, right?”

“Oh, God, please... please... please,” she continued to beg me and Stevie, who stood there torn.

“If I don’t marry you?”

“They die, Wonder.”

She looked at Jeffie and then back at me. “Skyler can’t find out about this... As far as she knows, we met on vacation, and I like you.”

“You want me to keep two people that robbed me blind alive, and lie... what fucking else?” I mushed shorty and moved back over toward my chair.

“She wouldn’t understand, and she would just say that she warned me about Priscilla.”

“Can’t say she was wrong,” Jeffie rolled her eyes, and grabbed her purse.

Stevie took a deep breath. “Well, I guess I should head home and face the mus—”

I laughed. “Wonder, your home is with me... fuck you think this is? I’m gonna negotiate a deal and let you off the hook. You Skyler’s cousin, not mine... I don’t fucking know your loyalty. Shit, I’m questioning it right now ‘cause this bitch should have a bullet smoking from her forehead.”

“I have to live with you?”

“Yes, Beloved.” I smirked, as I walked past her.

“Beans, get these niggas to Ryan so he have them flown out to Case Farms... I’ll figure out what to do with them until they pay their debt.”

I would have had Priscilla selling pussy, however, that wouldn’t be a punishment with the way the girls at Case House were treated. Shit would have been a luxury for her disloyal ass. My blood still boiled at how hurt Wonder looked when she realized that her friend had offered her up.

“Like slaves?” Priscilla screeched.

“*Like* alive ones,” I mocked and headed toward the exit.

Stevie



AS SOON AS WE STEPPED OUTSIDE, ANOTHER LARGE TRUCK PULLED UP AND Menace headed to the black one of the two. Jeffie headed toward the one that had just pulled up and turned for me to follow her. I was still trying to wrap my head around being in this warehouse for a week. Beans was super nice to me and made sure that I was comfortable.

When one of his workers started eyeing me funny, he broke his nose, and I hadn't seen him since. Since he was so nice to me, in return I doodled a tattoo for him on some loose papers in the back office.

Sleeping on the cot that was provided for me wasn't the best and my back was still suffering from going to a luxury resort suite to a small room in the back of a smelly, dirty, warehouse. The man that had kidnapped me held the door open for me.

"I thought we were friends," I gave him the stink eye and he laughed, holding the door open wider for me.

"Boss's order... nothing personal, Stevie."

I climbed into the back and looked around the massive truck, melting in the soft butter leather seats while Jeffie pecked away on her phone. "Is he not coming with us?"

"Menace has a full day, and usually I would be with him, but I need to get you settled and this situation under control," she spoke as she continued on her phone, never breaking her stride in texting.

"Jeffie, my cousin cannot find out about this... please promise to keep this secret. I promise I will tell her when I'm ready, but it has to come from me."

She paused, lowering her phone to look at me. "Why did you trust that girl, Stevie? You're a smart girl, none of what she was doing sounded shady to you?"

"I should have been smarter and listened... sometimes it's easier to turn my brain off. I can't explain it, but I like living in my bubble... I'm happy there."

She held her phone again and pointed it at me. "You need to make sure your cousin knows. I hate keeping things from her... that's my sister-wife... not healthy for me to keep things from her and Core."

"She and Core are broken up," I reminded her.

"And I have plans on reuniting them... enough about my family. This isn't a joke... he needs a wife, and he's really going to marry you. You're really going to live with him," she reminded me.

My father and Priscilla both deserved whatever came to them. I wanted to pretend that I didn't care so much. He had been out of my life since my mama's funeral and I hadn't heard a word from him.

Why should I care for a stranger?

My father was a stranger, and I shouldn't have given a damn about what happened to him. It was safe to say that he was innocent when it came to betraying me. He had no idea that Priscilla knew me.

The betrayal was hearing that Priscilla was willing to offer me up to this man without a second thought. Bringing up my virginity, something that I had told her in confidence really hurt. For a brief second, I wanted to die because all eyes were on me.

Menace was most definitely scary, and his eyes were very menacing with how he stared at you. Like he wanted to rip your head off and then eat a full course meal after. Even I could see his eyes soften when he heard what Priscilla had said about him being fine, and it wouldn't be that bad.

"I don't want my father or Priscilla to die. What they were doing was wrong and they should have to answer for what they did. Death just seems so final."

"It is final," Jeffie nonchalantly replied.

I looked out the window as we continued to drive. "Where are we?"

"Your new home... Staten Island. We'll make arrangements for you to get your things from the condo with Skyler... I guess that would be the time for you to be honest with her."

“Not yet... give me time to tell her. Skyler is always so hard with me, and she will tell me that she told me so, which she was right. I just don’t want to deal with that right now. I’m her big cousin, not the other way around. Allow me to tell my own business and sit with this for a little minute... you know?”

She nodded her head at me and agreed with what I was saying. It was hard to admit to my cousin that I didn’t listen and ended up in this situation. I’ve always been raised to look at the bright side of things, and the bright side was that I wasn’t dead.

It was because of the people and connections that Skyler knew that had prevented me from dying in that warehouse when that could have been my fate.

“I’ll give you that. Remember, your business includes me knowing and will break the trust me and Skyler have. She’s my best friend, and we don’t lie to each other.”

“I understand. I promise I will tell her that I made you promise not to tell.” I smiled at Jeffie, who went back on her phone. “What is he like?”

Jeffie laughed. “Well, he calls me his soul mate, so please don’t get all weirded out.”

I screwed my face up and she laughed.

“Not like that... me and Menace have been through a lot together... all of us have, and I’ve been the constant in his life. The one who never left, and the one he has always had. He’s a big brother to me... best friend, and I’ll deny it if you tell him, a soul mate in a way. I believe our paths were supposed to cross because he needs me.”

“Wow. How am I, as his future wife, supposed to fill such shoes?” I snickered, and Jeffie became serious.

“This is a business arrangement in a way. You marry him to help him with his problem, and he’ll keep your people alive, although he really wants to kill them. You have to know that what your father and friend did is a death sentence... that man has done worse for less, and the fact that he has agreed to keep them alive because of you is really big. I know this is an arranged marriage, but don’t think of it like that... get to know him.”

“Okay.”

You know how the most outrageous things happen to someone, and you joke and say that would happen to me because wild things *always* happened

to you? That would be me in this moment. Crazy things always happen to me, and I always just roll with the punches, and make the best out of them.

Things could be worse, like me choking on my blood in that warehouse. Marrying a billionaire couldn't be that bad... right?



WHEN JEFFIE SHOWED ME THAT THE CHAIR HAD HEAT, AND IT RECLINED back, I was dead to the world. Drool spilled out of my mouth when I felt the car jerk and go over what seemed like a huge pothole. I jumped up, thinking Jeffie had betrayed me and I was going to meet my maker. There were men in suits with a mirror on a long pole sticking it under the truck, and then nodding for him to proceed.

“Relax, he has security monitors on the floor, so when the truck goes over to get to the main gate, if there is anything on the car, it will more than likely fall off, and it scans to let him know who is entering the property. They are there to do a sweep under the car as well.”

“Does someone want to kill him? Who does all of this for a home?”

She smiled. “He’s Menace Caselli... a name that is very powerful. There’s a lot of people that want his position and he makes sure that they can never get it, and his family is protected.”

“Family?”

“He has sisters and a brother.” Jeffie looked at her watch. “I’m not sure when you’ll meet them... they don’t come around much.”

“That’s sad.”

Her phone sounded, and she quickly picked it up and jumped into work mode. I admired how she could keep everything together without a strand of hair being loose.

As we inched closer to the gates, the driver put the window down and waited a second before he quickly punched the number in and looked into the camera that moved in his direction. Soon as the camera verified who he was, he pulled up and lowered Jeffie’s window down, and she repeated the same process with the phone tucked between her ear and shoulder.

Soon as she was verified, the iron clad gates opened, allowing us access into what looked like trees. Each tree along the winding gravel road had a light that illuminated near the root of the tree. It was an overcast day, so the sun wasn't out, and it appeared darker, even for it being in the afternoon. We drove for a mile before we wrapped around a turnabout, and the house in question came into view.

My breath was caught in my throat when I took in the home in front of us. Forget home, this looked like it could be a college campus or something. It was so massive and black.

Very dark.

Every inch of this home with its sleek glass balcony, slate exterior and black gloss material screamed luxury. We pulled onto the Nantucket pavers that were perfectly layered.

On the ride up from the gate, I felt my ears pop and looked at the driver and Jeffie to see if they felt the same thing. Now, I knew why my ears had popped. We were surrounded by forest; however, this home was elevated on a cliff, far away from everything and everybody.

Talk about isolation.

The lush greenery made the harsh lines of this modern mansion soften. It was a give and take, and I think both elements, the home being slate, concrete and mostly glass, along with the greenery that surrounded it, complimented each other.

"This...this is where I'm going to live?"

Jeffie smiled as the driver opened the door for her. "Yes... not too shabby, huh?"

I didn't move from the seat as I watched her easily walk around the front of the truck and look through the windshield. The door on my side opened and I stepped out, not knowing what to do or say.

This was normal for Jeffie because she had probably been here over a dozen times. She picked up her phone again and gestured for me to follow her through the wide glass door. Soon as we walked in, we stepped through another door, and I jumped when a mist fell down onto her from the glass doorway.

"It's a sanitizing mist... kills germs."

I walked through and felt the cold mist sprinkle over my clothes as I walked further into the foyer. There were no family pictures on the wall,

just massive pieces of art and statues. The textured walls, dramatic modern chandelier and the floating staircase didn't disappoint.

The marble floors were so clean you could eat off them. They were sparkling as we walked into the house.

"He doesn't mind shoes downstairs; however, no shoes are allowed on the second and third level. Well, the third level is off limits to you... it's his bedroom, office, and his sanctuary."

"Noted."

"Mess... he hates a mess, Stevie. Legit will flip out if he sees crumbs or anything. The man has a way he does things. In the fridge, everything has an order, and he makes sure of it."

As I half listened to Jeffie running everything down, my stomach felt uneasy. It was so much, and I was suddenly feeling overwhelmed by it all. She spoke so quickly and knew *everything* that he liked and didn't like.

If her telling me everything wasn't enough, I nearly passed out when she slid a door open off the kitchen, and there was a full room dedicated to fridges.

Yes, plural.

This man had a wall full of industrial refrigerators, and they were all color coated. One had every green fruit, vegetable, smoothie, and drink color coded, and neatly put. Then another had a bunch of red smoothie drinks in it, along with red apples, because God forbid we put a Granny Smith in there.

"You can help yourself to anything that you would like... just make sure you don't mix things up. Colors go with each other, and then..." she walked over toward the other side and slid another door open, and my eyes nearly fell out of my head.

It was a candy store.

A literal candy store filled with different variations of candy. I was no longer worried about everything that Jeffie had run down to me, I was focused on all the candy and snacks she had shown me.

"I know this is a lot, and I do plan to run everything to you. Just wanted you to have some of the knowings of living with Menace Caselli."

"Some?" I blurted.

Jeffie laughed. "I know, I know, it is a lot and that is the reason I no longer live with him."

"You used to live with him?"

She waved me off. “Years ago, when we were younger... me and Menace practically grew up together.” I watched as she checked her watch. “I have a meeting to make for this ball in Monaco... we’re hopefully finalizing the last details, and I can’t miss this one. Let me show you where you’ll be staying, and the driver has brought in your suitcase and cell phone.”

I followed her through the museum of a house. It looked unlivable and perfect. There wasn’t a pillow or carpet out of place. As we made our way through the house, I started to see if I could spot something that is out of place.

I never did.

Jeffie opened one door to the double doors down the hall on the second level. “This is my room?”

She smiled. “Yes... maybe one day you both will want to share one room.”

“Yeah, no thanks,” I muttered and walked past her into the room, taking in the hues of beige, cream, and mauve. The tufted wall behind the plush bed filled with bedding that matched the entire room had me in awe. The plants in the corner were fake, still, it added to the decor of the bedroom.

My room was right off the backyard, so there was a sliding door and a glass balcony I could utilize. From where the house sat in the hills, you got a full view of Staten Island, and the Verrazano bridge in the distance. It felt like we were royalty looking down on the kingdom.

The driver came into the room and handed Jeffie something. She thanked him and gave him an ETA on when she would be done and ready to leave. “You’re leaving me here alone?”

“You’re not alone... my assistant is here as well. She’s interning right now, and the goal is for her to be able to fill some of my roles when I decide to step back some.”

“Hmph.”

“You are probably tired and want a shower...I know this is all a lot and happened so fast. I can also tell that you are overwhelmed as well. Call your cousin and everyone who has been looking for you.” Jeffie handed me my phone and I slowly took it while sitting on the edge of the bed.

“We’re supposed to get married and then live life together... for how long?”

Jeffie sat down beside me and put her hand on my shaking leg. “Me and Skyler talk... a lot. I know life hasn’t been easy for you since you lost your mom, Stevie. Don’t think about how long you’ll be married, look at it as a way to reset. Focus on you and the things that you love... reinvent Stevie and find that spark again. Yeah, sure, you’re sharing a home with a stranger, but I can assure you that you’re safe with him.”

I released the tension in my shoulders and swiped away a tear. When she mentioned my mother, something inside of me broke. I don’t know why hearing Jeffie mention my mother caused me to break down.

“I always find myself in some foolishness... none of this would have happened if my mother was here.”

“Or this happened because your mother put this into play. I mean, without the stealing and killing. However you choose to look at this is up to you.” She smiled, squeezing my knee and standing up.

“Thanks, Jeffie.”

“Don’t mention it... call your cousin please. Greene is somewhere around here, probably in my office on the ground floor. The buttons on the wall near the night tables can connect you to the kitchen, housekeeping, valet, and takeout.”

“Takeout?”

“He rarely uses the button. Menace is particular when it comes to his food... so it’s rare that he eats out. He has his chef prepare anything, anyway... Lupita lives in the guest house through the trees... she spends the day in the house, so you can catch her in the kitchen or out back if you’re hungry.”

“Thanks, Jeffie.”

She smiled and then headed out the room as I sat there with my cellphone in my hand. The second I powered it on, I waited for a few seconds before all the messages and missed calls bombarded the screen.

Skyler, Alex, and even Core’s name popped up on my screen. He called twice, which I assumed he stopped calling because he found out what his sick best friend was up to. I pressed Skyler’s name and took a deep breath as the phone rang.

“Stevie Raye, you better be gone and calling me from the spirit world... one second. How can I help you? Yes, DA Fern is out for a family emergency... I can take a message and schedule something when she’s back in the office... sure... Berkeley? I thought I recognized your voice. You

want an interview with her? Um... sure. Let me take a message and give it to her when she's back to work... cool...you, too." I could hear her hang the phone up, which meant she was at work. "The fuck she wanna interview Capri for?" she muttered, probably forgetting I was on the phone.

"Skyler?"

"Where in the world have you been? What happened to keeping communication when on vacation? I've been calling, worried sick about you. I even called Alex."

"And got him worried."

"For good reason... I tried to look into your hotel, and it said that you checked out. Priscilla was no use because she didn't answer her phone. Are you alright?"

"Yes, I met someone," I prepared myself to lie to my cousin about what I was involved in. What she didn't know at this moment wouldn't kill her.

"What? You went ghost because you met someone?"

"He's perfect, Skyler... such a gentleman, and sweet, too. God, I think I'm in love," I continued to lay it on thick. "We wanted to commit all our time to each other."

She groaned into the phone. "Who is this man, Stevie?"

"You'll never believe me."

"Try me." I heard her slurping an iced coffee. How did I know it was an iced coffee? Because Skyler had at least three a day. We both would have so much coffee and forget to eat, then complain about a headache.

We were just girls. Okay?

"Menace."

Skyler broke out in a fit of choking, so much so that I could hear someone in the background asking if she was alright. "I'm...I'm alright," she choked out as she tried to get her coughing under order. "Who?"

"Menace Caselli... we met in the Bahamas, and I think I'm in love." I rolled my eyes, while my tone remained excited.

"Core's best friend, Stevie? You cannot be talking about Menace, the nutcase."

I held back my laugh. "Not too much on my love."

It felt so weird lying to her because I always told her everything. This time, I couldn't bring myself to tell her what I had gotten myself mixed into because I knew how she would act. Skyler was the kind of person that

always wanted to fix everything, and this was my mess, and I had to fix it on my own.

This was something that I had to do and prove to myself. Skyler couldn't get me out of my mess every time. She was a mother, and if she stopped being stubborn, she would have a family with Core.

Where did that leave me?

Marrying Menace was outlandish, however, what if it wasn't the worst thing? If anything, it would be cool to be friends and married. We were helping each other out and could still live our own lives.

To the public we were married and in love. Behind closed doors we would do whatever we wanted with our own lives.

"Where are you? When are you coming home, Stevie?" she sounded fed up listening to me tell her that I had fell for Menace.

Skyler knew him better than I did, so I wasn't convinced that she believed me. He did seem out there at the warehouse, and a bit of a loose cannon. Every time he wanted to do something impulsive; I noticed he would rub his hands together.

Seven times.

I was so nervous that I watched his every move, counting each time he did it. One of the times, we made eye contact, and I was sure that he was going to kill me for watching him too hard.

"Soo, about that... I'm not coming home. He invited me to move in with him, and I think I'm going to do it."

Skyler was full on choking now and I could actually hear someone hitting her back to help her stop. "Drink some water... Jesus," I heard someone instruct her in the background.

"Pam... I am alright... Thanks," she replied. "Moving in with him? You don't even know him, Stevie? What were you doing... drugs?"

"He makes me feel so good, Skyler." I yawned, wanting to shower and then climb into this bed to get some sleep.

"Well, I'm coming to see you at his house... I want to make sure you're not being held against your will... do you need me to bring anything?"

I ran down everything I wanted her to bring before she told me to reach out to Alex and we ended the call.

Me: Alex... I'm alive. Will call soon.

Alex: Okay. Don't do that again, Stevie. Was worried.

Me: sorry.

I grabbed my luggage and rummaged through what I had and found a pair of pajamas before walking into the massive bathroom. The glass encased shower was the star of the bathroom with a rain shower head.

Between the bamboo ceiling and travertine and glass shower, the bathroom was like a dream. I looked at the controls on the wall and smiled as I pressed whatever. When I discovered how to control the temperature and make the glass frosted, I went over to the sink and unpacked my cosmetics bag that had my makeup and skincare along with my travel toothpaste all in one bag.

Looking in the mirror, I smiled at myself and then closed my eyes and said a prayer to my mother. I needed her to lead the way, show me what I was supposed to be doing. Tell me if this was the right move for me.

No matter if Skyler wanted to admit it or not, she was slowly building something – a family – when it came to her, Core, Jeffie, and Estella. She just needed to stop being stubborn and realize it.

I just wanted my own thing, too, so even if I had to fake it until I made it... I had no other choice but to become Menace Caselli's wife.

OceanofPDF.com

Menace



SHE SLEPT PEACEFULLY, HER CURLY HAIR WAS FRESHLY WASHED. I COULD smell the almond and rose shampoo and conditioner I kept in all the bathrooms in the house. She smacked her teeth like she was eating something and did a few small jumps as she slept.

Her chest slowly lifted up and then fell as she made small noises while she was asleep. There was no doubt that she was beautiful. I've had my fair share of women, some of what the world would consider the baddest, and it was this unique shorty that had me sitting in her room watching her sleep.

There was a part of me that wanted to slide into bed beside her and lay next to her. Shit was weird because I hated for anyone to touch me. I remember when I was fucking Kim and she strung her arms around my neck, I nearly head butted her for doing something so stupid and out of the norm for our situation.

Even thinking about the shit now had me wanting to call her, invite her over here, so I could headbutt the shit out of her for trying that shit with me. Wonder stirring from her sleep pulled me from my thoughts. A soft melody played from her phone and her hand found its way to the night table as she blindly felt around for her glasses.

It was dark, a little after ten at night, and here I was showered and sitting in her room in my monogrammed robe. She took a little minute before she located her glasses and then rested them on her chest.

"Jesus, what did I get myself into?" she spoke out loud. "He's not that bad... aside from the weird rules and full sanitizing mist to enter the house. You can live with that, right?"

“I’m not bad at all. You’re the one talking to yourself and then answering yourself, Wonder.” I made my presence known and she shot up in the bed, her wild hair all over her head.

Her curls were thick and full, perfect coils that framed her face. She quickly put her glasses on as she looked across the room at me sitting in the seating area. “Were you watching me sleep?”

“I was.”

My honesty caught her off guard. “Why are you sitting in the dark? I can’t even see you.” She finally found her words, while turning the lamp on next to her.

With the size of the room, the small light only illuminated the area she was in, leaving me in the dark.

“I like the dark, Wonder... calms me.”

She nodded her head and looked around the room. “Your home is very beautiful.”

“Appreciate it.”

“Like a fortress... nobody is getting in here.”

“I take protecting myself seriously... I have a soon to be wife to protect, too.”

She smiled. “Yeah, right.”

“What’s on your mind, Wonder? I can hear your thoughts way over here.” She pulled the covers off her body and sat on the edge of the bed until she got up and walked toward the windows.

She hugged herself as she looked out the window, as I took in the cami pajama set that she wore. Witnessing her ass in those shorts made me happy that I was still in the dark because I was about to fucking drool.

As she remained quiet and stared out the window, I observed her. My job was to observe women, make sure they were up to the standard of Case House. Observing them wasn’t just physical, either. I had to mentally get inside these women’s minds, and learn who they were. I was a good judge of character, and now with so many women under Case House, I wasn’t as hands on as I used to be.

Hence why I allowed some thieves in my camp, and it was really fucking with me that I couldn’t kill two of the people involved. The Case House women that thought they were slick were no longer breathing.

I didn’t sit around and wait for shit; I moved on things the minute I found out about the shit. The only reason Raye and Priscilla weren’t

stinking, was because of the beauty in front of me. She was the person holding their lives in her hands.

“All I wanted was a vacation. It’s been so long since I’ve been on one... not since my mother passed away. Life has been so up and down... I have my high moments and then the low moments are so low that it makes me think what is life for anyway,” she rambled.

I removed myself from the chair and walked across the room, standing beside her and taking in my massive backyard, and view of Staten Island. Whenever I took in this view, I always felt like the king looking down on its subjects. I would never say that shit out loud, but the shit made me feel like royalty.

“Why the fuck would you do some dumb shit like transferring money into your account?” I asked, and she was caught off guard by the question or I guess how blunt I was.

Her head snapped in my direction before she turned to look back out the window when she realized I wasn’t going to apologize for the way I asked the question. “She’s my friend, I didn’t think she was doing something that could come back to kill us.”

“Was.”

“Yeah... was,” she sighed.

I slipped my hands in the front pocket of my robe and picked with the seam as we both took place in the window. “Look, I trust Jeffie with my life. There’s not much I do without getting her advice and she seems to think this shit is a good idea for the both of us. I need a wife, and you want your father and ex-best friend to live. The other side of this is that I kill them and you don’t marry me... and I really want to kill them.”

“How would this work?” she finally turned and was staring up at me. “Are we allowed to have relationships outside of this, you know, because this is fake. Do we continue to live together... I have so many questions.”

“Wonder, the minute you let another nigga touch you is the moment you gonna see why they call me Menace.”

She raised her eyebrow, skeptical of my statement, then folded her arms. “I’ve seen how you get down... earlier in that stinky warehouse.”

I laughed. “Nah, baby, that was light compared to how I come... not many can speak about it because they’re no longer with us.”

“So, you’re allowed to have relationships and I’m not.”

“Never said that.”

“Then we’re supposed to be miserable in this house without companionship... I mean, I’m not looking for anything right now, men kind of suck... especially Cornell,” she rolled her eyes and muttered to herself.

“Tony... Cornell... who the fuck are these people?”

Her head snapped up when I mentioned Tony. “How do you know Tony?”

“Wonder, you mentioned it at the warehouse.” I looked at my watch, and then over at her as she watched me.

“You and Jeffie always look at the time... what is so important that you need to know the time of the day at every second?”

I yawned. “You hungry?”

“Starving... Beans was very nice and got me chicken one of the days, but if I never see a sandwich again, I would be perfectly fine with that.”

“I see Beans had favorites.”

She smiled. “Maybe he knew I was innocent and I’m not a thief.”

“You steal grapes while food shopping... you’re a thief.”

I watched as she stomped her foot, sending her thighs jiggling. She squinted her eyes at me, then wrinkled her nose at me in this cute smirk. “Tell me you haven’t eaten a few grapes while food shopping.”

“Don’t food shop, so I wouldn’t be able to tell you.” I turned to head toward the door and looked over at her. “It’s just us tonight, so you can wear a robe or not.”

I watched as she looked at the robe with the Caselli crest on it. She grabbed the robe and put it on as she followed behind me.

Some nights Duke stayed in the guest house in the back with Lupita, it was two units. Other than security making their rounds around the property, it was always only me in the house after Jeffie left for the day.

I coolly walked down the hall and heard her bare feet slap against the floors behind me. “Why does one need a house this big?”

“I like having space.”

“You don’t get lonely here?”

“Nah.”

She continued to trail behind me. “I would get lonely here... then again, I’m lonely in my apartment sometimes. Estella usually keeps me company, but when she’s not there I get lonely. Why are you talking about your loneliness?”

I stopped and turned around. “You talk to yourself often, Wonder?”

She goofily smiled at me. “Is that a problem? I mean, we don’t have to get married if that is a problem.”

“You didn’t have many friends growing up, huh?”

“No.” She looked down.

I lifted her chin. “Me either.”

She smiled at me and then continued to follow me down to the kitchen.

“Can I make us something? I’m a really good cook.”

“My food is already prepared.”

“Meal prep? Are you on a meal plan?”

“Nah.”

She whispered something to herself as she followed me into the kitchen and then into the walk-in fridge. I went to the fridge that was designated for my prepared meals that Lupita made every day.

She would make all my meals for the day before I was up in the morning and have them sitting on the counter to cool, then put them in the fridge if I didn’t get around to eating them for the day.

Like now.

I was busy all day and hadn’t eaten anything except for breakfast. Stevie looked at the meal in the plastic container and turned her nose up. “You can have anything in the world, and *this* is what you’re eating?”

Baked chicken, white rice and corn – fresh corn.

“The fuck wrong with my food... here... I didn’t eat lunch so you can have that one.” I handed her the second container and she looked at me and sighed.

We went back into the kitchen, and I pressed the button, and the microwave came out the drawer. While my food heated up, I leaned on the counter and watched as she shook the food around in the container.

“Guess I’m confused on why you’re having the same meal twice in one day? I can understand being on a strict diet... but you don’t take me as someone who is.”

I wasn’t about to get into why I liked what I did. This had been one of my favorite meals since I was a child. I didn’t eat it every day, but I did have it often. I was picky when it came to my food, and what I had.

My food couldn’t touch, and I didn’t like sauces on my food. The shit freaked me out whenever Landon squirted a ton of fucking ketchup on his eggs. What sociopath used ketchup on their eggs anyway?

I enjoyed shit the way that I did and lived alone because I never had to explain anything. With Stevie looking down at the meal, I knew eventually I would have to explain my way of life to her. It was one thing to hear it from Jeffie, and another thing to hear it from me.

I wasn't there with her yet.

After I snatched the container from her and heated her food, we sat at the counter together. She pushed the chicken around the plastic container before she took a small bite.

I waited for her to say something because although it was a simple meal, Lupita made the best baked chicken. "Wow, it's so flavorful, and moist. Chicken breast is almost always dry."

I cut into my chicken and nodded my head, while she ate her food. Silence consumed us, neither of us feeling like we needed to have a conversation right now.

A lot happened today, so we didn't need to sit and discuss anything. When I woke up this morning, I didn't think that I would be welcoming a woman that stole from me into my home.

Stranger shit has happened... I guess.

OceanofPDF.com

Stevie



THE AUTOMATIC BLINDS THAT HAVE BECOME MY ENEMY OPENED AND I switched my position in the bed, so the sun didn't beam into my eyes, causing me to howl in absolute pain.

Maybe I was dramatic.

I kept the room dark, so when the automatic shades opened, the sun felt like a stab to the eyeball every morning. It was hard waking up when I felt like I was going blind in both my eyes. I tried everything to figure out the system the house ran on, especially the one in my bedroom. I felt stupid trying to figure it out, so I had a system to switch positions and bury my head under my covers.

One day turned into two, and then one week turned into two weeks. Menace wasn't around much. He had been out the country, so it was up to me to entertain myself and not die of boredom. Security popped their head in every once in a while to see how I was doing. Green, Jeffie's assistant was here, too.

Her name was strange, and I was still trying to figure out why her mother waddled into a hospital, had a painful labor, and then decided on the name Greene for a little girl. Each time she checked on me, I wanted to ask her how she felt about her name.

The soft knock on the door caused me to further bury myself under the covers. "Come in," My muffled voice called out.

I could hear the doorknob turn and the slight creak of the heavy wooden door. "Good morning, Stevie, am I disturbing you?"

“No... the automatic blinds always wake me up around this time.” I remained under the covers, not wanting to chance a migraine because of the brightness of the room.

She giggled. “I can fix that for you.”

After a few presses of the keypad, I heard the shades lowering, making the room dark again, and under my blankets even darker. “Thank you so much.”

“Don’t mention it. Skyler called and said she should be here within the hour. I can have the chef prepare lunch for you guys on the back patio if you would like.”

I removed the blankets from my head. “Do you think we can get some Chinese takeout? I really would like some Egg Foo Young with fried rice... gravy on the side.”

She reminded me of Jeffie with the way she took notes on her iPad. “And for your cousins?”

I smiled. “She’s bringing Estella, too?”

“Yes.”

Sitting fully up in the bed, I looked at Greene. “You don’t have to be super professional around me, Greene. We’re probably the same age.”

It was like my words released a boulder from her shoulders, as she looked at me. “Jeffie told me I have to always be on... I have to earn the right to move comfortable around Menace... Mr. Caselli.”

“That’s Menace. I hate when people act stuffy around me, and it’s very lonely around here... Lupita speaks to me, but she is also in her fifties, and we have nothing in common.” I gestured for her to take a seat on the edge of the massive bed.

Greene wasn’t sure if she should sit or follow the advice Jeffie had given her. “Are you sure, Stevie?”

“Positive... I’m not sure you know the ins and outs of this arrangement, but I’m going to need a friend. Jeffie is very busy and doesn’t have time and my future husband doesn’t have time. He’s been gone a week and a half, and I haven’t heard from him once... a girl can get lonely.”

She offered me a weak smile. “I’ve heard conversations in passing. Why save your father and friend? You’re sacrificing your life and the chance to find real love to save people that don’t seem like they deserve it.”

I tossed myself back on the mountain of pillows behind me and sighed. “It’s complicated.”

“Doesn’t seem that way. I get wanting to save your father, but the friend? She offered up your virginity on a plate.”

I shot back up. “How do you know so much?”

“I sit in on meetings with Jeffie and Menace at times, and she was pissed about your friend doing that. Can’t say I don’t agree because that is very messed up. Why are you a virgin anyway?”

“Safer that way. You give a boy your virginity, and then things change... some only want it for that reason.”

Greene looked at me briefly before she spoke. “Men.”

“Huh?”

“You said boy... you would be giving a man your virginity, not some boy. It’s scary giving something so precious and sacred to someone, however, you can’t hold onto it forever.”

“Who says?”

“Um, you... you’re going to marry Menace Caselli. Do you honestly think you wouldn’t want to have sex with him?”

Menace was the epitome of sexy with his tattooed covered toffee skin, lush beard, menacing eyes, and that smirk that he wore. If you watched him long enough, you could catch a quick glimpse of the gold teeth he wore on the left side of his mouth. One of which was an outline of his actual tooth.

He towered over me and his body was muscular because he worked out every morning. I was never up when he was working out and never ventured down to the basement where the gym was. I knew he worked out because the few times that I had been up before noon, he was coming from that direction with no shirt on and a towel around his neck.

Lupita would always be right there with his red smoothie, and he would nod and continue up the steps, making sure to snatch his sneakers off before he made it to the bottom of the steps. Menace Caselli was every woman’s wet dream, and I was supposed to marry him.

Greene wasn’t wrong.

How could I deny a man that damn beautiful of taking my virginity? Especially because I wanted him to when I looked at him.

Then again, I didn’t know Menace enough to even consider those things, which was crazy because I was supposed to marry him. “We barely know one another, and I’m pretty sure I trigger the hell out of him.”

She stood up with her iPad in tow. “I’m sure we will see when he arrives tonight. He and Jeffie are in route back to the United States, and he

should land tonight. Jeffie never comes back with him to the house; she goes home and probably takes her head off after dealing with him non-stop.”

“Why does he travel so much?”

“Businessman... he owns a lot of things, Stevie. Aside from Case House, the man has his hands into everything... either way, I will go and get your lunch for you and your cousin.”

“Chicken nuggets for Estella... she loves them.”

She held the doorknob and smiled. “Noted.”

By the time I dragged myself out of the bed, showered, and got dressed Skyler was beginning security clearance through the front. I pulled my hair into a messy bun, switched my glasses to my favorite round pair, and then pranced out the room, down the hall, and stairs until I got to the foyer.

Even though I was lying to her, I missed both Estella and Skyler very much. I was used to seeing them every day and the fact that I had gone weeks without seeing them was strange. Me and Alex kept up through text message or calls.

Alex was alright as long as he knew I was safe and was fine with me not being home. I was trying to figure out a way to tell him that I was getting married. He knew I was a little out there and supported me, so I was nervous to see what his reaction would be.

Washington, the head of security of the home opened the front door. Soon as he opened the door, Estella looked around like she was in the White House, while Skyler was used to it. She had mentioned she had been here a few times.

“Welcome to my humble abode,” I held my arms out and spun in the massive foyer, while Skyler shook her head and laughed.

“Stevie!” Estella dropped her bags and ran full force into me, as I bent down to hug my little Sour Patch Kid.

The reason she’s a Sour Patch Kid is because she stuck her gum in the back of my head last year, and Skyler had to cut a few curls to get it out. Then, she kissed my cheek and said that her mama said she’s not supposed to have gum.

“Hi, my favorite girl. I’ve missed you so much.”

“You come home.” She looked into my eyes as I kissed her cheeks and rubbed my hands through her curls.

“Um, not yet... soon, okay?”

Greene came around the corner and smiled at Skyler. "Hey Greene, how has it been since Jeffie has been gone? You can tell me... peaceful," she teased her.

I watched as Greene smiled. "Less tense, and I've been flowing through my work easier. Jeffie is tense... she doesn't play when it comes to things being in correct order."

"Well, you met your boss... I listened to that man throw a fit over how a woman used the toothpaste... that's who you're so in love with, right?" Skyler looked over at me.

"Yes, he's my little apple dumpling butt," I forced a smile, picking Estella up and walking further into the house. "Zip it," I mouthed to Greene as I passed by her.

She was smart, took the hint and went to do whatever she was going to do. I led us out to the backyard where our lunch was already set up on the concrete outside table. The waterfall from the pool was going, and it was a warm summer day.

The shade from the house gave us a slight relief from the brutal sun. "I haven't had anything to eat today. This morning, we had mediation with Keyshawn and his mama... why nobody told that lady that those braids aren't for her... I could put four of my fingers in each part... old bitch."

"Bad word, Mama," Estella corrected her mother.

Skyler smiled. "Mama is upset, and I am very sorry. Want to eat your nuggets over there with the TV?"

Estella nodded her head as Skyler took her over toward the outside TV. Menace had his home set up where he never had to leave. I had been in the house for two weeks, and although I was bored, he did have everything.

I was the kind of person that never sat still for long. Sitting still for too long forced me to think, and I didn't like my thoughts all the time. They weren't a safe space for me all the time. It was better to keep myself busy.

Greene told Skyler she would get Estella set up. Skyler held her bag to her side and then smiled at me. "Stevie, I love you."

"Love you more, Skyler... always will. It's us against the world."

She smiled at me. "Then be honest with me and tell me why you're here... I'm not stupid. Menace is an acquired taste and the both of you are like oil and water. Jeffie has been avoiding me because she is holding something in, and Core who calls me every damn day, has dialed back on his calls which tells me that he's hiding something too."

I lowered my head and then looked up at her. "Promise me that you aren't going to lose your shit, Skyler."

She got settled into her chair. "I promise."

"No... really promise."

She sucked her teeth and then looked at me. "I put that on our old ass granny's life."

Satisfied with her reply, I took a deep breath and looked at her. "Priscilla was stealing money from Menace. The money she put into my acco—"

Skyler shot out of her chair with that infamous pointer finger in my direction. "I fucking knew it, Stevie Raye! I knew she was up to no good and we all felt the same way... Cindy included."

"You promi—"

"I don't give a fuck about that old hoe... what did she get you into, Stevie? And why are you alive and not stinking somewhere?"

I heaved a sigh. "She was sleeping with Raye."

Skyler slumped down in the chair and looked across the table at me. "Your father, Raye? My uncle, Raye?"

"Yes. He didn't know that she was my friend, and she didn't know he was my father."

"Find that hard to believe," she snorted.

"And she offered her virginity up to toss Stevie under the table," Greene blurted, placing both hands on the concrete table and taking a breath like she was so relieved.

I looked at her and she mouthed *sorry* before scurrying away. "Wow."

"Wow?"

"Wow," she repeated for the second time while her mind was wandering. Skyler was trying to find a way to fix this, and I didn't need her help fixing this.

"I know that look."

"What look?"

"The one where you want to fix everything for me... I love you, but no. I should have listened and now this is my mess to clean up."

Skyler folded her arms. "And how do you plan on fixing this mess?"

"Menace needs something, and I need to keep my father and Priscilla alive."

Skyler choked on her spit because she hadn't touched anything since sitting down. "You want to keep them alive?"

"Well, Raye didn't know the money was going into my account. He's kind of innocent in all of this when you think about—"

"Innocent? I understand that he's your father, but he was stealing. Not only stealing, but he also stole from a powerful family like the Caselli's. That's like me walking into the Delgato's compound and slapping Jean Delgato... dangerous and stupid, Stevie."

I put my face in my hands. "What do you want me to do? Give the word for him to kill my father... I don't care about him, but damn, I can't live with knowing I didn't do something to save him."

She reached across the table and grabbed my hands from my face. "Would he do the same for you, Stevie?"

"I can't think like that, Skyler."

"You should though, Stevie." She took a deep breath and then looked at me. "Raye aside, you want to save someone that offered your virginity up. What if it wasn't Menace they stole from and some sick fuck that would have taken the offer." Skyler had tears in her eyes as she looked at me. "I love you, Stevie, and I know sometimes you like to live in this world of make believe, but this could have ended bad for you. What would I have done if you were...." She couldn't get the words out as she broke down crying.

Estella saw her mother start crying and ran across the yard to console her while I came around the table. Like we've done before, we all hugged each other as Skyler tried to stop crying.

"Love you, Mama," Estella kissed her mother's arm, as I kissed her temple.

"Love you, Skyler."

She sniffled. "Love you three the most... it's us against the world."

"Always. Nothing changes with that. I promise it will not change," I assured her, not knowing if I could keep that promise.

Estella went back over to her half-eaten nuggets while I returned back to my seat and Skyler dabbed her eyes. "Why does Menace need to marry you?"

"I don't know... assuming it's something business related."

"Stevie, what the fuck," she held her face in her hands as she peered at me through her fingers.

“This is my mess, and I will clean it up. You wanted the truth, and I gave it to you... allow me to do what needs to be done.”

“By marrying Menace Caselli?”

I leaned back in my chair. “I’ve done a lot of thinking on this, and the arrangement isn’t that bad. No more being late on rent, I can live in this big ass house and not have to work unless I want to.”

“What about the actual marriage, Stevie?”

I paused and thought about it. “One thing at a time... did you bring my nail stuff?”

She handed me the second bag she brought, and I smiled. “I’ll take a fresh set for the emotional trauma.”

“I promise if I’m not alright I will let you know.”

“I put that on our old hoe.”

She broke out into laughter. “God forgive me.”

“Uh huh.”

For so long I struggled with my purpose and what I wanted to do with my life. It was a struggle before my mother passed away, then became an even bigger struggle once she was gone. I didn’t know what my purpose was, and I was floating around the world trying to figure out what’s next for me.

When was the change supposed to happen for me? Menace needed a wife for whatever reason, and maybe my purpose was to be the best damn fake wife in the history of fake wives. Living in this home and being taken care of by him wasn’t the worst thing in the world.



I SAT IN THE MAIN LIVING ROOM WITH THE HUGE TV DISPLAYING MY favorite movie. ‘Grown ups’ was my favorite movie, and I had watched it so many times I could put on a one woman show. It was dark throughout the house with the small spotlights that illuminated the floors.

Greene left for the night, so I ate dinner and went upstairs to shower before bringing my blankets and pillow downstairs and making myself comfortable on the couch. Lupita looked at me like I had called her mother

a bitch when she saw me stretching out on the massive couches. Either way, she excused herself for the night. I put on my favorite movie and enjoyed the snacks I had accumulated on the coffee table in front of me.

I recited one of my favorite parts and laughed as if I hadn't watched this movie a million times. When my mother passed away, I slept on the couch and kept this movie on a loop for weeks. There was no one there to stop me, aside for Alex, and even he couldn't get me to shower or leave the house.

His wife tried her best and then decided it was best to allow me to have my process while grieving. As long as I promised her to eat and shower, and unlock the door when she came, she allowed the process.

The movie was so nostalgic for me. You ever listen to a song, smell a fragrance, or watch a movie and you feel the exact moment when you first heard, smell, or watched it in your chest? You could envision the memory so vividly that it almost hurt to reminisce?

That was how I felt about this movie. Me and my mother loved Adam Sandler movies, and we would have movie marathons when we were burned out from life. She would take a Friday off, order our favorite Chinese food and watch movies all day.

Although we had seen the movie a million times, we laughed like we hadn't. Every time I watched this movie, it hurt for a bit, then I smiled because I could hear her laugh, feel the little shove she did when something was *too* funny to her, and see her smile.

God, I missed her smile more than anything.

For a while she lost her smile because of life and having to raise a child alone. My father got to keep his smile while hers slowly faded because she had to step up and do what *needed* to be done. She had to raise me, and I can admit I wasn't the easiest child to raise. I remember I joked once that I wasn't the easiest to love, and she sat me down and told me to never say those words. That I was her biggest blessing and raising me was her absolute honor.

Even as I sat here wiping the tears from my eyes, I remember seeing her face. Some people you could tell that they were lying.

Not her.

I could see the pride, honor, and love exude from her face down toward mine. I used the blanket and dabbed my eyes as I watched one of our favorite scenes in the movie.

"Why are you crying, Wonder?"

I jumped and slowly turned to see Menace standing there. “Christ, were you there the entire time?”

“You’ll never know... answer my question.”

I wiped my face and looked at him real good. He was dressed down in a pair of sweats, white T-shirt that was too crisp for someone who just got off a long flight, and sneakers.

“Do you ever wear anything aside from sweats? Jeans, perhaps?”

“Don’t like ‘em.”

“So, sweats and suits.”

His hands were clasped in front of him. “Only when I have to wear suits, I wear ‘em.”

“What’s so wrong with jeans?”

He looked at me. “What’s wrong with a bra?”

“Makes me feel constricted.”

“Same.”

I eyed him suspiciously. “You wear bras?”

He laughed, and I noticed he had only one gold cap today. “Wonder, why the fuck were you crying?”

“Personal.”

“I’m gonna be your husband. Don’t you think I should know your personal shit?” His hands started to move, and he rubbed them in circular motions.

“This is business... right?”

He didn’t reply, just watched me. Menace had this thing where he observed you, right in front of you. That glare was enough to make you never sin again in life. “It doesn’t have to be.”

“Well, you made it business when you went out of town and never called me.”

“Don’t have your number.”

I shoved my blankets into my arms as I removed myself from the couch. “You had ways to get my number, and you didn’t call to check on me once. Jeffie called me every day, and I heard you in the background and you never asked for me.”

“Are you mad at me because I didn’t ask how you were, Wonder?”

“My name is Stevie. I get this marriage is something that helps us both out... mostly me because you can marry anyone you want. We don’t need

to pretend this is something that it's not. Just let me know when the wedding is so I can show up."

I stomped away, my blanket trailing as I headed to my bedroom, and he stood there. No emotion, rebuttal, or anything. It was like he was content with pissing me off and would sleep like a baby because of it.

When I made it to my room, I hated that I had blown up like that. The truth was that he had scared me and saw me vulnerable about my mother. I didn't feel comfortable enough telling him about her.

This was fake and my mother's death was very much real. The two should never mix, and I needed to check my emotions at the door.

It was business.

OceanofPDF.com

Menace



THE FLIGHT FROM JAPAN WAS EXHAUSTING.

It didn't matter if you traveled in style either. My jet was equipped with whatever I wanted or needed for long flights. Half the time me and Jeffie never saw one another because I stayed on one side, and she stayed on the other.

After a business trip and long flight, I was always greeted home with silence. The sound of the TV blaring could be heard from the front door. It was always quiet in my house when I returned home.

The silence was deafening and at times I would play music to kill through it. This time, the sound of a movie playing in the distance made my heart jump. It was like I remembered there was a woman now staying in my home.

When I rounded the corner, she was wiping her face as tears fell down her cheeks. I thought it was something she was watching that was making her cry and dispelled that thought when I saw she was watching an Adam Sandler movie.

That man's movies never made you cry like the way Wonder was sitting on the couch crying. I stood there for a minute before making my presence known.

What I didn't expect was for her to go off about me not calling her. This shit was new to me. Was I supposed to call her? I mean, shit, I made sure she got water, sun, and food. The fuck else was I supposed to do from across the world?

The word business arrangement hit me harder than it should have. Wonder wasn't wrong, this was exactly what this was. I didn't like to think of the shit like that because she was in my home.

My home was sacred, and I didn't welcome anybody in this bitch. She was not only in my home, but she had settled in and made herself comfortable. The sound of my automatic shades opening had me open my eyes.

I remained in bed for a few seconds too long and was inside my head. Thinking about how she called me out about not calling her.

Why did she care so much?

Not knowing why she was crying kept me up most of the night, too. What made a woman like Wonder cry? She was easy going, spunky, and always positive, even when she was moments from dying.

The light knock followed by the shuffling across my heated floors, and the humming caused me to lean up in my bed. Purple was putting down the laundry on top of the chairs in the room to be put away by housekeeping.

She had one headphone on and was shaking her hips while humming, which was further pissing me off. When she turned, she jumped, dropping my white cashmere Brunello Cucinelli shirt on the floor.

A shirt that cost eleven hundred dollars and she had my shit on the floor. "You used to make your Barbies fuck, huh?"

"Excuse you?"

"Why the fuck are you in my crib with those little ass shorts, knowing my future wife is on the bottom level?"

Plum's cheeks turned red as she looked at me. "I promise I didn't mean anything. Before coming in, I worked out and didn't have time to go home to change, so I came right to work... Jeffie is out for a few days."

I watched as she shifted her weight on each foot, and stood there looking awkward. "Bottom drawer... take a pair of sweats and put them on. Don't ever come in this house with shorts that fucking little on. You see Jeffie walking around like that?"

"No, Mr. Caselli."

"Fucking Menace!" I roared, tossing myself back onto the bed, and whipping the covers from my body.

She grabbed a pair of sweats, picked my shirt up from the floor and got ghost. I hit the button on my night table to turn the heat on the floors up

more and then went to shower. Grabbing a fresh washcloth, I climbed into the shower and grabbed my body wash.

One.

Two.

Three...

I counted the amount of times I squeezed the shower gel onto the washcloth. The waterproof clock on the wall told me the time, and I spent the time washing my entire body four times.

If I didn't wash my body four times, then I wasn't clean and then I couldn't function for the day. As a child, I remember my father forced me out the shower because we were running late. A nigga broke out in hives because I felt like I was dirty.

My mother had to pick me up from school because the shit was so bad. It wasn't easy having my brain wired like this. The shit became exhausting to myself and the people around me, but I couldn't function if I didn't do the things that I had to do.

As I wrapped the towel around my waist, I looked in the mirror and grabbed my pill bottle. Popping two pills, I swallowed them without water while looking in the mirror at myself. I was so much to so many, and nobody really even knew the real me.

It was hard letting someone in and never knowing their intentions. My uncle fucked over my father, so how the fuck was I supposed to trust people? Trust was something that had to be earned, and even then, you had a few years of me really watching you to see if you were as solid as you portrayed.

When I came out the bathroom, housekeeping was already making my bed. She smiled at me as she continued with the same routine while I entered the closet to get dressed to head down to work out.

Everything in my life had a schedule. If you worked in my house, then you knew the schedule and moved accordingly. I liked things to move how they were supposed to.

How it moved in my mind.

Tossing on a shirt and shorts, I grabbed my sneakers and carried them downstairs before slipping them on and heading to the bottom level to work out for the morning. Hitting the buttons on the wall on my way into my state-of-the-art gym toggled on my song of choice.

Viva La Vida played through the gym's speakers as I nodded my head and started to stretch. I started on the treadmill, running six miles before moving to each machine while the song played on a loop.

I sang that shit in my head every morning while working out, even when I was out the country. The song had no use for me once I completed my workout. It was like fucking a bitch and once you got that nut, everything disgusted you.

Including her.

Alone in my own world, I completed my workout, snatching a water out the fridge and then heading upstairs. My phone buzzed in my pocket, and I saw my sister's name and quickly answered.

"Kora, you good?"

"I am always good," I could picture her smile, even over the phone, as I leaned in the kitchen and accepted the smoothie from Lupita.

"Tacos, Menace," she stressed, wanting me to try anything but what I had her ass making. We had a rotation of meals I liked, and she was always trying to get me to try something new.

"Pasta... sauce on the side."

She groaned and then smiled at me before going into the pantry. "I'm almost certain Jefferey Dahmer ate his pasta the same way. Mav, when are you going to try it mixed together... you've been doing this since a child."

"Why am I getting a call from you?" I switched the subject because I wasn't having fucking tacos, and I wasn't mixing my damn pasta.

She sighed. "I'm off today and figured we could do something. It's been a while since we've done anything together and I miss you, Mav."

I smiled. "Miss you, too, K."

"I have a few online meetings this morning. Text me and let me know what we're doing, and I will meet you there."

"Bet."

"Have you spoke to Zoya?"

"Her man still alive...so no," I nonchalantly replied.

"I didn't hear that... see you later."

"Yeah."

I ended the call and watched as Brown floated into the kitchen, then tried to double back when she noticed me standing in here. "Where the fuck you running to, Purple?"

"It's Greene," she corrected as she slowly turned around.

I stared at her. "Is that not a color?"

"Yeah... I guess."

"Where you going?"

She looked down at her clothes and then the bag she wore on her arm. "Oh, no where... just going to run some errands. Beans is coming to pick me up to take me... my car has been acting funny."

"You fucking Beans, Purple?"

"No... I swear. We're really good friends."

I took a sip of my smoothie. "You wanna fuck him, huh?"

She looked away. "Mr. Caselli... um, Menace, we're just friends."

I looked at my watch. "Since Corleon wanted to make his move on Jeffie, you bitches think this is actual Case House in this bitch... just swapping spit and shit with each other," I ranted and looked across the room at her. "Where were you going? I know for a fact Jeffie left some shit for you to do."

I watched as she walked further into the kitchen. "Stevie is bored. She was telling me how she loves Legos, and I think that it might be fun for her to do. I was going to pick her one up."

Looking at my watch, then back at her. "I'll do it."

"You?"

"The fuck is the problem, Lavender?"

"Nothing... I mean, I could tell Beans to leave."

"Do that, Lilac."

She rushed off to tell Beans to leave, and I made a mental note to ask his ass what the fuck was between them. While she was acting all coy and not wanting to say what it was, I knew Beans would give me the real.

My Wonder was bored, so I was going to take the first step and offer the truce. If she wanted Legos, then I was going to give her Legos.

Me: Meet me at the mall... actually, text me the address to one.

K: The mall? Maverick, you have never even been to the mall... not that I can remember. Are you sick?

Me: Text me the damn address, Kora.

A couple minutes later and she was texting me the address to the nearest mall to me. I headed up the steps, removing my sneakers, and went to shower for the second time today. Three showers a day kept me from

feeling like I was losing my mind at times. On the way up to the third level, I looked down the hall at the room that Wonder was staying in.

The door was cracked, and I could hear music coming from the inside of the room. Brushing off the urge to head down the hall, I continued up the stairs to my bedroom.



“YOU’RE WHAT?” KORA DID A TERRIBLE FUCKING JOB WITH HER FAKE ASS whisper.

She followed behind me with her Hermes Box Kelly Sellier propped on the crook of her arm, button down shirt, and linen shorts with a matching belt to her purse. Her curls were perfectly coiled, and she continued to follow and study me as I picked up different boxes of Legos.

Kora was the Hilary Banks from the sitcom Fresh Prince Of Bel-air with brains, and she didn’t have a father as a judge, she was the judge. While Zoya loved to hang in the hood and mess with niggas that didn’t deserve her spit on their face, Kora was different.

She dated men, usually White, and they nine times out of ten had a trust fund and their father had a hair piece. I knew she played it safe after her last situation, and one would never know if she truly liked these men or just used them to pass time.

The shit didn’t keep me up at night, so I didn’t care what she did. While Kora cared about her brother’s sleep, Zoya could give a fuck if I never slept a day in my entire life. She loved to cause me stress and push my buttons.

While both my sisters were big fucking deals and handled business, they handled it different. Zoya was a fucking big dawg, shark, and whatever animal that described someone who got the shit done.

Kora was quiet with hers, however, get her to that point and she was handing out football numbers and letting you know she wasn’t to be fucked with in and out the courtroom. Despite their differences, they were thick as thieves and leave it to Kora to always try and defend Big Zoya’s fucking honor.

“I paid for that expensive ass school, so I know you know what marriage is.” I pointed to one of the boxes and let one of the workers know I wanted it.

He quickly came over and smiled. “Is that all you want, Sir?”

See, I could respect a man like Josh. He came right over ready to assist and not ask if I could afford the nearly three hundred dollar set. If anything, the man was ready for me to spend more money with him, and because he didn’t start out pissing me off, I was going to do just that.

“I want to grab a few more things.”

“No problem. I will take this upfront and if you need help, let me know and I’m your guy.” He nodded and took the set from me and went to the front.

“Maverick, what in the world is going on?”

“Marriage, Kora... I’m marrying this woman because if I don’t then we won’t be the third founding fucking family anymore.”

“There isn’t any other way around this?”

“No.”

“If this was legal documents, I can probably find a loophole,” she muttered. “Are you forcing her to marry you?”

“We have an agreement. I keep her father and shitty best friend alive, and she marries me,” I explained as I picked up a set that was shaped like an old school radio. “Think she would like this?”

“Maverick, you getting married scares me.”

I paused. “Why?”

“Well, you have never had a relationship... not since.”

“Don’t go there.”

“I’m just saying... that relationship never counted. I think it truly fucked you up from giving real love a chance.”

I ignored my sister and continued to pick out different sets, sitting them on the floor while Josh ran behind me to grab them and put them behind the counter.

A man that is about business.

“We’re not going there.”

“How do you expect a marriage to work?”

I paused, blankly staring down at my sister. “She’s living with me.”

Kora nearly toppled into the display of ‘Twilight’ sets when I mentioned she was living with me. “Living with you? So, this is real... why haven’t

you told me? You're in love, Mav, I can tell."

I laughed. "You can't tell shit because everything is new... I barely spent time with her because I was in Japan, and then she went off on me last night because I didn't call her while I was away."

"Why didn't you call her?" Kora folded her arms with her expensive ass bag still on her arm. To know Kora was to know that she was going to spend money on purses and clothes.

We had that same thing in common. I could get a pack of regular white T-shirts, but wearing a nearly two-thousand-dollar shirt felt better because I could.

I'd like to think every time I spent money my uncle was Harlem shaking in his grave with anger.

"Why should I?"

"Maverick, seriously? This woman is going to become your wife, share our last name and you're asking why you should call her? She's not Kim... this is different from how you treat her. Have you taken her on a date?"

"Nah."

"Jesus, even Landon knows how to treat a woman. How are you this dense when it comes to understanding women?"

"I understand how to fuck, Kora... all I've ever needed to understand."

She paused, looking at the car Lego set. I watched as she put it on the floor and then continued to look up at me. "It's clear I haven't had a heart to heart with Jeffie in a while. What does she think of this?"

"It was her fucking idea." I read the back of the Lego set four times while listening to my sister ask a million questions.

"I haven't been to the house in a wh—"

"Six months."

Kora took the box from me. "You only count obsessively when you're stressed or nervous. Which one is it, Maverick?"

"I don't like the way I feel when I look at her, K."

She was trying to figure out where I was going with what I was saying. "Is she a negative person or something? If you have a bad feeling about her... don't go through with it."

"Last night I came home, and she was in the living room eating snacks and crying watching a movie... loud as shit by the way. I didn't pay attention to the crumbs I'm sure was on the couch or the volume of the TV,

I was more concerned about why she was fucking crying... I don't like that shit."

Kora smiled as she pushed the box back onto the shelf. "You like her, Mav."

"I still don't know why the fuck she was crying and the shit still bothering me. Then she don't want to tell me because this is *business*."

"You're Maverick Caselli. You don't ever have to put in any work when it comes to a woman. Kim would come to you right now if you called her... there's never been a moment when you had to let your walls down and actually get to know a woman, and I'm not talking about her. She must be remarkable for you to actually care. Mav, you have to make her comfortable, allow her to lower her walls to let you in. Plan a date without Jeffie's help and actually take her out to know her."

There has never been a time when I had to put in the effort. I never cared to get to know a woman's name. There was never intimacy, or a deeper connection with the women I've had in the past.

Soon as we fucked, I was sending them back home in a black SUV. I never did that cuddling shit or pretending that it was more than just me getting a chance to relieve some stress. I learned early on being direct was what made things easier in life.

There was never any confusion when it came to being direct. I hated confusion and that was probably why I was counting the Lego pieces in the display that was above my sister's head. If I had to blame anybody for this shit, I would have to say it was Ghost and fucking Rahmeek.

"Now you want me to do shit that I pay Jeffie and her flunky a lot of money to do?"

Kora laughed and checked her phone. "Yes. That shows that you cared enough to do something for her. As much as this was a nice little outing, I have to run."

"Somebody always has to run, and then I never hear from none of you bitches until weeks later."

Kora laughed. "I will call you this coming week. Maybe we can do something at your house... all of us get to know your wife before she actually becomes your wife."

"Yeah."

Kora hugged me quickly, knowing I would have denied her request for the hug. "Love you, Mav... okay?"

“Love you, too, K.”

She smiled before she picked her phone up and headed out the store. I nodded toward Josh, and he grabbed the last remaining Lego sets I wanted and then rang me up. I tapped my titanium card, while Josh and the other employees all decided to shut the store down to help carry all the bags out to the car for me.

Her ass better be so happy that she shows me all her damn teeth once I show her all these Legos I bought her.

OceanofPDF.com

Stevie



GUILT KICKED IN THE NEXT MORNING WHEN I REALIZED THAT I BLEW UP ON Menace and all he asked was what was wrong with me. I avoided him for the next few days, only coming out my room when I knew he was gone. Soon as I knew he was back, the housekeepers talked, I made my way back to my room. On his way up to his room, he would pause on the steps heading to his floor, as if he wanted me to come out and speak to him.

Menace could have called me when he was in Japan, but that wasn't the problem. I was so angry, sad, and resentful because my mother was gone. I was angry with her for leaving me here alone, and then I was resentful of my father.

God continued to keep sparing his life, and this last time he happened to use me to do it. I missed her so desperately and being put in the current situation I was in; I was missing her more. She would know exactly what to say and help me figure this out.

The guilt of watching him stand on the stairs last night was eating me alive, so I woke up early this morning and looked over the clothes that I had left and decided to get dressed. Housekeeping had been washing my clothes, so I didn't feel the need to make a fuss about needing more clothes.

I slipped into the orange maxi dress with frills and thin spaghetti straps. The entire back was out, and it was a risky buy because I hated my back rolls. Since we were going to be on vacation and I would never see those people again, I threw caution into the wind and bought it.

Now I was standing here in the mirror unsure if I even wanted to wear this. The bright side of this was that I wouldn't be leaving the house.

Menace barely paid me any kind of attention anyway.

I removed my sock curlers from my hair and fluffed my curls up, adding a hair perfume into my hair, and checking my dress out. It wasn't that I was insecure about my body – okay I was.

Since I was a child, I had always been a bit chunkier than the other girls. When I was a teenager, that chunk eventually filled out to breast, ass, hips, and thighs, which should have been a relief.

Those curves came with thicker arms and rolls, too. When it was just me staring at my body in the mirror, I loved my body and curves. It was hard to truly stand in your confidence when you had men that wanted model figures. Women with bigger asses, smaller waist, and had no body fat other than their ass.

“I like it.”

I jumped, something I learned that I would be doing often because Menace was like a cat. He was quiet, and you didn't know he was there until he spoke.

My door was open, and he leaned in the doorway watching me in the mirror. Had I actually been paying attention to the mirror, I would have saw him standing there.

“Really?”

“I do.”

I quickly ran across the room. “You don't think the off-white one is better?”

As I held it up to my body, he looked at me weird. “That shit look like a fucking nightgown that a woman that's not trying to get fucked would wear.”

“Okay, Menace... was that necessary?”

“You wanted my opinion, right?”

I put the dress back onto the bed. “I wanted to apologize to you for the other night. You just came off a long flight and I blew up on you for no reason.”

“You had a reason.”

“I didn't have a reason.”

“You did.”

“How are you telling me that I had a reason when I did not have a reason?” I folded my arms and stared at him.

He looked down at his feet, then back up into my eyes. “I didn’t call you and that bothered you. Some other shit bothered you, too, and I want to know why. I also understand that I have to earn that privilege.”

I looked behind me because this couldn’t be the same man from the warehouse a few weeks ago. He had me speechless as I stood there not knowing what to say. “Well, you could have sent a text.”

“Is that something you require in this marriage?”

I nodded my head yes. “I understand this is bu—”

“Fair. I require you not to refer to this as a business arrangement.”

“Is that not what this is?”

He smiled. “Nah.” I watched as he turned to leave the room, then he paused. “I want to take you out on a date, Wonder.”

“Why?”

“Wear that, too... you look beautiful in it.” He winked, and then continued down the hall, leaving me standing in the middle of this room grinning like a fool.

I spun around in my dress and did a quiet giggle because he wanted to take me on a date. My mother always told me to speak my mind, and it wasn’t something I always did. I liked to remain quiet and just silently stew on my feelings.

Telling him how I felt about the non-communication seemed to have worked. He was nicer to me, and he actually smiled and complimented me. It confused me why he didn’t want to refer to this as a business arrangement. It was as if this meant more to him than us both helping the other out.

“Wonder, we leave in twenty minutes,” I heard the intercom on the wall, and I quickly went into the bathroom to put on my gold accessories and put a little oil behind my ears before snatching my purse and heading downstairs.

Duke was at the kitchen counter eating his usual apple. Everyone had a routine around this house, and it drove me crazy. “He’s in the office down the hall on the left.”

I headed down the hall, my sandals slapping the freshly buffed floors in search for this office of his. When I found it, I pushed one of the heavy doors open, and Menace was sitting on the edge of his desk.

It wasn’t the view of him sitting on the edge of the desk that caught me by surprise. He had a bunch of Lego sets all aligned. Each box was aligned

perfectly with the other and laid out on the floor of his office.

“Blue told me that you like Legos, so I went to get you some.”

I looked at the different sets that I dreamed of owning one day, and they were in front of me. “Her name is Greene.”

Don’t ask why that was the one thing I thought to say while taking in all the different sets. “These are expensive, Menace.”

He nodded. “Not for you.”

“Thank you so much... it’s going to take me months to complete these, but I’m so excited.” I placed my purse onto the table and got on my knees as I took in the huge plane that he purchased. I felt like I was in an expensive Lego store with the way he had each box on display for me to see.

He remained on the edge of the desk and watched me move from box to box. When I got to the last box, I stood up and fixed my dress. “Like them?”

“Like? I love them... I had a few of these on my bucket list of things I want.” I rushed into his arms, and he was stiff as a board as I held him. “Um, you usually put your arms around the other person.” I removed myself and looked up at him.

“Don’t do hugs, Wonder.”

I smiled. “Well, I have another requirement.”

He tilted his head to the side and folded his arms. “Let me guess... you want a hug?”

“Hugs. If this isn’t a business deal, then you have to act like it, too. This is the first step, so thank you for thinking of me. It warms my little heart to know that you cared enough to do this... no one does things like this for me.”

Menace Caselli was different, and I could tell from the quirks that I would watch him do. His day was very scheduled and in order, while mine was scattered. We were two opposites expected to be married and share this home together.

We both had managed to stay on our ends of the house. I tried not to get in his way and chose to come out the room when he wasn’t around. Other than the meal we shared the first night I was here, we didn’t eat together.

His meals were still prepared and sat in the fridge. I think Lupita enjoyed cooking a meal for me that wasn’t the same shit that Menace would

eat. She had opened up to me more and had a full menu prepared every morning for me.

She was more excited than me to prepare the food. I loved food, so I never complained about anything. As long as it was good, I was going to finish my plate and want seconds.

“You ready?”

I touched his wrist and looked at the smashed looking watch. “Can I wear your watch today?”

“Fuck no, Wonder.”

“Is it expensive?”

“Not about the price.”

“Then what is it about?”

He started to pick with his thumb, and I looked at him. “If it makes you uncomfortable, it’s alright.”

Menace looked down at me, then pushed up from the desk. He didn’t reply to me, he just grabbed my hand and pulled me behind him out the office and down the hall to where the massive garage was.

All of his cars were on display in the garage with huge glass doors that opened. He had a full staff that worked in the garage, because on one of my main quests through this massive home, I accidentally stumbled into the garage and met them.

“Boss, we pulled the car out for you in the front... you haven’t pulled that one out in a while.” The short Spanish man smiled.

Menace nodded and smirked. “Let’s see if I remember how to drive that shit.”

“What?” I blurted.

“Chill out... till death do us part.”

I tried to remove my hand from him, and he pulled me closer, putting his arm around me in a side hug. “We’re not even married yet... I ain’t trying to die because you don’t remember how to drive.”

He chuckled and pulled me in front of him as we headed to the awaiting car. “Another requirement, Wonder... know that your life is always safe in my hands,” he whispered into my ear before he released me, then swaggered in front of me toward the car.

Why was I breathing so heavy at his words? They were just words, and they had me feeling all out of sorts like he had crooned the words to my

favorite love song. Menace opened the passenger door, and I looked at the Bugatti that was in front of me.

Behind the car, there were three large SUVs waiting to follow behind him. He held the door open for me and made sure I was good before he made his way around the front and then hopped into the driver's seat.

"You ready, Wonder?"

I checked my seatbelt and held onto the door. "Yep."

He revved the engine and then put the windows down before putting Nipsey Hussle on. I watched as he looked over at me and then whipped away from the garage and down the winding driveway to the gates at the bottom. With one hand on the wheel, the other on the stick shift, he maneuvered down the winding road with ease, as the SUVs tried to keep up with him.

He hit the button on the visor, as we came speeding down the hill, and out the gates. The security cheered, as he continued onto the public street and continued to drive with ease. I watched as his forearm flex with each shift of the stick.

"Need a week to think," I rapped the words, and his head snapped in my direction like he was shocked I knew the song.

"Fuck you know about this song, Wonder?"

I smiled. "Me and Skyler love music... why are you surprised?"

He bobbed his head to the music and kept looking over at me as he continued to speed through these Staten Island streets. It was funny that we were on the same streets that we looked over at every morning.

I didn't know where he was taking me, but I enjoyed the ride and the air whipping through the car as he carefully maneuvered in and out of traffic like he had practiced his entire life for this. Like they were paid to do, the SUVs kept right up with him, mimicking his every move. When one of my favorite songs played, I rapped along while throwing fake gang signs like I was affiliated. Menace laughed at me, as he continued switching the gears.

It wasn't a fake laugh either, or those small chuckles he gave me. This laugh came from the belly, and seeing a genuine smile on his face made me smile. "What?"

"Nothing."

It took me a few seconds to figure out how to turn the music down. Once I did, I turned to him because we were in traffic. "Where are we going? Did you have Jeffie set this date up for us?"

“Nah... I planned it.”

I screwed my face up. “If I call her right now?”

“She gonna tell you the same thing.”

His phone rang, and I sat back while grinning like a fool because he planned a date for me. Menace was busy and Jeffie and Greene ran his entire life for him. If he took time to plan a date for me, what did that mean?

“The fuck you mean that nigga is missing? How the fuck does one go missing, Ryan?” he questioned in this manic tone. His veins bulged in his hand and forearm with how tight he was holding the stick shift.

This wasn’t the first time I heard him bring up Ryan’s name. Every time I heard his name when Menace and Duke were talking, it sounded like he was on thin ice. His tone, and how tense his body had become told me that the ice had chipped, and Ryan had better run.

“Uh huh... oh yeah, right... oh now I understand. I’m not using my gun when I shoot you, I’m gonna make you swallow each bullet before I reload and then empty my shit in you, Bitch!” He removed the phone from his mouth and screamed into the phone.

I moved closer to the door in case this man forgot that I was his soon-to-be wife and decided to crash out on me next. He turned the music up and the nice atmosphere and vibe that we had going was ruined.

His thoughts were so loud I felt like I could hear them. When traffic cleared, we were back on our way in silence. As we sped across the bridge into Jersey, I looked down at the message from Cornell.

I wished he would leave me alone. He didn’t even really care about being sorry, he was nervous I would expose him. If he knew me, he would have known I was the last person that would ever expose someone.

My eyes grew heavy as Menace whipped in and out of traffic, so I leaned my head back and took a quick nap. It wasn’t like he was speaking anyway, and the nap would help with the tension in this car. I wanted to add another requirement and decided against it because I read the room.

Skyler would be proud of me for actually following her advice and *reading the room*.



THE CAR DOOR SLAMMING CAUSED ME TO JUMP OUT OF MY SLEEP. ONCE MY eyes adjusted to the light, my heart left my body, and it was my soul looking around at my surroundings. Tears accumulated in my eyes as I started to panic and look for anything.

Something.

“Fuck, Stevie! He’s going to kill you because of whatever Ryan said to him... God, Jesus, Shamu... someone please help me,” I started to hyperventilate and check the mirrors.

He was going off on his security and they stood there allowing him to go off, while Duke stood to the side and watched. I noticed most rules didn’t apply to Duke. He was his security, but he seemed like family and a friend at the same time.

While they were preoccupied, I unlocked the door and tried to open the door. I couldn’t figure the stupid shit out and was trying to remember how he had opened it. *Jesus, if you let me out of this, I promise I won’t steal grapes anymore.*

As if he knew I was telling the truth, I heard a click, and the door started to raise. Soon as I had enough clearance not to knock my head on the door, I hopped out the car and held my dress as I ran on the gravel toward somewhere. I didn’t know where the hell I was going, but it wasn’t going to be in one of these damn grave sites.

“Wonder, where the fuck?” I heard Menace’s voice, and continued running, wishing that I had truly worked out more.

You never knew how much working out was important until you’re sprinting in a pair of Tory Burch sandals, in a maxi dress while clutching your purse and the hem of your dress. I felt a hand on my shoulder, and I screamed.

“Nooo! Help! Please, no!” I screamed, giving up on my trek toward Narnia.

I was flinging my purse and arms around while crying because as much as I missed my mama, a bitch didn’t want to go with her right now. “Wonder, what the fuck are you doing?”

I opened my eyes and noticed it was Menace, without a shirt on and his chest heaving up and down. “Why do you want to kill me? Dawg, I ain’t have shit to do with whatever Ryan did... that should be a requirement... you cannot kill me, please.”

He stared down at me and started laughing while I was bearing my entire soul to him. “Why do you think I’m going to kill you, baby?”

If I wasn’t so upset that he was going to kill me, then laughed about my fear, I probably would have swooned at him calling me *baby*. Except, I was upset that he thought my pain was hilarious.

“Do I amuse you, Mitchell? Am I a fucking... God... give me a second.” I held my hand up and rested my hands on my knees because I felt the vomit tickle the back of my throat.

“Why in the fuck would you jog without stretching?”

My head shot up and I looked at him. “I was running, Mitchell.”

“Why the fuck do you keep calling me Mitchell?”

“’Cause I don’t know your name and I’m being serious right now.” I turned around and spit, feeling the vomit wanting to come because I had decided to run today.

Once I was able to get my breathing under control and knock the vomit back down, I stood up and looked at him. “Why are we here if you’re not trying to kill me?”

When I looked behind Menace, his security and Duke were laughing at me. “This is our date.”

“You took me to a fucking cemetery for a date? Maybe you should have let Jeffie or Greene plan something because what is this?”

He grabbed my hand, and we walked back over to security as they laughed at their phones. “It’s not funny.”

“Mrs. C, you were running like someone in a scary movie... shit was hilarious.”

“I am not, Mrs. C... we don’t even know if I will make it out of this cemetery alive.” I looked at them through squinted eyes.

Menace put his shirt back on and that’s when I noticed his gun tucked in the back. “He always carries a gun with him,” Duke explained when he saw my eyes widen as I said my prayers.

He removed the gun and handed it over to Duke, grabbing my hand and pulling me behind him. For a man I thought was going to kill me, I felt safe

while holding his hand. We walked through the cemetery past all the dead people that I may or may not be joining.

He stopped when we got to a mausoleum with a crest on it. "I told you I was taking you on a date."

"To a fucking cemetery? What in the fuck, Mitchell?"

"My fucking name ain't Mitchell, Wanda."

I paused. "My name ain't no fucking Wanda."

He used his key and opened it, and that's when I backed away. "We're having lunch with my folks."

"Menace, are you alright?"

He stopped messing with the lock and looked at me. "Yeah... the fuck you ask that for?"

"'Cause you took me on our first date to meet your dead parents. I mean, I get it... I would love to schedule some time for you to meet my mom, but she's fucking dead and in the ground."

"You wanna meet them or not?"

He was serious as hell, and I was now thinking back to hearing Skyler talk about how odd he was. Maybe that was why she was skeptical in the first place. This man took me on a first date to meet his dead parents in a mausoleum.

I leaned on him as I peered on the inside and he had it all set up with candles, and takeout bags on a blanket. Honestly, it wasn't as creepy as I thought it was. "Mitchell, this is strange."

"Yeah, get yo' ass inside," he replied and slapped my ass.

I jumped and smiled on the inside. Why did his touch send a damn jolt of electricity through my entire body? Menace helped me onto the floor, as he removed his shoes to avoid creasing them and sat across from me.

"Do you visit here often?"

"When I get the time... haven't been in a few months."

I nodded and looked around the inside and there were pictures of him and who I assumed was his parents. There were family portraits with his siblings, trips of them skiing in Aspen, and so many more pictures.

I read the law degree on the wall that said *Zoya Caselli* and smiled. "Wow, this feels really special."

Now all of a sudden, I felt bad for overreacting the way that I did. He was showing me a piece of him so I could understand him better. Menace wasn't a man of many words, so I assumed this was his requirement.

He wanted me to know him.

It was him showing me that this wasn't a business arrangement to him. "It is...when Kora and Zoya were both sworn in, I made sure to bring their pictures here."

"They're proud."

"How you know?"

I shrugged. "I just have a feeling that they are. The burden of the oldest sibling isn't the easiest to carry."

"Ain't you the only child?"

I folded my arms. "How the hell you know that?"

"I know everything, Wonder." He grabbed the bag of food and opened it while he continued to take everything out.

"Well, just because I don't have any doesn't mean I don't know the burden of being everything to someone. Were you young when you lost your parents?"

"A teen."

"I'm sorry."

He nodded letting me know he appreciated my apologies. I watched as he looked through the containers and then over at me. "I'm about to put somebody in a fucking grave because why they put the fucking barbeque sauce on my fucking chicken?"

He was disgusted as he held the plastic bowl in his hand. "What kind of chicken did you order?" I scooted closer to him and took the container from him.

"Barbeque chicken."

I stopped and had to run the conversation back in my head, so I didn't sound stupid. Maybe I missed something in the conversation. "You wanted barbeque chicken, no?"

"Yeah."

"Mitchell, they gave you what you asked for." I shook the container with the chicken in it, and he looked at me like I was the one talking foolish.

"I don't eat sauce on my food, Wonder... don't like that shit. I'd rather eat the chicken with the sauce on the side."

While he continued to look through the bag to make sure everything was good, I opened the chicken and looked at the goodness. The smell alone had my mouth watering as I looked at him.

“It wouldn’t be so bad to try a piece.”

“Nah.”

I used the plastic fork and knife, and cut into the chicken, taking a bite. “Yumm, it’s so good... wow, so moist.”

He watched me as I continued to make the chicken sound way more appealing than it was. “I’m not three, and you not about to trick me to try something I don’t like.”

“How do you not like it when you wanted the same thing, only with the sauce on the side... why do you eat the way that you do?”

“Why do you talk to yourself?”

I cut into the chicken and popped a piece into my mouth. “I’m an only child, so I spent a lot of time alone.”

“What about Skyler?”

“She didn’t always live in New York. We only saw each other during the holidays or funerals. My mother didn’t come around my father’s family as much when they divorced.”

“Hmm.”

There was a time when all I remember was my parents screaming at each other. I couldn’t recall one conversation when they didn’t scream or tell each other they hated one another. It always ended with the door slamming, and my mother crying because she was so tired and frustrated with my father.

“My mother enrolled me in art classes at our local community center when she and my father divorced. I guess she thought it was a distraction from all the mess that went on in our home.”

“Is that why you do nails?”

I smiled. “You sure know a lot about me.”

“You’re living under the same roof as me, I have to know a lot about you.”

I looked down at my food. “I do nails because they pay the bills. It’s a way to express my art while making money. Being an artist doesn’t pay the bills, so I paint to escape.”

“I haven’t seen you paint.”

“In your home? I already drive Skyler crazy with my paint, I don’t even want to set you off. I draw on Skyler’s iPad... she brought it when she came to visit me... I know she wants it back, but I’ve been complaining about it being boring, so she’s letting me rock out with it,” I snickered.

“I have OCD and ADHD,” he revealed and watched me, as our eyes both met. “I obsessively count when I’m stressed or anxious... shit always has to have an order with me. It’s something I can control.”

“I have ADHD.”

“I know.”

Laughing, I gasped acting like I was offended. “Did you look up my medical conditions or something?”

“Nah... I could tell.”

His phone rang and he looked at it before excusing himself, leaving me alone in here with his parents. I looked around and took in everything inside here. As creeped out as I was before, this felt like love.

Menace brought me to his comfort, somewhere not many people probably visited, and I felt honored that he showed me this.

Scared at first, but very honored.

OceanofPDF.com

Menace



“JEFFIE, I DON’T GIVE A FUCK WHAT HE CALLED YOU CRYING ABOUT. WHEN my eyes land on that man, I’m handling my business. I’m feeling like he knew about the shit that went on and I’m never wrong.”

“Understandable. Ryan has been with us for so long. I would hate to even thin—”

“Which is why you handle everything else but that side of things. Too much shit hasn’t been adding up, and I purposely told Beans to let that nigga handle transport. I know for a fact if Beans would have handled it, none of this would have happened.”

She sighed. “Well, how is the date? Where did you end up taking her?”

“Cemetery. We’re having lunch in my parents’ mausoleum.”

The line grew quiet.

“Maverick, I’m waiting for you to laugh.”

I paced around a tombstone as I held the phone to my ear. “Ain’t shit funny... my parents being dead is funny to you, Jefferina?”

“Now you know that’s not what I mean. Why would you take her there... Kora told me she gave you some advice.”

“All you both do is talk about me... I’m so worried... he’s gonna die lonely... he’s too handsome, rich, funny, smart, and got a fire ass dick game to be lonely.”

“Maverick, you know damn well we never said no shit like that,” Jeffie laughed into the phone. “Well, what does she think about it?”

“She tried to run because she thought I was going to kill her.”

“Can’t say that I blame her, Maverick. Is the date at least going well... Kora told me that you went and bought her a bunch of Legos... that was very nice of you.”

“Kora sure runs her mouth... huh?”

“It’s been a minute, and I had to put her onto everything going on with me. She sent me flowers this morning. I love her so much.”

“You good?”

“Yes... I have my days... I’ll be back to the house tomorrow. I just needed some time to decompress and unwind. Since Bali we didn’t get to do as much relaxing, Core wants to take me away with him. Says I need a true breath.”

“He’s not wrong. Real life happened to the both of you. Stop trying to rush back to work and rest. Turquoise been handling shit... other than her walking around with booty shorts on, she been straight. She fucking Beans, Jeffie?”

Jeffie had a miscarriage, and it was some shit I never experienced before. She had always been my rock, the one that keeps going no matter what. Witnessing her break down and hold onto me while she was hurting fucked me up. Core had some business in a country not too far away, so he was able to hop on a flight and be there in a few hours.

“Work helps me feel centered, Maverick. I don’t like sitting around and feeling helpless about this, and her name is Greene, Maverick. You call that girl everything but her actual name... I don’t think so. I do know he has a crush on her, and she might have one on him.”

“Hmm.”

“Anyway, you need to talk to her about the heir... don’t keep her in the dark,” she reminded me, and I looked at the phone. “Don’t you think about hanging up on m—”

I ended the call and slipped my phone back into my pocket, going back inside. Slipping my sneakers off, I sat back down and watched as she was on her phone.

“Who is Tony?”

Wonder lifted her eyes up from her screen and stared at me. “An ex-boyfriend.”

“Why you look like that every time his name is mentioned?”

She shrugged me off. “I don’t look like anything... he’s an old boyfriend, that’s all.”

“Not lying is another requirement.”

I watched as she put her phone down. “He’s an ex-boyfriend... we dated, and then we broke up. He left a bad taste in my mouth.”

“Is he the reason you’re a virgin?”

“Can’t a girl just want to be a virgin? Why does it have to be because of some boy?” Her face told me that my suspicions were right.

“Yeah. He’s the reason.”

She put her phone down. “He is not.”

“You don’t even believe the shit coming from your mouth.”

I watched as she looked down at her phone, rubbing the back of it, before she looked at me. “Is this a safe place?”

“It’s always a safe place, Wifey.”

“No Wifey, please.”

I noticed at the warehouse she didn’t like when I said it. “Tell me why.”

She took a breath. “I feel like the word is stupid. Men use it to make women feel better about not actually being married... I have a whole theory on the word.”

“You’re gonna be my wife though.”

“I’m not right now... speaking of that... when is that supposed to happen?”

I snorted. “Do you need to fit me in your schedule?”

“Actually, yes.” She smiled at me.

I waved my hand in her face. “Wonder, we getting off topic... this is a safe place... proceed.”

She looked back down at her phone before looking into my eyes. I watched as she shifted in place and then told me the story of what happened with this soon to be dead nigga Tony.

As she told me, I watched as she swiped away a tear that fell down her cheek. I didn’t move from my place because I was upset. Mad that someone would take advantage of her, and she was in front of me placing blame on herself.

She trusted him, and he took advantage of her and then brought his brother in on the deal. I couldn’t imagine how long she had been holding this in, and then her friend knew this and offered her up like she was a fucking free meal.

“Okay.”

“What does that mean?”

I reached over and wiped her tear. "It means that I don't have the right words right now, but I see and hear you. I hate that happened to you, and I hate that you blame yourself because you weren't to blame, Wonder. You trusted the wrong bitch and he took advantage of you."

"Yeah."

She looked at the food. "Are you not going to eat anything?"

"Nah."

Just as quickly as she had tears, she had this cute fucking smile on her face. "Try the chicken... for me, please?"

"I don't eat that shit."

"You do eat it, Mitchell... just a different way. Try something different, you may like it." She coached, as she got closer to me.

I watched as she cut into the chicken and put it on her fork. "I don't want this shit, Wonder."

"Requirement, you have to try new things... even if you don't like it. At least you tried it and can say that you did it."

"Hurry this shit up, Wonder."

She brought the fork to my mouth, and I tasted the chicken, wanting to throw up. "Don't you spit it out, Mitchell." I stared at her, and she laughed. "Chew it."

I fucking refused because I felt like I was eating wet fucking chicken. "I'm about to spit this shit out."

She reached her little hands up and put them on my face, smushing them so I could chew them. Usually some shit like that would have set me the fuck off, and it didn't. Her sweet scent, like warm pistachio and vanilla calmed me.

While holding the food in my cheeks, I took her wrist and smelled it while looking in her eyes. "My name is Maverick, Wonder."

She smiled. "Thank you for finally telling me... chew the food now and stop smelling my wrist."

"You smell good, Wonder."

"Chew the food."

I kissed her wrist, and she blushed so hard I was sure she was about to float away. "Maverick, chew the food."

"I told you my name, doesn't mean you need to start using it."

She smirked. "I'm going to be your wife, no? I think I should have the privilege of calling you by your actual name."

She reached for the napkin and handed it to me. “Don’t make me do that shit again.”

I watched as she looked at me. “I promise I won’t... you tried it and didn’t like it. We’ll just become a household that dips our barbeque chicken.”

I tossed the napkin into the bag and kissed her wrist again, and she looked away. “Why you looking away from me?”

“You make me nervous.”

“Why?”

“I haven’t figured that out yet... fill you in when I find out?”

The conversation I had with Jeffie popped in my head and I silently groaned, knowing she needed to know. “Look forward to the debriefing.”

“Is this going to be a big wedding? Do I need to go on some starvation diet to lose weight... like fill me in because no one has said anything. Oh, and I need to get clothes from my place.”

“Wonder, you better not lose no fucking weight.”

She fixed the straps on her dress as I took in her full breast. They sat up on her chest without any bra, and I couldn’t keep my eyes off them. When I watched her from the doorway before making my presence known, I watched as she pinched her rolls and bickered with herself.

Wonder didn’t give me insecure, but there were things about herself that I could tell that bothered her. If she only knew how fucking sexy I thought those imperfections were when staring at her.

That dress on her, as flowy as it was, I could still see her curves. Her cute stubby toes that she had folded in front of me... all of that shit was beautiful to me.

“Well, the dress surely can’t be backless.”

Like she put her damn hands on my face, I put mine around her and squeezed her rolls and she snorted. “These are perfect. Actually.” I flipped her ass over my shoulder and bit her roll while she screamed out in laughter.

“Maverick... please, stop,” she begged while I tickled her, and bit the second one while she heaved, trying to catch her breath.

When I finally released her, she pulled my beard and fixed her dress. “That was uncalled for.”

I stood up, putting my sneakers on and held my hand out. “Requirement?”

“We sure have a lot of requirements and didn’t make it down the aisle yet.” Wonder stared up at me, then started to clean up our area.

“Security gonna clean it and lock up.”

I grabbed her hand as she allowed me to pull her, until she was in front of me. “Can we get milkshakes?”

“Yeah.”

She skipped to the car, as I trailed behind her, happy that I didn’t have to run behind her ass. As I watched her, I shook my head because this shit couldn’t be happening to me. The feeling in my chest was telling me otherwise.

Wonder turned back around and looked at me. “Can I drive?”

“Fuck no, Wonder... car too powerful for you.”

She rolled her eyes. “Is it because I’m a woman, Maverick?”

Duke chuckled, knowing that I had told her my real name. Not too many people knew my real name, and I preferred it that way.

“Fuck you laughing at?”

He smirked. “Nothing, Boss... nothing at all.”

I held the door open for Wonder, and she slipped in before I walked around the car, looking back at my parents’ final resting place.

I just knew this had my moms written all over it.



WITH ALL THE SHIT I HAD GOING ON, QUIET HOUR WAS IMPORTANT FOR ME. I needed to sit and read the stack of newspapers that I hadn’t got the chance to read. As I flipped through the pages, I thought about how Wonder’s father and his chick were now missing in action.

I knew Ryan had something to do with the shit because a lot of things had been slipping through the cracks with him. How did you let the nigga steal that much money without knowing it? Not knowing what was being booked off the app that we had for Case House.

Menace Caselli didn’t believe in coincidences. Shit happened for a reason and me and Ryan were going to have a talk. Until then, I was enjoying being in my office now that all those damn Legos were removed.

I flipped the page and enjoyed the stillness during my quiet hour. Stevie was somewhere focused on tackling one of the Lego sets. We had breakfast together this morning and I needed a minute from her.

Lupita made her a full spread of breakfast and I watched this girl slather jelly onto her fucking eggs and then layer them onto the toast that had butter on it and then take a bite. If that wasn't enough, she didn't wait to finish chewing before she washed it down with orange juice. Which meant she had all those flavors and juice mixed in her mouth as she continued to chew and swallow the shit down.

I sat the newspaper down for a second to take a breath. Stevie was sent to kill me, and I was starting to think this shit was a scheme cooked up by Todd. Why the fuck did such a beautiful woman have to eat that way?

As I sipped my smoothie and waited for my toast and eggs, I watched as she listened to her videos out loud while laughing. Her feet were tucked up under her, and she was still in her pajamas with her hair matted to her head.

Even with me staring her down, she had this peace about her. A peace that I wished I could have for myself. While I thought this was chaotic and it stressed the fuck out of me, Stevie was just existing. This was who she was, and she wasn't going to change for nobody.

As if she knew I was thinking about her ass, she came into my office. "Hey Mavie."

"Hi Wanda."

She put her hand on her thick hip... fuck, why the fuck did she have to look so good in those leggings and cropped shirt? "My name isn't fucking Wanda, Maverick."

"Then stop calling me Mavie."

"I refuse."

"Okay, Wanda."

"I let you slide with Wonder... I refuse to be Wanda."

I chuckled, picked the newspaper up and continued to read about the state of our world. Damn world was a fucking mess, and White men thought their focus should be on an app and women's rights.

As if they didn't come busting out their fat mama's pussy into the world. It always killed me how men could never put women first when we needed them. Without them, none of us would fucking exist. I was that nigga and ran shit, however, shit didn't run without that little iPad obsessed woman. It was the reason I wanted women to work for me.

“I’m a little stuck on my current piece... more than stuck, I cannot figure out one piece.” She plopped into one of the chairs. “The hair dryer in my room doesn’t work, either... I tried everything and it will not work.”

I don’t know where she pulled a small bag of chips from, but the noise of her rattling that damn bag sounded like drums being hit. She popped a chip into her mouth as I continued to focus on this article that was pretty fucking interesting.

“I want to start getting up and swimming in the inside pool. Why didn’t you tell me that you had an inside pool, Mavie? Is it heated, and do you know how to swim?”

I had read the same sentence six times because her talking was throwing me off.

“Lupita is going on a date tonight so I was thinking I could make us dinner... what are you in the mood for? I can go to the grocery store, and I won’t steal—”

“Shut the fuck up, Wonder!” I barked, startling her. “Got damn... it’s quiet hour and you just fucking yapping... not even saying nothing,” I continued.

Stevie looked at me and I could see how hurt she was. “Noted.”

I watched as she stood up and turned to leave the room as quickly as she came. Tossing the newspaper across the room, I fucking groaned. “Fuck.”

I hit the intercom button. “What up, Boss?”

“Pull the truck around, I got some shit to handle,” I told him.

“Bet.”

Checking my watch, I had about twenty minutes left of quiet hour. I didn’t give a fuck that I had time left, I was more concerned with Stevie and what I had said to her. Yellow came into my office with my water and nuts.

“An hour is over that quick?” she whispered.

“Nah.”

She already knew I didn’t want any conversation, so I left the room to head to the truck. I needed to head to the only gym outside of mine that I frequented to blow off some steam. Nothing felt as good as beating the fuck out of somebody and then shaking hands at the end of it.

When I bypassed the kitchen, Stevie wasn’t in the kitchen. Half of me wanted to find her and apologize, then the other half just figured to give her space.

OceanofPDF.com

Jefferina Collins



MAVERICK CASELLI GOT ON MY EVERLASTING LAST NERVE. EVEN IF THAT nerve died, he would find one just to continue getting on my nerves. Despite the nerves that I was barely holding onto, and him picking every nerve, that was my heart.

My big brother.

Soulmate – if you let him tell it.

There was no one in the world like Maverick, and the world didn't understand him. He never let anyone in long enough to truly see who he was, including his sisters and brother. They all saw him as the annoying, overly dramatic, nutcase who stayed away.

He was all those things, but he was also more. Maverick loved hard, and he was the kind that went out of his way to do something to make someone smile. He never wanted the credit for it, either.

I remember when Lupita's mother lost her home, and she was crying about it to me. He overheard and had Core look into some things. He bought her mother's home back from the bank and gifted it to her. Lupita had no clue it was Menace who set everything into motion.

He forced the bank to tell her family that it was an error on their end. The man would give his entire heart if he knew it would help someone else out. He was a good man.

A good person.

It was because he was different that made him hard to deal with. I knew him better than I knew myself, and he had always been different. My

mother would show me how to care for him, always saying he wasn't like everyone and that was fine.

Their relationship was close because she understood him. Before I stepped into my role as his assistant and unofficial handler, she was that first.

My mom walked so I could run.

I looked over at him as we drove through Long Island, not knowing what business we had here. Menace had his eyes closed with his hands rested on his lap. I went back to looking over my iPad and at our schedule.

"Mav, where are we going?"

I knew he wasn't sleeping. He couldn't sleep unless he was under his own roof, and in his own space. Naps and Maverick Caselli didn't mix, and at times I didn't know how he handled it. Some days I found myself in a spare room getting twenty minutes because I was tired.

He always kept going.

"To see about getting some furniture."

Now I was really confused because he only got custom Italian furniture. He still had pieces that he ordered over two years ago that hadn't made it to him yet. "You don't need any furniture."

"You don't know what I need."

I pulled up my notes and swiped through them. "Actually, I do. I do know that you've been avoiding your therapist... she called me."

Menace opened his eyes. "Fucking snitch... matter fact, fire her."

Therapy was something that he struggled with. This therapist wasn't weak like the others, and she didn't scare easily. As much as Menace tossed around threats, she showed up dressed to the nines in a pair of heels that one could only dream of owning, ready for another session.

Some days Menace would give her one-word answers, and then others he would clip his toenails on this woman's time. I had to constantly remind him that she was being paid even if he didn't speak. While he was clipping his toes and being absolutely ridiculous, she was filing her nails allowing him to be ridiculous.

Dr. Killian Hill was one of the best in her field and the fact that Menace tolerated her told me that she was. He would toss anybody else out on their ass, but he chose to allow her to come into his home, even if he spent their time doing nothing.

I was the one who forced him to see a therapist because I believed he was depressed. He would never say he was, or show it, but I knew him better than anyone and I spent so much time with him. Aside from his siblings, he didn't have any family and no love life. If you asked him, he didn't need love to fuck a bitch and send her on her way.

He did need love though.

Everyone needed love, and I thought him seeing a therapist would help with him lowering those walls he had safeguarded around his heart. Trying to know Menace was like trying to find the cure for cancer.

Impossible.

There was only a select few who really got to know the real him. Not even Zoya and Landon really knew their brother. Kora was let in because they were closer in age, and the closest. Kora respected her brother and understood what came with loving him. Landon and Zoya secretly resented him, and that was something I couldn't fix.

"I am not going to fire Killian. She's great and eventually you will open up to her... even if it has been over six months and you haven't said a word to her."

He was ignoring me, which came with the territory and our relationship. Even when he tried to ignore me, he was listening and eventually it would absorb into that hard head.

"This is where you want to get furniture from?" Duke turned into the outlet mall and pulled in front of Gino's Furniture Bazaar on East Main Street in Long Island.

"Mav, what the fuck are we doing here?" I questioned, sliding my iPad into my purse, and looking at him.

He looked between me and Duke before he got out. Soon as he opened the door, Duke rushed to get out behind him. "Stop doing that shit, Boss... let me get the door and scope out the situation."

Menace ignored him as he put a pair of dark Celine sunglasses on. Duke quickly opened the door for me, and I followed behind him into the low end furniture store. It smelled like stale air and shipping boxes when we entered.

A tall brown skinned man came from the back and greeted us, overly dressed for this dump of a store. "How are you doing... welcome in."

Menace looked at him. "I want to see your beds."

He was taken back at how forward Menace was and quickly recovered. "Sure, man... we have a few this way. Anything in particular that you're looking for?"

"Something big enough... fit three people."

I was so confused and should have been used to this man's shenanigans. How did he even find this place and why was he looking for a bed here? "Cool... I can dig that." The salesman's response forced me to roll my eyes.

He took us to a black wooden sleigh bed that had scratches all over the headboard, which told me this wouldn't hold up for years. You would be replacing this in a year, upset that you bought it in the first place.

"Looks comfortable." Menace rubbed his hands together and checked it out.

The man, desperate for a sale, got on the bed. "Nice and big for three people... I have some other colors in the back, and we sell mattresses, too. Actually, we have a deal on them right now."

Menace sat on the edge of the bed, which shocked the hell out of me. I could see he didn't want to in his face, although to someone who didn't know him, they would think he was cool. With the glasses over his eyes, I could see the crazy in his face.

Before I could even ask what he was doing, he flipped over on the bed, snatched that man up and held him in a chokehold like a UFC fighter. Duke looked at me, and I didn't know what to say or do.

"W...what the fuck? Let me go... I can't breathe."

"Should be thankful that you can breathe, Tony... why the fuck you hurt my baby?"

Tony, because that was his name apparently, looked at me, and Duke wanting help. "Wh...what baby?"

"Stevie Raye... ring a bell?"

Tony was trying to remember who Menace was talking about and then I clocked the moment it registered. "That weird bitch from my old high school? I haven't spoken to her in years, man... you can have her."

"Don't fucking tell me what I can have like she's yours to fucking give." He tightened his grip around Tony's neck, and he made some weird noise, letting us know that his breath was leaving his body slowly.

"Menace," I warned.

He loosened his grip. "You took advantage of her when she fucking trusted you. Got her all fucked up years later because you hurt her... I don't

like when people hurt her.”

Maybe there was something wrong with me because it touched my heart. He cared about Stevie because he wouldn't have done this for someone he didn't care about. On his own, he found out who this man was, found where he worked and came to defend her honor.

I looked at my watch and decided that maybe I needed to speak with my own therapist because why was I becoming choked up over this?

Core: I know Geeky not gonna respond but miss you both... miss Stellie too.

I smiled when I saw the message in our group chat from Core. He had been busy lately with things going on within his business.

Skywhore: Miss you too, Core.

Skyler surprised me when she responded with a picture of her and Estella blowing a kiss.

Tears welled in my eyes as I looked at the picture.

Me: Miss all three of you.

Skywhore: Dinner at your house?

Me: Yes... please. Miss Stellie.

Skywhore: See you soon.

“It was years ago, man... we didn't mean it and I apologized to her.”

“Oh really?”

“Ye...yeah,” he stammered.

Menace smirked, as he continued to apply pressure to his neck. “What the fuck is going on her—”

Another man came from the back and Duke grabbed him up, slamming his head on the dresser while he held one of his arms behind his back. “Your brother finally decided to join us... you remember taking advantage of his girlfriend?”

The brother looked like he did whatever they accused him of doing. “It was years ago, and she said we were cool, right, Tony?”

“Ye...yeah.”

“I’m not fucking cool with it. We gonna make a video with you both apologizing and I won’t slam this bed on your head, and cave your chest in.” Menace finally released him, stood up on the bed, and stepped on that man’s chest while jumping down from the bed.

He looked at the brother, as Duke released him and punched him in the face. “An...anything you want, man... we’re so sorry.”

Menace took a seat on the edge of the bed and pointed for Tony to stand next to his brother, who was holding his nose. “Go ahead and film them, Jeffie.”

I pulled my phone back out and looked at them as they stared at me with pleading eyes. “What am I supposed to say?”

Menace jumped at him, and Tony nearly flinched out his skin. “*What am I supposed to say?*” he mocked. “Start with your husband is a great man, and then I’ll give you creative control on how you want it to go.”

Tony stared at me and the phone in my hand. “Stevie Raye, your husband is a good man.”

“I said great, bitch.”

“G...great man. I’m so sorry about what happened years ago in my bedroom. It was wrong for me to allow that to happen when you told us no. As a grown man with a daughter of my own, I know how reckless, careless and disgusting my actions were, and I want to apologize to you for it.”

Menace nodded and looked at the brother.

“Steve, I ap—”

Menace leaped on the bed, grabbed his damn head like a pillow and looked him in the face, snatching his glasses off. “She don’t fucking like to be called Steve.”

“My... my bad. Stevie Raye, I’m sorry for my actions. I shouldn’t have done that to you. It’s something that bothers me ‘til this day and I am so happy that you have a husband who protects you like this. Making me be held accountable for me and Tony’s actions. I hope you are healthy, happy, and safe wherever you are.”

“You just said you wanna fuck my wife?” Menace asked this man the question with a straight face, and he was so confused.

“No... I didn’t say that... did I?” He looked at all of us to make sure he wasn’t tripping and didn’t say what Menace was accusing.

“Why the fuck you worried about if she healthy, happy, and safe... sound like you want her to me... Duke, how much time I got?”

He checked his watch. "Not much, Boss... we gotta head out."

"Grab the surveillance tapes and send his mother flowers to her job, too." I never witnessed a soul leave a body until I watched both these brothers hear Menace mention their mother. "Wonder, I want to apologize, too... I'm sorry for yelling at you the other day. The silent treatment been stressing me out, talk to me, Wonder... just not during quiet hour."

I smiled as I hit end of record and slipped the phone back into my pocket. Menace threatened them once more before we left the store. No sooner than we left, they broke their ankles to lock the door behind us.

As Duke headed to our next destination, I looked at my best friend. "You like her, Maverick."

"Alright, I'll have her come for therapy."

"Don't try and switch the subject, Mav... you like Stevie. I knew this felt right. I saw how you looked at her at the warehouse but wasn't sure."

When the bag was removed from her head, I saw how he looked at her and could tell he was smitten with her. You noticed small things about him and being that his face was always stoic, I saw the millisecond that it slipped, and he actually took in the woman who was Stevie Raye.

"I yelled at her, and she been ignoring me. Don't come out her room, and she sends messages through Coral."

I've been between working home and handling everything for the annual Case House ball. This year we were ditching the mask and doing an old Hollywood theme for the ball, which everyone in attendance was happy about. This year, the ball had been pushed back because of renovations on the island that were wrapping up soon.

Greene had been taking lead at handling things at the house and Menace hadn't complained, so I was grateful. "Why did you yell at her?"

"She was talking so fucking much, Jeff... you know quiet hour is important. She wouldn't shut up... shit."

"Quiet hour worked because you were technically single and lived alone. It doesn't work with having a soon-to-be-wife that you like."

"Chill out on me."

"Why is it so hard to admit that you like her? The thief who steals grapes, and the man who counts them like one another."

He looked over at me. "Word, she told you that she likes me?"

"No. I have my suspicions."

"And those are?"

“You took her to a cemetery to visit your dead parents and she didn’t call me screaming. She matches your crazy, Mav.”

“Whatever.”

“Apologize to her... I know you have it in you, so make it right. We need to be focused on planning this wedding. So, that is both of you guys’ tasks for the next week... okay?”

“Yeah, if she talks to me.”

“Figure it out.” I smiled.



I DOWNED MY GLASS OF WINE WHILE SKYLER STARED AT ME. “WANT THE whole bottle?”

“I’ve had a day today... Menace apparently went to handle some unresolved issues that Stevie had with some boyfriend from high school.”

“Tony?” she raised her eyebrow, as she combed a sleeping Estella’s hair.

They were staying the night over tonight since neither of them had school. “You know about him?”

“Honestly, it’s the reason that Stevie is so scared to let someone in. One night when we were getting drunk, she broke down and told me. I don’t even think she remembers telling me. I know it may sound silly since it was high—”

“Not silly at all. They sexually assaulted her, and then she had to live with that. I would never think it sounds silly.” I smiled at her.

“She always says she feels silly for being upset about it years later. Though, she doesn’t think I have context on the situation. All she thinks I know is that she had a bad breakup. I have to remind her that her feelings are valid, and they deserved whatever Menace did to them.”

I refilled my wine glass. “You don’t even want to know, but he likes her. Skyler, he really likes her.”

She eyed me suspiciously. “Stevie sat on the phone with me for an hour talking about how she can’t stand him, and how she doesn’t even want to marry him.”

“He yelled at her. The fight is very much juvenile, and he doesn’t like her giving him the silent treatment,” I laughed.

It was funny watching Mr. Silent Treatment dislike someone giving him the same treatment that he often gave. “Do you think these two will work? I’m trying very hard not to interfere with them... it’s hard not trying to fix things for her.”

“She’s grown and you cannot fix everything for her. If she really wanted out, I know Menace would allow her to go... he likes her that much where he would want her happy.”

“When is the wedding?”

“Girl, I put them on that duty... so we shall see where that goes.”

Skyler continued to comb her daughter’s hair and looked up at me. “How are you doing? You never take any down time for you... want to make sure you are alright.”

“I am taking it day by day... Jean Delgato really helped me more than she knows. God, Capri is lucky.”

“You and Core’s trip together will allow you to recenter and get both of you on the same page. I know that’s the reason Corleon is overworking himself. That man cried in my arms, Jeffie... he’s just as hurt as you are.”

“I’ve been selfish... only focused on me.”

“No, you were trying to heal yourself in three to five business days. You have to allow it to happen naturally, and this trip is perfect for both of you. You’ve been going crazy planning this ball.”

She reached her hand and held mine. “You being there for him probably meant everything to him.”

“I know it did... held onto me like he never wanted to let go.”

“Neither of us do, Skyler.”

“What do you want me to do? I can’t risk him ever getting my daughter, Jeffie... I’m always here for the both of you.”

“Wish you were coming, too.”

She smiled. “All I’m thinking about is the day that we see that positive pregnancy test and then can plan a whole string of parties.”

“Then you right after so they can be close in age.”

Skyler gave me that look. “Now you doing too much.”

I laughed. “Look, Corleon already said that he wants two more... I give him one and you give him two, ‘cause you can’t tell him that Stellie isn’t his daughter.”

“You know he sent me an email saying he would take me to court for custody? As if I’m not going through court already... he is pure madness.”

“I mean, he is Menace’s best friend, and he has that Delgado blood flowing through him... craziness all wrapped into one smart geek.”

“And lord is he fine,” she fanned herself and I laughed.

We both cheers and took our wine back as we got comfortable on the couch and caught up on our shows together. Skyler was my best friend, more like a sister. Our relationship meant so much to me, and even though Corleon wanted us both, we never felt like we were competing with him.

He knew how to handle us both. I had been so against what he wanted, and now I only wanted to share him with Skyler. She and Estella were our missing pieces, and we couldn’t do this without them.

I hated when people asked questions about how we would explain it to Stella. We didn’t need to explain anything, other than she was loved. She had three people in her life who loved her and would do anything for her.

Our situation wasn’t for everybody, and I understood that, and I didn’t care at the same time. Corleon was the head of our family, and he would lead this family. If you didn’t like it, then you didn’t need to read our story.

We were family – together.

Stevie



HE YELLED AT ME.

Actually, yelled at me like I was a child.

It had been a week since he yelled at me, and I hadn't spoken to him. If I needed something I would tell Greene, and she would handle it. Every time he came in the same room as me, I quickly left.

He wanted to speak to me and every time he tried, I dismissed myself from his presence. Greene told me that he had quiet time. What grown man had quiet time? As if he was Estella's age or something.

How was I supposed to know he had timeout hours? Maybe he should have gotten a sign on his office. I noticed how he watched me when I ate my food, as if he wanted to shake me or something.

Maybe I was way over my head with thinking I could become his wife. My father dying wasn't that bad... maybe he could make amends with my mother and apologize. Why should I save his damn life when he never gave a damn about mine?

My phone pulled me from my thoughts as I sat on the terrace off my bedroom. "Hey Cindy!"

"Girl, are you alive?"

I had been keeping in contact with Alex, and it slipped my mind that I had a job and clients. It wasn't like I had that many, and since my books were closed prior to vacation, no one could book me.

"Hey Cindy, I've had a lot going on and it slipped my mind to call you."

She sighed. "Are you safe?"

Like a true big sister or aunt, she was checking to see if I was alright before she chewed me out. "Yes. I am safe."

"Good, because when I get my hands on you, you won't be. Why in the world wouldn't you call and let me know something?"

"Life has been crazy."

"No excuse, Stevie... I worry about you."

I felt guilty for not telling her what was going on. "I'm sorry, Cindy. How is everything at the shop?"

"A mess per usual. I haven't seen your friend around here either... is her selfish ass alright?"

I couldn't answer for that because I didn't know how Priscilla was and hadn't asked. She had betrayed me in a way I couldn't forgive, and I didn't want to think about her. Any time she sat on my mind for too long, I tried to think of something else.

I thought that girl was my friend, and it turned out that she wasn't. She put me in a position that could have caused me to lose my life. While I worried about both of our lives, she was only focused on her own, which was so messed up.

"I wouldn't know... we kind of fell out."

"Hmm, girls' trips will do that to you. Let me tell you this, you were better off without her. She was jealous of you, and you may have not seen it, but everyone around you did."

"How? She was the one with money and all the designer clothes... how could she ever be jealous of me?"

"Baby, money cannot buy the kind of person you are. Stevie, I know I give you mess for being so forgetful, so forgiving, and kind... but you are a light, honey. There are women wanting to be their true selves, and you are that unapologetically."

I smiled. "Maybe I am too much for people."

"Nope, you are just enough and the light everyone needs. Life is hard, and we need that light and person to remind us not to take ourselves too seriously... you are that person, my baby. When you get some time, come visit me so you can really tell me what you've been up to."

"Okay... Thanks, Cindy."

I ended my call and stretched before going back inside my room. My stomach growled, and that's when I realized I hadn't eaten anything. Menace was home, so I knew he would be somewhere downstairs.

Quickly checking myself over, I went downstairs in search for something to eat. Soon as I got downstairs, I saw him in the living room with his leg crossed at the ankle, with an iPad in his hand.

“Good afternoon, Wonder.”

I looked at him, then went into the kitchen. “Asshole,” I mumbled, and continued into the fridge to find something to eat.

“Lose that attitude before the wedding, baby!” he called behind me, which caused me to abort the mission to fill my stomach and go back into the living room.

“What do you mean before the wedding? I don’t even want to marry you... you’re forcing me to marry you.” I looked at Menace, as he continued to carelessly scroll on Greene’s iPad.

“Periwinkle... I’m thinking ivory and navy blue for the colors... shit sexy together. Ivory is her color, ‘cause I know my new bride is a virgin. She ain’t been popping that pussy for nobody.” He raised his eyebrow at me.

“You’re crazy... I am not having a wedding with people I don’t know and a man I don’t even like... nut job.”

He chuckled, as he swiped on the iPad. “‘We Belong Together’ by Mariah Carey as our first dance.” I watched as he leaned forward, licking his thick pink lips. “You see that empty spot over that fireplace... our wedding portrait will hang there, and yo sexy ass better fucking smile... now, where do you wanna honeymoon, sour pus?”

“I’m leaving.” I needed to get the hell from under this roof with him and I didn’t care where I went, as long as I was away from Maverick Caselli. I went to stomp out the room and bumped into Duke.

“Take the jet and go wherever you wanna go... I know how and where to find you, Wonder.” He winked at me. “Yeah, ivory and blue... make sure my fitting is scheduled, and that nigga don’t have people in the spot when I come.”

“Ughhh! I’m not going on the jet... I’m going... I don’t know... to the mall to sit and people watch.”

Menace snapped his fingers and Duke pulled out a metal black card. “Go people watch and take your anger out on that card, baby... dinner is at nine.”

He swiftly handed the iPad back to Greene, who bypassed me on her way leaving the living room. “Enjoy.”

I stared at him feeling heat all over my body because he was so nonchalant about it. No apologies for the way he spoke to me, and then planning a wedding like we were on good terms. Menace probably never had to apologize to anyone because he wasn't the type. People just accepted that because of who he was.

Not me.

I snatched the card from Duke and stomped past him to the garage. "Mrs. C, where you going?" he called behind me, but I was on a mission.

Soon as I entered the garage, the men smiled and greeted me. "How can we help you, Mrs. C?"

"Stevie, my name is Stevie," I blurted.

Mrs. C this, Mrs. C that and I wasn't even married to this man. "Stevie, what can I help you with?"

"A car... not one where I have to shuffle the stick around to drive."

"Can you even drive?"

"Yes."

He folded his arms and looked at me. "Can you really?"

"I can drive... do you want to see proof?"

"Actually, yeah."

I dug into my back pocket and pulled out the card holder that Skyler had gotten me. "See." I nearly slapped him in the face with my driver's license.

He looked over at Duke and chuckled. "I think we can put you in the Rolls Royce today, Mrs. C."

"Stevie," I corrected him.

He grabbed keys from a lock box and then came around the counter, I followed behind him as he showed me to the all-black Rolls Royce Cullinan. As upset as I was from my argument with Menace, I was excited to get behind the wheel.

Frank showed me everything I needed to know about the car, and I was behind the wheel ready to go. Duke got in the front seat and looked over at me. "I'm still not over you kidnapping me."

"Like I said, nothing personal." He chuckled and put his seat belt on as I slowly pulled out the garage.

I increased speed down the hill toward the bottom of the hill. "You know I can go to the mall alone."

"Not being Menace Caselli's wife you can't."

"Not his wife."

“Yet.”

“I haven’t decided.”

“You decided.”

My head jerked in his direction. “What is with you men telling me what I’m thinking?”

“You like him... just like he likes you. Silent treatment for a week and checking for when he’s coming home.”

“’Cause I need to know not to be near him.”

“Right.”

“You said he likes me?” I asked, almost allowing that to slip through the cracks of the conversation.

Duke chuckled. “I’ve known Menace a long time... I can tell when he tolerates people and when he likes them. Man don’t go out his way for nobody and he has for you.”

“How so? By telling me to shut the fuck up.”

Duke was clearly tickled. “Nah... he knows he’s wrong for that. You won’t allow him to speak to you, so how is he supposed to fix it?”

I pressed the button on the visor and Duke nodded to give them the okay to let us through. “I don’t want to speak with him.”

“Marriage isn’t any easier, Steve-o.”

I looked at him and smiled. “Steve-o?”

“You hollering that you’re not Mrs. C... yet. So, Steve-o fits you.”

I continued to drive and put the window down to feel the breeze. “Is this what my life will look like?”

“Yeah. Menace moves a certain way because he has to... never announcing anything, just appearing places.”

“And you?”

“What about me?”

“Will you follow me everywhere?”

“Most definitely. You’re going to be a Caselli... he has security on every Caselli. At least you’ll know... the others don’t.”

I gasped. “Why not?”

“Complicated. We can go to the mall, take it out on his pockets and then hear him out, Steve-o. I know you bored with avoiding him ‘cause you made me sit and listen to some drama on the news while you finished your second Lego piece.”

I rolled my eyes. “You spoke back and seemed pretty interested, Duke.”

“No doubt... don’t watch much TV, but I know you wanted to talk to him about it, too.” He smiled at me.

“Nope.”

“Stubborn... both of you. I’m gonna leave you with this, and then we can stop and grab me a coffee.”

“What?”

“Menace and Maverick are two different people. Maverick had to become Menace because he didn’t have a choice. Maverick was the one who brought you to his parents... he doesn’t do that. Which means he deemed you special, Stevie. I’m not saying his outburst was right but hear him out and allow him to make it right... make that nigga grovel... and record it because the shit is rare.”

I smiled and turned the music up as we headed to the mall. This was someone who knew Menace better than me, so I needed to follow his advice and figure out how to interact with him. I did miss talking to him this week, and it was lonely hanging out in my room. He purposely kept calling Greene so I didn’t have no one to talk to and would be forced to talk to him.

Ugh.



*Recommendation: "If I Ever Fall In Love" by
Shai*

NO ONE EVER TOLD ME HOW FREEING IT FELT TO SWIPE A CARD ON anything you wanted. I went into every store possible in American Dream Mall, and I swiped that card so much I think I scratched it. Duke held my bags as I went into each store doing more damage and not being told no. I was used to going to buy something and praying that my overdraft assist kicked in, so I didn’t get the decline message.

People treated you differently, too, when they knew you could afford what you were looking at. I picked up things and tossed them to the sales associate and allowed them to box everything up. Duke had to make three trips to the truck to put my bags inside. I got Skyler and Estella something, and then I was ready to head back to the house.

A shower and Chinese food was on my agenda, with one of my favorite movies. Soon as I pulled up to the gates, they did their security check and allowed us access through the gates. That was something that I couldn't get used to because I felt like I was visiting the president every time.

Duke had the staff bring all my bags to my bedroom. Menace wasn't anywhere to be found when I walked through the sanitizing mist. I shrugged it off, grabbing something to drink before heading upstairs to shower.

The sun was setting and most of the staff was gone for the day. Jeffie was away with Corleon and checked in with me as much as she could. I kept telling her to focus on her vacation and not worry about me.

When I made it to my bedroom, all the bags were in the closet. I grabbed some fresh pajamas from my clothes that had been washed and went to shower. I washed my hair and sang out the words to my favorite song.

After moisturizing, I tossed on my pajamas set and pulled my hair into a bun before heading downstairs to order something to eat.

"Wonder?"

I heard his voice, but I didn't see him. "Yes, Mitchell?"

He chuckled as he came into the light from the living room. "Had fun at the mall?"

I watched as he rubbed his hands together. "Won't be fun for you when you get your credit card bill."

"I'll survive. I missed talking to you this past week, Wonder."

I folded my arms. "You told me to shut the fuck up, so I did. Now you missed talking to me... oh brother." I walked into the kitchen, as he trailed behind me.

His presence was so loud that I couldn't even focus on anything. "I'm sorry."

"Hmm." I continued to ignore him, as I looked in the fridge for, I wasn't exactly sure. All I needed was a distraction from him, anything for me not to look him in the eyes.

Staring in his eyes told me exactly what Duke had told me. I knew I wouldn't see Menace when I stared in his eyes, I would see Maverick, and I really wanted to be angry with Menace right now.

"I hate looking people in the eyes, but I need you to look at me, Wonder." I closed the fridge and turned to look at him.

He smiled at me. "I am sorry for telling you to shut the fuck up. It was wrong of me, and I don't ever plan to speak to my future wife that way. I've said shut the fuck up to plenty of people and never felt anything after." I watched as he used one hand to touch his chest. "I felt something when I said that to you... you didn't deserve that from me, Stevie."

"You hurt my feelings, Maverick," my stupid ass started to cry, and looked away with my arms folded. "I know I talk a lot and I've been told that my entire life."

He walked closer to me and pulled me closer to him. "I am so sorry, Wonder. You do talk a lot, baby, but I can find other ways to tell you to be quiet... okay?"

"And promise to never speak to me that way again." I peered up into his eyes, and his usual harden glare was softened, as he peered back into mine.

"I promise to never speak to you like that again."

We both stared at each other before he held my chin and placed his lips onto mine. I stood on my toes as I pushed my lips against his, and he wrapped his arms around me. Pulling away from our kiss, I continued to search his eyes.

He was genuine.

"Wanted to do that for a little minute now." He kissed my lips again and removed a loose curl from my face. "I got you this."

He went into his pocket and pulled out a paint brush. I gently grabbed it, and then nearly poked myself in the eye trying to get a closer look at it. "Mavie, this is a four-hundred-dollar paint brush."

I felt like I shouldn't have been holding it in my hands. It was too precious, and too expensive for me to be holding. "Walk with me real quick, Wonder."

I allowed him to pull me out of the kitchen, and throughout the house. I've spent my time trying to explore every inch of this home, and there were still more places to be explored. We went down the hall, and then out the back door around the pool until we came to a small glass house.

"What is this?"

“Pool house.” He pulled me in front of him and opened the glass door.

I gasped when I saw the inside. The cedar wooden floors, panel windows allowing the moonlight in, and the canvases.

There were canvases of every size in here, and easels everywhere along with different paints and paint brushes. On the wooden table in the corner, there were two tabletop easels, flowers, and candles lit.

Soft R&B music played in the background as I clutched the paintbrush like it was a piece of gold. I turned to look at Maverick, and then back at what he had done. My words were caught in my throat, and this was one of the moments where I could shut the fuck up without being told.

I kept going back from the studio that he had made for me, and then him, not knowing what to embrace first. “I want you to be comfortable here, and Skyler told me that painting brings out a peace inside of you that she loves and hates.”

“Hates?” I whispered.

“She hates the mess that you make and has warned me that you usually have paint in your hair and everywhere.”

I smiled. “You spoke to Skyler?”

“I did.”

“What did she say?”

He shrugged. “My business, Wonder. I want you to experience that peace here. Our situation isn’t ideal, and we’re getting to know each other. Giving someone my last name, my mother’s last name, is something that I take seriously. I don’t want to fuck this up... ‘cause I have a habit of fucking shit up with the people I care about.”

I quickly hugged him, and he surprised me when he hugged me back. Standing on my toes, I kissed his cheek and smiled. “Thank you for this, Maverick.”

“You’re welcome.”

He stood by as he watched me run around this entire studio taking in all the expensive art supplies he purchased for me. I touched the roll of canvas linen and looked over at him. He stood with his hands in his sweat pockets, as he watched me.

“This is all very nice... want to know what is even better?”

He cocked his head to the side. “What’s that?”

“You apologizing to me.” I walked over toward him.

He pulled me into his arms, causing me to squeal and laugh. "I don't like hurting your feelings, Wonder... it hurts my feelings."

"Is this another date? We're going to paint?"

"Figured after you tried to run from me that we needed a redo."

"No... I enjoyed that date."

"Yeah?"

"Uh huh... aside from the part when I thought I was going to die." I giggled as I stared up at him.

We sat at the table, illuminated by the candles and this felt perfect. Maverick messed with his hands when he was nervous. It was a little tick that I noticed about him, and right now as we sat at this table, he was nervous, though he wouldn't show it through his emotions.

"Are you nervous, Mavie?"

"Yeah."

"I half expected you to lie to me."

He smirked. "You make me nervous, Wonder."

"Why?"

"Cause you do."

"I think someone has a crush on his future wife," I teased and dusted his nose with the dry paint brush.

"Haven't had a crush in a long time."

"When was the last time you had a crush?" I asked, curious to know more about him. He had been slowly piecing me together, and I didn't know anything about him.

"Since I was seventeen."

"Awe a little schoolboy crush. The popular girl at school? You seem like you were popular back in school."

He wet the brush and dipped it into the gold paint and started to paint as I watched him. "She was a grown ass woman, Wonder."

"Wait, what?"

"Jeffie's mom... Angelica. She's the reason that I was diagnosed and took care of me... never made me feel different. Did everything for me, so naturally I had a crush on her."

"Well, having a crush on an adult is normal. I had a crush on my tenth grade art teacher. Mr. Woodson was fine as hell, and he wasn't much older than us."

"Don't make me go fuck Mr. Woodson up."

“As you’re telling me that you had a crush on Jeffie’s mom,” I giggled. “Did she know you had a crush on her?”

“Yeah... she took my virginity.”

I choked on my spit when he said the shit so casually, as if that was normal and everyone was doing it. “Wait, what?”

“We fucked around until she met her little husband and ended shit. First and last time a woman broke my fucking heart.”

I couldn’t focus on painting anymore because I was concerned. “Mavie, she groomed you... I’m sorry.”

“The fuck? I wanted it just as much as she did... I wasn’t fucking molested or no shit like that.”

This was a sensitive subject because he had abandoned the paint brush and went right into rubbing his hands on his legs. “You were seventeen, someone that she was supposed to care for. She was a grown woman. I know you wanted it, but she took advantage of you.”

“I’m not talking about this shit no more, Wonder... you making the shit weird.”

“I promise I’m not, Mavie... you were taken advantage of.”

He stood up and pushed the chair away. “Stop saying that shit to me... ain’t no-fucking-body take advantage of Menace Caselli.”

I remained quiet as he looked at me, clearly worked up. He stood there for a minute, then he left me in the studio – alone.

He needed a moment to process it, and I was going to give him that. Angelica was supposed to protect him, and she had a relationship with him. I didn’t care about the age of consent being seventeen, either. That woman should have protected him.

I picked up the chair that was knocked down onto the floor and looked around the studio. How could a man so sweet be so guarded? Menace was someone who had so many levels and layers to him that I was becoming dizzy trying to figure him out.

The only problem I had was that I *wanted* to figure him out.

Menace



*Recommendation: Listen to "Interference" by
Tems*

"I'LL DENY THIS SHIT IF YOU TELL YO' MAN... BUT SHE NOT SPEAKING TO ME."
I paced from my windows to my bathroom and back again.

Skyler laughed. "Well, isn't it the Menace Caselli that needs my expertise in Stevie language."

"Skyler, stop fucking around with me. You already raising a damn serial killer, and got the nerve to laugh... she still squeezing that toothpaste?"

"Yep, and want to know something?"

"What?"

"Stevie taught her." She busted out laughing like this shit was funny. As if my chest didn't become tight and I didn't sit on the ottoman near my bed to catch my breath.

"Stop fucking lying."

"Oh... you haven't shared a room with her yet. Wow, you're in for a treat, Menace."

I ran my hand down my face. "She won't talk to me and because you her cousin, I figured you could help me."

"I don't know if I truly agree with this whole arrangement. Why do you care about her not talking to you if this is business?"

"'Cause it's not fucking business... I care about her weird ass."

“Well, ain’t that the pot calling the kettle black.”

“You racist, Skyler?”

“What?” she blurted.

I groaned feeling like this wasn’t getting us anywhere. “What do I have to do?”

“What did you do?”

“Told her to shut the fuck up.”

Skyler gasped. “Nooo.”

“Yeah.”

“Why?”

“She talk too damn much, Skyler. Be answering herself and it was quiet hour.”

“Quiet hour?”

“You gonna fucking help me fix it?”

She sighed. “I guess since you want to fix it, that means you’re sorry. You have to apologize to her because that is harsh. Menace, she’s going to be your wife, not some random chick... not the one from Monaco.”

“Kelsie.”

“Her name was Kim, Menace.”

It had been a minute since I even thought about Kim’s ass so getting her name correct wasn’t the top of my list in the moment. Stevie wasn’t talking to me because I fucked up, and I missed hearing her talk. I never thought I would ever miss hearing someone talk.

I missed hearing her though.

“Any fucking way, how I fix it, Skyler... you saying a bunch of nothing.”

“Apologize to her. If you both are going to go through with this, then you need to learn how to humble yourself and go to her. Make it right and show her that you’re sorry and care. Stevie is so forgiving, too forgiving at times.”

“Think she would like an island or something?”

“Island?”

“Yeah, I own a few.”

“Menace, be so for real right now... your money doesn’t impress her because she’s never been like that. While she likes nice things, that doesn’t make it right. Do something that you know she would enjoy... Tap in, twin, has she told you anything?”

I thought about the conversation that we had when visiting my parents. "Ight."

"Ight? No thank you Skyler you are the best... let me buy my God daughter a pony and a mansion."

"She want one?"

"Menace, no. I am kidding. Look, I am doing my best not to try and control Stevie's life because I have been since moving in with her. She's been lost since my aunt passed away, and I understand her pain because I lost my mom, too. I had no choice but to keep on pushing because I have Estella. Stevie has kind of been in the wind, going wherever it blows her. She hasn't had someone, aside from me, who cares about her and wants to give her the love she deserves. If you marry her, can you promise me that you can give that to her... she fucking deserves it, man."

Listening to how passionate Skyler was about her cousin's happiness did something to me. She cared about her cousin and realized she was different, so she required someone different. "I got you."

"Cool... my fee is six million."

"Skyler, you broke over there?"

"No. Your best friend makes sure of it."

"Then stop being stubborn and let us get at homie... then go get married on that damn beach he always chatting about with him and Jeffie."

"See, now you in my business... later, Menace." She ended the call.

The look of sorrow she gave me while telling me that I was groomed irritated me. I knew what me and Angelica had. I may have been in love and wanted a life with her, while all she wanted was what we had on the low.

It was the reason that Jeffie and her mother's relationship was so strained. I told her that we had something going on, and she felt the same way as Wonder did. Kora felt the same exact way and refused to acknowledge it.

The only reason Kora knew was because she caught Angelica giving me head when she was supposed to be asleep. After Kora found out, that was when she wanted to cool it. Breaking my heart because I was in love with her old ass.

I ain't never been someone who gave a fuck about forever. To me, forever ended when my parents were lowered into the ground. Angelica had restored that for me, and I thought we could be together.

I would have taken care of her, made sure she never needed anything because I would handle it. Zoya and Landon were heartbroken when Angelica moved out, and I told them that she deserved to have her own life.

Shit, I told the story so much that I started to believe it myself. It was then that I realized that love wasn't real. Every person that I loved ended up leaving me, and that wasn't real.

"Maverick, I am coming up... okay?" I heard Wonder's voice and waited for her to appear at the top of the steps.

My bedroom was an open two-story concept, with my bed on the main floor, and then floating steps that took you to my work area, a pool table, and a bar. I spent a lot of time in my room, and at times I didn't want to leave, so I made sure I had everything I needed in here.

I could smell her before she fully finished climbing the steps. She looked at me and took in the room. "What up, Wonder?"

"You don't get to do that, Maverick."

"What?" She continued to look around the room, taking in the huge wall of windows going from the floor, all the way up to the roof. Since it was dark, I had the shades pulled up because I liked to see the view of Staten Island when I sat at my desk.

"Walk away from me in the middle of a conversation."

I continued to lay on my back with my hands behind my head because I was about to rub those bitches raw if I continued. She came and stood in my view, her hands on her hips as she looked at me.

"I was done with the conversation."

"That's not how you end a conversation, Maverick. I'm sorry that you feel some way about what I said, but that's the truth. We can choose not to talk about it again but know those are my feelings and thoughts on the situation."

"You have to give me a baby, Wonder." I wanted to desperately switch the subject from what we were talking about.

"Come again... say what?"

"The other part of the deal is an heir... you gotta give me a seed."

"Like now?"

I leaned up and laughed. "Nah, not now... eventually."

She continued to stand there, and I moved her closer to me, resting my forehead on her stomach. Her hand rested on my head, as I hugged her legs,

wanting her to be in my skin because her presence brought this calmness I hadn't experienced in a long time.

"My favorite song is 'Fire and Desire'."

"By Drake?"

"No... Rick James. It's one of my favorite songs in the entire world."

I continued to rest my head against her as she held my head. "Good to know."

"Maverick, can I add another requirement?"

"Yeah."

"Please don't break my heart. I've been hurt in the past, and I don't want to go through that again. If this is a business agreement, let it be that. Getting our emotions involved, and you have no plans on letting me in, I can't go through that."

"Wonder?"

"Yeah?"

"You think too much." I pulled her down onto the bed and leaned over the top of her as she stared up at me.

She reached her hand up and touched the side of my face. "I've never had anyone that could silence it... make me turn my brain off."

I kissed her lips and stared down at her. "Remember the first requirement?"

"Remind me."

"Stop referring to this as a business deal. It may have started like one, but I don't think it will end like one... Stevie, you're going to become my wife, and I take that serious."

"You take your business serious."

"Yeah, but this is different. I have to move differently when it comes to you because I actually care. I don't give a fuck about business because I pay people to care. I can't pay someone to handle your heart with care. That's my job."

She smiled at me. "Do you solemnly pinky promise to the moon and back?"

I laughed and kissed her lips. "Yeah, all that."

Her eyes roamed all around the room. "Your room is really dark... there are other colors besides black."

"Told you I like the dark... come on, I want to show you something." I pulled her off the bed, and we walked upstairs where my desk was.

I sat down at the desk and put her on my lap. Clicking around, I pulled up the video from the furniture store. Soon as the video started and Tony and his brother appeared, her body became tense.

Rubbing her arms, I allowed her silence to listen to them apologize, hopefully giving her some closure to something that had been bothering her all of these years. A tear fell down onto my hand, so I knew she was crying.

“You alright?”

She nodded her head and continued to watch, as I came into view and apologized to her. “You really missed talking to me, Mavie?”

I couldn’t see her, but I could hear the sobs in her voice. “I did.”

She turned slightly so I could see her face. “Thank you for that. It’s been years, I never got an apology or anything that showed them acknowledging what they did. Tony actually threatened that he would tell everyone that I let them run a train on me if I said anything.”

“What the fuck? I’m gonna go—”

“No, this was enough for me.” She held my hand. “Thank you so much... seriously. Do I wanna know how you found them?”

“On a need-to-know basis, and you don’t need to know right now. What I do need you to know is that nobody gonna ever fucking play with you and think they safe.”

“Thanks, Mitchell.”

“Don’t mention it, Wanda.” She giggled and wiped away her eyes.

She yawned. “I kind of feel bad for the damage that I did on your card today.” Standing up, she stretched and then looked at me. “Not that bad, but a little bad... night, Mavie.”

Turning around in my chair, I watched her. “Stay the night with me, Wonder.”

“As in the same bed?”

“Yes.”

I watched as she paused in the middle of the stairs. “Really?”

“That’s what I just said, Wanda.”

She smiled as she sucked her teeth. “My name isn’t Wanda, Mitchell... my bed won’t like that I’m not sleeping in it.”

“Alexa, play ‘Stingy’.”

“‘Stingy’ by Ginuwine played lowly through my bedroom as she looked around.

“I’m stingy, Wonder... can I have you in my bed tonight?”

Her eyes widened as she leaned on the railing. “In *that* way?”

I laughed. “Not that way... let me have you other ways.”

She looked away, biting down on her bottom lip. “We’re gonna have to share a bed sometimes, right?”

I abandoned my chair and met her in the middle of the steps. “All the time... honestly. You gonna let me touch you, Wonder?”

The goosebumps rose on her arms as she stared up at me, wanting exactly what I wanted to do to her. “Maverick, remember what I told you.”

“Your heart is safe with me... I pinky quadruple promise.”

Soon as she smiled, giving me the green light, I picked her up while she squealed, begging me to put her down. I tossed her onto my bed, a place that no other woman had laid before. Kim always got fucked in the guest room down on the lower level.

She thought that was my bedroom and I allowed her to think that because she didn’t need to know everything. “I need to go grab my skincare from downstairs.”

“I’m going to shower,” I told her, as she kissed me and then climbed out the bed while I went to take a shower.

By the time I showered, brushed my teeth and did my push-ups, I walked out the bathroom and Wonder was in my bed. She was cuddled in the middle under the blanket fast asleep.

“Spending all that damn money got you tired.”

“Resting my eyes, Mavie,” she replied, never opening her eyes. “You sure take a while in there.”

I went over to the bar and poured myself scotch. Taking it back, I looked around my room to make sure everything was in order before getting in the bed. My blankets were so damn soft and weighted, so it always felt like I was being held whenever I got into the bed.

Right in the middle of the bed, Wonder was laying there with no pants on. “No pants, eh?”

“I can’t sleep with socks and pajama pants... it feels like I’m suffocating.” She yawned, as she got even more comfortable.

Fuck.

I wanted to be close to her, and although the feeling was something I hadn’t experienced in so long, I wasn’t scared of the shit. Wonder didn’t scare me; she made me more drawn to her than anything. There had never been a woman in my bed, and there she was.

Laying in my bed like she owned it.

Shit, if she asked, I probably would have signed the deed over to her. Her skin was so soft as my leg touched hers. "Is this new for you, Mavie?"

"What?"

"Cuddling with someone?"

"Yeah."

She moved closer to me and got into my arms. "I used to cuddle with my mama... always made me feel so warm and safe. I would give anything to feel like that again, been so long since I've felt like that."

My arms held her as she rested on my chest. "I wanna make you feel that way, Stevie."

She looked at me. "You already do, Mitchell... just don't ever tell me to shut the fuck up ever again."

I laughed. "Never."

"Good... night."

"You ever got your pussy ate before, Wonder?"

She slowly pulled her head up and stared into my eyes. "You won't put sauce on your chicken, but you'll eat my pussy?"

I licked my lips. "I'm a complex person, Wonder... I'm picky about food and pussy... answer the question."

She shook her head no. "Never."

I kissed her lips and flipped her onto her back as she looked at me. "First time for everything, right?"

"Maver—" her words were caught in her throat, as I pulled her panties down, and rubbed my thumb down her crease, feeling the wetness she felt for me.

I looked at her. "You wet for me, Wonder?"

She blushed as she nodded her head. "Are you sure?"

I didn't warrant her question with a response, as I kissed her pussy lips while she kept inching back. Placing another kiss on her swollen lips, I held her legs, pulling her closer to me.

"I don't like when somebody plays with my food, Wonder," I growled in her pussy, and she arched her back, as her legs opened wider for me.

Placing small kisses on her lips and her inner thigh, I stared up at her as she leaned on her elbows and watched me. Flicking my tongue between her folds, she gasped so hard I thought her damn teeth were going to come flying out of her mouth.

Her scent and taste sent my senses in haywire. I was like a dog getting his favorite treat and couldn't contain myself. It had been so long since I ate pussy, and the way that it came back to me like second nature was a God send.

"Oh, God..." she moaned out.

"Not God... baby, this all me." The vibration from my voice sent a shock through her body as she tried to scoot back onto the bed, and I pulled her closer to me, as I continued to flick my tongue over her pearl.

Slowly.

Then I sped it up, as her hand found its way on top of my head, holding it there. Showing me what she wanted. "Tell me, Wonder... you like getting your pussy ate?"

"Hmmm," she couldn't get her words together because I was tongue deep inside her. Lifting her legs up, my tongue went from her pussy down to her ass, and she squealed. "Mav...It's my as—"

She couldn't get the words out because I made her feel so good. My dick was hard as a rock as I inserted a finger inside of her. She was so damn fucking tight. I knew when I got in there, I was gonna fucking explode.

I told her about me needing an heir, so it wouldn't be no surprise when her ass was pregnant soon after with how her pussy was nearly squeezing my finger. "I gotta stretch you out, baby," I told her as I kissed the inside of her leg.

"Uh hmm... it feels so good," she had her head tossed back as I inserted another finger inside as she squirmed.

"You gonna give me the silent treatment again, Wonder?" I asked as I inserted one more finger, and she tried to scoot back again. "Stop running from me... how you gonna take me if I don't stretch you out... Answer my question."

"Never... no silent treatment."

"I want you in my bed every night, Wonder... no more downstairs... you hear?"

She nodded her head, not saying anything, and I softly bit one of her lips, and she gasped. "Mavie... wha..."

"You hear me?"

"In your room... right," she breathlessly repeated.

Alexa still had music softly playing through the speakers hidden within my room. "Late Nights & Early Mornings" by Marsha Ambrosius played in

the background as I watched her struggle to lean on her elbows.

Removing my fingers, I reached up and unbutton her pajama shirt, watching her breast fall out of the button down.

I licked my lips, tasting her juices on them. “What?” She looked at me, starting to feel self-conscious.

“You’re perfect, Wonder. Don’t let nobody say anything different or I’m gonna kill ‘em for you... K?”

“K,” she smiled at me, as I lifted her legs and dove back in, causing her to scream out.

When her legs got to shaking, I knew she was near, as I inserted a finger and flicked my tongue inside her quickly, while she gripped everything from the blanket to the pillow trying to hold onto something.

Anything.

She leaned up. “Mavie... I’m about to...”

“Go ahead.... I wanna taste more of you.”

She tossed her head back as I never lost my groove. Eating Wonder’s pussy felt like art. Every lick was a stroke of the brush, every slurp was a splatter of the paint. When her body started to shake, it was the water cup filled with mixed paint residue spilling over.

Placing a kiss on her lips, I leaned up and took her in. “Definitely not picky when it comes to eating yours.”

My baby had this goofy ass smile on her face as she looked up at me and then kissed me. “Mitchell.”

“Wanda.” I kissed her lips back, as she pulled me onto her.

I rested my head on her chest, as she held me as best as she could, rubbing my beard as my eyes became heavy. Her heartbeat was slow and smooth as it played against my ear. Her smell, warm and inviting – like her spirit.

I’ve always felt safe, and I paid a lot of money and knew how to protect myself to assure that I was safe. However, I had never felt safe and warm like she had described in a woman’s arms. Even as I dozed off, I listened to her humming the tune to whatever was playing while she continued to stroke my beard.

Stevie



MY BLADDER FELT LIKE IT WAS GOING TO BURST INTO PIECES, AND I couldn't move. Maverick was sleeping too peacefully. Every time he moved, he made sure he remained on me, kissing my chest, before he went back into a deep sleep.

Staring down into his face, I appreciated his long lashes and his own small specks of freckles. You didn't notice them because who the hell wanted to be up close to him? Menace Caselli was scary.

Not Maverick though.

Maverick Caselli tracked down Tony, whipped his ass and made him apologize to me because I shared my story with him. It was Maverick who turned his pool house into an art studio for me because he knew I loved to paint.

His alarm had gone off three times and I silenced it each time because he was so peaceful. There was no telling the last time that he had slept like this. Since I had been here, he was up every morning like clockwork going downstairs to work out before having his smoothie. He was so rooted in regimen, and I understood that was because of his OCD.

Maverick liked control and being that certain things in his life happened that he didn't have control over, he wanted to get that control back. I wish he knew no matter how much he tried to control something; life was going to happen, and certain things were out of your control.

Shortly after his alarm went off, the soft knock made me turn my attention from this man on me, to where Greene was sneaking into the room. "Finally stopped giving him the silent treatment?" She snickered.

“Purple, the fuck you want?” Maverick’s rough voice vibrated against my chest as his eyes remained closed.

“Kora is on the phone... she said she called you and you didn’t answer.”

Greene grabbed the house phone and handed it to him, as he pressed the button, putting it onto speaker. “Yeah.”

“Are you alright?”

“Yeah... I’m always good.”

She paused. “Maverick don’t do that to me. You always answer the phone for me... I got worried.”

“Not going anywhere, K... what you need?”

“I have to pee,” I whispered while trying to slide out of the bed.

He pulled me back. “Wonder, you hate me?”

“What? No... why would you say that?”

“’Cause you trying to mess up my comfort,” he grumbled, as he lifted up and allowed me to slip out of the bed.

“Wait... is she in your bed with you?” His sister sounded too thrilled.

“K, don’t sta—”

“Hi Stevie!” she greeted on the phone.

“Hi Kora,” I smiled.

I mouthed that I was going to pee, and tip toed into the bathroom, closing the door behind me. The minute the door was closed, I did a low squeal and danced while thinking about what that man did to me last night.

His eyes always appeared lower because of his long lashes, and as he slurped me like my favorite milkshake, he kept eye contact with me. He was so intense, and the look on his face turned me on even more.

On the way to the bathroom, I had swiped my phone off the nightstand. Rushing into the water closet, I closed the door and sat on the toilet to relieve my bladder while hitting Skyler’s name in my contacts.

“Talk to that damn man, Stevie,” she answered the phone.

“Hi Skyler... how are you?”

She laughed. “I’m sorry... I thought you were calling because you were mad at him.”

“I heard he called you... which is funny because I wouldn’t think he would call you... my silent treatment must have messed with him.”

“He likes you, Stevie. No man, especially *that* one, is going to care that the woman that willingly put stolen money into her account isn’t talking to him.”

“I guess you’re right... I like him, too.”

“Enough to marry him?”

“I have to marry him.”

I could hear keys tapping in the background. “You don’t have to do anything, and he wouldn’t make you. Menace cares about you, so he would let you go before forcing you down the aisle.”

“What if I want to see where this goes... he took me on a date.”

“To the cemetery... don’t know who is crazier, him for taking you, or you for sounding like it was exciting.”

“It was exciting to me. I was scared at first, but it was sweet in a Menace kind of way.” I took a breath. “Skyler, he ate me out last nig—”

“Stevie, Jesus! Hold on.” I could hear something moving in the background, and then she came back onto the line. “I had you on speaker and I’m in the office today... anyway, Stevieeeee you got some action... tell me everything.”

I ran everything down to her while I wiped and then left the water closet. “I’m scared, though.”

“Of what?”

“I saw what he’s working with... I might die, Skyler. How do you... never mind.”

Skyler laughed. “Girl, I’m over here a newly virgin since I stopped fucking with Keyshawn. I will say, don’t overthink it. I remember my first time; I had a damn panic attack because I was scared. Just allow him to lead the way because he’s more experienced and don’t be afraid to tell him that something hurts or is uncomfortable.”

“Okay... got it.”

“Be sure this is what you want to do, Stevie. Don’t feel like you have to, and a man like Menace would never rush you. He’s a nutcase, but he’s a real nigga, too... and being that all I’m surrounded by is big dawgs, I know how they move.”

“Time for you to go get your big dawg back, Skyler.”

She sighed. “I don’t know... enough about me. I love you, Stevie, and let’s do lunch or something this week. Feel like all I have been doing is working and need a little release.”

I smiled. “Sounds good. I love you.”

After ending the call, I brushed my teeth and washed my face before going back out into the room. Menace was laying in the bed with his phone

on his chest staring at the high ass ceiling. How this was someone's room was beyond me.

My sisters want to meet you, Wonder."

"I want to meet them, too... how about I plan a brunch or something for us to get to know each other?"

"You know I pay people to do that." He looked at his wrist, forgetting that he didn't have his watch on.

"Be honest... when's the last time you slept in like this?"

He put his phone on the night table and looked over at me. "Can't remember."

"Do you feel like you about to die because you didn't get up and work out?"

"Yeah."

I shoved him as he chuckled. "Let me plan something for your siblings. I would like to meet them, too. We're going to be married, so we should start getting acquainted."

"Your father and Priscilla are missing, Wonder... you can dip out of this anytime that you want to... 'cause I can promise I'm not going to hold up my end of the bargain."

My heart rate increased as I stared down at my hand. "Why would he do that?"

"Niggas create their own storms and then get mad when it rains... this ain't on you, baby." He looked over at me. "You can go if that's what you want to do, Wonder... no hard feelings."

He got up from the bed and stretched. "You want to get rid of me?"

I watched as my words sat with him. "Never want to get rid of you... I also don't want to hold you here. I'm too real of a nigga to make you go through with this when I have all plans on handling your father and that bitch. He shot one of my men, and I can't look the other way."

"You're not holding me, Maverick."

He walked around the bed and sat where he was closer to me. "What you trying to tell me, Stevie?"

I scooted closer to him. "You need a wife and an heir, and I want to be the one to do both of those things. I like you, Maverick... you are strange, and I am, too."

Maverick smirked as he looked over at me. I noticed he wasn't rubbing his hands, and I climbed into his arms. "So, you want to marry me? I come

with a lot of shit, Stevie.”

I touched his face. “I do, too.”

“Not more than me.”

“Are we really about to compete on who comes with more baggage?”

I kissed his lips. “Our paths were supposed to cross for a reason. You’re used to doing what is controlled, and I am used doing what is chaotic... I wanna be controlled chaos with you, Mitchell.”

“I don’t know about the chaos, but you the only chaos that I want... real talk, Wanda.” We hugged, as his phone rang, and I climbed back onto the bed.

As he stomped up the steps, I got comfortable back in the bed and quickly fell back to sleep, thinking about the mess my father got himself into.

Why would they risk their lives when I had done everything to save it? My life was already saved the minute Jeffie walked into the warehouse. It was their lives that were on the chopping block.

Certain things were out of my control, and I couldn’t tell him how to run his business. Raye and Priscilla had stolen from him, and he had looked the other way because of me.

I couldn’t ask him to spare them again, especially when his own men were being hurt in the process.

Menace



“WHEN THE FUCK YOU STARTED DRIVING AGAIN?” CORLEON ASKED, AS I bent the corners with security flying behind me.

I looked over at him. “Come around more and you would know.”

“Fuck up. I been trying to get shit right in my life... for real, when the fuck this happened?” He looked in the rearview mirror.

“Took Wonder out on a date and decided to drive,” I explained, as I focused on getting to where I needed to be.

“Nigga, you calling her Wonder?” He broke out into laughter, his gun rested on his lap as I bent another corner.

I just knew Duke was back there cursing me out because I was gunning it on them. After that call, and the moment I shared with my baby, I needed to handle business. “Core, that’s mine... I ain’t losing her.”

“Is she being held against her will, Menace?”

“Nah. I told her about her father and that bitch, and she looked hurt that I was giving her an out... said she wanna marry me and give me a seed.”

“Can’t believe Ghost and Rahmeek got you out here about to commit to somebody. Shit, I can’t believe you ‘bout to be family to Geeky before me.”

I looked at him. “You clowning me calling her Wonder, and you run around calling that girl Geeky... how shit with the two of you? I spoke to her the other day, but didn’t give a fuck then.”

“Thanks.”

“No problem.”

He shook his head and looked out the window. “We on speaking terms now. I’ll take that over her ignoring the fuck out of me and acting like we

didn't share nothing."

"I didn't know she was slow... sorry, Core."

Corleon nearly craned his neck to look at me after I asked the question. "The fuck you mean? Skyler smart as shit."

"Then why the fuck she acting like we can't handle the situation for her? We know where that nigga be... as easy as," I did gun motion with my fingers and manically laughed.

Corleon was used to my shit, so it didn't bother him. "She don't want my help and I'm trying to respect that. If I step in and handle it, I might lose her for good, Mens."

"There you go having morals and shit... Wonder already know what it is with her father." I shrugged.

Raye and Priscilla should have been using their freedom to pick out a plot because they weren't going to live when I got my hands on them. All they had to do was sit they asses on that farm and work off the debt that they had.

It was never about the money; I was only giving them the grace because that's what Wonder wanted. She wanted to keep her daddy alive when I was ready to end him.

Nooo, he wanted to plan an escape with the help of Ryan, and now one of my men was in the hospital because he decided to turn a gun on him.

He decided to shoot one of my own and thought I wasn't going to do him dirty had me laughing to myself. "Think she gonna stick around once you send her pops yonder?"

"I tasted her, Core... slept on her fucking stomach all night. She not going nowhere now. If she wanna leave, she need to be prepared to wake up to me watching her sleep again."

Corleon waved his hands. "Nigga, we close, but too much fucking information... damn."

"Just being real with you."

"What you mean again, Menace? You was watching her when she was sleep?"

"I always watch her when she's sleep... I sit in her room after she goes to bed and watch her until I'm ready for bed. When she wasn't fucking with me, I was in there every night."

My best friend looked at me and shook his head. "You really be on some different shit... I ain't seen you this invested in a long ass time."

“She know about that shit, too.”

“You smashing Angelica?”

“Yeah. Said some shit like she groomed me... I wasn’t fucking molested, Core... I fucked Angelica because I wanted that shit, too.”

He remained silent, and didn’t say anything. Looking over at him, I stomped on the brake, causing my security to slam on theirs. We all jerked forward, as I turned to look at him while his hands hit the dashboard.

“Mav-fucking-erick! Why in the fuck would you do some stupid shit like that?”

Traffic behind my security was piling up because they too had to slam on their brakes. “Why the fuck you silent, Bruster?”

“’Cause I ain’t got shit to say.”

“Nah. You always got some shit to say.” Horns blared, and I looked out the rearview mirror and was about to hop out and Corleon beat me to it.

I watched as this nigga bypassed security and went to the car that still had their hand on their horn. Seconds later the horn was quiet, and he came strolling back with keys in his hand. Hopping back into the car, he leaned back. “Now move without your fucking keys, bitch.”

“Why the fuck you quiet?”

Corleon tossed the keys out the window, and I pulled away, hitting the corner with security right on my ass. “’Cause you were fucking groomed. I know we all had a crush on Angelica’s fine ass, and said we would smash, but we were teenagers, Mav... she was in her thirties. The little ass shorts she would wear, and how she would always pay extra attention to you, that shit wasn’t right. Not when you just lost your parents, your life was shifted, and you were confused.”

“I wasn’t fucking confused,” I muttered.

“You were fucking confused, nigga. Overnight you went from having two parents to both of them being murdered, then having to move from the only home you knew into some new shit with this woman who was supposed to protect you. Do you not remember that night?”

“Shut the fuck up.”

“Nigga, you shut the fuck up!” Corleon yelled back. “Nigga, you walked the entire backyard, counting until you counted every paver back there. Yeah, we didn’t know why you were that way until Angelica recognized it, but don’t forget how fucking stressed and anxious you were. Me, Kora, and Jeffie saw that shit.”

“She ain’t never judge me, Bruster.”

“Yeah, I get that... I told you that you need to stop doing other shit and actually do the therapy. Mens, you got shit with you and hold that shit in because you had to. You carry a lot on your back so Kora, Zoya, and Landon don’t ever have to... you the realest nigga, but even the realest nigga need therapy.”

I sped into the parking lot of the warehouse and looked at him. “Heard you.”

Core cocked his gun back, and I smirked as I hopped out at the front and did a slight skip into the warehouse. Ain’t nothing made me happy like taking someone’s life that didn’t deserve to live. After the call I received, I was going to have a time handling this before getting back to my baby.

Soon as I walked in niggas was already on edge. Ryan was nervous and nodded at me because I told him that we were gonna talk the shit out. “Yo, Ryan, hold this for me.” I pulled my gun from behind me and put three in his head, his body hitting the table he was near, and dropping to the floor. “You his cousin, right?” Corleon asked.

“Ye... Yeah, but I ain—”

“Nah, no problem... hold this down,” Core sent some through his head, and he dropped just as quick as his cousin.

“Oh shit... you got a pussy?”

Young nigga looked at me like I was crazy. “I ain’t got no fucking pussy, Mens.”

I shot him in the leg, and he dropped to the ground and started hollering while blood poured from his leg. “You rolling yo’ eyes like you got one. This shit taking up your time?” I walked closer to him.

“N...Nah,” he winced in pain.

“Then when I’m fucking talking act like you fucking interested... matter fact, all of you sit the fuck down because we about to have story time in this bitch.”

Duke pulled me up a chair while I had these grown ass men on the floor like a reading circle in elementary school. “I can’t breathe!” Homie screamed out while still holding his leg.

Beans lowered the lights, and I used the flashlight from my phone and put it under my face. “Once upon a time there was a big bad wolf, and he found out that the other wolves, who he fed real well by the way, were stealing his... chicken. Now Mr. Wolf made sure there was chicken for

everybody. He liked extra lemon pepper on his, but other than that every fucking body got chicken... we following."

"Chicken, yeah, we hear you, boss," one replied.

I leaned back in the chair and crossed my legs. A nigga was sitting in this chair like Barack Obama. Now I understood why his ass sat like this during interviews, shit was comfortable as shit.

"The wolf let some new wolves in based on one of his trusted wolves... he told him shit was cool and then those wolves stole from him. The OG wolf acted like he ain't know shit while Mr. Wolf had to find out who was responsible. He found the person responsible, and she was fine as shit... fucking beautiful, a motor mouth though, but beautiful... she's beautiful, right?"

"Yeah, she's real beautiful," they all said in unison.

I pulled my gun out. "I'll shoot all your faces off for calling my fucking wife beautiful!" They all stared at me confused as if I hadn't just asked them. "The end of the day, the OG wolf fucked up and Mr. Wolf handled him. I don't keep disloyal fucks around me, so I got rid of the dead weight. I want that old bitch and his bitch, and I want them now."

"What happened to the other one responsible?" one of them raised their arms with a question.

"I like someone who asks questions... fuck is your name?"

"Melvin."

"Well, Martha, the one responsible is mine." I swayed my foot as I thought about Wonder. "Kind of obsessed with her... you ever felt that way about a woman, Mary?"

They were unsure on if they should answer me or not, and I nodded giving them the okay. "Feel that way about my fiancée... she can get whatever out of me. She got a nigga whipped."

"Ah, so you know what I'm feeling like... see, when I'm feeling like this, you would think I would be more relaxed, right?"

They all nodded, thinking I was going to say I was going to be more relaxed. "Yeah."

"Fucking wrong... I'm on yo' asses even more 'cause let some shit come to me and my baby, and I'm chopping heads off. You remember what happened to that other nigga."

They all gasped and looked away, remembering the last time that I picked a nigga's eyes out his head while forcing them to watch. Ryan was

in the front row, so I don't know why he wanted to betray me like this.

"Sick ass nigga," I heard the one in the back mumble.

A fun fact about me is that my ears were sensitive. I could hear every fucking thing, even when somebody mumbled some shit in a warehouse that echoed. It was the reason my room was on the third floor. I originally had it on the second floor, but I could hear the humming from the fridge's downstairs. Jeffie thought I was crazy because the distance from the kitchen to the second floor was vast, and she couldn't hear what I was talking about.

I could.

Ryan knew how I got down and decided that he was going to stick his neck out on the line for somebody who wouldn't do the same for him. He knew when I got to the edge, there was no pulling me back. The only thing that made sense to me was crazy.

"Yo, Mens?" I heard Core's voice and had come back to reality, realizing that I was now in front of homie, and my gun was lodged in his throat.

I looked at my phone and then called Wonder. "Yes?"

She was painting. I could hear "Fire and Desire" playing softly in the background and her voice sounded far away, which meant she had me on speaker. "Do me a favor, Wonder?"

"Sure, one sec'."

"Nah, baby, you don't have to stop what you're doing... give me a number."

"A number?"

"Yeah... any number, Wonder."

"Why would you want me to give you a random number, Mavie? Unless this is like a surprise, and you need the number to confirm... um..."

"Wonder, baby, this ain't rocket science. Give me a number, Beloved." I continued to hold this gun in his mouth, drool spilling from his mouth, pissing me off.

"Four."

"Bet."

I ended the call and pulled that trigger four times while everyone around him scattered, even homie holding his leg. "Don't fucking call me a sick nigga ever in your life."

"*You're fucking sick for killing your family... A fucking Menace,*" I heard my uncle's last words before I took his life ringing in my head. I

opened and closed my eyes a few times to get that shit out of my head.

Nobody said shit as I looked at the gun and then commenced to beating the fuck out his dead body, blood splattering everywhere. When I was done and had enough, I tossed the gun on the floor beside him, and Duke handed me a towel to wipe my hands.

“You straight... breathe... your point was proven, Boss,” Duke whispered to me, and I nodded my head. “Change of clothes in the back and we keep pushing... need to go pick that up for Steve-o.”

I looked at the back and headed to change, while Corleon kicked a dead Ryan in the head. “Big Mens... handled business.”

OceanofPDF.com

Stevie



I LISTENED TO MY FAVORITE TEMS SONG AS I PAINTED WITH NO DIRECTION. All I was doing was stroking the brush on the canvas while soaking up the energy of this studio. I've never had a studio, a dedicated space for my art. Maverick had housekeeping put my finished Lego sets up on display on the other side of the studio.

My favorite [Caposcents](#) incense burned in the distance as I hummed the song, feeling the words with my entire soul. Every time I listened to this song I related to it on a deeper level. The hair on my arms stood at attention, and my heart became tight because I had never related to a song so much.

With my eyes closed, I sang the song with my heart, sounding horrible, but feeling good. There were days when I sang this song and sounded horrible while feeling the same exact way. As I sat on the stool, crooning the words to Interference, my soul felt happy.

The sun was shining down on me from the glass roof, and I smiled when I looked up. Was this a sign from my mother? I've been asking her for a sign, something that told me that she was watching me, and I never got one.

As the sun was shining down on me, not blinding me, I felt this warmth, like a hug. "I feel you, Mommy," I whispered, as I stuck the paint brush into my messy bun and continued to sing. In a way, I felt like she was telling me that I was going to be alright. The circumstances that landed me on Maverick's radar may have started out bad, however, there was a reason I was here.

God had a reason for putting me in his path. It felt crazy even saying a man like Maverick needed me because he didn't need anyone.

Except, I felt like he really did need me.

My phone pulled me from my thoughts, and I saw my grandmother's name come across the screen. Sucking my teeth, I put the phone on speaker and pulled the brush back out of my hair to continue fucking around on this canvas.

"Hey Nanny, how are you?"

"Stevie, I know your cousin acts like her bitch of a mother... but I thought you were different. I haven't heard from you at all, and then your father is telling me that you're the reason he can't come visit me."

I looked at the phone confused. "I have nothing to do with what Raye does with himself, Nanny."

"Raye?" she choked.

"Yes. I haven't called him dad in quite some time. He's Raye." I felt the back of my head hurting because of this conversation.

She scoffed so loud that it could be mistaken for her spitting on the phone. "He's your father, little girl. A damn good one, and he has done everything for you and your mother... do you understand me?"

"Yes." Although I didn't understand, it was better to keep the peace than to argue with her about something I knew more about.

Nanny only knew what her sons told her, and she thought they were both the perfect angels. They couldn't do no wrong in her eyes, and she stood ten toes on that shit. "Good... don't let that damn Skyler rub off on you. Went downhill when she went and had a baby as a baby her damn self."

"Skyler is in college and works with the district attorney of New York... the first woman district attorney might I add. I think she's doing pretty well for someone who had a baby young."

"Stevie, baby, we know you're not the best at thinking. Raye always said that you took a bit too long to speak or walk." She chuckled, trying to make the insult seem light. "You got me getting off topic. I'm running low on groceries, so I need you to come by when you can to get this list and get me a few things to hold me over."

"Um, Nanny, I don't live as close anymore so I'm not sure I can come all the way over there." I fidgeted with my feet on the stool.

She huffed into the phone. “Well, figure it out. I need some groceries, and my pain has been a lot. I would call your cousin, but she never answers the phone with her evil ass.”

“Skyler isn’t evil.”

“Let you tell it... when can I expect you?”

I looked at the time on my phone. “I can come by tomorrow.” I lied.

“Alright. See you then.”

I ended the call and slumped my shoulders forward feeling the stress of talking to that woman. It was a toxic relationship that we had, and I was smart enough to know that much. Skyler couldn’t understand why I continued to keep in contact with her with how hateful she was toward our mothers.

When my mother passed, and my father went on about his life, I wanted that feeling of family, even if it meant running errands for her, and never hearing thank you. I would sit and listen to her complain about everything and everyone.

Bitter.

“Old bitch not getting groceries from you.” I spun around in my stool, and Menace was leaned in the doorway with Greene standing beside him.

“Were you both standing there the entire time?”

“Jeffie emailed some options for venues and Yellow was going to get your opinion. I came in here to see you.”

I smiled, pushing a loose curl behind my ear. “Do I have a say in this wedding, Groomzilla?”

“Always.”

Greene flipped opened her iPad and had her pen ready. “Let’s get married at city hall.”

“You don’t get a say in the wedding.”

“Maverick,” I laughed.

“City Hall when I can give you the most beautiful wedding in the world. What kind of shit is that... that shit ain’t normal.”

I folded my arms. “This entire thing isn’t normal. We’re not normal, Maverick... why plan this crazy wedding when half the people I don’t know, and the half you do know, you don’t wanna talk to.”

He was considering what I was saying because he didn’t have a rebuttal. I was slowly learning the many dealings of Menace Caselli. “He’s listening,” Greene answered for him.

“Nothing about this is traditional. I don’t even have an engagement ring. Why not do things our way, Mavie?”

He continued staring at me, making me second guess the idea to get married in city hall. “Give me another reason.”

“My mom isn’t here. I would want to do all those wedding things with her... have her brush my hair, help me with my dress, and make me feel seen on that special day.” I looked up into his eyes, the tears threatening to fall.

Every girl dreamed of getting married to the man of their dreams. While I wasn’t sure Maverick was the man of my dreams, a wedding was going to happen between us. A wedding that came with having those you love the most right by your side, and I only had two people on my side. My mother wasn’t here to give me something borrowed, blue, or new. She wasn’t here to sit in the front and dab her eyes as she watched me get married.

There wouldn’t be a celebratory toast where she told stories about how crazy I was as a child. I would never have those moments and having to go through a wedding, not being able to have those moments felt cruel and like a punishment.

Maverick abandoned the doorway and walked over toward me. He pulled me off the stool and hugged me. Put his arms around me and squeezed me as I squeezed him back, needing a hug like this.

Despite him initiating the hug, he was still a little stiff, but these were baby steps. The fact that he wanted to comfort me meant a lot to me. “Turn yo’ ass around, Magenta.”

She quickly turned around, and he held my face kissing my lips, and grabbing my ass. “Thank you,” I said when we finally broke away from our kiss.

“For what?”

“The hug. You don’t like hugs, and you hugged me.”

“I don’t like hugs, but I like hugging you.” He kissed me on the neck and then turned to leave. “You not giving her ass no groceries. Wonder, the disrespect don’t fly with Caselli’s.”

“I’m not a Caselli yet.”

He winked. “You wanna be, right? At city hall you said.”

I smiled. “Really?”

“I’m going to sit in the sauna... inform Jeffie of the changes, Chartreuse.”

Greene rolled her eyes and laughed, because he never got her name right, and he never used the same color, either. I sat back down and looked at the canvas, while Greene came over and sat down.

“Do you do private coaching?”

“What?”

“That man doesn’t have a heart. I mean, I was almost sure he didn’t have one, and you got him walking around whistling and smiling. He asked me how I was doing and said my name right.”

“He did?”

“Well, he called me Emerald, but it was in the green family so I’m going to take that as a win. Then, he offered me some of his smoothie... poured me the rest he had in the blender. Gross by the way.” She gagged.

“Maybe he’s just feeling happier these days, Blue?” I teased her, pulling on one of her curls while we both laughed.

Greene placed her iPad down. “You are the reason he’s feeling happier these days. Now, maybe you can give me some tips on talking to Beans.”

“Ah, you have a crush on Beans?”

Beans didn’t come around the house often, other than when he had to talk to Maverick about something. I did notice the few times that he came over that Greene would be fixing her hair or trying to do something to keep busy.

“I wouldn’t say a crush...”

“Then what would you call it?”

She shrugged. “I don’t know. How do I even approach him?”

“Greene, have you met me? I didn’t exactly have a bunch of men beating down my door. I’m someone that would still have a man circle yes or no to ask if he liked me. Be yourself, because clearly that is how you attract the real men.”

She smiled. “Thanks, Stevie.”

ONCE I FINISHED IN THE STUDIO, I WENT UPSTAIRS TO SHOWER BEFORE changing into some biker shorts and a flowy crop top. Since I never got the chance to read on the beach, I planned on reading by the pool.

Flashes of Menace staring into my eyes while he tasted me bombarded my mental and forced me to cross my legs because my girl was throbbing. After he finished tasting me, I thought he would want to have sex with me. I

wasn't thinking about my virginity at the moment, just wanting him to continue to make me feel good, and I wanted to make him feel good, too.

Even now, he hasn't tried anything other than wanting me in his arms at night. Nothing was happening and according to him, he needed an heir, so shouldn't we have been having sex? It wasn't like he was waiting until we were married because neither of us were traditional at all.

As I paced in front of the kitchen counter, I abandoned my thoughts for lunch and went downstairs to where he was in the sauna. I couldn't have these internal thoughts. How would he know? Menace was a person you had to be literal with, he didn't catch hints and things that you would throw his way.

When I made it to the sauna, he was sitting inside with his head back. "Stevie, you can do this... just ask him what's up? Say... what my pussy not good enough for you? No... don't say that... just ask... nigga, is it because I'm a virgin? Are you scared?" I shook off the intrusive thoughts telling me to bust up in there with conflict.

Taking one last deep breath, I opened the sauna door, and my hair immediately puffed up. "How are you sitting in here? Are you the damn devil or something?"

Maverick opened his eyes. "Nah, I know one though."

"Why don't you wanna have sex with me, Maverick? Did you not say we need to produce an heir, no?"

He leaned up while licking his lips, looking so damn good that I had to look away. "Who says I didn't, Wonder?"

"Then why don't you?"

"You a virgin, right?"

"Yes," I mumbled while folding my arms, avoiding eye contact with him because now I felt foolish. I should have busted up in here guns blazing like I originally had planned. "What does that—"

"Which means you ain't never took dick before, correct?"

"Yes, but I'm still not understa—"

My words were cut short when he removed himself from the bench with no shirt on. How was I supposed to focus when he was in front of me looking this good? He licked his thumb and wiped the side of my face, which I assumed was paint on my cheek. Then, he lifted my chin with his finger and stared into my eyes.

“A woman losing her virginity is a very special moment for her, I heard. I take that seriously, Wonder. I’ve had pussy before, and this ain’t that for me... you’re going to be my wife. This is going to be your first time. I’m not about to rob you of your first time... can’t do that to you.”

My breath vanished for a second as he spoke to me. “Well, alright, I’m going to go read.” I stumbled toward the door, not knowing what else to say.

“Wonder?”

“Yeah?”

“With those little ass shorts on, no doubt if the situation was different, I would have sat you on this dick right now.”

I let out an inward squeal and quickly left while he laughed at me. His lips as he spoke, his lashes as they swept down as he stared at me had every part of my body heated. I used my book and fanned myself as I thought about Maverick Caselli.

My book of choice didn’t make it any better because Miss Jenesequa was known for her spicy novels, and her novel *I Got You* was no different. I needed to take a cold shower, and I had just finished taking a shower.

Jesus, I need a rose.

A cold shower.

And to *not* share Maverick’s bed tonight.



MAVERICK PROMISED ME THAT HE WOULD ASK HIS SIBLINGS TO COME OVER for a family brunch. With everyone’s schedule, we agreed on a dinner. I spent the morning with Lupita making sure everything was good. Well, who was I kidding? I watched as she obsessed over what needed to be right for Maverick.

The dining table was set, and I kept going in there checking to make sure it was perfect. They had been here more times than I have, so they were used to everything. Maverick had business to handle, and he went out of town for two days.

As he crossed my mind, I smiled when his name came across my screen. “Wonder, we taking off now... be there in an hour.”

“Your sisters texted and said they are on their way. I’m not sure about your brother though... he didn’t confirm if he is coming or not.”

“That nigga don’t ever stick to a schedule.”

“Hmm, the opposite of you.”

He laughed. “Yeah... see you soon.”

“Safe flight. I’ve never been on a jet before.”

“Your future husband owns two... gotta make that happen for you.” I could hear him chewing something. “The fuck kind of gum is this? I need the other kind... nah. I ain’t taking the fuck off until they find the shit I need... the popping in my ears fuck with me, Jeff.”

“Hey, relax... let them find the gum.”

He was quiet and I heard someone in the back say they found the gum he used. “Here you go, Mr. Caselli.”

“See.”

“You good luck, Wonder.”

“Might be. See you soon, yeah?”

“Yeah.”

I smiled as I ended the call, then headed upstairs to change my clothes before his sisters arrived. My hands were sweating because I was so nervous to meet them. Maverick was a big presence, so I could only imagine his siblings being the same as he was, which scared me.

In the past, me and other women never got along because I was different. I never fit in, and I always felt like I was forcing myself to be someone that I wasn’t. Don’t get me started on how mean women could be.

Soon as they found out you weren’t like them, then you became a target. There were a few stylists at the shop that acted like that with me and Cindy had to put them in their places. I hated to even sound like this, but I just wanted people to like me.

Why couldn’t we bake cookies, watch anime, and drink iced coffees while forgetting about eating an actual meal?

“Hey, Kora is here.” Greene popped her head into my room, and I took a deep breath.

Sisters didn’t play with their brothers, so I was nervous about meeting her. Especially since she was a federal judge. What if she locked my ass up because she didn’t believe I wanted to be with her brother?

I mean, I couldn't believe I wanted to be with him some days. Especially the days when he was in the dark, and then randomly made his presence known. No warning, just a simple word and my soul leaving my body because I didn't know he was even there.

"Okay."

"Relax, they are going to love you. Just be you, Stevie... don't be fake," Greene advised and I took her advice before joining her downstairs.

"Leave it to Maverick to not even be here yet," I heard her soft voice before she rounded the corner, and I saw her. "Listen, get me the files so I can look over them tonight," she barked at whoever was on the phone.

As she rounded the corner, I couldn't help but be amazed at her. She was small, had to be around 5'4, and she was petite. Her curly black hair didn't have a hair out of place, and her pecan skin had not one blemish.

With her purse on her arm, she smiled when her eyes landed on me. "Stevie!"

"Hi Kora," I bowed, and she stopped to look at me.

"Stevie, she's a judge, not a damn princess," Greene muttered.

Kora laughed as she came closer and hugged me. "It's nice to finally meet you, but please don't bow at me ever again. If anything, I should be bowing at you because you're higher on the family's pecking order... the future Mrs. Caselli."

"Sorry." I nervously laughed.

"The fact that you raced me, and I got caught up at security is the only reason you won." A chocolate plus size woman rounded the corner next.

She was dressed down in a sweatsuit and had a Chanel bag on her arm. Her black hair was clipped up with a claw clip, and she smiled when she saw me. "You are so damn pretty... your curls... Oh, the bawdy is tea... I'm glad he didn't come with some stick figure like Kim... I'm Zoya." She hugged me too.

"Thank you," I blushed.

"Well, he never invites us over, so we know this had you written all over it." Kora kissed her sister on the cheek, and they both turned their attention toward me.

"I really wanted to meet you guys. He talks about you all the time, and I wanted to put a face to the people."

Zoya laughed. "No, he doesn't... Stevie, you don't have to lie to us. My brother doesn't mention us at all, and the feeling is very much mutual."

“Stop being like that, Zoya.” Kora pinched her sister and then turned her attention back to us. “Did Landon say that he was going to come?”

“He never replied to the text message, so probably not.”

I was hoping that everyone could show up so I could meet them all at the same time. “He’s going to show up... we haven’t had a family dinner...” Corleon walked into the living area. He kissed Kora and Zoya on the forehead before giving me one, too.

“Ever,” Kora finished his sentence.

“I knew when I got the message from his phone that it wasn’t his doing. Menace don’t ever invite us over here.”

“You don’t ever come,” Corleon corrected her.

Zoya shrugged and went into the fridge that was actually in the kitchen. “Do you blame me? Look at his fridge... I don’t know if I want to take a drink or a picture because who has a fridge this perfect.”

“He called not too long ago and should be here soon,” I told them, as Zoya decided on if she wanted to take a drink. “Please take a drink.”

She laughed. “Let me know if you need legal representation. It cannot be easy living here with him.”

“Oh stop... Maverick isn’t that bad.”

I noticed both sisters called him by different names. While Kora referred to him as Maverick, it was Zoya that called him Menace. “Why do you call him Menace?”

“’Cause he is one.”

Lupita made us some drinks as we sat outside while she finished getting the table together. “Are you sure that you want to marry him?” Kora looked more concerned than judging me.

It was like she wanted this to work so bad for Maverick and me. I could feel her softness and how genuine she felt when she asked the question.

“You can run now before locking that down,” Zoya added while accepting a drink from Lupita.

I laughed. “He’s not all bad, you know... I’m learning there is a different side to him,” I defended. “So, not too much on him.”

Kora smiled at me. “Defending him already. I like you already. Maverick has always had to be strong... he’s always been different, too, which doesn’t come off well with people.”

I fixed my glasses. “I am different, too, so I guess we have that in common. I don’t always say the right things, and I’m not the most polished

person... so I can understand his quirks.”

“He’s misunderstood. Maverick loves hard, he just has a problem showing it.” She crossed her legs. “When we lost our parents, he never cried... There was three of us and he had to step up and make sure we were all good, even though he was still a kid himself.”

Zoya remained quiet while her sister spoke. “He took me to visit them.”

“And you’re still here?”

I couldn’t help but to laugh at the way I tried to run away. “It helped me understand him a little bit more. Have you visited?”

“No,” Zoya quickly added.

“I never go inside... can’t bring myself to do that. I place flowers outside and spend a little time with them.”

“You should look inside the next time you go. If you ever doubt how your brother feels, that will show you exactly how he feels,” I told them both.

“Is Menace dying?” I had met Landon a few times because he and Skyler were friends. It wasn’t until I was seeing him right here and now knowing what his brother looked like that I was stunned by how much they resembled each other.

Landon was Maverick’s younger twin, as if he could be his father. “Hey Stevie... I’m happy to see you alive and shit.”

“Well, thanks I am happy to be alive, too,” I laughed, as he took a seat next to Zoya, all three of them stared at me. “What? Is there paint in my hair?”

“You paint?” They all nearly screamed when I revealed that I painted.

I looked at them strange. “Yeah... Maverick set up a studio for me.”

Kora was now really interested. “He allows you to paint in his house, Stevie?”

“I’m in the pool house... that’s my studio.”

“And he allows you to use actual paint?” Landon had to make sure what I was saying was what he was actually hearing.

“Yes, why are you both acting like this is something amazing?”

“‘Cause that man doesn’t like anything that is a mess and seeing that he set up a studio for you speaks volumes. I have to admit, that is really cute. I want a man that’s gonna set me a studio up.”

“Nah, you would rather one who gonna set a daycare up for you,” Landon snickered, as he leaned back on the couch.

Corleon came outside with a drink and sat down beside me. “Feels weird having all of you in the same place... how’s work, Kora?”

She rolled her eyes and laughed. “Tiring. I will say, you are spinning the hell out of this Amante case, Zoya. I have to keep hiding my smile because I am so damn proud.”

“This case has been something else... I haven’t slept good for months.” She sighed, as she looked at her phone.

“Homie?” Core asked.

“None of your business, Corleon.”

He nodded his head and finished his drink. “Yeah, it’s that nigga.”

Landon looked over his sister’s shoulder. “I think you doing that shit to piss Menace off... not knowing you gonna take that man away from his kids.”

“My business is my own. I don’t get involved in either of your business, so mind your fucking business,” she snapped.

We all sat out enjoying drinks and the little tapas that Lupita prepared for us. She was having a time serving more than just me and Menace.

“Can we see the studio? I love art... who is your favorite artist?”

I jumped at the chance to show off my studio. In this short time, it had become my pride and joy. “Faith Ringgold.”

Kora gasped. “I love her pieces... listen, I have an ex that owns a gallery. When this trial is over and I have more time, we should do dinner and stop by there.”

I got excited at the thought of going out to dinner and spending the evening looking at art. “Seriously?”

“You’re going to be our sister-in-law... I’m not into the arts, but when you want to shop, we can go and max that card of my brother’s out.”

“Shit don’t max out... no limit, hater,” I turned and saw Maverick coming from inside the house.

He was wearing an all-black suit with the neck of his collar loosened. On the lapel of his suit, he had a gold CH pin clipped on it, and he wore a pair of Tom Ford dress shoes. How was it possible for him to look this good, even with a scowl on his face.

Somebody had pissed him off.

Even as he walked over here, I could smell his cologne. He always smelled like Oud Wood by Tom Ford. I noticed he never wore any other scent but that one, and he had a stockpile of it inside his closet.

“Did your ears pop?” I asked.

He bent down and kissed me on the lips, removing that stubborn curl from out my face. His siblings gasped hard. “Why the fuck y’all in my business anyway?”

I blushed as I kissed him back. “Do you wanna shower and stuff before dinner?” He nodded and looked at Zoya, Landon, and Kora before going back into the house. “Well, who wants to see my studio?”

“He came out here to greet only you... kissed you,” Zoya pretended to faint on the couch, while Landon fanned her.

“Both of you need to grow up.” Kora laughed.

I showed them my studio. Me and Kora were hung up on talking about different artists and our favorite pieces, while Landon had grabbed a paint brush and started to paint on a blank canvas. Zoya was on her phone and very uninterested in what we were doing.

“Would you date a man that’s in prison, Stevie?” she asked, as she took a seat on the stool, and watched me.

“I’m about to marry a man that wanted to kill me, so I’m not the best person to give this kind of advice.”

“Very true,” she giggled.

Kora leaned on the counter. “Is this about Gerald? Why don’t you just go and see him... you know that you want to.”

“It’s not as easy though. If Sigel finds out, then that’s issues that I don’t want to have.” She groaned. “Is it so wrong to know how he’s doing... I do have that ticket he never paid.”

“His days are numbered anyway,” Landon tossed over his shoulder.

“Are they?” I asked.

“Who knows when it comes to Menace... I know one thing; I can’t be with him for the long haul. How can I be with someone I can’t even bring around my family?”

“And he has a lot of children, too,” Kora reminded her.

“I don’t even deal with the kids.”

Kora sighed. “Doesn’t matter. You need to stop trying to piss Maverick off. We both know the only reason you choose these guys is because you know it pisses him off that he can’t control you.”

“Helps me sleep at night.” She smirked.

“Dinner should be ready... I’m starving,” I switched the subject as we headed back into the house to eat.

OceanofPDF.com

Menace



HIGHLIGHT OF MY DAY WAS WALKING IN THE BACKYARD AND SEEING Wonder sitting there. When she turned to look at me, there was excitement. Nobody ever got excited to see me, so it was different seeing and feeling someone actually radiate happiness when they saw you.

Lupita cooked a full spread, then made my food to the side. These niggas was eating all kinds of mixed shit. It was hard to even finish my food with the way that Landon was mixing his mash potatoes and green beans together.

I was quiet for most of dinner because my mind was on that nigga Raye. There was nothing I wanted more than that nigga handed to me on a silver platter. Where the fuck would an old roach and his hoe hide?

While I had everybody flipping over every rock, I still had to handle business. Being away from Wonder for two days had my ass tripping out. I never liked staying away from home, but I really didn't like being away knowing she was here.

We were all in the living room trying to digest the feast that Lupita had prepared. "My mom used to do this when I was younger. Say something nice about someone... let's all say something nice about Maverick."

"I love how organized and structured you are," Wonder started first, and I kissed her on the cheek while she looked at everyone else.

"One of the realest niggas I've met... always down for some shit," Corleon added, and I smirked and nodded my head.

"Loyal. The most loyal person I know and committed. Living the way you do is a damn commitment," Jeffie laughed.

Wonder looked over at Zoya. “Zoya, say something nice about your brother.”

She looked at Wonder. “Are you going to make us become a family that shares feelings and hugs?”

Wonder giggled. “Hugs are the best... come on, Zoya. You surely have something to say nice about your brother.”

“He’s not rubbing his hands like Birdman.”

“Um, okay, that seems nice.”

“Wonder, where the fuck was that nice?” I pulled her onto my lap, and she laughed while looking over at Zoya.

“Baby steps, Mavie... your turn Landon.”

“He got a jet.”

“That you ain’t never using, bitch.”

“Mavie!” Wonder pinched me and sighed, realizing her little positive exercise wasn’t going to work on us. “Kora, you can end this off.”

K smiled. “He’s the strongest man I know... life was tossed at him early, and he’s done things that many wouldn’t have done. He has put us all into positions where we don’t ever need him or anyone else, so I would say he’s the rock of this family, even if you two are too immature and bull headed to admit it.”

“Kiss ass,” Zoya did a fake cough.

Landon sat up. “He killed my fucking best friend.”

“Beans is your best friend,” I corrected him.

“Beans is my best friend *now*... you gave me a random worker and told me he’s my friend like he’s a stuffed animal.”

I leaned up ready to fuck his little ungrateful ass up. All I ever heard was complaints and had given each of them everything I fucking had. Wonder held me, pushing her ass back onto me. Had I not been so pissed; I would have been more focused on that ass pushing against my dick.

“You wanna fucking bitch about your friend, you a man... let me be real with you now. I killed that little bitch because he was going to kill you. He was lining you up, Don. I told you to watch his ass, he was jealous. Your problem is you think everybody happy for you. Nigga, you live in a fucking penthouse, drive exotic fucking cars, and have anything you want, you think a nigga that comes from nothing ain’t gonna wanna take it? He tried to fucking take you from me,” my voice cracked, and I hated myself for the shit.

Wonder continued to rub my leg as she sat on me. "What?" He looked over at me, with a face that mirrored mine.

"Since we being honest, your little boyfriend that you used to love so much back in college... yeah, that nigga had a bet to smash you and recorded himself fucking you. Then he tried to post that shit on the internet, and this nigga got an alert for it," I pointed to Corleon. "Never told you because I ain't want to see that hurt you showing now. Think you would have that corner office at that law firm had they seen you being a fucking freaky ass porn star in college? How you think that shit is gone and there's no trace anywhere? When a nigga disrespects my sisters, I handle shit. Yeah, I took it into my own hands because I knew you would have spared his ass. I put that nigga in a chair for the rest of his life and got him shitting in a bag with a wired jaw... Now that we had honesty hour, get the fuck out my house."

Wonder tried to move so I could get up, and I tossed her ass over my shoulder, and headed out the living room while she remained quiet. "Not you taking her with you," Kora laughed.

"Mavie, I think I'm becoming lightheaded."

I put her down on the second floor, and she looked at me. "This was supposed to be a nice dinner."

"Wonder, you had the nice dinner. I'm not about to sit there and be the villain in all of their origin stories." I headed up to my room and stopped and looked at her. "Bring yo' ass... ain't seen you in two days."

She came skipping up the steps behind me, as I pushed the conversation with my siblings out of my head. I've done shit to protect them, and I never wanted it to fall back on them. With Don, I didn't want him to have that burden of having to kill his best friend.

I took on that burden and the hate that he had displayed toward me through the years. It was always me being the problem, when all the fuck I tried to do was protect them as best as I could. Who fucking protected me when I needed that?

I took on the licks, so they never had to feel the pain of carrying this family. Zoya hated me because of her ex-boyfriend. She told me to my face that she hated me and wished that I died, too. Certain shit, no matter how emotionally detached you were, fucked with you.

She was this big ass presence and did big fucking shit. Zoya was top dog because I challenged her, reminded her who she was. It was always in

her, and she needed a reminder that we were Caselli's, and we did big fucking things. I was so proud of the woman she was but hated the choice of men she decided to be with. As the years went on, I realized it was because she wanted to spite me. Why date the good guy that deserved her when she knew the ain't shit nigga with three baby mamas would piss me off ten times more?

Even with Don resenting me for killing his friend, we still got along and every once in a while, he would come and chill with me. Zoya stayed as far from me as she could, and the only time we spoke was when it came to something business related.

I wanted a relationship with her, but I also wasn't about to kiss her fucking ass because I saved her from having her ass all over the internet.

"I'm sorry," Wonder apologized.

I looked over at her. "What you apologizing for?"

"I'm the one who decided to do the little game. I just thought it would be nice to hear how they feel about you. When you came in, I could tell something was bothering you. Is it my father being missing?"

She was leaned against the window. How was she this fucking perfect? Her curly hair framed her face, and the dress she wore hugged her curves. Her feet were bawled up because she always claimed the floors in my room were freezing, despite the fact that they were heated.

"This works if we don't talk about your pops, Wonder."

She took a deep breath. "I know."

"If you want to go, you can. I'm not holding you here, and I'm damn sure not going to promise you not to harm your father. I'm not in the business of making promises I plan on breaking."

"Do you want me to go?"

"Nah."

She folded her arms and studied me. I never liked looking anyone in the face, and with her I couldn't help it. Every time I stared into her face, I was counting her freckles, and the laugh lines on her face.

Wonder loved to fucking laugh. Something that I was a stranger to because my laughs were far and few between. With Wonder, I found myself laughing more because she was always doing something or saying something crazy.

Her phone pinged, and she looked down and smiled. "You gonna make me trip the fuck out in here smiling at your phone."

Wonder's head snapped up and she smirked. "One of my favorite vloggers posted a new video up about her latest trip... relax, Mitchell."

She took a seat in one of the windows and pulled her legs up to her chest to watch the video. This was her thing, and I learned to leave her in her space whenever she was watching videos. Sometimes she would be in her room in the window watching a video on her phone.

Unlike her, when I noticed her enjoying her time alone, I never bothered her. It was considered her quiet hour. "Man, I can almost taste it that's how good of a quality her camera is."

I took a seat in the window, and she turned her phone around and showed me a sherbet inside of a lemon. "It is good."

She gasped. "You have tried it?"

"Been to the Amalfi coast a few times."

She was suddenly not interested in her favorite vlogger and more with me. "God, to travel that way is a dream. Skyler went to Monaco and then Capri, Italy, and the pictures were so beautiful. One could only dream."

I pulled my phone out. "You don't have to dream with me, Wonder. This is somewhere you want to go?"

"Hell yeah. I don't know if you know this or not, but I'm a fake wannabe vlogger. I record my commute to work... well, I used to."

I laughed. "Let me see."

She grabbed her phone and scrolled through everything and then showed me different videos. I watched as she walked down the streets of New York with a smile on her face, telling her fake audience where she was going. She stopped past a gallery in one of the videos and turned the camera while still continuing to talk. I listened as she spoke about one day owning a gallery of her own filled with Black art, and hosting painting classes for children.

"You want to own a gallery?"

There was this sparkle in her eyes while she nodded her head yes. "I want to name it the Messy Muse."

I laughed as I watched her study my eyes for feedback. "I like it... fits you."

"I'm coming up," I heard Jeffie's voice, and she appeared in the doorway shortly after. "Wanted to check in on you."

"I'm straight."

"You're not, but you have no other choice but to be, right?"

I looked away. "There you go."

"You have other choices than being alright all the time.," Wonder added while they both looked at me with that look.

"They wanted the truth and now they spoiled assess got the shit. Jeff, they left?"

"Zoya was the first one gone... Landon hung around for a bit, but Kora convinced him to give you space before having another conversation."

"Before you leave with Core, do me a favor and have them fuel the jet for the morning. I'm taking Wonder to the Amalfi Coast."

Both Jeffie and Wonder nearly hollered at me in shock.

"We are going there? Seriously?" Wonder jumped all over me, kissing me on the cheek and in my damn eye while squeezing me.

Jeffie smiled as she looked at me, I knew that look and I was ignoring her. "A spontaneous trip, Maverick... wow. I'll go get everything in order for tomorrow," she winked as she left us alone, and Wonder continued to hug me.

"I cannot believe that we are going? Maverick, seriously? I have to go pack something... anything." She went to run out the room, and I pulled her back onto me.

I searched her eyes. "I want to make you happy, Stevie. Want you to have everything you've always wanted and deserve. I'm not perfect and I know I'm a lot to some people... even crazy to some. Promise me that you're not going to leave me."

Her eyes watered as she looked into mine. "Does everyone leave you, Mavie?"

I looked at her. "Eventually."

I had been alone for a long time. Aside from Corleon, Jeffie, and then Kim when I was fucking around with her, it helped with the loneliness at times. Traveling and business took up a lot of time, so I never had much time to sit and think about having forever with someone.

Whenever I was alone, I thought of having someone to share my life with. I had all this money, homes, jets, yachts, and islands, and I was lonely. Don't get me wrong, I enjoyed my own company.

Since Wonder had been here, I enjoyed her company more. She had me considering giving up quiet hour just to sit and watch her paint. I've never considered trying to change until I met her. It was because she didn't try and change me.

I tried the chicken for her, and she never forced anything on me again. She didn't find me annoying or call me out on shit. I always noticed when she took notice, and she continued on. She was constantly studying me like I was doing the same with her.

Doing a spontaneous trip to Italy was some shit that I would have never done. I wouldn't have ever fucking left the next day, and even as I sat here, I was getting anxious thinking about it. Her hands covered mine, stopping me from rubbing them together.

Whenever I was nervous, anxious or wanted to fuck something up was when my hands got to rubbing together. "I'm here, Maverick. I can promise you that I'm not go—"

"Don't make promises you intend to break."

She grabbed both sides of my face and kissed my lips. "I don't intend to break this promise. You have to meet me halfway. Don't do things that will push me away... okay?"

"Yeah."



Recommendation: Listen to "As" by Stevie Wonder

THE REASON JEFFIE WAS MY RIGHT HAND WAS BECAUSE SHE MADE THE impossible – possible. All I had to do was tell her something, and she was handling it without any question. I always told her she deserved the world, and I knew Corleon would make sure she got that.

Wonder was the first one up in the morning ready. While she slept, I packed a small bag of my things, while she tossed whatever in her bag in the morning. I told her we could buy clothes when we got there, but there was certain shit that I couldn't travel without.

The pilot came and told me there were three hours until we landed. Wonder came from the back and sat across from me. She didn't say

anything, which was unlike her, while I continued to work. There was a bunch of shit that needed my signature on it for this ball, and I had been putting it to the side because I hated dealing with the paperwork.

Jeffie could only do so much without me, so I had to handle my business. “Why you staring at me like that?”

“You’ve worked the entire time.”

I looked around the jet and then at her. “Got to work so I can take you on more spontaneous trips like this.”

She smiled. “Can we cuddle?”

The only reason I found myself working was because she had taken a nap. “What’s the matter?”

“I had a dream about my mom. I swear I have a love and hate relationship with her coming to me in my dreams. I love them because they feel so real and give me comfort that she’s alright. Then, I hate it because when I wake up, I feel so empty.”

It was crazy how much I could relate to her when it came to what she was feeling. When my moms or pops visited me in my dreams, I felt like I was smiling the entire time I was asleep. It was when I woke up that I was reminded that it was a dream and they were gone, and I would never see them again.

Unless you experienced it, then you wouldn’t understand how empty and numb you felt on the inside. “Come here.”

She abandoned the other chair and climbed on me, and I relaxed the seat back while wrapping my arms around her. “I hate feeling like this... it’s always the same thing when she visits. Never says anything, she just sits on the edge of my bed taking me in. I spill my guts to her, and all she does is look at me... doesn’t give me words of wisdom or nothing.”

I rested my head in her curls as she continued to ramble about her dream. She held me tighter, as she continued to talk, and I listened. “Wonder, it’s starting to sound like you have beef with your moms now.”

She popped her head up. “I do, say something... she can’t possibly not have anything to say about my life right now. I got kidnapped, fell for my kidnapper, gonna marry him.”

“You got a crush on your future husband, Wonder?” I fucked with her, and she looked away while blushing. “Nah, come say that shit in my face.”

“You say it first, Mitchell.”

“I got a crush on Wanda.”

She sucked her teeth. “Why you had to say it with that name... say it with my name, Maverick.”

I licked my lips before kissing her. “I have a big ass crush on Stevie.”

She did a little squeal and kick of the feet. “Why do you call me Wonder? Because my name is Stevie?”

Whenever Stevie was around, I heard the song “As” by Stevie Wonder. It was her personal soundtrack whenever she entered a room or spoke to me. She made me feel as good as the song.

I took my headphones from the table and put them on her ear before choosing the song from my phone. “I call you Wonder because you make me feel like this, Stevie.”

She sat on my lap and listened to the song while staring at me. It was when she looked away, then held my eye contact that I could see her eyes becoming moist. She put her hands to her mouth as she continued to listen to the song. When she was done, she removed the headphones from her ears and looked at me.

“You really feel that way about me?”

“I do.”

She took my hands into hers and smiled at me, as a tear dropped onto my hand. “Maverick, that is the sweetest thing someone has ever said to me.”

“You’re too pure for this world and even for me. I understand that but even knowing that I don’t wanna give you up. I don’t want to be without you... if there was a choice between you and having to eat my chicken with sauce on it, I would choose you.”

She snickered. “You would choose me over wet chicken? Oh, Maverick.” She wrapped her arms around me and rested her head on me. “If there was a choice between painting and you... I would for sure choose you, too. Maybe, because I really do like painting, and you go quiet on me sometimes... I get it is quiet ho—”

“Give me a kiss, Wonder.” I shut her up because she got to rambling about nothing. She smiled and kissed me on the lips, slipping her tongue into my mouth.

Her hands found their way to my dick, and I watched her, curious to see what the fuck she was up to. Her hands found their way into my sweats, and she pulled my shit out and looked at it before getting down onto the floor.

“Have you ever got head on a jet before, Mavie?” When I hesitated, she rolled her eyes. “Seriously, Maverick?”

“The fuck you want me to say, baby? I had a life before you came into mine... I can say I ain’t never had head by someone that I would kiss after.”

She was satisfied with my answer. “I can accept that.”

I pulled her head back up and stared at her. “Nah, you been giving somebody head before, Wonder?”

She snorted. “No, I have never gave anyone head before... but it cannot be that hard, right?”

Leaning back, I put my hands behind my head as she stroked my dick. “I don’t mind being used as practice, Wonder.”

She snorted. “Alright, be serious, Stevie... this is serious business... you need to focus.”

I held my head up. “Baby, why the fuck you doing all that talking? All I should be hearing is you choking.”

“Choking?” she nearly hollered.

“I got a lot of dick, Wonder... wanna touch the back of that throat.” I ran my hand through her hair, and she gave me this little mischief grin.

I watched as she pulled her hair into a bun. “I’m not no punk.”

As I relaxed back with my hands behind my head, I felt her hand tighten around the shaft and felt the warmth of her mouth. I wanted to interject, but she seemed focused like she was going to get it right.

I hit the button near the chair that let the flight attendant and whatever staff know not to come in this cabin. Wonder looked up into my eyes with those pretty ass eyes and her mouth full of my dick.

I don’t know how it was possible to be even harder than I already was. She was sucking for her life and looking at me for approval. She was decent for this to be her first time. “Relax, baby... treat it like your favorite lollipop.”

She popped it out of her mouth and sucked on the head. I damn near pulled her bun with how good that shit felt. With the way her tongue maneuvered around the tip while she feasted on it like her favorite blow pop.

Inch by inch, she accepted more of me inside of her mouth while I held her head, slowly easing her down. It was how she looked up at me with my dick in her mouth. Licking my lips, I was trying hard not to fucking bust because the shit felt good.

It had been a good minute since I had some head, and since I didn't fuck with Kim no more, sex ain't even been on my mind.

Bitch had disgusted me so bad that I didn't even want to fuck nobody else. Do you know how fucking disgusting you had to be for me not to want pussy? "Shit, Wonder... fuck," I groaned as I felt her going deeper.

I expected to hear her choke, and when she didn't, I was even more fucking intrigued. I could feel the tightness of her throat, and knew I was back there, and she continued to suck on me like her life depended on the shit.

It was when she started humming that I felt that nut rushing to the top and quickly pulled my shit out her mouth, letting it erupt. "The fuck was you trying to do to yourself, Wonder? Choke on the dick?"

"Don't have a gag reflex." She remained on her knees while staring at me, and I was in fucking love. I knew I was in love before she sucked my dick, but I was really in love now.

"Certain shit you have to lead with, baby... should have said that shit before."

"Mr. Caselli, you have an important call trying to come through." I looked at the speaker and shook my head.

I grabbed my phone while Wonder went to the bathroom and grabbed towels to clean up the mess she caused. Her fine ass had on a pair of leggings, and I watched her ass jump as she skipped to the bathroom.

My little baby wasn't going nowhere, and even if she tried, I would kidnap her again. I smiled at the thought while she returned with towels. "What?" I barked into the phone.

"He ain't make it... they called it an hour ago," Beans said on the other end of the phone, and I knew who he was talking about.

Peso was one of my longest men that had been with me. He was so damn loyal that the man would cut his own hand off if he had a disloyal thought. I never had a problem out of him, and he liked being on the farm.

His ass had put in his work, so he didn't need to be in the mix anymore, so I allowed him to oversee the shit at the farm. "Fuck."

"What's wrong?" Wonder asked, as she finished cleaning up.

I squeezed the phone in my hand, as my eyes blinked open and closed fast. "What the fuck is the update on finding this nigga, Beans? I'm being real calm about shit, but I promise if I lean the fuck up—"

“Mens, we on it and doing everything. I called to let you know, felt like you needed to know. Enjoy the trip and when you get back we’ll hand—”

I ended the call and slammed my phone down on the chair arm, tossing my computer onto the fucking floor while my chest heaved up and down. “Why the fuck did he have to do that shit? He could have just worked the farm and been alive... I hate when I go against what I know!” I hollered as I tossed everything off the table in front of me.

“Breathe, Maverick... please,” Wonder tried to calm me down, as she stood over me. I half expected her to take cover on the other side of the jet, and she remained right next to me.

I looked up at her. “Pull your leggings down.”

“What?”

“You want me to calm down, right?”

She folded her arms confused. “Yeah, but what does me taking my leggings down have to do with it?”

I held her hips as I stared up at her. “I need to smell *my* pussy, Wonder... want me to calm down, let me smell it. I’m two seconds from going to the cockpit and choking out the pilot.”

She touched my face as she looked down into my eyes before pulling her leggings down. I helped her foot out of one leg, while she leaned back on the table. Soon as her legs opened, I put my head right between, and inhaled my favorite scent, kissing her inner thigh.

“Are you calm?”

I pulled her to the edge of the table as I continued to take hits of her scent like it was coke. “Uh huh... you ain’t never getting away, Wonder.”

“Do you realize how crazy you sound when you say stuff like that?” She looked down at me as I continued to kiss *my* pussy.

Ain’t nobody ever been in this shit. It was fucking pure, untouched, and I was gonna be the only nigga to ever be inside of it, eventually planting a seed right in it, too.

Her voice was coming in waves because as much as I needed to smell her, she wanted that tongue in her pussy, too. “Never cared about sounding crazy, just truthful. I’m ‘bout to eat this pussy, Wonder.”

“Uh hmm,” she agreed, and I ate my favorite meal, while decompressing. Who knew all I needed was Stevie’s pussy to keep my ass from going over the deep end?

OceanofPDF.com

Stevie



I THOUGHT GETTING ON THE JET FOR THE VERY FIRST TIME TO HEAD TO Italy – for the very first time as well, was enough.

Getting my pussy and ass ate while being all the way in the sky was something that I never had imagined. Maverick was downright addicted to me and couldn't resist himself. If he needed to smell me to avoid going to choke the pilot, I would sit on his face to avoid that.

The minute he slammed that phone on the arm rest and tossed that three-thousand-dollar computer to the other side of the jet, then blinked his eyes open and closed, I knew he was gone. While I should have been running to the other side where Duke and Kai were, I remained near him. He wasn't going to hurt me, and as crazy as it sounded, I knew he wouldn't hurt me.

I don't know why he turned me on when he referred to my vagina as his. It was giving possessive, and I couldn't lie and say that I didn't like it, because I did. This was a man that had big fucking energy, and it took me to calm him down.

I almost wanted to pat my pussy through my leggings because wouldn't that make me a big dawg, too?

Either way, I knew the conversation wasn't good and that didn't look good for Raye. Instead of him trying to fix the mess he was in, he went and messed it all up. The one thing I kept thinking about was how he put my life in jeopardy. He didn't know what Maverick would have done to me. I could have very well been killed, too, and he didn't care to try and rescue me, either.

Didn't I deserve to be rescued after saving him and Priscilla's life? Not that I needed to be, but the option would have been nice. Just like as a child, he had let me down for the last time. I couldn't save him. It wasn't my job to make a grown man do right, and Raye never wanted to do right. Even when he was given the chance to make right on his decisions, he would always choose the wrong option.

"We had to make a stop in France, Mr. Caselli. The jet has some issues, and we don't want to continue on until we figure them out. We decided to land in Paris, so you can enjoy a few days, and then hopefully this will be fixed."

Maverick looked at the pilot and nodded his head. I held my breath scared this man was going to fly off the handle again. "Heard you."

He nodded and then went back to the front while I looked out the window at a black SUV pulling up on the side of the jet, and then another car with a light on top following behind. "Are we in trouble or something?"

"Nah. Customs, they coming to look at our passports and shit before allowing us off the jet," he nonchalantly replied.

I guess you would be nonchalant when this was your life. He was used to this, and all of this was new to me. "Oh. We don't go into the airport?"

"Not when you're a Caselli."

I continued to look out the window. "Lots of perks when it comes to the Caselli name."

"You don't even know the half."

We went through customs and were granted access off the jet. I was excited to go to Italy, but the detour didn't bother me in the least. Seeing the Eiffel Tower in person had me so excited. One of my favorite movies was *Ratatouille*, so being in the country the movie took place in was a dream to me.

Menace held my hand as he helped me in the back of the SUV, quieter than usual. I was sure he had a lot on his mind, and I didn't want to disturb him, so when he got into the car, I took his hand and just enjoyed the scenery as we drove further away from the airport.

I felt his lips on the back of my hand, and I smiled at him. "You okay?"

"Yeah."

"If you're not okay, you can tell me that, too." He gave my hand another kiss, and then looked forward as we headed to what I assumed was our hotel.

It was still hard getting used to that this was my life right now. There was this feeling of royalty whenever you were with Menace. He had this walk and aura that told you that he was money, and he wasn't someone you fucked with.

When people met him, they immediately called him sir and rushed to do whatever he wanted, even if he didn't want anything. Climbing onto a jet with custom embroidered seats with the Caselli crest was something you only ever experienced in movies.

The family had a damn crest.

You didn't have to ask twice for anything when you were Menace Caselli. Hell, you didn't have to ask once because these people acted like they could read his mind. He kept this unbothered blank expression on his face, as if he didn't give a fuck what anybody was saying to him.

I mean, he really didn't give a fuck about what they were saying. Half the time, he would sigh right in their face like it wasn't rude. Rules and manners didn't apply to him because when you had as much money as he did, people fell all over your feet to please you.

He wore a dark pair of Louis Vuitton glasses so they couldn't see his eyes, which added to the mystery that he already was. The fact that he was dressed down in sneakers and sweats but had the bank account that he had, puzzled these folks.

"You know they say Paris is the city of love."

"Oh yeah?"

"Uh huh. Loveeeeeeeeeeeee," I belted out the words to Keyshia Cole's song, and both Duke and the driver jumped, turning around to look.

"Keep yo' fucking eyes on the damn street," Duke barked at the driver, who quickly turned around.

Maverick smirked. "You crazy, Wonder."

"How about we warn a nigga before doing some shit like that." Duke chuckled as he shook his head.

When we arrived at the hotel, we were greeted upon arrival. Willshire Paris was beautiful, and I couldn't wrap my head around the fact that I was actually in Paris. When I called Skyler earlier to tell her Maverick was taking me away, she was so excited for me.

Me and Skyler were always happy for one another, no matter what was going on in our personal lives. When she was jet setting around the world, I was happy for her. Even with me going through my own shit, I was excited

that she was living her life. The girl was always on go, so seeing her send pictures enjoying herself made me happy.

I prayed that she got back to that again, and she could let down her guard and welcome love in again. I held onto Maverick as the manager greeted us at the hotel and then took us right up to our room through the back.

Checking in at the main desk didn't exist when it came to Maverick. The main desk came up to our suite to check us in while I watched him look around the room and inspect the room. I didn't know if I should scream or cry. The Eiffel Tower was right there in front of us. We had a view of it from all rooms in this suite.

"Mr. Caselli, we have you with us for two nights... that will be thirty-six fifty."

"Thirty-six hundred dollars for this suite... that's amazing."

The woman stared at me as if she wanted to ask me *ho, is you cool?*

"Thirty-six thousand dollars, Wonder," Maverick replied, and handed her over the credit card. She easily slid the card on her device. "I need a cleaning staff up here now."

"Is it not to your liking, Mr. Caselli?"

"Obviously not... I need to see them clean it in front of me."

She finished checking us in and smiled. "Very well, Mr. Caselli."

I went out onto the terrace and took everything in. Quickly pulling my phone out, I facetimed Skyler. She answered and was chewing in the phone, and the background didn't look like our apartment.

"Um, where are you?"

"In my business, why you in ours?" I heard Corleon's voice in the background.

She put her head down to hide from me giving her that look. "Makes a lot of sense why you didn't want to facetime with me earlier, come to think about it, you were whispering earlier, too."

Skyler was laughing so hard as she covered her face. "It is nine in the morning, Stevie. What do you want?" she continued to laugh.

"Are you in a bed?"

"I am in my business."

"Stevie!" I heard Estella in the background, and then her face came to view. "I miss you!"

“I miss you, too, my favorite girl. How about when I come back, we spend the whole day together, okay?”

“Okay.” She jumped off the bed, and then her mother got back into the camera. I watched as she climbed out the bed and saw a peek of Corleon in the bed beside her on his laptop. Estella was shoving a fake cup of tea to his mouth.

“Dang, Estella, this cup taste better than the other one,” he lied, because nothing was in her teacups, but she loved for us to tell her she made the best tea.

The door closed behind her, and she was in the bathroom. “I called to tell you about Maverick, and you are apparently busy... what happened?”

“I had a panic attack at work, Stevie. Everything that has been going on caused the attack and I couldn’t breathe... I still had to pick up Estella, and I didn’t know what to do.”

“Um, picking up the phone and calling me would have been an option.”

She sighed. “He was the first person that came to mind when my coworker asked me who to call. He dropped everything and came to me... went to pick Estella up and then brought me to his condo in the city.”

I listened to her whisper on the phone. “What does this mean?”

“Nothing.”

“All I ever hear is you telling me, ‘Read the room, Stevie.’ I’m now telling you the same thing. If this man is the only person, not your cousin who would have dropped everything, that you could think to call, that means something.”

“Everything means something, though.”

I looked at her. “Girl, you starting to sound like me... you want to be with that man, and you are fighting it because you’re scared. If Keyshawn wants to play games, then let him play them. You have people that will pull up... the legal way of course, and handle it.”

She nodded her head. “Where are you?”

“Paris!” I spun the phone around, giving her the view that I was witnessing in person. “We had to make a pit stop because of something with the jet.”

“Ohhhh, look at you... so, um, I have a list of things that I need. You know things are cheaper over there?”

“Wait, they are?” I asked, as I watched her walk back into the room and get on the bed.

“Girl, yes... girl math... I will text you the list of things I want and then let me know how much.”

“Money in your account already,” Corleon said.

She playfully rolled her eyes. “You know I have my own money, right?”

“My money is you and Jeffie’s money... wish you stop playing and take the credit card I got you.”

“How can anyone argue with that?” I chuckled.

“How is he, Stevie?” Corleon asked.

I sighed. “Quiet... he got some news on the jet, and he’s been quiet since getting it.”

“I got the same news... shit is fucked up.” I could hear the hurt in his voice as he spoke about the news he had also received.

“Well, I wanted to show you th—”

That familiar cologne lingered, and those muscles were what I gripped as he tossed me over his shoulder. “Hi Menace,” Skyler laughed.

“What up, Mens?”

He ignored them. “Wonder, you done on the phone?”

“Not you ignoring us... you know what, goodbye.” Skyler laughed in the camera. “I love you, Stevie Raye.”

“Caselli,” Menace corrected her.

“Oop, I love you, Stevie Caselli,” she corrected herself and smiled in the camera. “Don’t forget that we have those tickets for Zay’s birthday party at that new club,” she reminded me.

We had bought those tickets months ago because snagging concert tickets was nearly impossible, and this was the next best thing. “Oh, I forgot about those.”

“Same. They sent a little reminder email letting everyone know it was still happening... I’ll let you go. Love ya,” she said, and ended the call, while Menace continued to carry me back inside.

As he carried me through the suite, I saw why it cost as much as it did. It had four bedrooms, a terrace that spanned the entire suite, and this view alone was worth the price. We made it to the main bedroom, and he lowered me onto the ottoman in front of the bed. To know Maverick was to know that absolutely no outside clothes were allowed on the bed.

“Two days in Paris, what are we going to get into?”

“This all on you... I been a bunch of times, so I wanna do what you want.”

I gasped. "Can we go to the Louvre... please."

"We can."

I smiled, excited that I would be able to see the Mona Lisa in person. For years I had been able to see pictures, never the real thing. Being in the same room would go in my mental bucket list that I kept.

"Do you wanna talk about the phone call that you got?"

"Rather discuss me eating yo' pussy again." He sat down beside me, and kissed me on the cheek, trying to change the conversation.

"Mavie."

"Wanda."

I sucked my teeth, allowing the name to slide because I didn't want to switch the subject. "Seriously."

"I want to keep you and what I do separate, baby. This life ain't for everybody and I don't want that shit crossing into what we building. I would never keep you in the dark but let me handle this."

I looked out at the view. "I've been trying to come to terms of losing my father."

"Not an easy thing to come to terms with. Still coming to terms with losing my own and it's been years."

I reached for his hand and squeezed it. "I'm not going to leave you, Maverick."

He needed that reminder because I knew he worried. It didn't matter how cool he played it; he worried about if I would leave after he killed Raye.

I was the child.

It was never my responsibility to keep saving this man. All my life I had wanted that fatherly love from him, something that told me that he loved his daughter, and I never got it. Everything took priority but fatherhood.

My mom fought for me when I was younger, wanting me to have that fatherly bond. I learned a long time ago that it wasn't her fight, and it wasn't mine, either. You had to want to be a parent. Nobody could make you be that, and when it came to wanting to be a parent – Raye didn't want that.

"You're not going to choose me over your pops, Wonder."

"I already did."

"Why?"

“Because I am in love with you, Maverick. I can’t even think of leaving you, even though that was all I wanted to do when I first met you. The thought of you sitting in that house alone before you met me brings tears to my eyes. You are complicated, and some days I wanna choke you because why can’t you just fucking flush the toilet once... but those are the things that I love. You aren’t weird, baby, you are unique. Different isn’t a flaw, it’s a feature.”

He kissed the back of my hand. “I love you, too, Stevie.”

I allowed him to pull me onto his lap and hugged him. “I’m not that bad for a mail ordered bride, huh?”

I watched as he shook his head. “Why the fuck you always gotta say some wild shit?”

I rubbed his beard before kissing his cheek. “Now, what are we going to get into today?”

“A bath... I wanna take one with you.”

I smiled. “Can we order room service and eat in the tub?”

From the look on his face, he would have rather eat hot coal and washed it down with bleach. “Yeah.”



*Recommendation: Listen to “All Night” by
Beyonce (Listen in at 3:09 in the bathtub
scene.)*

I UNPACKED MY CLOTHES AS MAVERICK WENT TO HANDLE A CALL ON THE terrace. While he was out there, the housekeeper ran our bath. Our room was like a glass box. The tub was in the corner with the most perfect view of the Eiffel Tower, then when you walked into the bedroom, the same view followed you.

Housekeeping left and I ordered our room service while Maverick finished up his conversation. I was already in my robe, and he kissed me on his way into the bathroom. I cracked the terrace door in the bedroom to get that fresh breeze when we finished with our bath.

Before going into the bathroom, room service came so I let them in. Grabbing the bottle, the cigar, and my hamburger, I juggled all of that while going into the bathroom. Maverick was already in the tub when I entered the bathroom, and the lights were off, with candles illuminating the room.

“They sent my cigar?”

“Yep.”

I handed it to him along with the lighter, and he wasted no time lighting it up and pulling on it until it became lit. “Don’t pop your eye out, Wonder.”

“Trying not to.”

By the time I popped the champagne and ate a few fries, I slowly took my robe off. Maverick’s full attention was on me. “Your body is fucking beautiful, baby.”

“Really?” I smiled.

“Yeah, come in here.”

He held my hand while I climbed in and sank down below the bubbles. “Even though the jet had problems, this is nice, right?”

“Better with you, Stevie.”

“Do you mean that?”

He flicked bubbles at me. “You know I do... why you so far?”

I watched as he blew smoke, looking so damn handsome. He held his arms open, as he pulled me onto him, and I kissed his face. “Can I try?”

He held the cigar as I took a large pull, damn near choking up a lung. Maverick had to put the cigar out because I was choking so bad. “Damn, Wonder, I said try it... not choke the shit down,” he said in between pats on my back while I felt like I was about to lose my lung.

It was sad to be able to go to Paris and then lose your lung all at the same time. “I’m...I’m alright.”

I accepted the champagne and choked it down to help with the burning sensation in my chest. “I was trying to be sexy.”

“Yeah, and almost fucking died.” He started laughing as he looked at the view that was in front of us. “Don’t even care about that view.”

“No?”

“Cause I got this one.”

My cheeks were about to burn off with how hard I was blushing. Rubbing his face, I stared into his eyes. My favorite thing about him was his lashes. Every time he looked down, his eyes looked as if they were closed.

He held my waist, with one hand on my ass, as I rubbed his beard. "You're beautiful, Maverick."

"Oh yeah?"

I kissed every part of his face. "Yes. I know there are some things that you have gone through that makes you feel less than that, but to me you are beautiful. Every flaw, quirk, and part of you is beautiful to me."

He took me in, as he held me tighter. "Where did you come from, Stevie?"

I smiled. "It started with me being in the Bahamas."

We both started laughing. "I'm trying to come to terms that I have you, and I deserve you. That's not a you problem, it's a me problem."

"Want to know what I think?"

"Always want to know what you think." He kissed my neck, as I messed with his chain, while the flashing lights from the tower reflected off the glass, and his face.

"Since my mother passed away, I always asked for a sign from her. I felt like I could never get a sign from her, anything telling me that I was on the right path and doing it right."

He removed my hair from my face. "Doing what right?"

"Life. I want to say that I think you were the sign, Maverick. I mean, she could have been less dramatic, but I guess she had to make a grand gesture since she had been ignoring me."

"I never asked my parents for a sign... never felt like I needed one. If your moms made our paths cross, then I wish I could thank her in person."

I snorted. "This is going to sound dark as shit, please don't judge me."

"Tell me."

"She made our paths cross, had me fall in love with you, and you are going to take Raye out... this is his karma. She wanted her baby girl to have protection, and I never got it from the one man that was supposed to protect me."

He let out a deep hearty laugh with his head tossed back. "That's some dark shit, Wonder."

"I'm saying... doesn't it seem like it, though?"

“Hell yeah, but she’s right about one thing.”

“And that is?”

“Her baby girl will always be protected being Menace Caselli’s wife... niggas won’t even think twice when it comes to you, Wonder.”

“His weird wife.”

“Fuck it... they already think I’m weird.” He smirked, showing me his perfect white teeth. His smile was so beautiful, and I wished he did it more.

“Do you really love me, Mavie?”

Maverick softly kissed my lips. “I do, Wanda.”

“Okay.”

“You love me?”

It was my turn to kiss his lips. “I do, Mitchell.”

“Okay.”

Looking away, I looked back into his eyes. “I want to give you my virginity.”

His brow raised. “Oh yeah?”

“I’m ready.”

“How you know I’m ready?”

I snorted. “You’ve done this before... plenty of times.”

“Not with you, Stevie.” He kissed my neck and wrapped his arms around me, as I held onto him.

This moment couldn’t have been more perfect, and although I was a woman already, I was ready to become *his* woman and give him my most precious gift.

Menace



Recommendation: Listen to "Forever" by Damage

SINCE WONDER STARTED SLEEPING IN THE BED WITH ME, I COULDN'T remember what it felt like to sleep alone. When I went on that two-day business trip, I tossed and turned all night wanting her next to me. Wanting to lay on her as she rubbed my beard while I fell asleep.

I had gone so long without affection from the opposite sex that this shit was better than sex. People confused affection with sex, and I had gotten plenty of sex through the years.

Never this.

Feeling a woman rub your beard while humming softly. Wonder was like melatonin because half the time I didn't need my scotch to put me to sleep. Soon as I climbed into the bed with her, she opened her legs, allowing me to get between them and lay on her.

No words were ever exchanged because she was learning me. Her hands always found their way into my beard, and then she hummed the words to "Fire and Desire" or "Interference." I only knew the second one because she was humming so hard, I thought she was about to have a heart attack, and then she told me the song.

Since Angelica, I closed my heart to ever allowing someone inside. I've had relationships throughout the years, and they never lasted. If you were not worthy than you were replaceable, and half the time those bitches were replaceable. I could find another one of them without even trying.

Stevie wasn't.

I couldn't go out there and find another her because there was only one of her. There wasn't another woman that talked to herself and then answered herself. She always searched my eyes to see if I was alright.

Didn't matter what we were talking about, she would pause and search my eyes. At first, I didn't understand what she was doing until I caught myself doing the same when I looked into hers. I always wanted to know if she was alright, and I never gave a fuck what anybody was feeling.

The whole purpose of the stop in Paris wasn't because the jet had problems. I was going to propose to Wonder. This shit started out on a rocky start, and because she didn't want a typical wedding, I wanted her to have a proposal she would always remember.

A proposal that I had planned and didn't use Jeffie in anything. Even when she tried, I locked her ass out of my email which nearly made her break out into hives. She didn't know when it was happening until I told her to get the jet fueled.

Wonder didn't give a fuck about the money I could blow on her. It was my time that meant more to her than the gifts and the money. I loved her little weird ass, and I wanted to make her happy.

As someone who could give a fuck about anybody's happiness, mine included. When it came to Stevie's happiness... I cared a whole fucking lot about hers. I loved to hear her laugh and see her smile. It was my favorite thing about her.

Damn.

I loved her little snort before she laughed more than anything. The thought of not having her with me drove me up the wall. Even now, I was laying on her and could feel her hand on me, and I was over here becoming angry at the thought of not having her with me.

Lifting my head, I watched as she slept. Her hair was always everywhere. A few pieces were in her face, as I slid between her legs and softly pecked her lips. After a few, her eyes fluttered and a smile came across that face.

"Morning, Mavie." Her soft voice caressed my eardrums.

I kissed her lips again, as she roped her arms around my neck. "Morning, Wonder."

"I'm gonna need you to leave me alone 'cause this is my quiet hour." She yawned and then started to laugh.

Wonder couldn't even keep quiet because she busted out laughing. "You ain't gotta worry about that, I'm gonna be real quiet with what I'm gonna do to you."

It was the sheepish grin that came across her face. "Doing that?"

"Uh huh," I said as I sucked on her neck, and she held me tighter. "You ready for that, baby?"

"Yes," she kissed my shoulder.

I lifted my head and searched her eyes, and she wanted this. It took nothing for me to pull her panties down and come out my briefs. I pulled her tank top from her body, as she lay in my arms naked.

Her full breast staring at me as she looked up at me with those beautiful fucking eyes. I remembered the first time that I saw her face, when that bag was removed from her face. Even then, never knowing anything other than her being Skyler's cousin, I was drawn to her.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing... absolutely nothing, baby."

"Sure?"

She was so pure, untouched. Nobody has had her, only me. There wasn't another man on this planet that could say he touched my wife.

It was like she was preserved for me. I was supposed to take her virginity and love her. "Positive. You want me to take your virginity, Stevie? I need to hear you tell me, baby."

She reached up and kissed my lips slowly. "I want... you... to... take... my virginity, Mavie."

The shades were wide open with the sun crashing into the room because she wanted me to keep the shades opened and the music playing through the night. Shit like that would have usually set me off, and with her it didn't matter.

Yeah, I spent a little time trying to get to sleep, but I would do it again for Wonder. She could ask me to kidnap the Pope, and I would be on my way to the Vatican with my sheisty mask ready to grab that old man.

There were no bounds when it came to how far I would go for this woman. I kissed her neck, working my way down to her breast. Taking her nipple into my mouth, I rotated between both of them as she squirmed.

My hand made its way down to her opening, feeling how wet she was for me. Her legs widened for me as I massaged her pussy before inserting a finger inside of her. She gasped when I added another finger.

“Mavie,” she moaned.

“What up? Tell me something, Wonder.”

“I wanna feel you inside of me, Mavie... you’ll go slow?”

I kissed her lips. “The slowest. You feel how wet you are for me, baby?”

“Yes.”

“Ain’t nobody ever going to experience this, right?”

“No, Mavie.”

I sucked her lip. “Stevie, I will kill a nigga for even looking your way.”

She stared me in the eyes. “I know, Mavie.”

My ass wanted to go back to the warehouse and beat every last one of my workers for even calling her beautiful. I don’t give a fuck if I asked the question or not, either. I was a conflicted nigga because I wanted the world to see how beautiful my wife was, at the same time I wanted to end whoever even thought she was.

I stared down at her as my dick teased her opening, ready to push myself into her. “Tell me if you want me to stop.”

“K.”

This was her first time. As much as I wanted to fuck her in the sauna that day, she deserved better. Any other bitch would have gotten fucked wherever I wanted, not her. I took her out the country to lose her virginity.

If anything came out of this, I wanted to say I conceived my baby in Paris with my wife. Distracting her, I sucked on her lips and kissed on her neck as I pushed myself into her slowly.

Slowly...

Inch by inch, I pushed myself into her trying not to fucking cry myself. She was so tight, as she held onto my shoulder, as I continued to push into her. I felt her body tense up and paused.

She stared into my eyes with watery eyes. “I can stop, baby. Tell me you want me to stop, and we can try again another time,” I kissed her cheek, letting her know it was alright.

“No, keep going... please.”

I kissed her lips, tasting her salty tears. “Tell me why you crying?”

“I really love you, Maverick. You taking my virginity means something to me. I’ve held onto it my whole life, and you are who I want to give it to. You defended it before you even knew me. Never once tried to claim it as yours, baby. Mav, you protected me when you didn’t have to.”

She reached up with both her hands and wiped my face. “Fuck, Wonder, you got me crying in some pussy.”

“I am not any pussy, Mitchell.” She screwed her face up.

Kissing her lips, I said, “Nah, you not... you’re my wife. Ain’t no other pussy out there like this one.”

She held onto my shoulders as I continued to push further into her. Her teeth bit down on my bottom lip as I slowly pulled out and pushed back inside of her while she maneuvered her body for me to fit.

It was so tight that I was second guessing who the virgin was. I was about to nut already, and we hadn’t even gotten anywhere. “You gotta talk to me, baby... how that feel?”

“It hurts a little, but not bad.”

“It’s gonna hurt before it feels good, okay?” I kissed her neck, as she squeezed my neck and allowed me to continue stretching her out.

“Relax your body, you too tense, the worst is over... I already popped that cherry.” I roughly kissed her lips, and she reached up to kiss me again.

This wasn’t the time to break her back and have her screaming my name. She wanted this to happen, and I was honored that she wanted to give it to me. It was a fucking honor for a woman to want to give a man anything.

That was the reason I got pissed when men thought they could take or do shit to women. Like their bodies belonged to them and they had the right to make decisions over them. Even homie that did what he did to Zoya. She thought you were worthy of having her in that way, and you went and betrayed her.

When Priscilla offered my baby’s virginity up on a platter to save her own life, it wasn’t hers to fucking offer. Like she had the right to offer it out. Like Stevie’s feelings didn’t matter. I watched her father, and although he didn’t know it was Stevie at first, he would have gotten on board, too. She never had anyone to protect her since her mother passed, and I was stepping into that space for her.

“You are the most precious thing to me, Stevie Caselli.” Removing that man’s name from hers was the first order of business for me.

She was always meant to be a Caselli, even before I had met her. I wasn’t heavy into signs like she was, but I knew my parents sent her to me. They knew I needed her, and because they couldn’t be here, they sent her in their place.

“You’re so big, Maverick,” she adjusted her body again.

I rolled over on my back and put her on top of me. She held onto my chest as she lowered herself down onto me. “You gonna be taking this dick like a pro’ real soon,” I gritted, feeling like she had my dick in a vice grip.

Holding my chest, she moved slowly. “I’m not ready to ride it, baby.”

I kissed her hands as I rubbed her breast and then held her waist. “I’m on your time, Wonder. You can go as slow as you need to... like this, nice and slow. Unclench your shoulders and get out your head.”

She followed my advice and slowly started riding my dick. Her breast slowly bounced up and down as she stared down at me to see if she was doing it right. I continued to hold her waist and directed her on how to ride.

“Hmm,” the pain she felt was slowly fading and she was starting to feel good.

Her curly hair was all over her head as her breast slapped against her chest and her nails dug into my chest the more she moved. “Fuck, yeah... look at you fucking in front of the tower... you look so fucking sexy, Wonder.”

“I do.”

“Fuck!” I slapped her ass, and she moaned. “You like that shit?”

“Uh hmm,” she leaned down and started sucking on my lips before I slipped my tongue into her mouth. Holding her hips, I slammed her down onto my dick while we continued to suck on each other’s tongues.

“Shit, Wonder... pussy so fucking good... shit... fuck.” I gripped her ass and slammed her down each time, and she moaned out.

Her curls tickled my nose as she continued to kiss on my neck while I finished the job for her. I felt myself about to cum, and I looked at her, kissing her in the mouth. She leaned back up and bounced up and down while running her hands through her hair.

I flipped her back over and slid right into her while her mouth curved, and she scratched my back. “Why the fuck you so sexy, Wonder? Got me ready to lock yo’ ass in the closet... shit... you gonna cum for me baby?”

“Mavie... right there,” she cooed, as I lifted her leg, and started beating that pussy harder. I half expected her to be ready to tap out after, and she was massaging her breast, which had my dick about to explode.

“Pinch your nipples for me, baby,” I played with the other between my teeth as I continued to fuck the shit out of her.

“I’m right there, baby... I’m about to fucking...shit,” I didn’t finish my sentence because we both came at the same time.

Her arms hugged my neck as I kissed her face while I felt my dick releasing all my soldiers up in her. This wasn’t about Rahmeek and Ghost saying I needed an heir; it was about this woman carrying my name and legacy.

Two things I ain’t never gave a fuck about, but Stevie had to be the one to do it. I couldn’t see nobody else having that name, or carrying a stomach full of Menace Jr.

“Think I might name him Menace... Dennis maybe.” I kissed her neck, and she pulled her head back.

“Mitchell, you are really crazy. Why would you ever tell me you wanna lock me in a closet, and then name our kid Dennis the menace?”

I roughly kissed her lips. “Baby, you already knew I was crazy before I slid up in you. Shouldn’t have let me taste it... matter fact, lift your legs up so we know the sperm getting to the egg.”

“Maverick, please be serious,” she started laughing and hugged me around the neck, kissing me on the lips. “Mavie, you took my virginity.”

“Wonder, you gave it to me... put that shit in my pocket. Ain’t no getting away from me now... hear me?”

“Uh hmm, Mitchell.”

“You fucking heard me, Wanda.”

My dick was still in her and seeing that look she gave me had me getting hard again. When Stevie looked at me, you could see that her words weren’t just that. Everything she said, she meant that shit.

“I love you.”

She rubbed the side of my face. “And I love you.”



*Recommendation: Listen to "Fire and Desire" by
Rick James*

AFTER I HAD TO SPIN THE BLOCK AND GET SOME MORE, WE GOT READY FOR the day. All she kept talking about last night was the damn museum and how important it was to see the Mona Lisa in person. The funny looking bitch wasn't even that fire for people to be coming from all over the world to see her.

Since I wanted to do anything that Wonder wanted, I made some calls and was able to shut the Louvre down for the day. The last time some shit like that happened was when Beyoncé and Jay-Z shut it down to shoot their video.

The Parisian man on the phone kept asking me what I wanted to film, and I almost told him that I wanted to bend my wife over in front of Mona Lisa and fuck the shit out of her, but I heard Jeffie's voice in the back of my head.

After a little back and forth and a whole lot of money, I got that bitch shut down. I waited in the living room for her to finish getting ready. Wonder came out wearing a pair of jeans, sneakers, and a beret.

The beret was a nonnegotiable apparently.

She had a crossbody bag on, and when she spun around, I wanted to tell her to take the pants back. Her ass was something in anything, but the way her ass was poking in those jeans was truly something else.

"You hate the outfit?"

"Nah. You look cute, Mama."

She smiled. "Cargos... no sweats?"

I shrugged. "Figured I need to be dressed decent to see the Mona Lisa."

I wore a pair of cargo pants, a T-shirt and my favorite pair of Chicago 1's. Was the material from the cargos driving me up the wall? Yeah. I liked how sweats felt on my body and always had. For my baby I would wear a potatoes sack if she wanted me to.

"Prada sunglasses courtesy of your angry spending?"

She laughed. "Yes. It felt good to buy these for no damn reason, too... they go with my outfit."

I walked over toward her and kissed her forehead. "You go with my outfit."

"Now is the time for me to do my fake vlogging." She pulled her phone out and recorded a little video introduction.

I peeped how she didn't record me in her video and kissed her head. My baby knew that her man was a ghost, and that I only appeared when I was

called. After she got her footage, we headed to the museum.

We held hands as we walked in the front, and she looked around confused. “Where are the people? I watch videos on this museum, and it gets so many visitors a day.”

Duke trailed behind us as we made our way into the museum, the man I had spoken to earlier was waiting for us. “Hello Mr. and Mrs. Caselli, it’s an honor to have you with us today... we have tour guides if you would like one.”

“Are we the only people here today?”

“Yes madam, your husband has shut the museum down for you... a special lady.” He smiled a little too hard at her, and I looked at him, and he corrected his smile.

Wonder whipped around and stared at me with wide eyes. “A whole museum, Mavie?”

The man winked and then took off, leaving us alone. “I’ll shut the whole country down for you, Wonder.”

She hugged me and I kissed the top of her head, feeling her itchy ass beret against my skin. “We have so much ground to cover.” I watched as she took one of the maps.

I grew up in private schools, so they taught everything about the arts. I’ve even attended more than a few art auctions and bought pieces of art that I had no interest in. This wasn’t something I would have done with my time, but I wanted to be here and experience this with her.

How the fuck could I not be excited when she was over here doing her little stomping excitement dance because we were here? The man came from the other end, and he was talking to Wonder while me and Duke walked behind them.

Duke laughed and I looked over at him. “Care to share what’s so funny with the class, Duke?”

“I ain’t never seen you like this with a woman. Boss, you wanna be in Steve-o’s skin, and you not even like that.”

“She’s special... ain’t no one like her.” I watched as she laughed with the museum’s manager as he walked us through the museum.

He nodded his head in agreement. “You struggle with feeling like you don’t need love. I’m telling you that you need it, and you need her. She makes you a better person... calmer. Makes the house lighter.”

“Heard you.”

As we inched near the Mona Lisa, I became nervous. I rubbed my hands as we came near, and she grew more excited to see that picture. The ring in my pocket felt like a weight as we got closer.

“Mavie, do you hear that?” She stopped and looked around.

I pretended like I didn’t hear her favorite song playing throughout the museum. “Nah, what you hear?”

“‘Fire and Desire’... you don’t hear it, Duke?”

He looked around and then nodded his head. “Yeah, I hear it. Boss, you don’t hear it?”

I smiled. “How they know this is your favorite song?”

We were in front of the Mona Lisa, and she didn’t give a damn. She was trying to get to the bottom of how they knew to play this song. When she turned around to the manager, I pulled the ring out of my pocket and got down on one knee.

Something I just knew I would never do. Marriage was never in the cards for me, and even when Rah and Ghost told me that it was something that had to happen, the shit felt like a death sentence.

This didn’t feel like that.

I ain’t never felt lighter and surer of someone in my entire life. Loving and protecting her was my only job. Helping her accomplish her mental bucket list was all I cared about these days. Duke stood back, as we listened to her ramble to the manager about how much she loved the song.

“Stevie?”

She quickly turned around and then jumped back when she saw me on my knee. “Mavie, what are you doing?”

“Baby, what else it look like I’m doing.”

She slowly walked closer to me. “I mean, I know what you’re doing... but why are you on your knee doing it?”

I looked down at the box before staring up into her eyes. “You are what home feels like to me, Wonder. My house has never felt like home until you came. I wanted to ignore how I felt about you, but I couldn’t.... you wouldn’t allow me to. Always there with that smile on your face, being you. Baby, you are you without any apologies. You accept me and all that comes with me without judging me. Stevie, you are my safe place, and my biggest trigger. You see past Menace and see me in a way that I never let anyone else see me. You love me with all my flaws and shit because you love me. You are my home, and I want this with you forever. I want to smell yo’

pussy every time I need to calm down...I wanna eat that shit right now, too."

"This fucking man," I heard Duke laugh behind me while the director looked mortified by my choice of words.

"I want to hear you hum me to sleep while rubbing my beard every night. You got me fucked up, I can't even sleep without you next to me now... this started out one way, but I want it to end another way... Stevie, will you spend forever with me... never leave me?"

Her face was soaked as she stood there, kneeling down in front of me. "Maverick Kojack Caselli," she started.

I pulled away from her quickly. "Why the fuck do you keep making up names, Wanda? That ain't even my middle name... I don't have a middle name."

She snorted while laughing through her tears, holding my face. "I want to make up names with you for the rest of my life. I want to love you and feel the love that you give me, Mitchell. I want to make your smoothies and separate your sauce from your chicken forever." She kissed my lips as I pulled her into my arms and hugged her ass so tight.

I was so caught up that I forgot to put the ring on her finger. "The Eaton name was full of traditions and keepsakes. I bought this ring a few weeks ago because I want this ring to be passed down in our family... the Caselli family. I want this ring to be passed down for years... my pops said I made the right choice."

"Did he?" She stared at the emerald cut twenty-four carat engagement ring. "This is beautiful, Mavie."

I tossed the box to the side and slid the ring on her finger. I may or may have not sized her finger when she was sleep one night. "Don't take this ring off, Wanda... I ain't playing with you."

She flashed the ring to the manager who smiled nervously. He was still on edge with the words I said, and the way I tossed that ring box. "Beautiful."

"The ring or her?" I asked, and Wonder started to laugh.

"Stop, Mavie... what made you get me a ring?"

I got up from my knee and tried not to focus on the trillions of germs on my knees while I hugged her. "Didn't like you walking around without one. I respect you not wanting a big wedding, but I would be damned if you don't have a big ass rock on your finger."

“And a new car maybe... so I can stop using yours.”

I kissed her lips. “My cars are yours, Wonder.”

“Good, because I scratched the Rolls Royce when I went to the mall... the person was too close, and I accidentally pulled in too close to them.”

Duke shook his head. “We said a secret, Steve-o... damn.”

“The fuck?”

She quickly stood on her toes and kissed my lips. “I love my ring, Mitchell.”

“Wanda, you gonna show me the scratch when we back home.”

She let out her obnoxious ass laugh that I had learned to love. “Or I can let you smell something... your choice.”

Suddenly, I didn’t give a fuck about a scratch and was more concerned on my future wife.

Core: Did you do it?

Me: Yeah.

Core: Congratulations Mens! Love you! See you guys when you're back.

OceanofPDF.com

Stevie



“I TOLD YOU TO PACK THE NIGHT BEFORE WITH ME AND YOU WANTED TO wait until the morning. This shit is unacceptable, Wonder... why the fuck would you ever do that shit to the toothpaste?” All I heard was Maverick ranting as I came from under the covers.

The sun nearly knocked me back because it was so bright in here. He was still going on and it sounded like gibberish because I couldn’t concentrate. So much was happening at one time as I held my hand up to silence him for a second.

“Huh? I can’t hear I don’t have my glasses on... hold on,” I reached for my glasses and put them on.

Maverick stood there for a second before he spoke. “Wonder that don’t even make fucking sense.”

“It makes a lot of sense to me... I can now hear you. What are you ranting about, Mavie?” I yawned as he pulled the toothpaste from behind his back.

“I fucked up... when Skyler told me that shit, I thought she was joking ‘cause she slow. You let me slide up in you, take your virginity and now I can’t get rid of you because I’m all in love... all for you to do this,” he walked closer to me and shoved the toothpaste tube in my face.

“What’s wrong with it?”

“Wanda, why the fuck are you strong arming the damn toothpaste like this? You got eight set of teeth up in that mouth? I would know, my dick been in there... I ain’t feel extra sets of teeth where you would need to use this damn much and squeeze the shit like this.”

He was full on crashing out about the toothpaste and was serious. I couldn't laugh because this was serious to him. Everything was still foggy as he paced with the tube in his hand and continued his rant.

When there was a light tap at the door, I fell back onto the pillows happy that he was done chatting about nothing. Who cared about the toothbrush to toothpaste ratio?

"What?" he hollered, and Duke stood in the doorway staring at him because this was normal to him.

He was used to this man going off at any little thing. "I know you need to stop all that yelling... you sound crazy." I yawned. "Ahhhh!"

I screamed when he jumped onto the bed and was now in my face. "Do I, Wanda? 'Cause I wouldn't be set off this early if you wasn't in there fucking the toothpaste. Then you out here teaching babies... My God daughter to do the same thing."

"What in the fuck is wrong with him?" I looked at Duke who shrugged his shoulders and waited for him to finish with me.

"Yo, Boss... we got word on two things... important."

Maverick stared in my face, kissing me on the lips before climbing out the bed. "You lucky I love you, Wonder."

"I could say the same," I yawned, as I turned over and he left the room with Duke.

Snatching my glasses off, I got comfortable again until I heard my future husband's voice rattle off the damn walls with how loud he was. Glass being broke followed as I leaned back up in the bed.

"Duke, if I get to that fucking jet and we not ready for take-off, I'm fucking choking the pilot... on my dead mama."

He stormed back into the room, slamming the door behind him pacing in front of me. All he had to do was look at me, and I pulled the blankets from me as he climbed into the bed between my legs.

Like I was his personal drug, he kissed the inside of my thighs as he nudged his nose in between my legs and inhaled, while I rubbed his head. "Want to talk about it, Mavie?"

"Nigga killed one of the Case House girls... they fucking killed Teyana," he continued to kiss the inside of my thigh and smell me.

Everything inside of this suite screamed expensive, so knowing that he was out there tossing things, if this is what he needed to calm down, then I was going to calm his ass down.

“No Amalfi Coast?”

He looked up into my eyes. “I’m gonna make it up to you.”

“It’s okay. Your girls are important... was it my father?”

His look gave me my answer as I rubbed his head and leaned my head back. Raye was making more of a mess than anything. It was hard to feel bad and not want him dead when he was going around causing destruction for everyone.

“Then we go home.”

He kissed my thigh and looked up at me. “We go *home*.”

I rubbed his head as he continued to kiss between my legs and quiet his thoughts. As much as I was looking forward to going to Italy, I knew he had business to handle and that came first. Whenever we did go, I wanted his focus to be on just the two of us, nothing else.



I ALMOST FELT BAD FOR HIM AS HE TRAINED HARD LISTENING TO THIS SAME song on a loop. Taking a break from kicking the shit out of the little training device, he nodded his head to the song while he caught his breath.

He did this every morning.

Never skipped a morning.

I was slowly learning Menace and I noticed he became more obsessive with things whenever he had a lot going on, and lately there had been a lot of things going on. His hands were constantly rubbing together, and he screamed on Lupita because she didn’t have his smoothies ready at three in the morning.

Menace was out in full force, and I wanted whatever that was going on to be done so he could calm down. I watched him pop his medicine in the morning, and not even that helped. He had been down here since early this morning. I’m not sure he even went to bed last night and probably came straight in here to work out.

I held a cup of coffee in my hand as I came in from my studio this morning, so I heard the familiar tune and found myself humming to it while I stood in the entrance of the massive state-of-the-art gym. My ten-dollar

gym membership didn't have none of the equipment that he had. Maverick lived his life on a loop – nothing changed.

His home was the same exact way, his staff knew how he liked everything. There were no surprises in his life, and whenever there was, there was hell to be paid. I think I had been the only change in his life.

"Morning, Wonder." He saw me before I could make my presence known.

I was in the process of putting all the things I had bought when I went on my angry shopping spree away, and I fell asleep in my room. Menace hadn't gotten home by the time I woke up to pee, so I changed my clothes and climbed back into the bed. I also wanted to give him some space, too.

"Good morning... is it quiet hour?" I whispered.

"Why you whispering?"

"Answer the question first."

"Nah."

I took a seat on one of the bikes and looked at him. "How are you this morning?"

He turned, his chest glistening with sweat and tiredness in his eyes, which proved my theory that he hadn't slept. "Didn't sleep last night, so came downstairs to work out."

"Why?"

He walked over toward me, took the coffee out of my hand to sit on the stand near the bike, and picked me up. "What are you doing?" I giggled, as he held me in his arms, staring into my eyes.

"You know why I didn't sleep good."

"I do?" I scanned my brain to figure out why he wouldn't be having a good night's sleep. "I know you showered and probably counted your steps to the bed."

"Fourteen."

"Actually, it's twenty-nine," I countered.

"You shorter than me... I take bigger steps." He continued to hold me up as I smiled at him. "You wasn't in my bed... why?"

"Was giving you space, Maverick. I don't want to be overcrowding your space like I did before... see, I'm being mindful. Skyler says I don't read the room sometimes and I'm trying to do that with you, but I don't know where I fit."

I wanted to sleep in his room and be there when he came in, however, I was scared to do it. What if he came home and was pissed that I was in his space? After the way he blew up on me for ruining his quiet hour, I was learning my place when it came to sharing his space. At the end of the day, this was his home.

He had curated every corner of this massive home to how he wanted it. Every part of this house reflected him, and it was his comfort. I was trying to figure out how I fit into this home and into his world without being annoying to him.

“You fit here,” he lowered me until my ass touched his dick, and then he lifted me up again. “In my bed, Wonder. Did I complain about you being in my space?”

“Dawg, I’m not trying to get to that point. I don’t know if you know this or not, but Mitchell, yo’ ass be tripping.”

“Wanda, yo’ ass be talking.”

“See!”

He laughed and carried me out of the gym, across the hall where the sauna was. “I don’t want you to question where you fit in my life, Wonder. I told you where I want you, so let me come home and you not in that bed again... we gonna have a problem.”

I smiled. “Okay.”

He kissed me on the lips and closed the sauna behind us. “Remember when you wanted to fuck me in here?”

“I never said that. All I asked was a simple question and you answered it.” I looked away, and he pulled my face back to face him.

Lowering me down, I could feel his dick fighting to get out his shorts. There was no other way that I could have imagined losing my virginity. Since I was a teen, I had sat back and envisioned what it would be like losing it to someone.

Would there be flowers and a bunch of music while we stared into each other’s eyes and promised forever to one another? I remember my mom found my journal and I had journaled exactly how it would happen with Tony.

I just knew he would be the man that would take my virginity. That I would be staring into his eyes while I gave him my most precious gift. Instead, it was Maverick who took it, and I had no regrets.

He was so gentle, soft, and reassuring as he took something that I had been holding onto. As he pushed himself inside of me, removing the last of my innocence, the Eiffel Tower was right behind him.

How many women can say they lost their virginity in front of the Eiffel Tower in Paris? Not too many, and Maverick did that for me. It was just as important to him as it was for me. Then the proposal. I got engaged in front of the Mona Lisa, and after seeing the size of the ring, that funky hoe didn't matter that much anymore.

"Can I fuck you, Wonder?" He bit his bottom lip as he continued to hold me, and I looked up at him all giddy.

I kissed him. "I'm going to meet with your sisters in a little while for brunch at Kora's condo."

He kissed my neck ignoring anything that I had to say as he pulled down his shorts, and I felt him pushing my panties to the side. Maverick sat down on the bench and looked at me while he slowly placed me on his dick, and I held onto his shoulders softly moaning.

I didn't understand why everyone in the world was so angry. Getting dick was the best thing next to crack. I never did crack, but the way it had people out here begging for it, I can imagine it was similar to having sex.

It was always a struggle having to adjust myself to Maverick's size. How can a man be this powerful, rich, handsome, and have a dick as big as his? I guess his only flaw was that he was a looney bin.

A looney bin that knew how to fuck.

"Tell me what you were saying again... wasn't listening." He smirked as he held onto my waist, and I bounced up and down on him.

He bit down on his lip as he increased speed, slamming me down onto him harder. My breast slammed against my chest the harder that we went. "Mavie... hmmm... harder," I begged, and he did exactly what I wanted by slamming me down harder each time.

His hand gripped my ass, while the other held my waist as I felt his dick stretching me out each time he lifted me and slammed me back down onto him. His chain slapped against his chest as he bit down on his lip while keeping eye contact with me.

"Give me kiss, Wonder... let me taste that tongue," he grunted, close to his peak, and I was already at mine.

I held his face, sucking on his tongue while he went harder, and the bench started to move. "The bench, Mavie."

“Fuck that bench,” he groaned, as he held me tighter on the hips and lifted me one final time before he slammed me back onto him, and I exploded, while holding onto his neck. I felt his body tense up as he released himself inside of me.

Kissing his face, I looked at him. “This wasn’t what I expected when I came to say hi to you this morning.”

“Wouldn’t have had to get fucked down in the sauna if you were in that bed last night... don’t let it happen again.”

His phone started to ring in his shorts, and I reached down to give it to him. Looking at the number, I could see him disassociating, which meant the call was about to have him on ten. I tried to move, and he kept me in place, while he kissed on my neck and answered the call.

“I’m inside my fucking wife and you calling me, so this shit better be fucking good, or when I finish, I’m kicking somebody’s head off their shoulders.” I kissed his shoulder as he continued on his conversation.

I could never tell if the conversation went good or not because he was never pleased to be bothered. Duke was the only person he didn’t go off on because there was a mutual respect, more like friends. Some of the security would tell Duke to relay a message because they knew he wasn’t going to go off as much.

Grabbing his watch, I looked at the time and whispered. “I have to go and get ready.”

He held me in place while cradling the phone between his shoulder. When I felt him rising again, I quickly hopped off because he wasn’t about to slut me out in this sauna when I had things to do.

“Why you running, Wonder?” he called behind me, completely disregarding the conversation on the phone.

“I cannot be late for brunch, Mitchell... see you later, baby?”

He nodded as he smiled at me. “Def gonna see you later, Mrs. Caselli.”

“You keep calling me that, but I haven’t seen no talks about us actually making it official... don’t you have to be married?”

“Not worried about those niggas, Wonder... clear your schedule tomorrow, okay?”

I paused. “To get married?”

“Yeah... I wanna marry you. You still want to marry me, Boo?” He looked at me with that silly smirk that I loved so much. Not everybody got to see it, so I felt like it was reserved for only me. I watched as he pulled the

phone from his ear and looked at it with disgust while putting it on speaker.
“Nigga, you just said fuck my marriage?”

“What?” the other man nearly hollered. “Mens, I ain’t never say no shit like that. I’m happy for you and Mrs. C. That shit is beautiful.”

“Our marriage or her?” he questioned.

“Fuck... Mens is this a fucking trick question?”

He leaned back. “Depends ... answer it wrong and I got a trick for yo’ ass.”

“The marriage?”

“Answer it like we playing jeopardy.”

“What is the marriage?”

“Ding ding... you good for now.” He ended the call and turned his attention back toward me. I knew his men hated to see his ass coming because he kept their asses on their feet.

“I still want to marry you, Maverick. Tomorrow sounds so soon though. Neither of us have anything to wear.”

“And you acting like last minute matters to us? You ‘bout to be a Caselli... I’ll have your shit in our room, Stevie... don’t you go back down to that other room.”

“I have my stuff in there,” I protested as he stood up, his dick still out and shorts around his feet as he shuffled over toward me. “Why are you like this, Maverick?”

Backing me up into the corner, he leaned over me while staring in my eyes. “I’ll have them move it upstairs on the other side of the closet.”

“After the toothpaste crash out, I don’t know.”

Softly nibbling my lips, he grabbed my ass. “Don’t be in there strong arming the damn toothpaste and we won’t have no problems.”

I stood on my toes, pushed my lips against his and exited the sauna.
“See you later, crazy.”

Stevie



SKYLER AND ESTELLA BOTH RAN TOWARD ME WHEN I STEPPED OUT THE back of the truck. Duke held the door opened for me, and I jumped out running toward them. We all hugged and spun around in a circle while saying how much we missed each other.

Kora had invited Skyler to brunch and since Estella was out of school today, she brought her along. I was so excited to see my cousin that I forgot to show her my ring and tell her everything.

“Wait, look... he proposed to me.”

Skyler smiled. “I know, he told me.”

I gasped. “No.”

“Yes.”

“No.”

“Yes.”

“No.”

“Stevie, I am not about to do this with you.” She laughed, as she took in the ring. “Whew, this ring has to be at least a million or more... I see why he got you in that damn tank and with Duke.”

We walked into Kora’s building, and they granted us access up to her floor. “He asked me in front of the Mona Lisa...shut the whole museum down for the day.”

Estella was pulling on her bag, so she quickly grabbed her tablet so she could get on the elevator and keep quiet. “The whole museum? You’ve always wanted to go there, too... did you get your selfie with Mona?”

“Girl, no... I said fuck Mona when I saw him on his knee.”

“His knee?” Skyler nearly screamed in the elevator.

Everybody knew that Maverick was a germaphobe, so seeing him down on one knee in a public place was more romantic than the actual engagement.

I looked around the elevator like it was more than just us three in it. “He took it, Skyler.”

She gasped. “I knew you were walking a little different, glowing a bit more... how was it?”

I couldn’t stop blushing as I told her how everything went and she squeezed my hand, excited for me. We made our way down the hall to the only unit with double doors.

“Why am I nervous to have lunch with her?” Skyler whispered the closer we got to the door.

Estella was behind us, too into her tablet to care where or who we were having lunch with. “Kora is really cool. So down to earth... it’s Zoya that scares me.”

“Zoy is cool. You just have to get to know her more.”

“She hates her brother.”

Skyler made a nervous face. “Really?”

“The dinner I hosted didn’t go too well, and neither of them have reached out to the other. Landon has reached out to his brother, but Maverick is stubborn.”

Every time Landon tried to reach out, Maverick ignored him. It wasn’t like he could just show up because he made sure that security wasn’t letting him in. He was angry, hurt, and pissed all wrapped into one. For years he carried the brunt of doing what he did to his brother’s best friend, so Landon didn’t have to carry it.

To know the things he had done for his siblings and never asked for a thank you. He allowed them to resent him and make him out to be the bad guy when all he was doing was protecting them. It made me sad, and I wanted to hug him right now.

I pressed the button, and we waited until we heard the locks, and one of the doors swung open. Kora stood there with her curly hair pulled into a tight bun, high-waisted, floral wide-leg pants, heels, and a cropped shirt.

“Hey, I was wondering when you guys would get here. I’m Kora, Menace’s sister, and yes, I am normal... most of the time,” she laughed as

she hugged Skyler. “Who is this beauty here?” she kneeled down until she was face to face with Estella.

“Stellie,” Estella replied, and she pinched her cheeks too smitten with her.

Me and Skyler smiled at Kora taking her in. “You are the most beautiful doll I have ever seen. Do you like candy, Stellie?”

Estella’s eyes widened as she shook her head. “Yes.”

Kora stood up and held her hand out. Estella held her hand as she welcomed us into her condo, which was beautiful. It was full of Black art, and contemporary furniture. It was massive, and cozy all at the same time with huge floor to ceiling windows that showed the entire city.

How she ever got anything done was beyond me because the view was enough to keep me stuck all day. Her heels clicked on the bamboo wooden floors as she showed us around and pointed out certain pieces to me.

I took in her space, pictures of her in college and on vacations. There were a few pictures of her in different countries with a White man. He was pretty consistent all throughout her home with the different pictures of him. Kora’s home was night and day to her brother’s home. It was warm, inviting and lived in.

You could piece her life together by the pictures and different things within her home. When it came to Maverick’s home, you didn’t know who lived there because there weren’t pictures anywhere. As nice as his home was, it wasn’t all that inviting because the art was there, however, there weren’t that many pieces around.

“Your home is so damn fire,” Skyler said, as she took everything in while Kora led us to the kitchen and dining area.

Kora smiled. “Thank you. I spent a lot of time trying to make it my own. These luxury condos are hard to make your own because they are so sterile.”

“You’ve done an amazing job with it, too. Doesn’t feel like one of those places at all. Core’s condo in the city feels exactly like that.”

“I believe he only sleeps there when he’s not at Bruster Manor,” she looked down at Estella. “Can I pick you up, Sweetie?”

Estella looked at her mother, and Skyler gave her a nod. “Yes, please.”

Kora was so tickled by her and put her on the stool. She went around the counter and grabbed some candy from a dish on the back counter. “We

can sit in the living room until Zoya gets here. She finished in court not too long ago,” she led us to the living room, and we both sat down.

“Have she and Maverick spoken?”

Kora hopped from the couch. “Let me get you guys a drink.” I watched as she walked around the counter. “They won’t speak, and it has always been like that. For years I would try, and it would be useless. Neither of them think they are wrong, and both go at it every time.”

“Do you think she would come to our ceremony?”

Kora looked at me shocked. “Ceremony? What happened to the wedding?”

I sighed. “I don’t want a big drawn-out wedding. My mom is no longer living, and I always imagined her being there to see me get married... doesn’t feel right.”

Skyler rubbed my leg. “That doesn’t mean you shouldn’t have the wedding of your dreams, Stevie.”

“Yes, I agree. My mom isn’t here either, but I want to walk down the aisle to my forever one day. Right now, the pickings are slim, and every man is always intimidated when he finds out what I do.”

“As your sister-in-law, I will be there to hold your dress and do whatever you need. For me, I don’t want to have a huge wedding with people I don’t know.”

“I can respect your decision. When are you both thinking about doing it?”

I looked down at my shoe. “Your brother said tomorrow.”

“Tomorrow?” Kora nearly hollered.

“Look, I just found out today, too.”

She smiled. “And you want to marry my brother... I know that this was a deal between the two of you. For Mav, this isn’t a deal anymore, that man is in love with you. Might be obsessed, so I would be careful marrying his nutty ass.”

“Baby, it takes a special someone to be with a man like Menace. You know he called me slow?”

“You are acting a bit slow, Skyler,” I snorted.

“Whatever. Worry about stealing grapes while your man is counting them.” Both she and Kora fell out laughing when the door chimed.

“I’m going to need both of you to calm it down on Maverick.” I gave them both the stink eye while Kora went to get the door.

Skyler finished her drink. "Are you really ready to be his wife?"

"Is anyone ever ready to be a wife or a mother?"

"No, but you kind of have to get ready or know that you are... marriage isn't some game, Stevie."

"Skyler, I know that. Has any of this ever been a game to me? I'm not a virgin anymore, so you can't tell me what to do like I don't have experience."

"Just because you riding dick doesn't mean you know everything, Stevie."

We both had a brief stare down before we laughed, and she fell into me. "This feels right. Maverick needs me, and I need him, too. Sky, I promise I wouldn't do this if I didn't feel good about it."

She held her hand out. "That is all I needed to hear. If this is what you wanna do, then I'm going to be right there behind you."

Zoya rounded the corner with her work bag. "Hey Stevie and Skyler," she came over and kissed our cheeks before flinging her bag onto the table and plopping on the opposite couch. "Tequila and honey and hold the lime," she told her sister, who went right into making her drink.

"Long day."

"The longest damn day in history, and the day isn't even over. I had court all morning and cleared my afternoon to be here, but sheesh. I'm not even supposed to say anything, but because she's not my client yet, I can say it. Gerald's parole officer is suing the city and has retained the firm to represent her."

Skyler snorted. "Was she not fucking him in return for letting him slide all over the damn country and out the country?"

Zoya accepted the drink from her sister and took it back. "She was. They fired her because she had another parolee that she was doing the same thing with. Claims she hasn't slept with anyone and has only done her job. Gerald is sitting behind bars because of her... fuck you meannn."

Skyler laughed and I was trying to figure out the joke. "Just be honest with yourself, you miss that man."

"I do miss running into him."

Kora snickered. "From what you told me about him, I think he and Maverick would get along."

Zoya sucked her teeth. "Too bad I don't really care about impressing my brother. He told me to get the fuck out of his life."

“House, Zoy,” I corrected.

“It’s the same thing.” She shrugged.

“No one is saying that he isn’t wrong though. You just have to both be willing to sit down and talk it out.”

Zoya laughed. “Yeah, I’m not doing that. I love you for him because I haven’t seen that side of him... ever. I’m not about to pretend like me and Menace aren’t like oil and water.”

“Will you at least come to our ceremony? It would mean a lot to him if you were there.” I gave up the argument of wanting them both to fix things.

It would have to take them both to want to fix their relationship, and neither of them were in the space to do that. “He never invited me.”

“She’s inviting you,” Skyler added.

“Zoy, we have to be there for him. Maverick has always been there for us, no matter how he has felt. You told him that you wished he would die, and he showed up to your law school graduation with flowers and a brand-new car for you. He’s not always right and he doesn’t show us his feelings, but he does love us.”

“And you kiss his ass because you are his favorite.”

Kora leaned forward and pointed her freshly manicured nail at her younger sister. “No, I stick up for him because I know shit you have no idea about. I know the sacrifices that man has made and the trauma he has been through. Is he always right? No, but he fucking has come through for us when the rest of those Eatons could give a fuck about us. I remember when Mommy and Daddy died, you don’t remember much or maybe you don’t care to, but I remember. You are always complaining about him changing our names without our permission but don’t know shit about his reasons. Neither you nor Landon know shit but always got your fucking lips poked out. That confidence and big fucking personality you have is because that man showed you how to show up and never look weak to people.”

I sniffled and everyone, including Estella, turned to look at me. “You not being yelled at. The hell are you crying about?”

“I just really love that man... I’m sorry.” I wiped my tears. “And he took my virginity.”

“Stevie!” Skyler shoved me.

“What? We’re all friends here, right?”

Zoya and Kora both looked at me and laughed. “Oh wow, you were really sent special for Menace.”

“Usually, I wouldn’t want to hear this because it’s my brother, but yeah, go ahead and cry for your man,” Kora smiled.

Skyler held her shirt over her face laughing. “Stevie, I can promise you they didn’t need to know that their brother took your virginity.”

“In Paris by the way... and he proposed to me.”

Both Zoya and Kora jumped up when I showed them my ring. “As in getting down on one knee and professing his love for you?”

I smiled widely. “He did... Duke even recorded it for me to have.”

While they both held my hand, I grabbed my phone and showed them the video. While Zoya was trying to see, Kora took my phone and plopped down in the chair. Tears fell down her face as she watched the video.

“Damn, K, can I see the video, too?”

“You couldn’t stand him a minute ago,” Skyler added with a smirk on her face.

Zoya stuck her middle finger up. “Mind your neck and worry about why you been staying the night with Corleon.”

“Alright, not too much in my business.” Skyler quickly wanted to switch the subject when we got on her and Corleon secretly creeping on the low.

“Mama, Core-Core is calling.” Estella showed her tablet, and Corleon happened to be facetimeing her.

“You can answer.”

She got excited as she slid her finger across the screen. “Stellie Belly,” he greeted soon as he saw her face.

“You can go down to the room on the left if you need more privacy,” Zoya told her because Kora was still watching the video.

She had crossed her legs and was all into it. Skyler took Estella, and they went to talk to Corleon in the next room. Kora swiped away a tear as she held my phone in her hand.

“Do you mind sending me that video and the pictures? I have pictures of everyone... Landon graduating from college the first time, then Zoya, but nothing with Maverick. He never smiles in pictures—”

“He doesn’t take them at all,” Zoya added and snatched the phone to watch the same video her sister had just watched.

“Anyway, seeing him speak how he feels about you... God, I never thought I would see the day. You really make him happy, and I can see that he makes you the same way.”

We both turned and watched as Zoya quickly tried to catch the tear that slipped down her face. “What? I’m not heartless now... you both look so happy. The fact that he’s wearing pants and not sweats.”

“He did that all on his own.”

“I’ve only seen him in sweats and suits, and he only wears suits when he has to.” Kora smiled.

“Will you both come tomorrow? I know it would mean a lot to him that you are there. It would mean a lot to me, too. Aside from Skyler, I don’t have any family.”

Kora switched seats and sat next to me, pulling my hands into hers. “I wouldn’t miss it for the world.”

Zoya smiled. “The fact that you didn’t run for the hills means you love him. I will move some things around and be there.”

“Invite Landon, too. I know he’s been trying to talk to Maverick and he’s not in the space to talk to him.”

“And you see why I don’t reach out.” Zoya pointed to her sister.

“No excuses. I will call Landon tonight and we will be there... I will move some cases I have and make sure I am there.”

“Kora, you need to be careful,” Zoya warned her.

“I will make sure I am protected, but I am not missing my brother getting married.” She looked at her sister.

“Thanks, guys.”

Zoya continued to watch the video, and I could see that she felt the same as her sister. Where Kora was easy to show her emotions, Zoya wasn’t. They were the same person just in different fonts. Zoya was the kind of person that didn’t reveal her emotions, and she played hard. It would take a strong man to pull her out of this tough exterior that she put on.

“Don’t mention it. The food should be here soon... and while we’re waiting, I am going to book you with my hair girl.”

“Oh, don’t worry about it. I’m going to my stylist.”

I told her, and she lowered her phone. “Last minute?”

“She’s going to take me in... always makes time to squeeze me in.” I laughed, because Cindy was going to kick my ass and hug me all at the same time.

“Well, alright.”

“I wanted to host Thanksgiving this year, and I would like to do something away. It’s always me, Skyler, and Estella, so I would like for us to do something. When is the last time you spent the holidays with Maverick?”

Zoya snorted. “Not since I went away for college.”

“I’m ashamed to admit, it has been a long time.”

I sighed. “I think it would be nice to do something as a family before the baby gets here.”

Kora and Zoya both gasped super loud. “What? I’m going to be an aunt?”

“Oh, I have to start shopping now... I’m going to be Auntie Z... the fine rich one.” Zoya sat on the edge of her chair excited like Kora.

“Well, the baby is gonna have two fine aunts because Auntie K is fine, too, and she’s rich too.”

“I’m not pregnant, but you see how excited you were? Let’s keep that same energy for spending the holidays together.”

“Stevie, what the hell?” Zoya tossed a pillow at me.

“I’m saying... we need that excitement.”

Kora shoved me and laughed. “I can see what you mean, and I am down. My girls didn’t plan anything for around there, so I am down to go anywhere.”

“I guess I can come. Stevie, make sure your man is on his best behavior, I am not messing with him.”

“Both of you be nice to each other.” I smiled.

“I’m always nice.”

“Especially to Gerald,” Kora teased.

I was excited to spend more time with Maverick’s siblings. The dinner ended horribly, and I had been thinking of a way to fix things between them. As his wife, I wanted him to become closer with them. He had kept himself away for so long, it was time for him to make fresh memories with them.



SOON AS I OPENED MY EYES, I RUBBED MY BABY'S BEARD AS HE SLEPT ON me. This was an every night thing, and I couldn't imagine sleeping any other way. Every night after his shower, he would do his routine and then climb between my legs and lay on my stomach.

I rubbed his beard as I hummed, or we talked about whatever was on either of our minds. Maverick always had some dark shit swirling around in his mind, so we both agreed we didn't need to discuss what he was thinking.

For the most part, when I hummed and rubbed his beard, he was at peace. I was at peace, and I felt safe with him. He no doubt had a few screws loose, however, when he stared at me, it all made sense.

Every confusing thought I had ever had about my life made sense once I stared into his eyes. I knew everything was going to be alright and he would damn sure make sure of it. I was getting married today, and I thought I would be a nervous wreck.

We both knew that this was the end game for us. I just never thought it would feel like this. Part of me expected that I would have to be dragged down the aisle to marry him. Neither of us thought we would fall in love with the other.

Me and Maverick were opposites and not supposed to be attracted to one another. He was structured and I was chaos. I lived in my head, and was carefree, while he knew what he was doing for the next three years.

This was never supposed to work between us, and who knew if it would. All I knew is that right now this was working for us, and as long as we both wanted to make it work – it would. I rubbed his head as he held me tighter.

Maverick was someone a lot of people feared, and he had put fear into my chest when I first met him. Nobody got to see this side of him, including his own family. When he walked up to the third floor, he was able to shed that tough exterior and just be Mavie with me. I was able to hold him like he needed and love him because he needed that, too.

"I can hear your thoughts all the way down here, Wonder," his rough morning voice pulled me from my thoughts.

"How do you know that I'm thinking?"

He snorted. "You wake up with thoughts, baby. Wanna fill me in, or is this your quiet hour?"

"We're getting married today."

He looked up, resting his chin on my chest. "Tell me if this isn't something you're ready for."

"Do you think I'm ready to be a wife?" I questioned.

"I do."

"Are you just saying that 'cause you need one?" I giggled and pinched his nose while he continued to stare into my eyes.

He kissed my stomach. "I'm saying it because I think you are ready to be my wife. Forever ain't shit that I ever believed in until I met you. I want forever with you and I want to take care of you. This house has never had love in it, and you came in and brought that shit with you. The staff loves you, Wonder. You brighten their day when you come down humming or giving them a canvas that yo' ass never finished but got them looking at it like it's a deeper meaning to it."

"It is... why you being loud?"

"'Cause I heard you the other day talking about that canvas you half finished... why you lie to Carmen like that?"

I laughed so hard my entire body was shaking. "She said it was beautiful, and I messed up on it, so I gave it to her."

He kissed my hands. "Wonder, if you told me this was all too much for you, I would respect it as long as I don't lose you. I don't ever need no muthafucka, but you... I need you."

I held his face as he came closer and kissed my lips. "I need you, too, Mavie."

"You mean that shit?"

"With my whole heart, baby. I have so much to do today and that starts with going to the salon, and then explaining to Alex that I am getting married today."

"Bringing up a random man's name is a sure way to have me crash out, Beloved."

I laughed. "He's a fake uncle that owns the store on my block. My mother made him promise to always look out for me and he has. I've been keeping in touch via text message, but I know he's worried about me... like Cindy is."

"I get to meet this fake uncle?"

"If he can get away from the store to come... I kind of told him last minute on purpose because I didn't want to hear the lecture."

"Means he cares if he is giving you a lecture."

“I had to do this on my own, Maverick. When my mother was alive, I always relied on my mother to guide me and then when she passed away, I was so lost. When Skyler moved here, I relied on her guidance even though she’s younger than me. I’ve felt lost for a long time, and this time I needed to make this decision without anyone else’s opinion. I had to form my opinion on my own, go with what my heart and gut was telling me. As much as I love Alex, he would have called me crazy and tried to convince me to do the opposite.”

“What are your gut and heart telling you now, Wonder?”

I used my finger and brushed his lashes, my favorite thing about him. “That you are the one for me. You give me the space to live in my head, but you also reel me in, too. I can never get too deep in my head before you’re telling me that I’m thinking too loud,” I giggled while my eyes filled with tears. “I feel protected and safe with you, Maverick. I hope I make you feel the same way.”

He kissed my lips. “Ain’t never had a woman make me feel the way that you do, Wonder. When I pull through our gates, I can’t get up the hill quick enough because I know you are waiting for me. Coming home to an empty house was something that came with my life and I never put much thought into it. I was lonely and craved someone who understood me, and not many do. I’m not even sure that you understand me, but you are patient with me. You don’t try and make me someone that I’m not. Like I said, I need and want you... can’t see me not having you. I’m glad you’re a thief because we wouldn’t have crossed paths.”

“I am not a thief, Mitchell.”

“Wanda, you had shorty putting my money in your account... I’m gonna go with you a partial thief. Oh, and baby you don’t gotta steal grapes no more... we got money to buy some.”

“Anyway, we may have crossed paths eventually. When Skyler, Corleon and Jeffie got married... or tried to get married. Either way, when they had a ceremony, I would have met you.”

“That’s too long for me; I need you now. Skyler acting slow, so who knows when that will happen.”

“Maverick!” I pinched him, as he rolled over, and pulled me on top of him.

He wrapped his arms around me, and I rested my head on him. “See you at the altar, Mitchell.”

“Racing you there, Wanda.” He kissed my head.

After taking a shower and getting ready, me and Duke were on our way to Brooklyn to get my hair done. When Maverick said everything would get handled, he never lied. Greene and Jeffie made sure I had shoes, a dress, and anything that I may have needed.

They booked a hotel close to city hall for me to get ready in, and all I had to do was get my hair and makeup done, which I was praying Cindy could squeeze me in and do it.

When I mentioned moving the date because it was so last minute, Maverick was set on this date.

“Stevie Raye, you coming into this salon after I haven’t seen you in God knows when, and think I am not going to whoop your ass.” Cindy ran from behind the chair, crashing into my arms.

“Hey Cindy!” I held onto her as she squeezed the life out of me while cussing me out for showing up.

My station was still set up for me, even though I hadn’t paid my booth rent since I left for the Bahamas. Cindy was good like that, and she never held things over my head. I was going to miss working here with her.

“Look at this hair... dry and you need your ends clipped.” She turned to look at Duke who stood there. “Baby, are you in some kind of trouble?”

I laughed. “No, this is Duke... he is my security.”

Cindy continued to watch Duke, not understanding why I needed security. “Why do you need security, Stevie?”

I allowed her to pull me over to her station, which was empty. Cindy only took walk-ins on Fridays, which is why I decided to show up this morning. The morning I was getting married to Maverick Caselli.

She loosened my bun and started feeling through my curls with her mind going a million miles per hour. “Promise me that you won’t freak out on me.”

“I will not make no such promise. Little girl, tell me what you got yourself mixed in, and why this big man is in my shop like you are the president... honey, take a seat and grab you some water from over there,” she told Duke.

“I’m straight.” He continued to take his place near the door, watching me, and Cindy spun me around to face her.

“Stevie Raye, if you are in some kind of trouble, I have money to help you out of it. It’s not much, but I got a boo that won’t hesitate to lend me

some change.” Cindy was known to stay with a man that had some money.

Rumor had it that this salon was bought with drug money because she was that girl back then. “I promise I am not in any trouble anymore.”

“What trouble were you in?”

“Can we start with the good?”

She popped her hand onto her hip and stared at me, waiting for me to tell her. “Go ahead and give me the good, Stevie.”

“I’m getting married today.”

Cindy remained quiet as she searched my face. “Are you doing drugs?”

“What? No... I am getting married. Right, Duke?”

“To him?” she nearly hollered.

“Beloved, easy on me. Steve-o is old enough to nearly be my niece... I like my women seasoned... feel me?” He licked his lips, and Cindy blushed.

“Am I interrupting something here?”

Cindy turned her attention back to me. “Who are you marrying, Stevie?”

“His name is...” I paused, correcting myself. “Menace.”

There wasn’t much out there on Maverick, including his real name. All you knew is that his name was Menace Caselli, never his full name. Some people didn’t even know what he looked like because he moved in the shadows like a ghost.

As his soon-to-be wife, it was my job to protect him. “That last name, I’ve heard about it... Caselli. Where do I know that name from?”

“I don’t know, but that is who I am marrying today.”

“How does one go from a vacation to never coming back to work, and now you’re getting married. Stevie, this is me... what is going on?”

I sighed, and ran down everything that went on with Priscilla, and Cindy was so livid that she snapped the comb in her hand. “I told you that bitch was no damn good. I’ve been around my fair share of bitches that don’t mean you no good. Stevie, she could have gotten you raped and killed.” Cindy paced the shop, and Duke reached over and handed her one of the waters that she tried to offer him moments before.

She stood in front of him, facing me, and Duke swallowed her small frame up. If she had been behind him, you wouldn’t have seen her. Cindy snatched the water bottle and opened it, taking a few sips.

“It looks bad, I know—”

“Looks? The girl put you in a situation to almost lose your life. Then if that wasn’t enough, she offered you up to the man that kidnapped you in the first place. Thank God Skyler knew him, or you would have been dead. Men like that don’t care if you take a dollar, they want your head... Jesus, I need to sit down.” She plopped down in the chair and fanned herself.

I felt stupid because everyone that I knew had been trying to warn me about Priscilla and I refused to believe it. Being so desperate for a friend, I ignored red flags that someone normal would have noticed.

I’ve always known how serious the situation was, even when I was in that warehouse for a week. No matter how nice Beans was to me, I knew that my life was hanging in the balance, and I could be killed at the end of everything.

“I know.”

“Baby, I need you to use that head more and realize that every chick that is nice, isn’t your friend. That girl may have been nice, but she didn’t give a damn about you... not one bit.”

“Yeah.”

She took a deep breath. “And this Mania character... you are going to marry him because you want to or because he’s forcing you.”

I giggled. “His name is Menace, and I am marrying him because I want to. Cindy, I am in love with him.”

“Baby, how do you know this is love? He kidnapped you, then told you that you were gonna marry him or that bitch and your father would die... how is it love?”

“She could have left the first night she arrived,” Duke answered. “I’ve been with Mens for a while, and when he first laid eyes on you, I knew you were different. He paced the front of the house for an hour before walking in the first night you came to the house. If he wanted to kill you, he would have and Skyler wouldn’t have stopped that.”

I smiled as I looked at Duke. “I know I love him because my heart has never felt that way with anyone. I want to protect him, defend him, and love him all at the same time. I know he can protect himself, and he does very well, I feel like I have to. He actually sees me for the Stevie I am, I don’t have to pretend around him, and you know how much I pretend around guys. Not him, Cindy. He accepts me for who I am, and he encourages it. He made his pool house into a studio for me, and he hates mess. I can see

his body tense up with pain from the mess in there, but he likes to be near me, so he sucks it up... that's love."

Cindy studied me from the chair and took a deep sigh. "I have had my fair share of crazy stories from when I was younger and hanging my ass out in those streets, so I am not in the position to ever judge you. However, I want to meet this man and see who I am giving my baby girl away to."

I smiled as she stood up and held her arms out, and I ran into them, hugging her. "You can come to our ceremony... please."

"Chile, I'm already mentally preparing how I'm going to run across town to change clothes. First, let's get this hair together because I refuse for you to get married to that man with these split ends." She ran her hands through my hair, and I laughed.

"I've been roughing it out here."

"I can tell. You can go ahead and sit down, and lock that door... I know you need to protect her, but you standing is bothering me."

"I got you, Beloved."

Cindy smirked, as she got right to work, and Duke took a seat. I closed my eyes and put my headphones in to listen to my favorite song.

Stevie



STEVIE

NO STONE WAS LEFT UNTURNED WHEN IT CAME TO JEFFIE. SHE HAD everything planned down to what kind of underwear that I would wear with my dress. I told her that I wanted something simple, sexy, and not over the top. This was a courthouse wedding, and I didn't want to have to pick up a train to walk into city hall.

When people had courthouse weddings, they made promises to have a bigger one down the line. I didn't want one and didn't need one. All I needed was this one and knowing that Maverick felt the same as I did meant the world to me.

I've always had to pretend to be someone else when it came to dating. Never able to be the real me because that would turn a man off. I don't know how many dates I've been on that I have heard I was different or weird. Men only saw my body, my ass mostly, and decided I wasn't worth getting to know. They didn't care what I liked to do, or the fact that I had a brain, too. Every conversation always led back to them wanting to go back to their place or wanting to chill.

Menace noticed things and then he went the extra step to show me that he saw me. Buying me every Lego set because he heard that I liked Legos or going to find my high school ex-boyfriend and beating his ass and making him apologize on camera, those were signs that he saw who I was. When I spoke, he heard me.

“You look so beautiful, Stevie,” Jeffie came into the room where I was getting my makeup done and sat on the stool.

Cindy straightened my hair and pulled it up in a messy updo with a side bang that swept down the side of my face. The makeup artist finished my makeup, keeping my makeup as natural as could be. I told her that I didn’t want my freckles to be covered.

Maverick always counted them whenever I woke up and he was staring in my face. The first time that I opened my eyes, and he was staring at me, I nearly fell out the bed because he scared me. As handsome as he was, the man had a menacing look to him.

“Thank you for everything, Jeffie. You pulled all this together in the shortest time, and me and Maverick both appreciate you.”

“It’s going to feel different having someone actually say thank you because your big-headed ass man never says it,” she joked.

The makeup artist put the finishing touches on my lips and then went to clean up her mess. Jeffie was on her phone, and I turned to face her. “Um, Jeffie?”

“What’s up?” she put her phone down and looked at me concerned. “Are you having second thoughts... if you are, we can run out of here together.”

I smiled. “I’m running out of here to that man. Plus, I think he would track me down and bring me back kicking and screaming.”

“As much as you are joking, that man will always find you.”

“Good.” I smiled.

She touched my hand. “What’s going on?”

“Maverick told me about he and your mother.”

I could see the anger in her eyes when I mentioned her mother. “That is not who I am, Stevie.”

It was my turn to hold her hand. “I’m not saying that is who you are, and I can tell the subject is very sensitive to you.”

“I don’t agree with what my mother has done, and Maverick has shut down any conversation surrounding it because he doesn’t want to deal with it. I pray he opens up and does therapy, but I cannot force him. My mother broke his heart, and I had never seen him that way. I picked up the pieces she left broken on the floor while she went to live her life. I choose the Casellis over my own family because they *are* my family. They were tossed to the side and handed crumbs and look at all of them... fucking powerful.”

She reached out and pinched my cheek. “And you will rise to that same occasion becoming Mrs. Caselli, the love that this family needed.”

I smiled at her. “I just wanted you to know that I know.”

“You are now his secret keeper... his soul mate.” She smiled, as we both looked toward the door.

Estella rushed into the room with her floral dress on and little kitten heels. Her hair was pulled up into a bun with a floral headband. She rushed to Jeffie and hugged her, while Jeffie picked her up and smothered her in kisses.

“Jeff Bezo!”

“Hey my darling. Do you know how beautiful you look?”

She reached into her pocket and pulled out a credit card. “Core-Core got me this.”

Jeffie started laughing. “Not he used Stellie to get you to take the damn credit card... The man is smart, and fine... got to give it to him.”

“So damn fine,” Skyler admitted as she stood there.

Skyler looked stunning in her oversized wide leg pants suit with a pair of pumps. “Wait until you see what else he does... gonna have you climbing the wall,” Jeffie snickered.

“You want me to get laid so bad.”

“And do... you can be crabby, and we know that’s the reason.” Jeffie kissed Estella, as she further examined the credit card.

“Stevie, I don’t even want to look at you because I know I am going to cry. It’s why I have been ignoring you.”

“Awe, Sky... do you want a hug?”

“Please.”

I held my dress as I walked over and she hugged me, towering over me because she had heels on, and I hadn’t put mine on yet. “Thank you for allowing me to make this decision. Supporting me and not trying to talk me out of it.”

“Do you know how hard it was not to yank you out that man’s house? Menace is a nut job and knowing that you have tamed him... and he’s different with you. He cares about you and that is all I could want for you.”

I kissed her cheek and looked at my baby cousin. “I love you and we’re always going to be a family, Skyler. Now, we have even more people that care about us... okay?”

“I want baby sister!” Estella blurted.

Skyler smiled at her daughter. "Jeffie is going to give you one, okay? So, you can have baby sister."

Jeffie busted out in tears and Stella was concerned as she wiped her face. We both crowded over toward her and hugged her. "I am so sorry... just hearing you say that made it so real to me. Skyler, we're a family. No matter what we go through, it's us four in this together and Corleon has told us that. This doesn't work without you."

"I know," she admitted.

"And you will have a baby cousin, too," I announced and both Jeffie and Skyler gasped loudly, becoming excited.

"Menace is going to be a father?"

"Oh, no... I'm just saying. You know the future."

Skyler shoved me and went toward the door. "Stevie, read the room."

I laughed. "What?"

"I have one person that I think should witness you getting married today." She opened the door and Alex stepped in with a suit on with his head wrap matching the black suit.

"Alex," I gasped.

"Stevie, telling me last minute when you know the afternoon rush is crazy... even with all of that, I would never miss this. Although I have a bunch of questions and want answers soon."

I rushed into his arms as he held me and pulled me back to look at me. "You are the most beautiful bride I have ever seen. Your mama would be so proud, and I know she's watching over you."

"You think so?" He caught my tears and peered down into my eyes with this look of pride on his face.

"I know so. I also know she would never let me hear the end of it if I didn't see her baby girl get married today."

I sniffled. "I will be waiting for you there. Skyler called me and told me that you may have needed to see me before the ceremony."

"She was right."

He pinched my cheeks. "My beauty."

The makeup artist touched up my makeup while Alex left, and I sat back down. My emotions were all over the place and I couldn't contain them. "I'm so sorry. The tears won't stop coming."

"Girl, you are getting married. The tears are normal, and your future husband has paid for me to be with you all day." The makeup artist smiled.

When my phone started ringing, I looked down and saw Maverick's name. I picked it up and held it to my ear. "Hey Mavie."

"What up, Wonder?"

"Nothing. I'm getting my makeup done."

He chuckled. "Will I be able to count your freckles?"

"Yes."

"I was calling to make sure you still wanted to kick it with me for forever?"

The makeup artist quickly grabbed a Q-Tip and held it in my waterline as I held the phone. "I wouldn't have it no other way. Do you still want a life of paint in the bed?"

"Not crazy about it, but I'm crazy about you so fuck it."

"Okay."

"Okay, baby. See you soon."

"See you soon, Mitchell." I smiled and ended the call, while the makeup artist continued to work hard to stop the tears.

"Hey Mrs. Caselli." I turned and saw both Zoya and Kora come into the room, and I smiled while taking in their outfits.

Zoya was having a monochromatic moment with her beige high waisted pants and her dress shirt tucked in. She wore a pair of Celine sunglasses and paired it with a Chanel bag that matched perfectly with her outfit.

While Kora wore an olive green off the shoulder dropped waist dress with her Birken on her arm. Both of them wore their hair straightened as they took me in.

"You both look like money."

"Baby, we are the money... you are, too." Kora kissed my cheek and sat down where Jeffie had been sitting previously.

"I remember the real reason you didn't want a full wedding, and I respect that. Some traditions you want to have with your mother, I feel the same. You love our brother and that is all I have ever wanted for him. I want Maverick to be loved, and for someone to take care of him. He has taken care of us all of these years that he deserves the same back. While we aren't your mother, we wanted to stick to tradition by doing the something new, blue, and borrowed."

I smiled at both of them. "Really?"

Skyler came back into the room. "I'm giving you something borrowed. This is my mom's favorite gold hair clip; she wore it the day she had me. It

means so much to me, and I want you to wear it today.”

She kissed my cheek and put the clip into my hair, and it fit perfectly. “Thank you, Sky.”

“Never mention it. Family forever.”

“Even after that.”

Zoya left the room while Kora stood up. “We all have a CH pin... every immediate Caselli has this specialized pin. There are two versions of this pin, and this one only the Casellis and immediate family wears.” She produced a gold pin with CH on it, the same one that Maverick wore on his suits. “I don’t wear mine for obvious reasons, but it is always pinned on the inside of my robe when I’m behind that bench.”

“As for something blue... well, the Caselli’s don’t really do blue, but we do black and gold.” Zoya came back into the room with an orange Hermes box.

“Bitch, a Hermes bag!” Skyler hollered.

Zoya held the box while Kora carefully pulled the bag out of the box. She pulled the most beautiful black crocodile Birken bag with gold hardware. “Your husband put in a few calls and had this overnighted from Europe because he said his boo... his words, needed something blue.”

I had made plans to tell Maverick to pay the makeup artist double because the girl was working today. “God.”

“We’re dysfunctional as fuck, but I ride for my brothers and sister no matter what. Me and Menace may not see eye to eye, but he knows I work hard to protect him... can’t stand him, but will protect him with my life. We stick together, and now that you are joining the family, we will protect you, too.”

Kora looked over at Skyler. “That includes both the future Brusters, too.”

“Guys, thank you for this. I’ve never had many friends, and it’s always been just Skyler. Marrying your brother means I get sisters, and that makes me excited.”

“More than marrying him, right? ‘Cause you can tell me,” Zoya said, and we all laughed together. “Let’s get you married... seems like all I be doing is attending weddings, none of them are mine.”

“When Big G come home... fuck you meannnnn he coming for those chocolate babies, Ms. Lawyer,” Skyler snorted.

Apparently, this was an inside joke with them. “Let’s get you married. Stevie, I live my life in the shadows because I have to. I don’t even go by Caselli. I go by Case, and I’m never seen with Menace. As much as I want to be in pictures, I cannot under any circumstances be in any, and I have to keep my distance. So, if you see me in the back with this mask on, know there’s a reason and don’t be offended. I would never miss this day for the world.”

“I’m just glad that you are here, K.” We embraced and the makeup artist went to finish my make up.

OceanofPDF.com

Menace



MARRIAGE.

I sat in the living room with my legs crossed in my suit enjoying my own cup of scotch. Lupita had poured some into my favorite insulated cup before I left the house. Dressed in a black Armani suit, with my pins on my lapel.

In addition to the *CH* pin, I had my jeweler make me one that said *Wonder*. When I smiled at the pin, I scared the shit out of him because I was never chummy when I went to get jewelry. This pin was special because it was my baby. I would wear it every time I clipped that *CH* pin on.

Today I was getting married and usually I would be in here pacing and looking around to find shit to count. I was calm knowing that I had met my forever when it came to Stevie. She was beautiful, smart, and she was unique.

As someone who looked forward to having the same day every day, I never got the same woman every day. Some mornings she was loud and full of energy, and then some mornings her ass had an attitude.

It was usually because she was hungry, or she wanted some dick. I had her throwing fits when she didn't get any. Just sitting here thinking about seeing her in a few had me excited. I took a sip of my scotch and listened to the door open.

My men all got the shit together and got me a wedding gift. One that they knew I would love, and I was grateful for them. After having to pay for two funerals for two people that were important to Case House, I needed

something that would make me smile, aside from marrying the love of my life.

“I made it. Thank you for allowing me to stay at your property. I am tired of running... Raye claim that he’s going to fix this, and I don’t think he will,” I heard that familiar traitor voice coming from the foyer. “Alright, girl, talk to you after I take a bath.... Uh huh, love you.”

I sipped my scotch, used to the burning sensation that went down your throat when you sipped it through a straw – straight.

She was so into texting whoever that she walked right past the darkened living room that I was sitting in. Duke was with my baby today, so I had Beans with me. Beans was hidden to the side waiting for me to give the word.

I abandoned the doorway and went up the steps to see what the fuck was going on. Soon as I rounded the corner and saw Don standing over Jasper as he was fake acting like he didn’t know how to log into a computer his sick ass had logged into plenty of times.

“Put that password in before I fucking lose my shit... don’t have much patience these days. Not when sick bitches like you rape my girls.”

The woman in the corner, Tasha, was standing there unsure of what to do or say. She was irrelevant in this moment. Easily disposable if she tried to jump big and be the hero in this room tonight. Once he was in, Don shoved him and went to work getting all the files and everything that he needed.

“I have a crooked agent on my team... I can give you all his information. I have so much information on him that it would bury him, even that Governor.” He tried to butter me up with information I already knew.

Fuquan was a mutual that I did business with from time to time, and I didn’t need information on him when I knew shit about both him and the Governor. Me and the Governor had mutual respect, and even though I never needed to call in a favor, I knew the option to do so was there.

“Yeah?”

He grew excited thinking this was going to get him out the trouble that he was currently in. There wasn’t shit he could do or give me that would have me excuse him raping one of my girls. Then he had the nerve to rape her and record it like the shit was something to be proud of.

“Got the file,” Don said, as I watched him do his techy shit, and remove the files from the computer.

He went in and wiped everything that this bitch had on his computer, making sure it couldn't be restored. I wasn't stupid enough to bring a government issued laptop with me. As long as those files were destroyed, shit was sweet.

“If you think you're going to get away with this, you are wrong.” I watched in the mirror near the side of his desk and saw as he inched closer to that damn metal bat.

I ducked soon as he swung it. Spinning around, I leaped from where I stood, and snatched the bat, tossed it onto the floor, snatching his head, and snapping his neck while shoving my knee into his chest, cracking it.

When I tossed him, he fell back onto shorty while I continued to beat the shit out of him with my bare hands. Grabbing the stapler from the desk, I put staples in his face and shoved the entire shit down his throat as he laid on her lifeless and she was shaking.

I continued to stomp his ass down into the floor, while she was too scared to move. When we made eye contact, I winked at her and then headed out the room with Don behind me.

“Yo Mens, think she running a bath.”

Beans got my attention as I was thinking about the night I had to pull up on my hardheaded ass sister at her friend's house. I never cared to get involved in what the Delgatos and Infernos had going on. I had my life and lane, and they had theirs, and when ours crossed it was mutual respect, and if they ever needed it, I would always extend a hand, like I had in Monaco.

They never needed the favor because they handled shit on their own, like I handled things on my own. I remember seeing the horror in shorty's eyes as she watched me do Jasper in. I heard district attorney Fern handled her though.

Capone had a plan like I had for my siblings by making his sister go to college and then law school. It was funny that both of our sisters were best friends and crossed paths. Two Black women who were a force to be reckoned with.

I finished my scotch and handed my cup to Beans, as I slowly made my way down the hall. Before I made it down the hall, I back peddled and looked at the crooked picture on the wall. My black gloves fixed it, and then I continued down the hall.

The sound of water running could be heard as I came down the hallway. Not going to front, whatever she was using in her bubble bath smelled divine. I made a mental note to see what she was using. Cracking my knuckles, I looked into the bathroom as she lowered herself into the tub slowly.

She was tired.

That old nigga was supposed to retire her into the soft girl era, and he had her running worse than a YN would. He was supposed to be the retirement plan and now she was about to die. There was no other way around this, she had to die.

Had Jeffie allowed me to kill her when I wanted to, I wouldn't even have to be here on my wedding day having to end this big-headed bitch. My beef was personal with her because every time her name was mentioned I thought back to how she offered my baby up.

No remorse in her eyes as she screamed out that Stevie was a virgin, and she would marry me. I mean, I could thank her because now I was about to marry my baby. Although she offered it up, I had taken it the right way.

Actually, I was pissed that she took me as a nigga who would take what wasn't mine. Yeah, she had to die because she called me a rapist and I was just now noticing it. I shook off my suit jacket and removed my shirt while handing it over to Beans.

In my tank top, I looked over at him before I walked into the bathroom with my hands clasped. Priscilla nearly died when she saw me coming into the bathroom and those same tears came sliding down her face while she shook in fear.

She was scared, and she had every right to be scared of what I was going to do to her. "Hey Prissy... missed me?"

"I swear I had nothing to do with that girl getting killed or your armed guard. Raye told me he was going to get us out of there, and he did that... I didn't mean for them to die."

"Why did he kill Teyana? Sweet angel was innocent... best pussy of Case House. I almost had them put that on her coffin."

She stared at me like I was crazy for not knowing. "Teyana was the one who set everything up. She told Raye how easy it was to book things on the side, and she was doing it for a while."

"Oh really?"

She got more comfortable thinking she was going to talk her way out of losing her life. “Yes... that was how I met Raye in the first place. We hung out and she put me onto rich guys that she had slept with. Then she introduced me to Raye, who worked for Case House in Vegas. All I knew is they were meeting clients off to the side... I didn’t know nothing else.”

“But was spending my money.”

“I will pay it off at that farm. It’s so beautiful there, I enjoyed working with the animals.” I could tell she was telling the truth.

“How is Gutta Baby and Kick That Trick?”

“Who?”

“My fucking horses... how are they?”

“Great... I was in charge of KTT, I didn’t know that was what her name stood for.”

I smiled. “Yeah, she be out there tearing them up during races... bitch makes me millions per year on races. She won the Kentucky Derby last year.”

My hands were in everything, and nobody knew it. I had people in place who acted like the owners and made sure she was taken care of. Nobody knew the Caselli’s had horses that were worth millions.

I was waiting on Skyler to tell me that my god daughter wanted a horse ‘cause I was gonna buy her one, then have it race so she could be sitting on her own millions before she was ten. Her mama was playing slow for now. Not even knowing Corleon owned a few horses his damn self.

“O...Oh wow,” she stammered.

“So, Teyana is the reason for all of this?”

She nodded her head quickly. “Yes... Raye called her to help with some money and she was supposed to meet with him. Then I heard she was dead.”

I leaned on the sink. “And you want me to believe that you had nothing to do with this and didn’t see shit.”

“All I heard was what happened... I didn’t see anything. I heard a gun go off, and then the line went dead,” she continued to tell all that she heard.

I looked at the doorway. “Yo, make sure they dump that bitch body out my casket. I want my casket in my garage when I get home.”

Beans went to make the call. How dare she rob me, die, and make me pay for her funeral? Her mother better gather her body up and use a blanket

in that fucking grave. I would take the grave, but apparently her family had a plot for her already.

“What is going to happen to me?”

“Where is the old man?”

“I swear I don’t know. He’s supposed to call me and meet up with me. Honestly, I think he ran off without me... he’s a good liar. You know one of those that will sell you a dream and have you fully believing it. That is him.”

“Sucks for you. Want to know one thing you never asked about?”

“Wha...what?”

“Your fucking friend, Bozo. Not once did you care about her wellbeing. I could have killed her and had her stinking and you didn’t give a fuck.”

“Oh God, is she alright?”

“More than alright... actually, I don’t even share my business for real, but I’m getting married today.”

“To who?” she asked like she was surprised that someone was going to marry me.

I flinched at her, causing water to overflow out the tub. “Bitch, who else? The fuck you asking like I ain’t a catch.”

“To Stevie?”

“Yeah, that’s my baby. What my sister say... my little yeah yeah.”

“You’re using it wrong... you marrying her, right?”

“Uh huh.”

“Then she ain’t your little yeah yeah... she’s your woman. Yeah yeah is usually your little yeah... someone on the side, not really marriage material.” She broke down the dumb ass slang that I heard Zoya use when talking to Kora.

“She gonna be my wife after today so none of that even matters.” I looked at my watch. “I don’t have much time, so I need to wrap this up.”

“Please, God, no... I don’t want to die.”

Beans walked into the bathroom with an air fryer from the kitchen, and Priscilla nearly died when she laid eyes on what was going to happen to her. I was dressed for success, and I couldn’t waste time dunking her head in that water and risk getting wet with her booty juice water. Who knew the last time she took a fucking bath?

She screamed out while I turned it on and got it nice and hot. It wasn’t shit in there, it was just going while Beans walked over and dunked her

head into the water, while he waited for me to give him the word.

“Think she got good lungs?”

“I don’t know... she look like a smoker.”

“Yeah, those lips black so she has smoked some weed in her time. This little cheap shit is heating up pretty nice. Go ahead and let her loose.”

Priscilla came up with her arms swinging while trying to catch her breath. When she locked eyes with me, I waved as I used my finger and shoved it into the tub, sending electric currents and her body shaking like a cold stripper in the North Pole.

Her eyes rolled to the back of her head as she continued to cook in that tub, while me and Beans watched her. I watched her and smiled at her life leaving her body and I was responsible. This bitch didn’t give a fuck about my baby, and she didn’t need her around.

Girl was more concerned about herself, even after I mentioned Wonder. I could see in her face that she didn’t give a fuck what happened to anyone as long as she was the one not dying. I couldn’t stand selfish people, and I really couldn’t stand someone who treated my Wonder bad. Especially when my baby was a good person. Wonder would give her shirt off her back for the people she cared about.

People like her deserved the world and at times they were always given the short end of the stick. I could relate to Wonder because I never had friends growing up until Corleon came into my life. Even though I never had friends, I never wanted those bitches. Wonder was different because she wanted friends, and because she didn’t have many, she often jumped at being more of a friend to those shitty ones that came around.

“Yo Mens, you need to go ahead and get married... congratulations. Shit is beautiful what you and Stevie have.”

I looked at shorty still jerking around in that tub. “Make sure that bitch is dead, and if she even feel like she got some breath, snuff that shit out of her.”

“Of course.”

I walked out the bathroom and then doubled back. “You spoke to Don?”

“We went to get drinks last night... answer his call.”

He realized his ass overstepped. “Don’t make me have to kill another friend of his... he ain’t gonna recover.”

Beans chuckled because his ass wasn’t all the way there either. “I can see when I’m overstepping. Talk to him though, you did what needed to be

done... don't matter if he understands or not. He's alive to understand the shit and wouldn't have been if you didn't step in."

I looked at him and then headed back to the front room. Before putting my stuff on, I snagged shorty's phone from the counter. Quickly putting my shit back on, the door opened, and I stepped out to go and get married to the love of my life.

When it came to Wonder, I would kill whoever hurt her, and didn't mean her well. I wasn't ever letting up when it came to Mrs. Caselli.



*Recommendation: Listen to "For You" by Kenny
Lattimore*

WITH TRAFFIC, IT TOOK ME FORTY MINUTES TO MAKE IT TO CITY HALL. Apparently, you were able to rent city hall, and that's exactly what Jeffie did. She made sure we had a photographer and everything that we needed. That blank space over the mantel was going to have the picture of us, and I wasn't playing around.

My driver looked in the mirror. "Ten minutes eta."

I nodded as I looked down at my hands, not having the urge to rub them together. You would think I would be rubbing these shits on the back of my driver's bald head. Instead, I was excited to see Wonder.

Ten minutes seemed too long because I wanted to see her right now. Her little nervous half smile she did when she saw me. I made her nervous, and sometimes she avoided eye contact with me. I was someone who hated eye contact, but with her I had to see her eyes. Nothing went right unless I looked into her eyes.

Damn, she was so perfect.

I had a hard time wrapping my head around her being mine. She was going to be my wife, and the shit that tripped me out was that she actually wanted to be my wife. Wonder *wanted* to marry me, and she loved me.

I wasn't the most easy-going man in the world, and I lost my shit often. At times, I could be too much for a basic woman. Wonder recognized that I was too much, and she still wanted me. Where she could have went on with her life, she remained because she saw a future with me.

The future made me excited because I couldn't wait to experience life through her eyes. I've been to most countries and had always been bored with them. In Paris, I never went anywhere when I had business there. I usually stayed in the hotel room and waited to handle business before I was out again. A nigga found himself actually excited to explore because she was excited to do it. I wanted to hold her phone while she did her fake vlogs because those meant something to her. Years from now, I wanted to look at home videos knowing we had lived a life together.

A tear slid from behind my dark shades as we pulled up to the back of city hall. When the truck stopped, I screwed my face up when I saw Landon there. As far as I knew it would only be me and Wonder, along with Skyler, Jeffie and Corleon.

He stood there dressed in a suit with his CH pin, his hands in his pockets. My driver hopped out and opened the door, and I looked at him. "The fuck you doing here?"

"My big brother getting married, didn't think I would fucking come?"

"Nah."

"Then that's where you fucked up. Don't care how we feeling about each other, I'm there." He held his hand out, and I grabbed it, and he pulled me into a hug. "Relax, nigga... it's a hug."

I allowed my body to relax as I hugged my baby brother. "Thank you."

"You ain't even gotta say it... let's get you married."

He fell back and allowed me to walk in first. Before I could continue further, I felt a hand and turned to see Kora. She had a mask on and quickly removed it. Her eyes were already misty as she held my hand.

"Mom's birthday. That's why you wanted today." She hugged me and kissed me on the cheek. "You deserve this, Maverick. No one deserves this more than you, and I am so proud of you," she whispered before she slipped off.

Corleon walked toward me and held his hand out, pulling me into a hug. "Why the fuck everybody wanna hug me?"

He held the back of my head as he spoke in my ear. "This is your chance, Mens. To have happiness and the life you thought you would never

have. Stevie is one in a million and I know she makes you happy. I watch you with her and you are different, the man that you want to be. Continue to hold onto that and love her. Protect her with everything you have and choose her. Know that she is more than what's going on up there. Love you, Mens." After his speech, this nigga kissed me on the head.

"Don't do that again, Bruster."

He laughed. "Yeah, can't make no promises. Jeffie and your sisters went a little off script."

I walked from the back into the main area of city hall with the tall, vaulted ceilings and gold trimmings. Instead of going to the office we were supposed to get married in, they had an altar with chairs on both sides.

There was an Indian man sitting with a woman, then I saw Ghost and Free. Behind them there was Rahmeek and Giovanna. Karter nodded to me as he held Star's hand. Kora sat in the back and nodded her head as she remained far from us.

I looked at the grand staircase and saw a woman coming down. When she saw me, she stopped mid step, then continued down toward me. "You must be Menace... I'm Cindy. Stevie is like my shop daughter. She worked in my shop, and I love her very much. That woman deserves the world, and I pray that you give that to her."

I ain't really even know this woman so all she got was a nod from me. "I got her."

She smiled, and she went to take her place. Zoya came down the steps with Skyler and came over to me. "No matter what, I love you and would not miss seeing you have happiness."

She reached up and kissed me on the cheek and I looked at her. "All I want for you."

"Let's worry about you today... okay?"

"Okay."

Skyler smiled. "She's beautiful, Mens."

I could tell she had been crying. "I'm already knowing."

"Yeah." She smiled and took a seat.

Corleon and Don came and stood beside me next to the pastor. I kept my hands in my pockets because I had the urge to rub my hands because I was anxious waiting to see her come down those steps.

I didn't even need to see her to know that she was beautiful. Stevie was beautiful and fresh on the wake up. Every moment of her day she was

beautiful, and I found myself lost in her.

“Hold the pole, baby,” Skyler called as Estella came down the steps tossing flowers. She had candy in her flower basket, too, because she picked that up and then dumped all the flowers in one spot.

Frustrated with herself she started crying and Skyler went to get her, but Corleon stopped her. He went up the steps and picked Estella up, who held onto him while he kissed her cheek and told her that she was alright.

Corleon wanted to be a father more than anything, and I knew he would be great at the shit. The man had the patience of a saint and was built for that. How he soothed Estella without needing her mother told me that Skyler, Estella, and Jeffie were in good hands.

Jeffie came down the steps and Corleon waited at the bottom with Estella, reaching his hand out. She took his hand, and he walked her over toward Skyler. Estella reached for her mother. I took a deep breath.

“You good... breathe,” I turned when I saw Duke. “Boss, she looks like an angel.”

‘For You’ by Kenny Lattimore softly played as I looked up and saw her at the top of the steps. My heart jumped out of my chest as I watched her. She was dressed in an ivory one shoulder dress that hugged every curve she had, even those I ain’t never seen.

The dress hugged her body perfectly, with a little bit of material that trailed behind her. Her hair was straight and pulled into a messy bun with a few tresses hanging. I didn’t hear shit Kenny Lattimore was singing about because all I saw was her.

She waved at me with a nervous smile. “Mens, the fuck you doing?” Corleon whispered as I left the altar and went up the steps to get my baby.

“Hi Mitchell,” she whispered.

“Hi Wanda,” I whispered back, as I held my hand out, and her perfect hand slid right into mine, as she took one step at a time. “You look beautiful, Baby.”

She smiled. “You look handsome, Mavie. I love you in a suit.”

“I love you butt ass naked in my bed.”

She snorted. “Nasty.”

I kissed her cheek. “One... two.... three...”

Wonder blushed as we made our way down the steps. “You’re not going to count all of my freckles.”

“Watch me make them wait while I do it.”

She squeezed my hand. "Mavie, my heel got stuck in my dress that's why I was up there so long," Wonder snorted loudly, sending an echo through the hall.

I couldn't help but to laugh, as I bent down and unraveled her dress from her heel. "There you go."

Kora dabbed her eyes as we made it down the last step and walked to the altar. "Who gives this woman away?"

The woman that spoke to me, the Indian man, and Skyler stood up. "We do," they all said, and Stevie looked at each of them, blowing a kiss.

As we stood up there, staring into each other's eyes, nothing mattered in this moment. Not the fact that Priscilla was a crispy mermaid, or the fact that her father was somewhere out here. None of that mattered because I was marrying my baby.

Ghost and Rah both gave me a nod, and winked as I turned my attention back to Wonder. The pastor went on saying all that he had to say to bless this union. "What color panties you got on?" I mouthed to Wonder.

"Stop." She squeezed my hand while trying to hold her laugh in.

I never broke eye contact with her. She looked away from me a few times, but my eyes remained on her. How the fuck did I get so lucky with her? When did God wake up and decide to make my baby an accomplice to robbery? How did he know I would fall in love with her. My whole life was in this woman's hands.

Anything she wanted I would give her because she deserved it. "Mavie," she softly said, and I looked at the pastor and everyone looking at me.

If she asked me to choke this nigga, I would.

"What happened?"

"Do you have vows?"

I didn't write down vows because I needed to say how I felt about her in real time. No pen or paper could hold down how I was feeling about the woman in front of me. "Yeah."

"What?" Zoya's loud ass mouth said.

I looked at her and she whispered sorry while leaning back in her chair. "Tell her how you feel, Mens," Corleon whispered.

Public speaking wasn't my thing, and I wasn't for the shit most of the time. Standing in front of a bunch of people and confessing my feelings was torture for me. The difference was I needed to do it for Stevie.

I had to tell her and the world how I felt, because then if somebody tried to jump stupid I could kill them without an explanation. They knew how I felt about her and still wanted to be stupid.

“I’m not a man of a million words, but for you Wonder, I got two million. I love you so much that at night I think of how I’m gonna beat the shit out of the landscaper for the one time he winked at you three weeks ago. He had blue on that day, and you were wea—”

“Mens, nigga... focus?” Corleon whispered while trying to have a smile on his face.

The pastor was mortified, and I was sure he was going to toss Holy water on me next. “Yeah. I lay away at night thinking of ways to keep you happy. I never not want to see that smile on your face. You are the sweet and good that I need in my life. We balance each other out, Wanda.”

“Who the fuck is Wanda?” I heard Don whisper to Corleon.

I kissed her hands. “You told me that it had been a while since you felt warm and safe. Last time you felt like that was with your mother. As your husband, I promise to always make you feel warm and safe. I am your safe place, your home, and protector. For a while it has always been Menace, but I realized since you came into my life, there is no me without you. You are the missing puzzle. I love you, Stevie.”

She stared up at me with tears in her eyes. “Love has always been something that I wanted, but I was afraid. Afraid to open myself to a man, give him a piece of me that I was always certain he would break. How could something I wanted scare me so much? I had never been in love before... not with a man. My love had always been my mama. I never knew how it would happen for me. Then I met you, Mavie. I knew for sure I could never love a man like you, and I was so wrong. The more I was around you, I had this little feeling... like a sting in my chest and it only activated when you were around. I’m not perfect and you accept me for who I am, and you have never tried to change me, no matter how much I drive you up the wall. As your wife, I want to stand by your side and allow you to lead. I just ask that you allow one thing from me.”

I kissed her hands again. “What’s that, Wonder?”

“Allow me to show you how good it can get. How great we can be, and how happy you can be. I promise to never put sauce on your chicken or squeeze the toothpaste hard. I promise to never go to bed angry and allow you to sleep on me, no matter if you drool on me. I promise to give you my

whole heart because I know you would never break it. I promise to love you as you, Mavie. Never change you because what fun would that be? I want the challenge, and baby you are that. I love you, Mitchell.”

“I love you, Wanda.”

For someone that was supposed to be keeping a low profile, Kora’s loud ass nose blowing had us all looking back at her. She held her hand up and looked away because she was sobbing so hard.

Kora more than anybody knew how much I never thought this would happen for me. It wasn’t because I couldn’t get women. It was hard opening up and allowing someone in. As much as I wanted to fight letting Wonder in, she wormed her way into my heart.

“I now pronounce you Mr. and Mrs. Caselli... you may kiss your bride.”

I held her face and kissed her lips a bunch of times before slipping my tongue into her mouth. She pulled away and licked my nose, and then quickly used her sleeve. “Don’t you flip out in here, Maverick.”

I kissed her lips. “Don’t do no shit like that again, Wonder. Why the fuck would you lick my face.”

She laughed and kissed my lips. “I am your wife.”

“You are my wife, Mrs. Caselli.” I picked her up and carried her down the aisle and was heading back to the truck when Corleon ran behind me.

“Nigga, where the hell you going?”

“We done, right?”

“Yeah, but damn you gonna stick around for pictures.”

“Mantel, baby,” she reminded me, and I put her down onto the floor, and held her hand. “I’m going to have the makeup artist touch up my makeup.”

I kissed her lips and bit my bottom lip as I watched that ass switch away. “You don’t know what those jeans do to me, make me wanna get down on one knee,” I sang out the words to that infamous Ginuwine song that was now dubbed Wonder’s song every time I saw her ass.

“I don’t even wanna know.”

“If I tell you then we can’t be friends no more, Bruster.” I winked.

He squeezed my shoulder. “I already got into their systems and wiped all the cameras of us ever being here. Geeky got the cameras on all surrounding blocks of Kora, too. Oh...good looks on grabbing that phone.

Enjoy your night with your new wife, and then business right after. Congratulations, Mens... fucking happy for you.”

“Appreciate it.”

I watched as he walked over to Jeffie holding Estella, and pulled Skyler with him as they took pictures with Wonder.

We took so many pictures that my damn head was spinning when we were done. All I focused on was my new bride and how she was over there serving Top Model. She tossed that thick thigh up in one picture and was living for being in front of the camera.

We took one at the very top of the steps and I dipped her as I kissed her neck, and she laughed. The picture was fucking perfect. Duke went to walk the photographer out to grab all his memory cards.

There wasn't any pictures of Menace Caselli out there, and it damn sure wasn't about to start. “The Caselli's,” Rah clapped his hands. “Mens, I'm proud of you.” Rah came over and dapped me.

“Hi!” Wonder greeted.

“Wonder, this is Rahmeek Vanducci. If anything should ever happen to me, this man and those two over there would make sure that you are always straight.”

He nodded his head and hugged her. “Indeed. The families,” he held his champagne flute up, and Ghost and Karter followed.

“Nice to meet you.” Wonder held onto me, and I kissed her head, which had Rah freaked out. He was trying to figure out how to act because this was so outside of who I was.

We mingled for a bit before I was ready to get out of here. Wonder walked across the room and hugged the Indian man as he spoke to her. I could see from his expression that this was family. He was proud of her, and he loved her.

She walked over toward me while holding his hand. “Alex, this is my husband. Mena—”

“Maverick Caselli,” I corrected her.

My baby already knew not to give out the name to anyone, but this was as close as a father that I would meet of hers. He was her family, and I was a man that showed respect, so he got the honor of knowing my name.

“Maverick, it is nice to meet you. I would have loved to meet you sooner, but someone keeps secrets.”

Wonder snickered. “It was on a need-to-know basis.”

“Stevie, your mother would be so proud of you. I felt her spirit with us today, and I know she is happy for you.” He turned his attention to me. “Take care of her. She is a light and so special to me and my family.”

Wonder rested her head on his arm. “Love you, Alex.”

“Love you so much more, Stevie. I want to see you more, too, yeah.”

She smiled. “I promise.”

He hugged her, shook my hand, and then headed back over with who I assumed was his wife. I watched as Skyler smiled at him as she made her way over toward us. She stopped mid walk, and did this little gangsta walk while smiling before Stevie joined her and they jumped up and down.

“You are married, Stevie!” She jumped up and down, then turned to look at me. “To Menace.”

“Hi, fuck you, too, Skyler.”

She laughed. “I am happy for you both and can’t wait to witness this union between you two. I’m sad you’ll be moving out the apartment... into that big fortress. Guess you gonna have to have Thanksgiving with a mini serial killer, Mens.”

My jaw clenched. “You need to get her to stop doing that shit. It’s all cool until she standing over you with a knife because you told her no more cartoons. You saw that fit she threw on the stairs.”

“Menace, my baby ain’t no damn serial killer,” Skyler snorted.

Corleon came over with Jeffie. He was holding Estella, who was resting her head on his shoulder. “Her nap time is approaching and she starting to get whiny. She wanted candy and then started crying when I opened it.”

“She wanted me, and then cried for him,” Jeffie added.

Skyler hugged her cousin. “I love you so much, Stevie. I am so happy for you and know that Menace is going to take care of you. You deserve that, you know that, right?”

Stevie nodded her head fighting the urge to not cry. “I know that... do you know that?”

“Today isn’t about me. There will come a time when it is, but not today, Stevie... it’s about you today and you deserve all the attention to be on you because you are so damn amazing.” She looked over at me with watery eyes. “Appreciate how amazing she is, and don’t try to change her. So many have tried to change her. I’m sure many have tried to change you too. You both found love within each other for a reason.” Corleon kissed her forehead and pulled her into him.

“Menace, everything is a go. I love you both, and I’m so happy for you.” Jeffie smiled, as she looked at both of us.

“Thank you for all of this Jeffie... I was expecting to go into an office and get married quickly. This was everything I didn’t know that I needed.”

She hugged Wonder and smiled. “Everything you both deserved. The focus was on you two, no big overdrawn wedding that would send this one into a spiral.”

“Yeah, ight.”

Jeffie laughed and rested her head on my arm. “Love you, Mens. Everything is handled, and you are good to head on out.”

“What are you up to?” Wonder looked at me.

“Taking you on a quick trip before I have to come back and head back out for business.” I had business to handle, so we couldn’t go far. I wanted to take her somewhere and show her somewhere that meant a lot to me.

“Now?”

“Uh huh. I wanna fuck you in the air, Wonder.”

She kissed my neck. “Mile high club... bucket list item... check.”

I paused. “With fucking who?”

“Um, whoever had a jet. It just happened to be you... yay, let’s be happy baby.” She clapped her hands.

When she stopped in the middle of her clapping, she touched my Wonder pin. “I keep you next to my heart at all times.”

“Mavie,” she kissed my lips. “I’m so glad it was you with the jet that I get to sleep with. It would suck if it was someone else,” she snorted.

“Yeah, ight.” I kissed her head as Duke held the door open and I put her in the truck before climbing behind her.

Stevie Caselli



EVERMERE, TEXAS

“AYE, LOOK AT ME AND BREATHE, STEVIE... WE’RE LANDING NOW,” HE whispered in my ear as I held onto him tightly.

It was storming and the turbulence had my nerves bad. I had tears in my eyes as I held onto my husband for dear life. The minute that we landed I was going to beat him with my purse.

“What the fuck?” I screamed as it felt like the jet was getting lower and shaking at the same time. I didn’t get kidnapped, lose my virginity, and then married to this beautiful man all for this to be the end.

He kissed my neck. “He’s going through the clouds; it’s going to be a little turbulence. Look...” he pulled up the shade, and I looked out the window as we were nearing the ground.

Flying didn’t bother me. When we went to Paris, it wasn’t bad and we didn’t hit any turbulence, at least I never felt any because I was sleeping most of the time.

“This is not how I had plans on joining the mile high club.” The minute that Maverick took

his shirt off and we were in the back room, the plane started to shake, and he just knew he wasn’t getting any.

I was trying to hide under the bed in the room, and he had to pull me from under there, and we came back to the main part to sit. He held me on his lap and talked to me to soothe my nerves.

My heart felt like it was in my chest as I said a prayer and looked at Maverick. "I told you that we were going to be good."

"How are you so calm?"

"I fly all the time, Wonder. Never really thought about anything ever happening because things are in place to take care of my siblings if something ever happened to me."

I stared at him horrified. "You cannot think like that anymore, Maverick. I am here... things in place isn't you."

He kissed me on the lips. "I hear you."

The jet hit the runway, and I could relax because we were on solid ground. It was pouring, as everyone ran around like crazed chickens making sure the truck was pulled up close enough to the jet, and holding out umbrellas, Maverick snatched one and held it over us as we made our way down the steps.

He put me into the truck first and then someone held the umbrella over him as he got in on the other side. "Where are we going?"

"You're going to see." He held my hand, as we pulled away from that damn jet.

I couldn't believe that I had gotten married. Everything felt right when it came to marrying this man. I didn't have any nerves as I prepared to take vows to love him forever. His vows to me made me see that he loved me as much as I loved him.

It was a different feeling when someone loved you as much as you loved them. I've dated men in the past where I liked them way more than they liked me. The energy was different, and you constantly felt like you were trying to be something that you weren't just to get them to like you just a bit more.

With Maverick, I could tell that he was as obsessed with me, if not more, as I was with him. I squeezed his hand as he looked up from his phone and kissed my forehead. "I don't hear you thinking... a good sign, huh?"

I smiled. "A very good sign, Mitchell."

I watched as we pulled up to iron gates, and Maverick repeated the same process that had to be done at his house.

Our house.

Guards surrounded the truck and did their usual security check before we went through the gates. It was dark so I couldn't see much but trees,

land, and fences. The only thing illuminated was a massive luxury ranch style home that sat in the center of the property.

“Are we on a farm?”

“Case Farms,” he kissed my temple as they opened the doors for us.

I became excited. “You own a farm?”

“Baby, I told you I owned one when we were in that warehouse... this was where your father and shorty was sent.” He held his hand out to help me out the back. “And we own a farm.” I smiled when he corrected me.

Housekeeping staff were all there waiting for him to tell them anything. He held my hand as he pulled me into the house. The exposed wooden beams, cream and brick interior with the chestnut wooden floors made this massive home cozy.

I took in everything as he pulled me further into the house. “Why would they escape here?”

“They wasn’t in my shit... there is apartments over the barns. See, I tried to be nice and do what you wanted. Now you see why I have to resort to who I really am?” He stared down into my eyes, and I understood.

Why in the hell would they run away from this when their life could have been spared? My father called me slow, but I was starting to see it was him who was slow.

The exposed beam followed into the master suite with the creams, and the light furniture. The entire wall was window and showed the land that I’m sure would be even more beautiful when the sun rose.

I was excited to sit in the seating area that was outside the master suite and see the sun. Maverick’s arm wrapped around me as he kissed my neck. “What you thinking?”

“How this place is amazing, and I cannot wait to explore it tomorrow.”

“Can I explore you?”

He never had to do or say much for my body to react to him. Everything about this man made my body and mind react. Turning around in his arms, I stared up into his eyes and pushed my lips against his.

Maverick held me so tightly, as if he never wanted to let me go. Like I would disappear from his arms if he decided to let me go. I was his dream, someone that he had only dreamed about, never believing he would ever have this for himself.

True love.

I wanted Maverick and didn't care about the money, power, and everything that came with loving a man like him. His influence was something that many witnessed, and I could admit, it was a turn on.

I had fell in love with the person.

The man that had to have his shampoo and his body wash put in the shower a certain way, or his entire year would be ruined. While others found his ways exhausting, and it could be at times, I found them as his way of having control.

His compulsions were something that he could control. He created an entire life and home devoted to controlling how things were. For a regular woman that would have sent her running to the hills. I guess I understood Maverick because he was my mother in man form.

My mother wasn't as bad as Maverick, but she had her ways. As much as she was my everything, at times, she could be my own enemy. We often clashed over the silliest things like putting the milk inside of another container, even though it had already come in a container.

I also recognized that my mother had trauma as a child, and then she married a man that furthered that trauma for her. Whenever my parents argued or fought, and I would hear that door slam, I would watch as she cleaned things that had already been cleaned. All the wash cloths in the linen closet would be color coded and separated by the material on the small tags. It was my father who triggered her, and he was no good for her.

Maverick scared me at first because I didn't want to be his trigger. Someone that caused him to rub his hands even more than he already did or freaked out about broccoli being in the fridge with the apples.

I gave him something that I wished my father would have given my mother – a safe space.

He held the sides of my face as he softly kissed my lips. My eyes closed as his soft lips pecked mine, and his hands made their way down to my ass. Taking a handful of my ass, he sucked on my lips before he picked me up.

I've never in life felt small enough to be tossed around like a rag doll, and here came Maverick. He picked me up and tossed me over his shoulder whenever he wanted, with ease. There was never any struggle as he handled me.

My arms wrapped around his neck as he carried me onto the terrace off the master suite. It was fall, and the sun had gone down, so it was a little cool. Not as cool as it would have been had we been still in New York.

“What are we doing?” I searched his eyes, as he kissed my neck, and continued to hold me while I was wondering why we were out here.

“I want you to ride this dick under the stars, Wonder.”

It was his low husky voice, low eyes as he stared into mine, and him slapping my ass in the process. “Isn’t the staff going to see us out here.”

“Security is on the other side and the staff better be taking they asses to bed.” He roughly kissed my lips as he put me down onto the bed that was on the terrace.

He leaned over me as we both stared into each other’s eyes. It wasn’t registering that I had married this man and had no regrets. There was no panic attack to follow and questioning what I had done.

I was so sure and clear in my decision that it was almost scary. As someone who was an overthinker, and who second guessed herself a lot, it was almost healing to know that my heart did know what I wanted.

It acted out of confusion when it came to those that didn’t deserve to hold it. I was unsure and second guessing because they weren’t right and wouldn’t protect my heart for me. My heart was so certain when it came to Maverick that I didn’t have a minute to second guess anything. My brain was moving my feet to rush down the steps to get to him.

“You have my heart, Stevie Caselli,” he broke our silence and kissed my lips, while rubbing the side of my face.

I smiled and rubbed his face. “You have mine, Maverick Caselli.”

On the jet, I was able to change clothes and put on a white tracksuit that Kora bought me that said bride on the ass. I felt him removing them as he continued to stare into my eyes. Lifting my ass, I allowed him to pull them off me slowly.

“I can’t even remember what life was before you crashed into my life, Baby. I don’t want to remember what it was like because you weren’t there. I didn’t believe in shit when Rah and Ghost told me that I needed a wife because I never needed anybody.” He placed my hand to his chest. “You make me feel like this, and I know now that I needed a wife. I needed you in my life, and now that I got you, I ain’t never letting you go.”

“Good. I want you to keep making me feel warm and safe.” I pointed at his chest. “You make me feel that way, Baby.”

We shared a kiss, as I felt him removing his pants and sliding between my legs. I opened my legs and allowed him in, as he continued to kiss me softly.

He was always so slow and soft, as he took his time with me. Maverick was gentle with me, as if I was the most precious thing in the world. It was this look of pure love in his face as I felt him push inside of me.

The soft kisses he gave me to make sure that he was gentle were always my favorite. He pulled up and looked me in the face before he licked my face. "Mavie," I laughed.

"You the only person I want licking my face, Wonder. It's me and you forever, and then even after that we still rocking... come get me from hell."

I smashed my lips against his, as I held him around the neck as I felt him go harder, shaking the bed. The bed was up against the house, and each time he delivered thrust after thrust. My body jerked, as I felt him slowly pull out of me, and look at me.

"What's the matter?"

He hiked one of my legs up, as he maintained eye contact with me. "I'm about to fuck you, Baby... I ain't a slow and steady man."

I licked my lips, as I came out of my shirt and unhooked my bra. He stared down at me, and then pulled out of me some, and we both looked down. The sight of seeing him inside of me turned me on even more.

How shiny it was because I was so wet for him. He was the only man who had been inside of me, and the only man who could get this reaction out of me.

When he looked up, our eyes met and he had this smirk on his face. "You know I feel like that nigga, right?"

"Why?"

"'Cause this all mine... ain't nobody been inside of you. I get to teach you how to take dick, baby." He picked me up and I yelped because I didn't expect him to snatch me up so quickly.

I was butt naked while Maverick was naked from the waist down, his dress shirt still on. He put me on the edge of the metal and wooden banister with cable wiring. My ass hung off the edge of the banister as he pushed himself back into me, holding me up while I held onto his neck.

His soft bites on my shoulder while he beat my pussy to no end. Maverick wasn't showing me any remorse, as he held onto me so I didn't fall, but continued going without stopping. "Fuck this dick back, Wonder... I wanna feel you, too."

I held his neck and the banister as I tossed it back on him, tossing my head back. "Like that, Mavie? You like it?"

He sucked on my lips, never missing a step as he pulled out and quickly slammed all of him back inside of me. I screamed out while I held his neck tighter and bit down on his shoulder. He moved me from the banister, and put me back on the bed, flipping me over on my stomach.

“Toot that ass up, baby.” His hand slammed down on my ass, and he slapped it again, while the stinging was fresh.

I looked back at him, and he was biting down on his bottom lip as he watched my ass shake. “You want it like this?” I bent down so far that the arch was perfect.

“Where the fuck you learn this shit, baby? No nigga better not had been trying to teach you shit.” His dick fought its way back inside, and once it was inside, he held onto my hips and slammed me back. “Throw it back... harder... fuck me as hard as you be squeezing that toothpaste.”

I couldn’t even keep a straight face as I laughed and threw this ass back onto him. Making my ass cheek jump, he stopped. “What’s the matter, Mavie?”

“Don’t do that shit again... I’mma nut.” He slapped my ass again and then slammed me back onto him.

I was hardheaded, and knowing I had him about to tap out made me do it more. Instead of making only one, I made them both jump at the same time. “You want me to stop that?”

He slapped both ass cheeks and gripped them. “Since you hardheaded, you ‘bout to ride this dick.”

I giggled as he sat on the bed, laying back and pulled me on top of him. “I didn’t do nothing.” I sucked on his lips, as he caressed my chin, and kissed my lips.

“I’m about to slut you out, wifey.” As I was about to say something, he gripped my ass. “You my actual wife, so I can call you that.”

I smirked, as I flipped the opposite way, and licked the precum from his dick, and then commenced to taking him down slowly. Meanwhile, he grabbed my hips and I felt his tongue tasting me.

We were both competing, to see who could make the other cum first, and as I sucked and went deeper, he was winning because he wasn’t playing fair. “No breaks... suck that shit, Wonder... you tapping out?”

“Never,” I said while his dick was still inside of my mouth.

Reaching down, I massaged his balls, and he was the one that was taking the break. “Fuck... I need you on this shit now.”

“Sure?” I continued to talk with a mouth full of dick, while his toes were curling in his socks. I wasn’t as experienced in sex like Maverick was, but I was learning what he liked slowly. Feeling his dick in the back of my throat was one of his favorites.

He pulled me down onto his dick as he played with my nipples and made sure to hold me where he wanted me. I was too slow for him, so he always held me and sped it up, so I understood what he wanted.

“You nasty, Mrs. Caselli.”

I still became shy and nervous around this man, so when he was staring up at me while playing with my nipples, it was hard to keep eye contact. “Mavie... I’m going to cum.”

“‘Cause I’m looking in your eyes, Mrs. Caselli.”

“Uh huh. You make me so wet when you stare at me.” I held onto his chest as I continued to ride his dick, knowing I wouldn’t be any good in a few seconds.

He took both of his hands and held my waist and slammed me down onto his dick harder with each thrust. It started out chilly out here, and now I was full on sweating as he continued to fuck the shit out of me.

My pussy tingled, and the pressure from feeling him inside of me had me on the edge. I wanted to cum so bad, but I didn’t want him to stop. Menace used one of his hands, and he always pressed my stomach when I was riding his dick, and the pressure from him and his hand always caused me to lose control, and when he did, that was when I collapsed on top of him.

“I know for a fact I put Dennis inside of you.”

“Maverick, we aren’t naming our baby Dennis.”

“Why?” He slapped my ass again.

“Cause that’s ugly.”

He was quiet. “Make that ass jump again for me.”

On command, I did it for him and he started kicking his feet while I was on top of him. “Fuck, Wonder... I’m about to get a pole in the bedroom. You about to be making that ass jump for me on a regular.”

“Maverick, shhh.”

“Oh, now I gotta be quiet because you tired after getting some dick.” He kissed my head and wrapped his arms around me.

“Yes... you did this.”

We both were quiet for a minute before he broke our silence. “Wonder?”

“Hmm.”

“I wanted today because it’s my mother’s birthday,” he revealed and I lifted my head and stared into his eyes.

“Really?”

“Yeah.”

I kissed his face. “Happy birthday to your mommy. I think it’s special that you wanted to honor her and make me your wife on her birthday.”

“I’m always down when it comes to their anniversary, their birthdays, and the day they were murdered. My uncle took so much from me, and I want to reclaim something positive when it comes to them.”

“What did he take from you, Mavie?”

He looked at me as I rested my head on my arms while on his chest and stared at him. “He took my parents from me which was everything. Change my entire life and robbed Zoya and Landon of truly knowing our parents.”

“Do you think your life would have been different had they been alive?”

I rubbed his face, and he took my hand and kissed it. “Think my life would have been different. Never got the chance to have that life and can’t do shit about it now.”

“Where is your uncle?”

“All you need to know is that he took my family, and I took his.” He had this menacing look in his eyes as he spoke about his uncle.

“Our family.”

He looked down at me and smirked. “Yeah, you right, Wonder.”

I snuggled in his arms as he held me, kissing my forehead a few times as I kissed his chest. That warm and safe feeling I had been chasing for so long, I had found.



TEXAS WAS A DREAM.

The few days that we spent there felt like we were in our little bubble in the world. We never had to leave the farm, and when it was time to leave, I didn’t want to go. Case Farm had a bunch of expensive horses that had security with them at all times.

Skyler kept telling me that Maverick asked her if Estella wanted a horse, and I thought he was just being crazy. While we were there, a horse was born, and the staff allowed me to stay and watch it.

It was one thing to know that this man was rich, and then another to realize just how rich he was. The amount of wealth that Maverick Caselli had would take care of his future generations. It became real when the lawyers came to the farm, with Zoya on Zoom, and I had to sit down and sign a bunch of papers.

"I'm not understanding why I need my own lawyer." I looked at the screen and Zoya was eating lunch, while one lawyer sat across from me with Maverick next to him, and my lawyer sat next to me.

Maverick looked up at me. "Stevie, you are about to sign a lot of paperwork, and you need to negotiate what you want. Should your marriage not work, what do you want? Menace wants to make sure that you are always taken care of. The lawyer is for your own good... not connected to us, and he can negotiate what you want on your terms."

"I don't like this, Mitchell."

He looked up into my eyes as his hands were clasped together. "What don't you like, Baby?"

"I don't want anything. What do I have to negotiate? If we don't," I paused.

The thought of us not being together was breaking my heart. How were we discussing this when we just got married? "You thinking too loud."

I looked up at him. "I don't want anything."

My lawyer looked over at me. "Are you sure? You can negotiate anything that the Casellis own." He picked up the papers in his hand. "The private island off Grenada, stake in the credit union banks they own... you don't want anything?"

"I only want a child... so I can be the baby mama from hell when you leave me, Mitchell."

"Wanda, the fuck is you talking about?"

"You are trying to get rid of me and I don't like that shit."

Zoya laughed. "Stevie, I promise he is not trying to get rid of you. He wants to protect you. Being honest, us Casellis don't believe in forever."

"I do," Maverick corrected his sister, as he stared straight into my eyes.

"Then why all of this?"

“Because you may not believe in forever with me, and even though it would kill me, I would always make sure you are good.”

“I believe in forever with you.” I snatched the paper from my lawyer and looked at everything on this paper with wide eyes. “You own a small town in France?”

He nodded.

“Zoya, I don’t know.”

“Your husband is adding you to all the accounts and wants to make sure that you are more than taken care of if you both should call it quits... sign the damn papers and pick out some property.”

“You need to get me pregnant because I promise me and my baby will pop up everywhere you are. I will stalk you... squeeze your toothbrush and teach the baby, too.”

Mavie laughed. “Sign the papers, baby. Then I’m gonna take you in the room so I could put that baby into you.” His lawyer smiled, and Maverick’s smile dropped. “You just said you wanted to put a baby in my wife?”

“Menace!” Zoya screamed while the lawyer turned every shade of red.

I took the pen and signed all the documents as the lawyer told me what I was putting my name on. My name had gone from this regular name to being powerful. I was to have security with me at all times, and my life wouldn’t be the same anymore.

The phone’s chime forced me out of my thoughts. On the bright side, I was a new owner of two islands if me and Mavie ever decided to call it quits. I don’t know why I picked an island, but it sounded like a good idea.

If this went to shit, I could open my own resort on the island and live my day by the beach making sand art for the tourist with my baby strapped to me. Another chime came from his phone, and I went over to silence it.

I never touched his phone because there was never any need to. If he was messing with other women, it would eventually come out.

Dammit.

The thought of Maverick talking to other women never ever crossed my mind. Why the hell did that thought just cross my mind? It was like when you were in the middle of prayer and then your intrusive thoughts entered, and left you questioning why the hell you just screamed fuck God in your head?

I plopped down on the bed and grabbed his phone. Peeking over my shoulder, I could still hear the shower and knew he wouldn’t be out right

away because he counted the times he washed up.

Me: I'm getting married today, Ang.

Angie: I always want you to be happy. Even if it wasn't with me. I hope she makes you happy, Sweets. I mean that too. Love you.

My heart dropped at the message that he sent her. On our wedding day, he thought about her and sent her a message. Why would he do that to me? While I was ready to marry him, and start this new journey, he was thinking about the past that he had with her.

"Alexa, play 'Let It Flow'!" I hollered.

My blood boiled as I listened to Toni crooning the words to my life. That text message felt like it was etched in my brain. He reached out to her, and then she had the nerve to reply. My husband had the nerve to reach out to the very woman I suspected was responsible for him being the way that he was. He finally came out the room with his towel wrapped around him as I held the phone in my hand.

"Why are you still communicating with her, Maverick?"

He looked at me before he went over toward the bar and poured him a drink. "I felt like she deserved to know. Not a big fucking deal... why you got my phone, anyway."

"Your stupid ass phone kept pinging, and my finger slipped, and I end... don't worry about why I was in your phone, worry about why I found this in your phone."

I held the phone up to show him a picture of a woman showing her breast. "Kim's ass sent that a few weeks ago."

The more I sat there with Toni telling me that I needed to let it flow, the more my finger slipped and the more I dug deeper into his phone.

"And you didn't delete it?"

"I don't delete shit, Wonder. I got messages from when Zoya was in fucking law school asking for money. I replied back to Kim, I know you saw it."

I did see the response, and he sent her back a picture of a dog. I don't know what the reference was, but she was disturbed and cussed him out.

"Not the point. You don't think I can text one of my ex-boyfriends? I still have their numbers... two can play that game."

“No, you don’t.” He casually finished his drink. “Deleted every nigga in your phone that sounded like he tried to fuck you.”

I stared at him. “Maverick why would you do that? I don’t care, I know one of them by heart and I will reach out.”

He sighed as he rubbed his hands together. “We all have to live with the actions of our decisions, Wonder.”

“What actions?”

“Imagine living your life and your ex-girl hits you up to hang out. Homie excited because I mean, look at you... fine as shit. He rushing to meet you and then I clothesline him as he’s running out the door to meet you. Wrap the wire around his neck and ask him what his favorite color is while he’s slowly losing consciousness.”

“Why are you asking him his favorite color?”

“Small talk... rude as shit to just choke the man out and not make small talk... I’m a menace, not a monster.” He crossed the room and refilled his drink.

I stood there watching as he sat there explaining this hypothetical scenario as calm as could be. As if he was explaining taxes to me or something.

“You texted her on our wedding day, Maverick.” Tears pricked my eyes as I stared at him across the room.

He took a seat in the window. “Stop looking at it that way.”

“The day you were supposed to be focused on marrying me, you sent her a text to let her know that you were getting married. Anytime she calls, you answer and whenever she texts you respond. I can’t compete with your first love, Maverick.”

I watched as he continued to rub his hands together. He was anxious and nervous about this conversation. “You don’t ever have to compete with no bitch in this world when it comes to me. I’m here... I’m yours. What me and Angie had is done.”

“See, calling her Angie shows me that it’s not done.”

He stared at me before he spoke. “That’s her fucking name, Stevie.”

“No, her name is Angelica. You call her Angie... how many people call her that, Maverick?” I questioned and he looked away. “Exactly. When it comes to her, you are going to always answer a call because you have this sick connection with her.”

“I don’t have a connection with her. Haven’t had one with her in years, Wonder. I felt like I owed that explanation to her.”

“You are Menace Caselli, the man who does what the fuck he wants and never makes any excuses or explanations for it... and you felt like she was owed one?”

“Yeah.”

“I’m not her, Maverick.”

“The fuck you talking about?” He leaned forward, damn near squeezing his hands while he searched my eyes. I turned, not giving him the chance to read me, because he could read me well.

“I’m not the kind of woman that is going to allow you to make decisions that you want. You delete all my numbers out of my phone, but it’s alright to still be in contact with her? That shit doesn’t fly with me. I think I’m going to stay with Skyler to clear my mind. I really need to think because I can’t compete with her. She still has a hold over you all these years later.”

“You not sleeping anywhere but in this bed with me, Wonder. Go and do your little stomps and talking to yourself but get yo ass in this bed next to me so I can lay on you and sleep.”

“I’ll fart,” I threatened.

“I’ll inhale it.”

I did my stomps that he knew I was going to do and stomped into the bathroom. He didn’t apologize for it, and didn’t care how I felt about the matter. I wasn’t some friend in his home anymore, I was his wife.

I had the private islands to prove it.

“Stevie, you need to show him better than you can tell him... he’s used to no one saying no and getting his way. You don’t stand up now, then he gonna have you turning tricks with his girls in those upscale homes he owns all over the damn country.... Okay, slow down. He’s not going to have me turning tricks, relax.” I splashed water on my face, and then I put on some of my favorite pistachio scented oil that he loved.

Removing my hair from my bun, I shook my hair out and quickly changed into a thin T-shirt with no panties on. “Go put it on him, girl,” I spoke to myself and left the room.

He was now in the bed waiting for me to join him, so he could come into his favorite position to sleep. “Why you went and put that little shirt on, Wonder?” He groaned, as he sat up. “Then you got your hair down.”

I spun around, so he could see how the length of the shirt stopped a bit before the bottom of my ass, so my cheeks hung out. "You like?"

"Thought you were mad at me, Baby." He waved for me to come to him, and I walked slowly over toward his side.

"Not mad... just wanted to talk about it." I kissed his lips, and messed with his briefs, while releasing his already hardened dick.

With his help, I climbed onto the bed, and stood over him as he held my legs, rubbing his nose in my pussy. "I wanna feel you on this dick, Wonder," he said between smells, as he pushed me closer to him.

I held onto his head as he placed kisses on her, while rubbing my ass. "Whatever you want, Menace."

He pulled his head back. "Why the fuck you calling me Menace?"

I distracted him by lowering myself until I was on his dick, slowly going down as he gripped my hips and bit down on his bottom lip. "Like that, Baby?"

"Yeah, just like that... you almost had me pissed, Wonder. Don't do that."

"Nope, I won't do that." I kissed his lips and started to slowly ride him.

His hands tightened on my hips, and he increased my speed while I held onto his chest and matched how fast he wanted me to go. He tossed his head back as he moaned. "Fuck, you so damn beautiful, Wonder."

"Hmm," I moaned, because as much as I was sticking it to the man and this was all part of my plan, this man had some of the best dick I had ever had.

And his was the only one I ever had, so yeah.

"Right there, fuck... shit I'm about to cum," he gritted, as he held onto me, pulling me down onto him and kissing my lips as I continued to slide up and down until I felt my body weaken, and him release inside of me.

He kissed me, and I kissed him back. "She don't mean shit to me, Stevie. I need you to know that."

"Yeah." I laid my head on his chest, before climbing off him and going to use the bathroom.

When I came back, I climbed into bed, and he got into his favorite position as I rubbed his head while staring up at the ceiling until I heard soft snores.

Duke: What the fuck you talking about?

[OceanofPDF.com](https://oceanofpdf.com)

Menace



I TOLD STEVIE SHE WASN'T GOING TO LEAVE ME, AND I MEANT THAT SHIT. She was mad because I reached out to Angelica. We spoke occasionally and being that her shitty ass husband ain't have no fucking motion like I did, I helped her when she needed it. Jeffie would be pissed if she knew.

The shit caught me off guard when she held my phone in her hand asking me why I was still talking to her. I was used to doing whatever the fuck I wanted without any explanation because I ain't never had to explain myself to nobody.

I was the nigga that people explained shit to, not the other way around. If me and Duke wasn't so locked in, I would have emptied my damn gun in his chest for helping her leave while I was sleep. I should have known when she climbed on top and fucked the shit out of me that she was up to something.

Her sneaky sleepy pussy put my ass out, so when I woke up this morning and she had her dear John letter on my damn nightstand, I tore this damn room up before calling Duke, who happened to be sleep in the truck outside of her apartment she shared with Skyler. When Blush and Jeffie came into the room, they looked at me in shock with the way I fucked this room up.

"When the fuck did you start smoking cigarettes?" Core asked, as he took a seat beside me while I sat in the backyard puffing on these Newport 100's.

I had my leg crossed, cigarette tucked between my fingers, and leaned over like a single mom trying to do her best, but life kept bringing her back

down. "She got me fucked up, Bruster... she gonna sneak her ass out the house last night."

"How the fuck she sneak out without *you* knowing?"

I turned to look at him, mad that I allowed pussy to put me out like that. "Ask Duke's fat ass... you think I should kill him?" Corleon had the nerve to laugh at my pain. "Ain't you adopted?"

He continued to laugh. "And your wife fucking escaped you...how she got your security wrapped around her finger?"

I took a long pull of the cigarette and flicked the ashes away before stabbing the shit in my leg. "Mens, what the fuck?"

"She don't like that me and Angelica still talk every now and then."

"I mean, she's your wife so why the fuck would she like that? I don't know why you keep in touch when Jeffie doesn't deal with her own mother."

"I should kill Angelica, right?"

Corleon put his head in his hand. "What the fuck?"

"My boo don't like her calling me so, ending her would stop the calls and texts... make my baby happy, and get her back under our roof."

"Menace you have gone too damn far this time!" Jeffie stomped out with Gray behind her.

I lit another cigarette and waited for her to speak. "It's always Menace you have gone too far, never you are the best and we love you."

"You got her arrested and reported her ring stolen you fucking nut!" Jeffie mused me, and I continued to puff on my cigarette while Corleon was holding his stomach while laughing. "Why the fuck are you laughing, she called me crying because she thought she was going to prison.... I had to send over your marriage certificate and have Zoya go get her out and let them know it was a misunderstanding."

"She ran off in the middle of the night with my ring *and* pussy, Jeffie. You lucky I wasn't able to report my pussy missing because I would have." I went to take a pull of my cigarette, and Jeffie snatched it and dramatically stomped it into the ground.

"You don't even smoke cigarettes... where did you get them from?"

"Maroon got them for me."

She looked over nervously. "He told me to go and get him a pack or he was going to fire me. I like my benefits and pay."

“With the way she spitefully squeezed the toothpaste in the bathroom before she left, she deserves prison.”

I went to pull another cigarette, and she snatched the box from me. “I’m going to see her... this is not how you treat your wife, Menace!”

Corleon hadn’t said a word because he was too busy laughing, which pissed Jeffie off. “Bring her ass home.”

“Corleon, I’m so happy that this is funny to you because when you try to come over later, I won’t be answering the phone, and I am calling Skyler soon as I leave so she won’t be answering, either. Matter fact, you can lay with your best friend since you both think this is funny.”

“I don’t think shit is funny... I know what I did, and I stand on that shit.” Jeffie stomped in place, something women seemed to have in common, and took off back into the house.

Corleon shoved me. “Baby, I don’t think shit he doing is funny,” he called behind Jeffie, and she spun on her heels, sticking her middle finger at him. “Got me in fucking trouble with both of them. Why the fuck would you report her ring stolen?”

“Shit, I thought I lost it. It’s two million dollars, so I needed to make sure that it wasn’t missing.”

Corleon busted out laughing as I picked up the marker beside me and started to smoke it since Jeffie wanted to snatch my carton of cigarettes. “Mens you really need to apologize to her. You do know that you made it ten times worse?”

“We’ll fix that shit when she bring her ass home.”

Corleon looked at me. “She not going to come home after you got her locked up, Nutty. How you gonna be mad because she left you where you had her fucked up at?”

I took a pull of my marker, blowing imaginary smoke. “She went through my phone and got mad because I told her the truth.”

“The truth that you don’t want to let Angelica go because you feel like you’ll be closing that chapter for real?”

“Bruster, why you in my house?”

He sighed. “Is Angelica worth you losing Stevie? She fucking left in the middle of the night... You used to have to kick Kim out, and she willingly left, and this is her home.”

“I don’t even talk to her like that.”

“Problem is that you are talking to her, and she knows the significance of the relationship that you had. You walk around threatening everybody that even look Stevie’s way but can’t check your own shit.”

“The fuck you want me to do? Just end the conversations with her and act like we strangers.”

Core stood up. “Yes, nigga. You don’t need closure to a situation that has run its course. You are grown now and have lived without her longer than you were so called with her. There doesn’t need to be a conversation to end shit either... delete her number and move the fuck on.”

“So, you don’t be fucking Killian anymore?”

He shook his head. “Nah. The minute I made my intentions clear with Skyler and Jeffie I ended it with her. I deleted her number and haven’t reached out because I want those two. I want a family with them. It’s easy when you know what you have and the future you could have. Straighten up and fucking end communication with her, or you gonna not only lose your wife, but your fucking best friend, too. If she could cut her mother off and choose you, you can do the same.”

He walked back toward the house leaving me and my marker. “I see why they gave yo’ ass up for adoption, bitch.”

“That’s why yo’ weird ass didn’t have friends back in school.”

“I ain’t want them bitches.”

“Might be true... you still fucking weird, Mens.” He chuckled and then stopped and looked down at his phone. “The Amante’s got him, Mens.”

“How the fuck...”

“C’mon now, he’s a fucking gambler... can’t stay away too long. Finish smoking your marker, shake this shit off and we meeting them.”

“I ain’t shaking my wife robbing me blind and then leaving me.”

“Now how the fuck she robbed you blind?”

I smirked. Wonder robbed me when she took my pussy away from me and didn’t tell me. I had business to handle, and then I was going to pull up on wifey.



MY DRIVER PULLED UP AT A WAREHOUSE IN COLLEGE POINT NEAR THE water. I looked over at Core, and then security pulling up behind us. Since the head of security wanted to let a little 5'5 strawberry blonde curly four eye angel finesse him into sneaking her out the house, I had to handle business without him.

"Before we go in there, you good with letting them handle business or do you want him for you?"

"I don't give a fuck who does it, as long as somebody does the shit." I looked at my watch, and then back at my best friend.

He held his hand out and dapped me, as we both climbed out the truck and headed inside. Deuce Amante put me in the mindset of a younger DMX. Every time I saw the nigga; I wanted to scream "Where them dogs at?"

With the way Zoya and Kora were spinning the trial for his brother, the families were cool. Not cool enough for them to step in as the third family of Staten Island. I didn't give a damn if they were from Staten Island either.

There was never any competition at the top, just collaborations. We all were familiar with each other and respected each other. When needed, any one of us could call in a favor, and we would all be there or extend our resources.

My resources happened to be that I had a federal judge and a top criminal defense lawyer as sisters. Dane, Deuce's brother, got himself in a pickle, and he needed to spin some shit in his way, or else he was looking at them throwing his life at the wall.

Dane was the head of the Amante Cartel, after his father stepped down. Deuce was the enforcer, and made sure shit was handled, which was why he had Raye's ass in his warehouse. Dice was the youngest of the brothers, he was the lieutenant overseeing everything that the Amante's had their hands in.

"What up, Menace?" He nodded because everyone knew I didn't do all that touchy bullshit. He then looked over at Core, extended his hand and dapped him up. "What up, Core? I fired your shorty. She didn't need to be working there anyway."

Core extended his hand again. "Appreciate you. She hardheaded, and I knew she wasn't going to do that shit on her own."

"All love. I ain't like how they were looking at her any way. Congratulations is in order for you finding your forever."

“Why everybody know my business?”

He laughed. “My pops close with Rahmeek... mad I didn’t get invited.”

“You can attend her funeral.”

“What the fuck?” Deuce looked at me and then looked to Corleon for clarification that I wasn’t going to give.

If Stevie didn’t bring her ass home, then we both were going to see my parents in real time. “Don’t ask... I heard you picked up a stray.”

He nodded for us to follow him further into the warehouse. It was filled with cars and car parts. When we entered the bigger area, I smiled when I saw Raye hung up by his arms by the car lift. His head was hung, and if he wasn’t so damn fucking rotten you would have compared him to Jesus on the cross.

“Raye? That’s you, Raye-Raye?”

He weakly lifted his head and that’s when I saw how bad they had this man fucked up in here. When his brain registered that it was me, he tried to run, which was dumb because he was up in the air and his feet were hanging.

“Men...Mens, come on, man. I had nothing to do with this.”

I chuckled. “Why the first thing out your mouth had to be a lie?” Leaning on the post next to him, I smiled up at him. “Hey father-in-law... you good?”

Deuce looked at Corleon. “This is his father-in-law?”

“Yeah... complicated shit.” Corleon shook his head, as he watched me talking to good ol’ Raye.

“Me and Stevie went and got married. She real happy, Raye... my baby a billionaire, you know that? Nah, don’t answer that because if you answered wrong, I might snap your neck.”

He groaned as he tried to focus and make eye contact with me. “Is she safe?”

“You give a fuck about her now, but never even cared when you killed two of my people... one of which was lucky I didn’t kill her myself.”

“I needed to save her man.”

I looked at the wrench next to him and picked it up. Picking it up, I smashed him in the face with it a few times. “You ain’t never gave a fuck about her. If you cared about her, you would have went to that farm and did what you had to do and probably would have been able to return to life because I knew how much she wanted to keep you alive. See, you owe me

money, and then you owe the Amantes money, and in case you didn't see why the fuck Dane is on trial, you was better off staying on my farm."

"I can pay it back.... I can pay both of you back." He made dumb ass promises that he would never keep, kind of like he did with his own daughter.

Always made her promises and never came through on them. His ass was just as vocal as Priscilla when I told Stevie that she was gonna marry me. He was shoving his daughter with a stranger to fix his bullshit.

"What you wanna do, Menace? I can respectfully step back and let you handle him," Deuce called from across the room while he smoked a black and mild.

"How much he owe you?"

"A mill and a half."

Corleon choked. "Clearly you ain't good at the shit, nigga... the fuck you run up a tab you know you couldn't pay?"

I messed with my beard. "Which means that is why you were stealing from me... robbing the Caselli's to pay the Amante's... damn my guy."

"We can fix this. I can work for both of you."

"Nigga, why the fuck would I want a thief with a gambling addiction to work for my family? Mens, watch out." I moved back and he threw the football full force at this nigga's face, which explained why he was so fucked up.

Everybody knew Deuce Amante was on his way into the NFL, the [New Jersey Black Jackets](#) wanted him straight out of college, but an injury caused him to give up his football dreams.

"Glad you still working that arm out," I snickered.

He chuckled. "Your call... let me know."

I looked at Raye, who looked like he would have rather me take him than to stay here. "He's family, Deuce." Raye took a huge sigh of relief. "I'll let you handle him, so I don't have my wife's father on my hands... you know? We're newlyweds, we don't need that on us."

Corleon laughed while shaking his head. "I'm gonna take care of it... consider it my wedding gift."

"Appreciate that... let us know when it's done." I looked down at my phone, not recognizing the number. "Yo." I nodded toward Deuce and headed back out.

When an automated woman's voice came through the line, I looked at my phone. I thought Jeffie said she was sending Zoya to get my baby.

"Goon," I heard the name when the voice said who was calling. Now I was intrigued because other than Monaco, I didn't speak to that nigga.

Can't front like he didn't make me laugh and I slightly enjoyed his company the time he was around me. We bonded on our dislike of Morgan, and he had to pretend to be his security.

"Yo Mens."

"Goon, the fuck I owe this prison ass call. Thought you were my fucking wife for a minute." I got back into my truck and waited for talkative ass Corleon to finish his conversation.

I guess that was why our situation worked. He talked too much, and I didn't speak enough. "When the fuck you got a wife?"

"Guess you ain't been speaking to Ms. Lawyer, huh?"

He chuckled. "I'm gonna keep my ting brief with you."

It was his Jamaican accent that shocked me. "You went to prison and now you busting out fake accents?"

Goon laughed. "I'm Jamaican, nigga... moms was born and raised there."

"This about Zoya?"

"You already know. I heard you have plans on eating that nigga's food... I have a big appetite, so let me have that meal."

"Why you worried about another man's meal, G?"

It was the laugh that told me that he wanted Sigel more than I did. "Me and Ms. Lawyer got some history. She saved my life, and the reason I'm not sitting up in here for a long ass time."

"I've heard."

"And I ain't asking your permission for shit now 'cause I'm still sitting up, and I ain't never gonna ask her to hold me down. When my time is up, I'm coming for Ms. Lawyer."

"Oh yeah?"

"On your chocolate nieces and nephews, Mens. You already know how I'm coming and how I'm built when it comes to loyalty. Your baby sister's heart is safe in my hands. I'm telling you now that there will be time in the future for us to sit down and count some grapes and talk about it."

How in the fuck did he know I counted my grapes before I ate them?

"And about the food?"

“Oh yeah, let the food cool off some and then I’ll devour that shit when I’m home,” he replied, as I leaned back and Corleon got back into the truck.

“I’ll let it cool and wait for you to come home. We gonna have that talk though... you want Zoya, come correct. That nigga and all the others in the past never came correct.”

“And I wouldn’t have it any other way.”

“Keep yo’ head up, G.”

“Fuck you meaannnn, I’m always gonna keep this shit up. Got my god baby to get home to. We’ll talk, Menace... over some grapes and Hennessy.”

“Scotch.”

“Even better... one.”

I ended the call and looked over at Corleon. “Good?”

“Yeah,” I nodded.

OceanofPDF.com

Stevie



Recommendation: Listen to "Escape" by Kehlani

"HE WON'T LEAVE HER ALONE AND I'M NOT GOING TO STICK AROUND WHILE he tells me what he's going to do. I don't care who he thinks he is... I am Stevie, and I'm not going to come second to some cougar."

Skyler looked down at her phone. "Your grandmother is calling me again."

"I blocked her number after our last conversation. Plus, Maverick told me that I wasn't giving her no groceries after the way she spoke to me."

"Well, I love this new and improved Stevie... what is it the dickkkk?" she busted out laughing and then straightened up when she realized that I was serious. "Sorry. Nanny is bitter and she has never been there for us like a real grandmother should have. All she wants is to worship her sons who aren't worth the skin they are in and continue to talk down on our mothers. Let my father deal with her... not my problem."

"Raye's ass is a goner so all she's going to have to depend on is your father." I shrugged.

Skyler rubbed my arm. "How does that make you feel? Do you wanna cry?"

I looked at my cousin and laughed. "Fuck Raye... the way he acted with my mother, I don't care what happens with him. He didn't give a damn about her life, so why should I care about his?"

“I feel like a proud mother watching her child grow in front of her eyes.” Skyler smiled and nudged me because I’m sure I had a frown on my face. “How long do you plan on ignoring him?”

“He got me arrested because of a stolen ring and then had the nerve to send flowers to the apartment telling me to bring me and my pussy home. I’m not going back home because he’s a fucking lunatic.”

“Well, you knew that when you wanted to be all *Maverick, I love you... Maverick forever*,” Skyler snickered.

“The fact that Jeffie doesn’t even speak to her mother says a lot. Why does he need to speak to her? I have a problem with her calling or texting and he’s always available for her.”

“As you should. If he doesn’t want to fix the problem, then you stay right with me. I just don’t understand why you had to escape and take poor Duke with you.” She looked over at Duke, who was standing in front of the store.

We were shopping because I needed something to take my mind off the whacked out lunatic that I married. I didn’t expect to get arrested because Menace – he wasn’t my Maverick – got me arrested because I decided to sneak out the house.

Poor Duke tried to fight the cop as they put me in the back of the squad car because the ring I was wearing was reported stolen. I was only in there for an hour before Jeffie had Zoya straighten everything out.

I was pissed.

Did I squeeze all the toothpaste out the tube and switch his body wash and face wash in the shower?

Yes. Yes, I did, and I enjoyed every minute of it before I moved his phone from where he put it every night.

Jeffie sent me a picture of the bedroom and he was clearly upset because he tore that room up. I was standing on business when it came to this, and if he wanted his wife like he told me he did, he would fix it and make sure he deleted her number and stop communicating with her. She was his past, and it was unhealthy of him to keep in communication with her.

If she moved on, then why the hell was she still reaching out to him?

“Duke owed me this favor since he was the one who kidnapped me in the Bahamas.”

He looked over at me. “You still not over this shit?”

“No I am not.”

“Steve-o, you gotta let some shit go. Your husband keeps calling me, what you want me to tell him?”

I shrugged, as I walked over toward him, and he put the phone on speaker. “What up, Boss?”

“Oh shit, I’m Boss again, Duke? I could have sworn you let my fine ass wife talk you out of a job... where is the loyalty, D?”

“Where’s yours?” I muttered.

The line became quiet. “That’s my boo, D?”

I told him to say no, as he held the phone unsure of what to say. “Yeah.”

“Wanda, bring yo’ ass home... I gave you some time, but now I’m starting to get mad... I forgive you.”

I scoffed. “You forgive me? Mitchell, you can continue to sleep in that bed alone. I know for a fact that you not sleeping well, either... and for the record, I might let someone sleep in your place. See how you feel.”

I would never but knowing that I was able to get under his skin felt like a reward. “If a nigga even hold the door for you, I’m gonna make sure they know what the morgue look like, Beloved.”

I rolled my eyes and walked away while he was asking Duke why he hated him and why he planned to get him killed? Maverick was forever asking someone some wild ass question that never left they mouth. Duke shook his head and told him that he was my security, too, and since I was leaving that house with or without him, he came with me to make sure that I was safe.

“Getting you arrested was wild. Aside from that, how long are you going to continue to ignore him before having a conversation with him?”

“I had a conversation with him, and he didn’t feel like he did anything wrong. He’s used to never having to answer to anyone and doing whatever he wants, and I can’t be with him like that. I want to know that my feelings are valid, and he respects what I say. He can delete all the men in my phone, but can randomly have conversations with this woman? That’s not fair, and I’m not going to stand for it.”

“Giving him sex to knock him out, then sneaking out your own home isn’t mature either. Every time you get into an argument, are you going to come running back to the apartment... which won’t be around much longer.”

“We’re getting evicted?” I panicked, not needing anymore drama because truthfully, I was tapped out.

Skyler laughed. “There’s no more we when it comes to the apartment. You have a home, a huge one, crazy.”

“I’m actually homeless right now since you are getting evicted.”

Skyler stopped looking at a shirt. “I am not getting evicted... I am buying a house.”

“What?”

“I’m starting the process. Keyshawn had brought up during mediation that I switch apartments so much and Stella doesn’t have a stable home.”

“That is such bullshit. You have provided more stability for that little girl than he has. Where does he even live?”

She rolled her eyes. “Don’t care, but because he brought that up it makes me nervous. Maybe it would be good to move to a nice suburban neighborhood. A small house for me and Estella.”

“What about Jeffie and Corleon?”

“Jeffie owns her condo, and Corleon has a condo, and then his home. We don’t even know what we’re doing, so I’m not gonna move in with either of them.”

“Yet you told Estella that Jeffie was going to give her a baby sister.”

“I don’t mean it like that. God, I know what I want, but I also know what I need to do. I have more time since I was fired from Mante.” She rolled her eyes. “My relationship with Corleon is something that we’re working on, but I’m not going to rush into it and risk Keyshawn being petty.”

“I have a solution to Keyshawn.”

“What?”

“You let Corleon and Menace handle him, and then you don’t have to deal with anything,” I reminded her that she had options.

“Stevie!”

“All I’m saying is you need to start acting like you have other options, because if he gets visitations, I’m going to be very upset. Stellie doesn’t know those damn people.”

She wasn’t paying me any attention as she looked at her phone and smiled to herself. “Cause why would he do that?”

“Do what?”

“Send me ten thousand dollars.”

“Who?”

“Corleon.”

“Well, shit, I’m married to a billionaire and all he did was try to send me to prison. I know you didn’t want to talk about it the day of my wedding, but you deserved to be happy... Corleon and Jeffie make you and Estella happy. Fuck what Keyshawn says and go with your heart.”

“Yeah.”

After we finished shopping, we went to grab something to eat before going to pick Estella up. I was tired and just wanted a shower and my bed while keeping my phone on silent because I was tired of Maverick calling me.

He should have been calling Angie and telling her that he was done and couldn’t talk to her no more.

“Stellie, I am running your bath so make sure you pick those toys up!” Skyler yelled from the back where the bathroom was, as Estella continued to eat her snacks with her toys everywhere.

“Otat Mommy!” Estella yelled back, never taking her eyes from the TV screen while I grabbed my snacks.

Duke was downstairs, even though I told him that he could go home to shower. “Better pick them up, Stellie,” I said, on my way to my bedroom.

This was harder for me than it was for Maverick. I missed humming and rubbing his head while we went to bed. I just knew he was up in that house counting everything that he could. Meanwhile, I was laying in my full-size bed lonely because I stood on business too hard.

No.

I stood on business because it needed to be done. He wasn’t going to continue to tell me what he was going to do and not consider my feelings. It was the way he shrugged it off that didn’t sit right with me.

If he wanted us to work, then he had to realize that his ways had to change. It wasn’t about him anymore, he was married and had a wife now. I put my phone on my night table and kicked my slippers off before climbing into bed.

Pulling the covers over my head, I tossed and turned a bit before I sat up in the bed and started sniffing. “Why does it smell like cigarettes in here?”

“Cause you got me smoking them,” I heard a low creepy voice and jumped out of bed screaming.

“Skylerrrrrrrrrrrr!” I hollered while trying to dodge the mess on my floor and make it to the light to turn it on.

The door came busting open and Skyler had a gun in her hand. “What? What happened?” she aimed her gun while I ran out the room.

“There’s someone in my fucking room... they are smoking cigarettes.”

Skyler held her gun and had it trained in the room. “Where?”

“There’s smoke coming from under my bed!” I pointed and hid behind her, because clearly my cousin owned a gun that I knew nothing about.

“I am armed, get out and leave now... did you leave your window unlocked again?” Skyler turned around and looked at me.

I shrugged. “I like the fresh air.”

“And apparently rapist... you have a damn fire escape, Stevie!” she scolded me, as she held her gun and waited.

“Get the fuck out my room you creep. I have a husband, and I will call him to come and kill you!” I hollered, while still hiding behind my cousin.

Skyler started to choke. “Put that cigarette out now... and get the fuck out. I am armed.”

“Me too.”

I nearly passed out when Menace slid from underneath the bed with a cigarette tucked between his lips. “MAVERICK!” I screamed.

“What up, Boo?”

Skyler put her gun down and took a deep breath. “I don’t even know what to say. Why in the hell are you in our apartment?”

“Your apartment... she owns a home with her husband that she told she wanted a divorce.”

“I never said that.”

Skyler decided she wasn’t dealing with this and stormed out the room to finish getting Stellie ready for bed.

“Maverick you have me so fucking overstimulated. I need a vision break,” I removed my glasses and started to pace. “Why are you under my damn bed?”

“To bring you home.”

“I’m not going home with you. Did you tell Duke that you are here?”

He laughed. “He helped you sneak out and helped me sneak in here.”

I folded my arms. “That traitor.”

“He loyal to the family and you are the family. Come home with me, Wonder. I fucking miss you.”

I put my glasses down and picked up my Telfar bag that I started to paint and had given up sometime last year. Wrapping the straps around my hand, I beat him with the bag as he held his arms up.

“You got me fucking arrested, Maverick! Do you think I want to go home with you?” I slapped him once more with the bag.

“You done?”

“No. You think you can tell me what you’re going to do when it comes to *Angie*, and it doesn’t work like that. If you want to delete numbers out my phone and crash out if someone even looks my way, then I have the right to demand you cease communication with her. If you don’t want to do that, then you need to call the lawyers back so we can get divorced, and I can start my life on one of my islands.”

“Alright, come home.”

“Maverick, I’m not going home with you. You are used to always getting your way and I’m not giving you that... you got me arrested. Fucking arrested because I used free will and left.”

He looked down at me with the cigarette still tucked between his lips. “You said you wouldn’t leave me, Wonder.”

“No, you don’t get to use that. I left because of you, so before you start saying I left you... think about why I left.” I snatched the cigarette and put it in my glass of water. “When did you start smoking?”

“Since you left me... go through a pack a day.”

“Maverick, stop smoking cigarettes. I didn’t like that you shut me down. You made it seem like I had no choice and that was how things would be. You want to fix this, then prove it to me... now leave before I get *you* arrested.”

I thought he was going to leave out my bedroom door, but he pulled another cigarette out and headed toward the window, climbing on the fire escape. “I ain’t going home until you come home.”

“Do what you gotta do... giving yourself lung cancer isn’t going to help me get there quicker.”

“Let me smell it,” he asked, while he was on the fire escape.

“Nope... ask *Angie*.”

“I don’t want her old ass pussy, Wonder, damn.”

I slammed the window down and locked it before closing my curtains and storming out the room. “When I have the proper thoughts, I will debrief because, *Stevie*, your husband is certified.”

I grabbed the Lysol to get the smoke smell out of my room, then climbed into bed to get some sleep. As much as I wanted to go with him, he needed to end things with that woman. I couldn't compete with his first.

The difference was he was my first, and there was an attachment that came with that. I knew the same existed for him, and knowing she was the last person he had given his heart to added more layers to the situation. He had to cut things off with her, or we couldn't be.



“HAVE YOU GOTTEN THE MESSAGES FROM THE GROUP CHAT THAT MENACE made?” Skyler asked, as we were heading to the club.

We were in the back of an Uber as she continued to scroll through her phone. I hadn't been on my phone much because it had been a few weeks since Maverick was under my bed. While he still called in hopes to talk to me, he hadn't made a move to show me that he was fixing the issue. Maybe I thought that he would jump to end things with her because he said he loved me so much.

“I haven't been on my phone much. Other than when Kora called to check in on me.” I sighed, not wanting to go to the party anymore.

In my defense, we bought the tickets when I was talking to Cornell. The red flag should have been that he allowed me to buy tickets instead of getting us in because he knew Zay. Skyler was excited to get out the house, so that was the only reason that I was going.

“Well, apparently we are all going to the Amalfi coast for Thanksgiving on his yacht... now Stevie, I know I was against this at first but taking my baby out the country and having her on a yacht... these are the things I can get with.”

“You've been on a yacht and a jet, Skyler.”

“Not enough to not be excited about it. I already spoke to my lawyer about it, and I can bring Estella, as long as we have a return date which we do.”

“Cool.”

“Why are you so shitty today?” Skyler turned to face me.

“I’m not.”

“You are... you’ve been in a mood all week. Why don’t you answer the phone and see what he has to say.”

“I’m pregnant, Skyler.”

She went quiet and looked out the window behind me and then looked at her phone without saying anything. “I’m finding my words... I promise I’m trying to find my words.”

Whenever I was going through something mentally, my body could automatically tell, and I would feel sick. Usually, I felt it in my stomach, this impending feeling of doom within my stomach. I brushed it off when we were in Texas, and even before that because I figured it was nerves. Although I kept telling myself that I wasn’t nervous, maybe my body was telling me something different.

When I vomited in the holding cell, I assumed it was because I was nervous about going to prison. My period was late, which was never the case with me. It was always on time, and when my app reminded me that I was late the other day, I knew I had to take a test.

Here I was in my midtwenties, and I felt like a teen mother while me and Duke went to the drug store to grab a test. Why did women always feel like we were a teenager finding out that she was pregnant?

“You both weren’t using protection?”

“Never crossed my mind. He was going to be my husband, so I felt weird asking him to use one.”

She grabbed my hand. “What is going through your head? I remember when I found out, I cried and was scared that I made myself sick.”

“Scared. I’ve never been a mom before... Estella still has to remind me to pack her snack or give her vitamins when you’re working. How am I supposed to raise my own child?”

Skyler smiled. “You will figure it out as all mothers do. You’re not going to be perfect at it, but you don’t need to be perfect to raise a great kid. You also have the support of your family, too. Stevie, you have a husband, although strange, I know he’s going to take care of you and this baby.”

“Thanks, Sky.”

“Don’t mention it. I’m excited to be right there with you on this journey. I’m here just like you’ve been there for me and Stellie. Listen... don’t hire my nanny though, because I like her, and Core pays her well.”

I laughed at her not wanting to share Estella’s nanny. “Deal.”

When we arrived at the club, our tickets were VIP, so we were able to skip the line. Skyler didn't want to splurge for the VIP tickets, and now she was glad we did because that line was wrapped around the building, and there were talks of them not letting people in because they were about to meet the maximum people allowed in the club.

"Skyler!" we heard and looked up and saw Aimee.

She waved us up to her section, and we headed up there since we had a small table on the main floor. "Hey Aimee!" Skyler hugged her.

"Why didn't you tell me that you were coming to this?"

"Bitch, I told you that I was, and you said you were going to think about coming," Skyler reminded her and she laughed.

"Hey Stevie!" she hugged me, and then she pulled a light skin woman with long black hair and tattoos over toward us. "This is Syn."

We all got acquainted while Aimee poured herself cranberry juice. I noticed she had some liquor in her section, but she also had nonalcoholic drinks, too. "What has been going on with you?"

Aimee sipped her cranberry juice. "Girl, a lot. Capri actually made me come out tonight because things have been so crazy. Told me that I needed to go and have some fun."

"I mean with the way you been hanging off the back of bikes letting that thang go you should have some fun," Skyler joked. I was never in on these inside jokes, or knew if they were jokes or not.

I nursed my cup of orange juice nervous because I had to tell Maverick that I was pregnant. The goal was to produce an heir, and with the way we had been having sex with no protection, I shouldn't have been as surprised as I was. I looked up and saw Duke coming into the club, which meant he found parking.

He tried to get us to ride in his car and I told him that I wanted tonight without all the bells and whistles. Just me and Skyler in an Uber like we used to do before I married a billionaire with security.

"You say the test is for you... pay for it." I pulled my hoodie up over my hair, and continued to scan the different boxes for what kind of test would I need.

"Steve-o, ain't nobody gonna think the fucking test is mine. Why you acting all scared like you're not married?"

I shrugged as I shook the box, like it would tell me if I was pregnant right in the aisle. "Um, can I help you?"

“Did we fucking ask for your help? You been circling this aisle for the past ten minutes. How about I beat the shit out of you and then ask if you need help after.” Duke turned and towered over the skinny White man.

He was so nervous that I’m positive that he pissed a little as he scurried away from the aisle, and I decided on which test that I would get. “Meanwhile those girls on the other aisle are actually stealing.”

“Ain’t it always like that though. The fuck we need to steal a damn test when you can buy the building.” He was disgusted.

Duke had become like a big brother for me. Even though he was security, there was a brotherly aura about him. “What if I am pregnant?”

“What you nervous about, Steve-o?”

“Everything. Me and Maverick are in a weird space, and then kids... he doesn’t do kids so how would he react to his own.”

“There’s a lot of things that Boss doesn’t do, and he has done them because of you. You are the exception to a lot of his rules, so you have to get out of your head.”

“And Angie?”

“Not my business, Steve-o. Can’t speak on what I don’t know. I do know that Boss is a solid nigga, and I know he’s going to do what needs to be done. I’m tired of sleeping in my damn car.”

I sighed. “Alright... I’m taking the test here.”

“The fuck?”

“I cannot wait until we get back to the apartment. I really need to know right this second,” I told him, and he shook his head.

Duke stood in the women’s bathroom as I went into the stall and waited for me. He tried to wait outside the bathroom, but I convinced him to come inside with me because I needed the moral support.

After figuring out how to take the test, I peed on my hand and the test but it turns out that I had taken the test right. While I washed my hands, we both waited to see the results of the test. My hands were shaking as I waited to see if I was carrying Maverick Caselli’s baby.

I flipped the test over, and in the biggest digital font ‘pregnant’ was on the test.

“Um hey,” I heard Skyler’s tone, as I remembered that I was actually in a club and supposed to be enjoying myself.

When I turned to see who she was talking to, I saw Cornell walking over toward me and I groaned. I hadn’t spoken to him since he was being

weird and I hadn't replied to any of his messages. As I stared at him, I couldn't understand what I ever saw in him.

He was so flashy with a big ego, and he wasn't even the celebrity. Hell, he wasn't even the celebrity's best friend. I didn't want to speak to him or give him any of my energy because what was the point?

That night I left him and took the train home, I mentally ended whatever it was that we were doing. He was a creep, and I wanted to be far away from him.

"What up, Stranger?" He came and sat down next to me, since it was empty next to me. "I've been hitting you up and you can't hit me back?"

"I've been busy."

He touched my hand and looked at my ring, which you couldn't pretend to hide. It was the first thing that you saw. "This a cocktail ring or some shit?"

"No."

I felt Skyler's hand on my back. "Are you good?"

"Yeah, I'm fine."

Cornell wasn't about to ruin my night. He had ruined plenty of nights in the past, and I refused for tonight to be the same thing. I didn't understand why he was over here in the first place. His friends ended up coming in and joining the section and Aimee stood up.

"This is not what we're doing. We don't want nor need your company, so you can back it on up," she told them, and they looked hurt.

"Bitch, shut the fuck up."

Skyler laughed. "I promise it's in your best interests not to come crazy at her."

"This is why I have this tattoo because men will always show you how much they suck. Get the fuck out of the section or we're going to have security remove you... or I can just mace you." Syn dug into her purse to look for her mace.

The main man looked down at her and laughed, flicking a piece of her hair. "You fine as shit, Shorty."

"Chill, that one right there is a Delgato, and she stamped by Havoc. You don't want that smoke with them Delgatos or Inferno Gods," one of his friends said, and Syn turned to look at him.

"I'm not stamped by nobody... I am no one's property."

The friend chuckled. "Well, that big nigga put the word out that you are, and I ain't about to fuck with him... and you would be smart not to fuck with her." He tapped his friend's shoulder and left the section.

Cornell was still over here breathing the same air as me, which pissed me off. "You should join your friends."

"Why you being different? I hit you up and you don't respond, and then I see you out and you acting all funny with me." He roped his arm around me, and I scooted away, and he moved closer.

"I know you saw her move away from you. Actually, take yo' ass on, too," Aimee scolded, as she stood there.

"Why you minding everybody damn business... drink yo' shit and chill out." He continued to put his arm on me, pushing the boundaries I had set.

Everybody in the club was jumping to Zay's newest club anthem, and then the lights went out, which made everybody go even crazier and rap even harder.

It was so dark that I couldn't even see anything, but I felt a hand on my thigh and slapped the hell out of it. Scooting over, me and Skyler held hands while I prayed that Cornell was gone when the lights came back on.

"He's coming," Skyler muttered.

"Who?" I asked.

When the lights came back on, my eyes took a second to adjust, and I turned to see if Cornell was still there, and then my eyes landed on Maverick sitting on the other side of Cornell with a smile on his face.

"Honey, you in danger." Skyler and Aimee both fell out laughing as Maverick continued to smirk, his grills gleaming off the light in our section.

"My niggas couldn't stay, but this nigga could?" Cornell didn't know how to read the room to know that he was in danger.

I didn't expect him to know who Maverick was because not a lot of people did. The fact that the lights in the entire club went out and he appeared when they were back on should have told Cornell all he needed to know.

Corleon walked into the section and nodded at Skyler, and Landon was behind him, pulling his pants up and smirking. "What up, Sis'?"

I looked at Cornell and he still didn't realize that he was in danger. The dumbass inside of him told him that this was the moment to push his chest out more and act tough. "You said you wanted to fuck my wife?"

Anybody knew that when this man asked a question about something you never said, you got the fuck away from him. Cornell laughed as he looked at me and then put his arm around me. What in the way that Menace was looking him in the face told him that he was safe to even do that.

This man looked nearly manic when he put his arm on what was his, and I was what was his. “Steve ain’t fucking married.”

Menace nodded. “Yeah, you right... my fault. We good?”

He extended his hand to Cornell, who removed his hand from me to dap him up. “You good... me and Steve lock—”

No sooner than they embraced, Maverick head butted Cornell and snatched his ass up. “She don’t like being called fucking Steve,” he said through gritted teeth, as he sat back down, while he continued to hold Cornell’s neck.

“Mrs. Caselli, make yo’ way to the Rolls Royce waiting for you outside.”

I folded my arms. “Ask me nicely.”

He sighed and slammed Cornell’s head onto the table in front of us and then looked at me. “Mrs. Caselli, can you please take yo’ fine ass to the Rolls Royce waiting for you. I have plans for us.”

I stood up. “That is better.”

I walked past him, and he tapped my thigh, and I turned, and he had his lips puckered out. “No kisses for you. You lucky I’m going to get in your car.”

“Our car, Wanda... *ours*,” he called behind me.

I looked at Skyler. “I’m going to stay with Syn and Aimee... I will call you when I’m home.” Corleon went and sat next to her, so I knew he was going to stay with her, and she would be safe.

Duke reached for my hand and helped me down the steps and out the club to the Rolls Royce parked out front of the club.

“Told you he was going to make it right, I know my guy,” Duke whispered as he helped me into the car, and I smiled.

Menace



*Recommendation: "Don't Give Up On Me" by
Fridayyy*

"CORNELL... FLUNKY TO THE STARS. I THOUGHT YOU'D TAKE THE HINT when I deleted your text thread, which by the way gives me fucking weirdo creep vibes. Whatever you did to my wife, and the reason she's not talking to you is why you gotta get fucked up."

Homie was delirious with how many times I had slammed his head on the table in front of us, and I slammed it again for good measure. He had blood leaking everywhere, but he fucked up the minute he put his arms around my wife.

I was coming to the club to get Wonder anyway, but when I came in the club, I snatched my sunglasses off because maybe it was too dark, and my eyes were playing a game on me. The minute I saw him keep inching next to her and her body language told me she wasn't comfortable with him, it was clear they had some fucked up past that she never wanted to speak about.

When I deleted his number out of her phone, I saw him begging her to speak to him and apologizing. "I'm feeling nice today because I need to get out the doghouse and make nice with my wife. If I wasn't focused on that, I would fucking snap your neck in this section... whatever the fuck you did

to her, don't do that shit again to another bitch or I will appear in your house and finish the job, cool?"

He nodded his head quickly as I shoved him away, and he laid back on the couch. "You gotta go and die somewhere else because you already got blood on the table." Aimee shoved him, and he tried to stand up, but kept staggering.

"I'm out... you got the itinerary for Thanksgiving?" I looked at Skyler, and she laughed while nodding her head.

"You really wanna be on her good side again?"

"You just said fuck this family, Skyler?"

Corleon laughed and kissed her head. "The Brusters have already RSVP'd. Sexy already told you that we're gonna be there."

"I don't see a ring on either me or Jeffie's finger... tuh."

"The minute we finish this shit with homie, and I change Estella's last name to Bruster, you both gonna get the rings."

I looked at Landon, and he turned the lights back off, and I headed out of the section and out the club. As quick as I came, I was back out and heading to the car with my lady. She had her legs crossed, looking good as shit. She had this whole wine color outfit on with shorts, leather jacket, and then tights on.

Her hair was back curly, wild and free, while she had her arms crossed waiting on me. Duke held the door open for me, and I climbed inside, and we were heading to the next spot.

"What up, Boo?"

"Hello, Maverick."

"Miss you."

"I miss you, too," she admitted, which was better than the silent treatment she had been giving me.

She was mad at me getting her arrested like every nigga didn't send they girl to prison because he loved her.

"Can you come home now?"

"No."

"You look pretty, Boo."

She smiled. "Thank you. It was very expensive, too."

I watched as she held her foot up showing me the heels she probably spent a grip on. Whenever she was mad, she liked to spend money, and I

didn't mind. We had enough for her to shop every time she was mad, and we would never end up broke.

"Never gonna be mad at you spending money, Wonder."

"Where are we going?"

I took her hand and kissed the back of it. "I have something for you."

She yawned. "Okay."

"How many others had a problem with our friendship, and you end up calling me saying it didn't work. What makes things different with her, Maverick?"

"She's my wife and I love her."

She chuckled. "Maverick and love don't even belong in the same sentence. This is someone who has your attention, just like Kim, and then you'll get back to calling and venting to me about it."

I looked at my phone because she was trying to tell me how this shit would go, and I knew how it would go. It would go with me being happily married. "Angie, fuck all that shit you talking about. She's my fucking wife and she got a problem with us having a relationship."

"Who's fault is that? Why would you tell her our past? What we have is special and has always been special. You are my person... soul mates."

My jaw ticked. "Nah."

"Nah?"

"You fucking heard me, Angelica. All the shit I was doing for you has to stop. I'm not only betraying my wife, but my best fucking friend. Jefferina doesn't deserve that shit from me."

She scoffed. "Jefferina decided to cut me off without ever hearing what really happened."

"What really happened? You saw me in the kitchen eating and saw me stressed, pulled my dick out and sucked me off in the kitchen. Only reason I didn't bust a nut was because Zoya came downstairs, and you hid behind the counter. You seemed to love sucking my shit in the kitchen, which is why Kora eventually caught us."

The phone was on speaker as I rubbed my hands and listened to the silence. "We loved each other."

"I ain't even trying to hear all of that or revisit it. My wife means the fucking world to me, and if I hurt her, then I'm hurting me."

"She has you having emotions... something you could never give me."

Angelica was talking about everything else except what the fuck I was saying. Corleon said I didn't need a conversation, but I felt like I did before I cut her off. Now I was thinking I should have listened because this conversation was getting nowhere, and it was making me feel different about her.

When Wonder said she groomed me, I was offended and pissed because that wasn't the case. As I listened to her talk on this phone, I was feeling differently, and I didn't like how that shit felt.

"Can we meet up somewhere? I want you to say this to my face... fly me in so we can have a proper sendoff."

"I wish you the best, Angelica."

"No, you don't."

"Shit, it sounded nice. Angelica, I don't care if you call this phone again... just know I ain't answering the shit. Spend more time trying to fix your relationship with your daughter than trying to see me. She's fucking amazing and you missing out on the life that she's building."

"Phone works both ways, Maverick."

"Yet, your phone always seems to work to call or text me." She was trying to say something, and I ended the call.

The driver looked in the rearview giving me the signal that we were getting closer. "Boo, put this on for me."

I handed her a blindfold, and she looked at it and then at me. "You not going to kill me, right?"

"Nah."

"Send me to prison?"

I laughed. "Put the damn shit on, Wanda."

She pulled it over her eyes, and I waved my hand in front of her to make sure her sneaky ass couldn't see anything. The driver opened my door, and I went around and helped my baby out. She held onto me as we stood outside, and I grabbed her ass in the process.

"Maverick, my ass has nothing to do with leading me... why are we standing in the cold? I'm freezing."

"Shit... I missed it."

"Shouldn't have tried to send it to prison."

"Damn, baby, you gonna keep bringing it up?"

She snatched away from me, turned in a direction that I was not in and pointed her finger. I held my laugh in as she swayed her head and cussed

me out. "So, yes, I am going to continue to bring it up."

I came behind her and kissed her neck, feeling her fold into my arms. "I'm sorry for getting you arrested, Wonder. You make me fucking crazy and waking up with you gone had me lose my shit. It made me see how much I not only need you, but I also want you, too. I love you, baby, and I'm sorry if I made you feel like I don't consider your feelings."

"Thank you. I appreciate that."

I kissed her lips, and she allowed me to before she finally kissed me back. "I handled that, too. You told me what makes you uncomfortable and my only job is to make you comfortable. I was a bozo not taking my wife's feelings into consideration over an ex-bitch."

"Oh, she's a bitch now?"

"Any woman I fucked with in the past is a bitch. You the standard, the wife, my one and only... your name on all those papers."

"And I have two islands."

"And you have two islands," I kissed her lips. "I'm sorry, Wonder... I want you home where you belong and not in the damn club."

"Can I tell you something?"

"Anything."

"I don't plan on going to a club again... not my scene. I used to love it, but I was annoyed the whole time."

I could see it in her face that she didn't want to be there. I've never been into the club and the only reason I found myself there was because my wife was there.

"We don't have to go to another club."

"Mavie, we might not be allowed with the way you head butted that man. Are you alright?" It was hard not to laugh with her still being blindfolded.

"Always good. I wanted to give you something to show you that I hear you, I love you, and I'm going to do better. I'm not always going to get it right, but when it comes to you, I am damn sure going to try, Wonder."

I softly removed the blindfold, and she searched my eyes. The only person I allowed to truly look into my eyes that way.

"This was supposed to be a business agreement, and we found love with each other. All I want is for you to try, and I don't need you to be perfect. Just be you, Maverick. I want to know that I matter, because to me you matter. This wasn't about her. It was about you putting her before my

feelings. I'm your wife, so I needed you to see that I can and will walk away from this. Your money, the islands... okay, the islands do mean something. But I will start my life on that island newly divorced."

I kissed her lips as she spoke because I missed her. Since she had been gone, I ain't even been home because I couldn't sleep under that roof knowing she wasn't there. Wonder made it a home and without her, it was just the same place it was before she existed in my world.

"I love you, Wanda."

"Mitchell, I love you so much. You don't even know the half of how I feel about you." It was like she was saying something without saying something. "Why are we in the cold on this street?"

I turned around and pulled her back some so she could see what I was showing her. "I remember everything that you tell me, Wonder. Everything about you interests me and I love learning you, boo."

She was choked up and trying to put her words together. I held her and kissed her neck, as she spun around in my arms and looked at me. "Maverick," she choked out.

"I want you to have all the things that your heart desires and this is one of those things. Stevie, I was put on this earth to make all your dreams come true, and that's what I plan on doing 'cause you breathing the same air as me makes my dreams come true."

She kissed my lips, and I tasted her tears as she held onto me. "The Messy Muse," she cried, and hugged me tightly.

Every time she spoke, I listened because I thought she was the most interesting person I had ever met. Conversations would usually bore me quickly, but not with her. I could listen to her talk for hours and never get tired.

Except during quiet hour.

What I loved about my wife was that she never stopped dreaming. Even though when I met her, she was nowhere close to having her dreams, she still spoke them into existence and never gave up on them. I watched all of her little fake vlog videos when we were in Paris and watched how she spoke to herself and how she was so determined to have what she wanted.

Stevie always spoke about feeling lost and never knowing what was next, but she wasn't lost at all. She knew what she wanted and where she wanted to go. Life was just hard for her, and I was sent to make it easier for her.

Quiet her mind when she needed it.

This gallery and giving back to children was something she was passionate about because the seed had been planted by her mother. Her mother put her into an art class, which molded Stevie into who she was.

Life got her down and she couldn't afford to follow her passion, so she found other ways to express her creativity. I wanted her to have what she always wanted, and it was a gallery for her to truly follow her dreams.

I've bought a jet without even taking a second look, so investing in my wife and her career was nothing for me. I wanted her to have her own life, not just become Menace Caselli's wife. I wanted her to be Stevie Caselli, and have things that she accomplished on her own, so if me giving her this nudge was what it took, a nigga couldn't wait to see it.

"You remembered," she whispered as she held my face and kissed my lips. "Sometimes I don't think you listen because I talk so much."

I kissed her lips. "I hear everything that you say. Wonder, I wanna spend the rest of my life hearing everything that you have to say. I want your advice on art, so you can spend big money on making our family artsy."

Her eyes widened as she continued to hold my face. "Like auctions and stuff?"

"Yeah. I want you to follow your dreams, Wonder. Boo, I wanna continue to quiet your mind, and keep you warm and safe."

She hugged me so tight and then looked up at me. "Can we go inside?"

I held the keys up and she snatched them and ran over toward the door to let us in. Soon as she stepped into the gallery, she screeched and did my favorite stomps. "Where you gonna have the kids paint?"

I stood by the door with my hands in my pockets watching her. "Over there. I want to host classes every weekend and even after school some days. I want them to be free, too... something for the kids. Parents need that at times, you know? I have to call Kora because I need her help getting some local Black artists in here. I want so many new and upcoming artist on all of these walls. I think we may need to knock that wall down because we can then put more art there... is that alright?"

"You got the accounts, Wonder. Do whatever you need to do because this shit is yours. I want you to do exactly what you spoke about on that video you made."

She stood there and looked down at her feet. "God, how is this my life? I need to call Kora tomorrow."

“You can talk to her on the jet to our holiday vacation as a family.”

She folded her arms. “I may have heard you reached out to your siblings, and they all agreed to come.”

“You the only one that didn’t confirm if you were coming, Mrs. Caselli.”

She ran her hand through her hair. “I don’t know, I’m a gallery owner and very busy. Lots of auctions and events and such.” She put on this snooty voice and flipped her hair.

I laughed. “Even too busy for me? Damn, I’m one of your biggest clients.”

She looked at her phone. “I don’t know, Mitchell... I have to speak with my assistant and make sure everything is all good. I’ll have Greene contact you.”

I shook my head. “So, you just going to steal Mahogany from me?”

Wonder walked over toward me and hugged me. “You just put a battery in my back, Maverick. I’m excited to have something... to do something. I was scared about losing myself when I married you, not having anything of my own. This has renewed me, made me want to finish a painting and actually immerse myself further. I really think I can do this.”

“I don’t think you can do it, Wonder.” She looked down, and I lifted her face, and kissed her lips. “I know you can do it, and I can’t wait to witness everything that you do. You gonna be fucking great, Mrs. C.”

She kissed my cheek and then took off running to the back of the gallery. Stevie was sent to heal me. Every time I counted my blessings, and a nigga never counted his blessings, I counted her twice. I never thought I was supposed to ever be someone’s husband, and at times I still questioned it.

Wonder knew that I wasn’t all the way there and even knowing that she loved me. She wanted to be with me because of who I was, not what I could do for her. When she left, she showed me that she wasn’t about to put up with shit and demanded what she deserved.

I never wanted to imagine a world without my baby, and her leaving our home and being gone was something I never wanted to experience again. Stevie came into my life and shook shit up, made me anxious, nervous, and intrigued all at one time.

While she triggered the fuck out of me, I couldn’t stay away from her. We were learning each other, and I think she knew me best. She handled me

with care, and she never judged. No matter how stupid something that I had to do was, she always respected that.

Stevie Caselli was one of a kind, and I would smoke a whole carton of cigarettes if she left me again. I was considering buying me a little jail so if she tried to leave the next time I could lock her ass up, and it would just be us in jail together.

I was downright crazy about Wanda.



“LISTEN, I NEED THE ROOM WITH THE BALCONY BECAUSE I HAVE TO HAVE fresh air at night,” Zoya got off the speed boat barking demands.

She and Kora had to fly in later since they had to wrap up cases before the holidays. Kennedy boarded the yacht and smiled at me. “Hey Menace... thanks for inviting me.”

“Didn’t invite you Kennedy.” I looked at Zoya.

She rolled her eyes. “She’s your goddaughter, Menace.”

I kept my hands in my pockets as the staff pulled up all the luggage up onto the yacht. Kennedy came over and hugged me. “I am alright, promise.”

I looked in her face and she gave me a reassuring smile and then went with Zoya to claim a room. Kennedy was my God daughter, and as much as I hated that she worked for Case House, the girl was stubborn like her damn father.

Xander was my father’s best friend, and he asked me to be his daughter’s God father. I thought the shit was weird because I was young, and why the fuck would anybody want me to be their child’s God father? He wanted someone to look out for her, and to make sure she was always good.

It was a conversation that we never got to finish because he was murdered soon after. He didn’t give me no information on who the fuck his daughter was and how I was supposed to find her. All I knew is that I had a supposed God daughter somewhere out there, and she was put up for

adoption and he lost touch with her when all the shit popped off with my uncle.

I received a packet with a lot of information from someone without a return label. Inside there was a bunch of information on this said God daughter, who happened to be Kennedy. By the time I found out who she was, she was grown, and I couldn't locate her ass until her information popped up in Case House database that I found her.

Kennedy was stubborn and had been doing what she wanted for so long that she didn't want to hear shit from me. At the end of the day, as much as I made a promise to her father, she was grown. The fuck was I supposed to do? I never signed up for the shit in the first place, and Kennedy was going to do what she wanted to do anyway.

Shit, she was working for me before I even knew she was. At twenty-one, she was a grown ass woman and could do what she wanted. It was one time when I didn't protect her, but I damn sure made sure those bitches got handled.

It was the reason I told Don he needed to stay the fuck away from her. Not only was she a Case House girl, but she was also my fucking God daughter.

Landon was knocked out on the couch and the minute he heard Kennedy laugh with Zoya, his ass jumped out his sleep and was looking around like he was hearing shit. I watched him as he sat up rubbing his eyes and looked around.

"Leave her the fuck alone, Don... I already warned you," I told him, as I continued to the back deck where my baby was.

She had been fucking up those lemon Sorbets since we got on the boat. The chef had been making it every damn day. I walked over to her and Crimson on the day bed with their laptops out. She had her hair pulled up, a pink bikini that had her breast looking right. Instead of getting her own, she had my Celine sunglasses on as she was telling Crimson whatever plans she had.

It was crazy how she came and stole my second assistant like it was hers. Then she went and raised her salary and gave her personal mental days. The second I gave her the keys to that gallery; I saw my wife tap into someone she always wanted to be. All she spoke about was her plans. Instead of humming at night, she picked my brain for business advice.

"Hey baby, what you doing?"

“Zoy just got here.”

She clapped her hands. “Kora told me that she should be here later on today. I spoke to her earlier this morning while you were in the gym.”

“You talk to my sisters more than me.”

She smiled. “You started this family group chat and never reply back to any of us.”

This was the first holiday that I was spending as a married man, but with my family. We hadn’t spent any holidays together, and this was happening because Wonder wanted it to happen. She wanted our family to be close, and as much as I fought her on it, it felt nice to be surrounded by family.

“Mens, your suit and Stevie’s dress arrived in Monaco.” Jeffie came from inside with her iPad in one hand, and Estella on her hip.

Once we were done here, we all were going to Monaco for the ball. This was the first time in a long time that both Zoya and Kora had attended one. Landon attended them because he was always with me when it came to handling most of Case House affairs. It was my sisters that was never around for them.

This was the one place where Kora could show her face without any problems. I had blackmail on every single person that attended. They opened their mouth about anything at the balls, and they could kiss their life goodbye.

“Jeffie, I am her assistant now, you gotta let me do things for her,” Burgundy told Jeffie, while taking her sunglasses off.

“You are so right... I will remember that the next time.”

“Why are you working anyway?” Stevie asked, eating that damn sorbet.

Jeffie turned to leave. “Not you both about to gang up on me... I am shutting it down after I make sure the final details are handled.”

Estella yawned. “I’m gonna put her down for a nap, and then we gonna go to shore for lunch.” Corleon took Estella, as Skyler came out and sat on the bed next to her cousin.

“Who is going to watch Stellie if we’re all going?”

“Me,” Stevie volunteered.

“Wonder, you don’t ever volunteer to babysit,” I told her. Clearly the damn sorbet had been going to her damn head.

“You don’t remember all that God daughter talk?” Skyler reminded me, as she took some of Stevie’s sorbet.

“Clearly I have too many,” I muttered.

Don came out without a shirt on and stretched while standing near the banister. “Landyyy!”

He looked up, and Kennedy was there waving from the top deck. “Oh shit, what up, Kennedy?”

I gave him a death stare.

“The fuck you want me to do? Ignore her.”

He was sweet on Kennedy and had been for a while. Don knew the rules, and he knew that I didn’t play when it came to breaking the rules that I had put in place for this shit to run smoothly.

“I think I’m going to come with you to shore, too,” Don told Corleon and then went back inside.

The one promise I had Wonder make is that we wouldn’t do the whole sitting at the table for family meals. That shit wasn’t us and had never been. I could get with us being together on this boat and spending time together, but I wasn’t about to force sitting around a large table and pretending.

Every single one of my siblings agreed with me.

My baby had to take baby steps when it came to us. We would eventually get there, but not right this moment.

“Let me change and then I’ll come, too,” Kennedy called over the banister.

“I’m trying to take my wives out for lunch and here come the fucking third wheels.” He kissed Stellie’s head and turned to head back in to put her down.

“Watch his ass,” I told him.

“Mens, he a grown ass man. He knows what the deal is, I can’t stop him from doing what he wants to already do.”

“Baby, wanna go sit on the top deck and eat sorbet with me?”

I looked over at my baby. “Yeah. Finish up here and meet me up there since everybody is going to the shore.”

“I’m good for the day?” Indigo looked at Stevie.

“You were always good... I was minding my business, and you came out working with your laptop.”

She laughed. “You right.”

“Yo, Don... I saw some fire ass hoes,” I heard Beans call from the lower deck. “You know how they love Americans... especially the niggas.”

“Fuck it, we ‘bout to get us a room on shore so we can hit the night life tonight,” Don called back down to him.

“Bet.”

“I wanna party, too!” Teal hollered behind Don.

“Me, too,” Kennedy yelled, too.

I looked at them, while trying to refrain from putting both Kennedy and Orchid on punishment. “They are grown women, Mavie.”

I smelled the familiar pistachio scent and soft hand rub my chest. “I don’t give a fuck, Wanda.”

“Come on... I wanna talk to you about something, and we can do it over sorbet.”

I allowed her to pull me back inside and up to our room. “What you wanna talk about?”

“Priscilla’s cousin reached out to me and told me that her cousin was found murdered.”

“Oh yeah.”

“Yes.”

“What you wanna know, Wonder?”

She kissed my chest. “I don’t want to know anything. Think it’s best for me to never know anything when it comes to that side of your life. Requirement?”

“One that should be number one. Long as you know that I’m going to do everything to make sure you never have to worry about anything. Buy us pretty art and make us money with the art shit.”

“I can do that.”

“What else?”

“My dad... have you heard from him?”

I never planned to lie to my wife. “He got into some trouble with some other people. Shit I couldn’t stop, so I let them deal with him. I didn’t want his blood on my hands because no matter how much you may hate him, he’s your father. I don’t know what happened to him and I didn’t ask, baby.”

Wonder nodded her head. “Okay. I’m going to get our treats.”

While she went downstairs to get the sorbet, I relaxed on the bed upstairs and watched the sky. The shit was so beautiful and peaceful, even with hearing Don and Beans argue over who is driving the boat.

“Neither of you niggas are driving the boat,” Corleon said.

“Bossy ass,” Beans said.

“Aye, wait the fuck a minute... let me and my wives get the fuck on first. Sexy, come on... hold my arm. Baby, where you at?”

“Getting your wallet because you left it.”

I tuned out their conversation as I continued to relax and closed my eyes. “Hey, you sleep?”

Opening my eyes, Zoya stood there. She took a seat at the edge of the bed, and I leaned up. “What up, Zoy?”

“I wanted to check in with you.”

“I’m straight, what about you? Heard you doing your thing with the case.”

She smiled. “Dane don’t make it easy because he’s forever trying to kill someone. He threatened the prosecutor the other day. I think because I have him on the straight and narrow, he is becoming restless.”

“Those Amante brothers are ruthless. Did you find that witness yet?”

“Nope. Wherever she is, she is hiding in plain sight... I got Core working on it, so we shall see if she turns up. Deuce is already on alert to get rid of her the minute she resurfaces because if the other side finds her, Dane is going away for the rest of his life.”

“I got faith in you and K.”

“Yeah.” She looked down at her hands and then looked up at me. “Thanks, Maverick.” Zoya never called me Maverick.

When she was younger, she used to, but as an adult I was always Menace. It was less of a nickname to her, and more of who she thought I was. Her apology had nothing to do about me having faith in her and Kora. It was about the information she found out about her ex-boyfriend.

“Don’t mention it.”

“I know you don’t agree with me being with Sigel, and some days I don’t either. Allow me to have my own life and make my own decisions.”

I broke out in laughter, and she stared at me crazy. “Zoy, I can promise you don’t have to worry about me getting at him.”

She was confused. “So, you want to meet him?”

“Why did you just call me a stupid bitch, Zoy?”

“Menace, I never called you that... you want to squash the beef, so I think it’s only right you meet him.”

I smirked. “I’m not who you need to be worried about, Ms. Lawyer.”

“Gerald?” she screeched.

“You want me to mind my business... that’s what I’m doing, Ms. Lawyer... heard you gonna have some chocolate babies.”

“Fuck you meannnn! I’m not having no kids,” she stormed back inside, leaving me to close my eyes and smile to myself.

Me and Goon would be having that sit down depending on how he handled Sigel. If he could come behind my baby sister as hard as I would, then he could have that sit down and gain my respect.

“Alright, here is your sorbet... eat it before it melts.”

I opened my eyes again to a lemon with lemon flavored sorbet in the inside. It wasn’t the sorbet that threw me off, it was a fucking pregnancy test sticking out of my fucking sorbet.

“Boo, I’m trying real hard to get my personal shit under control and then you go and do some nasty shit like this... you pissed on that?”

“Mitchell, pull the stick out the damn lemon,” she raised her voice.

I pulled the stick out of the sorbet and looked at the word *pregnant* on the test. “You carrying my baby, Wonder?”

“I am.” She nervously smiled, as she stood over me.

She kept shifting her weight from one foot to the next. I snatched her down on my lap and kissed her all over her face. “You got Dennis in there, Wanda?”

She giggled as she held my face. “Maverick, how do you feel?”

“How the fuck you think I feel... I’m nervous as shit.”

“Excited though, right?”

Kissing her lips, I searched her eyes. As I held her, she was nervous and needed to know that I was okay. “Wonder, you carrying my legacy... I’m fucking excited. What you thought?”

“I was nervous.”

“Tell me how you feeling, boo. I need to know.”

She kissed me on the head. “I am nervous to become someone’s mama, but I am excited.”

“Requirement?”

I could see the nervousness swirling in her eyes. “Yes.”

“We do this shit together... me and you. We’ll figure this shit out together, Wanda?”

Wonder tossed her arms around my neck and hugged me so tight. “Together, Mitchell.”

“I got Wanda pregnant!” I hollered off the balcony.

The chatter from below stopped. “Who the fuck is Wanda?” Don yelled back.

“I’m going to be an auntie! I need to call Kora right now because she gonna fucking bug out... move out the way, Beans.” I couldn’t see her, but I just knew she football shoved the fuck out of Beans.

“Damn, Zoya... I was moving.”

“Yo Mens,” I heard Core’s voice, and got up to look over the deck. He smiled, as he saluted. “Happy for you.”

“Appreciate it.” I looked at Jeffie, Skyler, and Duke. “Why the fuck none of you surprised? Y’all said y’all hate my baby?”

“Bye Menace!” Skyler laughed.

“Because Stevie told us already and we cannot wait to spoil the hell out that baby.” Jeffie blew me a kiss.

“You straight?”

“More than straight... Love you, Mens.”

Duke coughed. “Your wife forced me to wait with her while she took one. So, I knew before everyone.”

“Thanks again, Dukey!” Stevie came over the banister beside me.

“No problem, Steve-o.” He smiled, as he got onto the boat so they could head to shore. I picked my wife up and spun her around.

“We’re going to be parents, Mitchell.”

“For the rest of our lives, Wanda. I love you, baby.”

She kissed my lips. “I love you more than you know, Mavie. You and me makes three... you ready?”

I sucked on her lips. “More than fucking ready. One more requirement.”

“Go ahead.”

“We’re in this forever.”

“Forever, Mavie.”

I held her tight as we shared a kiss, and I thanked my lucky stars for the woman I had. Stevie Caselli was sent to me by her mother and my parents. I liked to think they were up there having coffee knowing they made this love connection. A messy, carefree woman with a structured obsessive man, who both had ADHD.

“I got something for you now.”

She looked at me weird. “What do you have for me?”

I dug in my pocket and pulled my phone out. “Toss it.”

She held my phone in her hand. “What do you mean?”

I kissed her lips. "You told me that you wanted me to be done with Angelica, and I told you that I am. I changed my numbers, and this is the last piece. Toss that shit in the ocean."

She held the phone in my hand. "Are you seriously done with her, Maverick?"

"So done, Wonder. I hurt my boo's feelings, and I don't like that shit. It was toxic holding on all this time, and my loyalty is to you and Jeffie."

Stevie looked at the phone. "Are you going to ever tell Jeffie about you still talking to her mother?"

I shrugged. "One day... not today. One thing at a time, Baby."

She smiled and continued to hold the phone. "I want you to toss it. This was never about me... this is closure for you."

I took the phone from her and tossed the phone far into the water. We watched as it dove into the water, and she kissed me. I spun her around, as I held her tightly and she giggled. This was a match made in heaven, and I refused to believe anything else.

"Put me down."

"Why?"

"I'm going to vomit." She jumped out my arms and rushed inside.

"Oh fuck, Wonder... I don't do that throw up shit." I gagged. "That shit gonna make me vomit." I slowly followed behind her, feeling like I was gonna empty my stomach next.

What the fuck did we get ourselves into?

Some good ass pussy... that's what.

Stevie knew if she ever tried to leave me, she would smell the cigarette smoke, and I would be wherever she was. This shit was forever, and she wasn't going nowhere, not that she wanted to. It was Wanda and Mitchell forever.

Epilogue



STEVIE CASELLI

*Recommendation: Listen to
"F*ckwithmeyouknowigotit" Jay-Z ft Rick
Ross*

EVERYONE CLAPPED AS THE LIGHTS WENT OUT AND WE ALL TOOK OUR places on the steps. I held my husband's hand, as everyone stood around us. When the lights came on, we saw all of the attendees of Case House's annual ball. I stood next to Maverick. Landon stood behind Maverick to the left while Kora stood in the middle, and Zoya on the other side of her.

Corleon stood in front of us with Skyler and Jeffie on each side of him. "Welcome fuck heads... another year, more pussy, and way more money. I'm usually up here alone, but it's time to introduce you to the Caselli family... and the Brusters."

Everyone clapped their hands and cheered for us as we stood on the steps. My husband was sexy in his suit, with his CH pin and his Wonder pin on his lapel. I wore a gold ball gown with my own CH pin pinned to the corset of the dress.

“I want to introduce you to the love of my life... my beautiful wife, Stevie Caselli. She plans to be in your fucking pockets because I know you bitches buy art. If you can buy pussy, you can fuck up a bag with her gallery when it opens.”

I squeezed his hand and mouthed *love you*.

I went from never knowing what was next for me or feeling lost since I lost my mother. When I met Maverick Caselli, I had no clue the plans that God had for me. All I knew is that I needed to save two people who didn't deserve to be saved.

There was a reason I allowed Pricilla to put that money in my account. Yeah, had it been anyone else I could have been dead. It wasn't anyone else, it was Menace Caselli that I ended up meeting. Though this started with him needing a wife and me needing to save my father and best friend, this turned out to be more than that.

I learned about Maverick, not Menace. Loving this man taught me that I wasn't really lost, I was waiting around for him to come and save me. We both needed one another to complete the other. When he climbed between my legs and I held him every night, I never felt so safe, and I knew he felt safe in my arms.

Although he still tensed up at times when I hugged him randomly, he was learning to feel love. He had gone so long not letting anyone in, not even his family, and I didn't want him to go another second.

Our baby was going to further heal this family and bring us closer to each other. I wanted his siblings to come to our home for Sunday dinners, and for us to continue to spend holidays together. It broke my heart knowing that this man spent his holidays alone.

Never again.

My baby would never spend another holiday, birthday, or moment alone with me as his wife. Like I knew he would protect and love me, I would do the same when it came to him. I trusted everything that came out that man's mouth and knew he would never hurt me. He was the warm and safe feeling I had been searching for and I finally had it.

He was considering going back to therapy and actually talking to the therapist. Maverick had a lot of things to work through that my love couldn't heal. As much as he hated to talk about Angelica and their relationship, there was a lot to unpack there, and I prayed he did the therapy.

I was so content with life that it scared me. My gallery was going to be amazing, and I couldn't wait to have a grand opening and invite all of Maverick's rich friends. This was exactly what I should have been doing, and I wouldn't have done it without my baby.

Skyler was in the house hunting phase, although Corleon wasn't with it. He wanted her to continue to rent and then move into his house with Jeffie. Both of them were standing firm on having their own until they had rings on their fingers. I wanted Skyler to have the happiness she had with Jeffie and Corleon so bad. Time would tell if she would allow herself to have what she wanted with them.

Cindy was still at the shop and checked in with me often. I missed working at the shop, but I now had a new responsibility and that was baking a human, being a wife, and getting the gallery together. When I made time, I would stop by and see her and catch up because I did miss her.

Alex was still at the store, and he still texted to check in with me. He used to worry about me so much, and now that he met Maverick and knew I was happy, he stopped worrying so much. Every so often he would send his infamous check in message, and it was always nice to tell him that I was happy, safe, and loved.

As for my father, I don't know what happened to him and I don't think I wanted to know. Steve Raye had done a lot of people wrong for the sake of money. In the end it bit him in his ass. He had every chance to make things right, and he decided to make it bad for himself. It wasn't my job to save a grown man. At the end of the day, he was the parent, and he had failed me so much that it became normal.

Being failed by a parent should *never* become normal.

Priscilla loved money so much that she allowed a man to ruin her life. I like to think we were friends at one point, and then I shake the thought away because it couldn't be true. A true friend would have never put me in the position that she had put me in. The more time that passed, the more I saw she was for herself and didn't care about me.

One thing about God, he never played about Stevie. He put me in a messed-up situation, and I ended up marrying a billionaire. All this time I was waiting for a sign from my mama, and she was putting the pieces in play for me.

Again, she didn't have to be as dramatic about it.

I had fell in love with the man that took me to meet his dead parents on our first date. It didn't get any crazier than Maverick, and I wouldn't trade my sexy mental patient for the world. Long as he could smell me when he was about to hit the roof, all would be great in the world.

Menace touched my stomach. "Y'all said fuck my son?"

"Maverick didn't nobody say that, and we don't even know what we're having," I smacked his hand away from me.

Everyone didn't know if they should clap to congratulate us or run with how quick his attitude changed. "To baby Caselli," Corleon lifted his champagne glass, and cheered.

Everyone cheered. "To baby Caselli."

I'd spend forever and a day with Menace Caselli. I searched his eyes as he did mine, and then we kissed each other. "I love you, Wanda."

"Love you, Mitchell."

I was Stevie Caselli, and I was married to the ghost, the rumor, *the* Menace Caselli.

The End.
(Keep reading...)

OceanofPDF.com

Alright... now we continue with season four... ready
to spin some shit? ;)

OceanofPDF.com